Wild

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Wild

by limey_limey

Summary

NOW COMPLETE: Born in the woods at the base of the Crystal Castle, the cub has no idea that she is anything other than a hunter; a wild thing that roams the Whispering Woods, until she meets a little blond Horde cadet and everything changes.

Cub

A rough tongue tickled at tiny ears, pushing them back into a brown mane as she was cleaned by her mother. She purred and giggled as her father prowled the mouth of their cave; watching, always watching for anything that could harm his cub. It didn't matter to him that his cub was still small after so many turns of the seasons, or that she would walk on her hind legs as often as on all four. She was their offspring and he would protect her.

As strange as the cub was, she was an excellent little hunter and could catch even the swiftest of small prey. She could navigate the trees more like the ape creatures than the cats, leaping from branch to branch, at times losing her parents as they sought to hunt her out. Honing her skills to hunt, and to hide. Her parents were proud. The rest of the pride had cast them out when they had seen the cub, thinking she would damage the bloodline.

They had left and made their lair where their cub had been born, at the base of the monstrous blue mountain that rose out of the woods and shone ghostly in the night. It was covered in lines and groves that the cub would use as handholds and scale the otherwise smooth surface to the top. It was a good training ground. It would make her strong. The mountain would hum, day and night, a low frequency that only animals like them could perceive; the lullaby that the cub lived and slept to.

Padding back into the cave, he curled around his offspring and his mate, sheltering them with his powerful body. He rested his head on a large paw and relaxed to sleep. His daughter squealed in delight, tumbling away from her mother to pounce onto her father's broad head and chew at his ears. He chuffed indulgently at her, flicking his ears. After long minutes, he tired of the game, swiping a long tongue across her face and nudging her back into the warm nest of their bodies. She curled into a purring ball and easily gave into slumber. He nuzzled his head with his mate and settled down to sleep.

The cub woke first at dawn. The shy tendrils of hazy light sifting through the mouth of the cave and mixing with the feint blue glow of the mountain wall that made up one side of their cave. Her mismatched eyes took in the sleeping faces of her parents an her heart made her purr with contentment. Usually her father woke first and hunted, bringing them breakfast before the trio would stalk the woods hunting and being together. This morning the cub would hunt. She would bring back the small tasty things that climbed the trees. Using all her not inconsiderable stealth she leap out from her parents, careful not to disturb them and scurried for the entrance.

Once outside she sped to the tree-line and scampered up the nearest tree on tiny silent paws. The Whispering Woods came to life around her.

+++++++

Dashing back through the foliage, barely a leaf moving in her wake, she swung back into the clearing. Limbs gone gangly from growth she stumbled a little as she came to a stop close to the mouth of the cave. Darkness surrounded here, night having beaten her back to her home. Releasing her kill from her mouth into her clawed hand she, she clasped it tightly and walked into the hazy blue glow that came from the cave. The cave was warm and the blue glow was dull enough to allow sleep but also to feel like company.

She stretched languorously and collapsed in a boneless heap at the back of the cave, still small enough to tuck into a small pocket between the wall of stone and the gently humming mountainside. The warmth of the building and the gentle sound soothed her and made her feel less alone. She wiggled to get comfortable, realising that soon her expanding body would not fit here, and felt a weight press on her. Bringing the plump tree creature to her mouth she tore through its fur and flesh, feeling the still warm blood fill her mouth, before taking a generous bite. As she ate she purred to herself, bringing further comfort, missing the feel of her

parents around her. She had been alone for a full turn of the seasons now but still had not grown accustomed to being alone.

Finally exhausted, hunger sated and claws and paws licked clean, she curled her tail around her body and made herself a small ball. She would sleep with one eye slitted open and ears alert to the smallest sound, just as her father had taught her. She was small, but she was still alive and if she wanted to stay that way she had to be the best hunter.

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Speeding across the way on the back of a skiff was the most exciting thing that had happened to the four young cadets in ever. Three of the children, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle, sat huddled behind the pilot, sheltered from the rushing wind by the bulk of the vehicle. The fourth child, a blond girl with a gap toothed grin, stood fearlessly at the front of the skiff, delighted by the speed and the wind that whipped her ponytail away from her face. Adora was going to see the Whispering Woods for the first time.

The Horde feared and coveted the Whispering Woods in equal measure. No matter how many times they had tried to break their way through it to attack the kingdoms that lay beyond, the woods would hold them back. Or would writhe and change almost before their eyes, throwing obstacles in their paths. Many had lost their lives careening into trees that had not been there a moment before or pounded to dust beneath the jaws of the large beasts that hid in the trees. And yet. The allure of the land, the territory, was worth the loss of life for the greater glory of The Horde.

That meant that once a rotation a group of junior cadets would find themselves flown to the edge of the woods and set down to camp as close to the woods as possible. They would set up tents and spend three days happy the very outskirts of the place, looking for possible pathways. As children they were more agile and could fit in crooks and crannies that adults could not see, and if one of them failed to return it was an acceptable loss of a soldier as yet untrained. Mostly they did come back - less afraid

and full of excitement about their next trip and how they would be the ones to conquer the dreaded Whispering woods!

This was to Adora's teams first expedition to the woods - their first time outside of the Fright Zone. Adora felt exhilaration in every fibre of her eight year old self. Turning from the wind she flashed a huge grin at her friends, and got a weak, queasy smile in return from Kyle and a thumbs up for Lonnie. Rogelio, arm around Kyle to keep him secure, was staring out at the horizon much like the blond. Turning back, blue eyes zeroed in on the trees that were rapidly getting closer and closer. Shades of green, yellow and blue everywhere. She couldn't hear much over the sounds of the skiff's engines, but she was sure that as well as the riot of colour that there would be a cacophony of sound.

Shadow Weaver had told her to take in everything she could, to remember to make maps and keep her squad under control. She had to remember that this was just one more step on her path to greatness in The Horde and that she must always remember that everything was for the greater glory. Shadow Weaver would be so proud of her if she could go back and tell her that she had found a path. She WOULD find a path!

Soon the skiff came to a halt on a strip of short grass that surrounded the edge of the woods. The children spilled out followed by their trainer. His voice barked out ordered as he instructed the children to take the tents and set them up in a rough semi-circle and set up a fire pit. With the practiced ease of a team that had been together for as long as they could remember the 4 children had the tents prepared and the fire pit arranged. Adora volunteered, eagerly, to fetch wood from the perimeter of the wood. With a column nod the trainer agreed - emphasising that at no point should she attempt to enter the tree-line. With a swift salute she dashed away.

Even the edge of the woods felt creepy, charged with a strange kind of menace, something that Adora couldn't quite put her finger on but that danced up her spine like spiders. Grabbing every loose twig and branch she could carry, she could barely see

over the pile in her arms as she turned to head back to the landing site. Taking more tentative steps now that her vision was somewhat obscured, she felt a pricking sensation on the back of her neck. All the hairs standing up below her swaying ponytail. She continued to move, trying to move faster while still looking calm but she was certain of one thing - something was stalking her from the trees.

+++++++
Mismatched eyes looked down at the golden head below her. The cat-girl had seen these creatures come and go, day-in day-out. Sometimes she would watch them from the trees when she had found a kill close to the edge of the forest, devouring the flesh as she took in the strange coverings of their bodies or the odd sounds that they made to each other. Some of them looked like the cub below her, hairless save for their head, while others looked like lizards or sometimes a scorpion. Nobody ever looked like her. The thought always made her ears lay flat and her tail thrash as thoughts of her parents, large feline bodies so different from her own filled her mind. Their images had faded in the seasons since their passing but she still knew them.

Today's group was small; one larger creature - blocky and blue - noisily directing the smaller ones. This set of cubs were the youngest she had seen, probably no bigger than herself. The lizard was larger. She licked her lips, it would probably taste good; the small ones she managed to catch in the trees were some of the most delicious in the woods. Though the thought of hunting one of them had crossed her mind, she knew when she was outnumbered. Then one of them walked away, so she followed.

Leaping from tree-to-tree, landing silently among the leaves, she followed the golden haired one walking the edge. Watched as it crouched and collected fallen wood, piling it so high on their chest that there was no way that they would be able to safely see. This could be entertaining. She continued to slink through the underbrush, eyes fixed on the child. She found that she liked the way that the fading light glinted off of her hair. Was almost transfixed by it. She noticed when the creature shifted nervously

and started to furtively glance to the side. Not wanting to be spotted she tore her eyes away and disappeared back into the safety of her home.

Camp

Chapter Summary

Some carnivorous devouring of small animals here.

The fire had been tamped down to nothing more than grey ashes and the junior cadets packed away into their tents. The instructor had given each strict instructions that they were to remain in their tent and only leave when it was their time to go on watch at the perimeter. They would be in pairs - one taking either side of the campsite. The large instructor would take the first watch while Kyle and Lonnie were to take the second while dusk still painted the surroundings with some fading light, while Adora and Rogelio would follow them 4 hours later in the dead of night.

Snug in her sleeping bag, Adora pulled it up to her chin and and curled onto her side facing Lonnie. Grey eyes focused on her tent-mate who was still tossing and turning in a vain effort to get comfortable on the thin foam pad unfurled beneath her. Finally with a loud huff the dark haired girl flopped onto her back and turned her head to look at Adora.

"What?" The impatient words were spat out.

"Do you think there are things in the woods this close to the edge?" She couldn't shake that feeling of being watched from earlier. But she wasn't afraid. She wasn't!

"Nah, no enough food out here for 'em. Those big things are supposed to need loads of food." Adora hummed like she agreed, yet she had definitely had a shadow. "Now go to sleep." She reached out and slapped off the light laying between them, throwing them into darkness.

Adora tried to sleep, she laid still counting her breaths as Lonnie fell into a deep sleep, puffing out not-quite snores. Minutes ticked by slowly but the more she tried to drift off more awake she felt.

Her skin seemed to prickle with anticipation, but of what she didn't know. She could hear the rustle of the tents as the wind blew through the clearing, the jingling of the equipment that was set out. Even Rogelio's familiar hisses drifted to her ears and every one of them seemed to set her nerves more and more on edge. By the time that Lonnie groaned and got up for her shift with Kyle, Adora was ready to crawl out of her skin.

Knowing that sleep was a lost cause she crawled out of her sleeping back and bundled herself into her winter-uniform coat, stuffing a flashlight in her pocket. It was chilly on the outskirts of the woods at this time of year, and as Adora left the tent she could still make out her breath clouding in the air. Like all children she couldn't help but take a long breath out into the night and imagine that she was a dragon! She knew that Shadow Weaver wouldn't approve of such childishness but she knew it wasn't hurting anyone. She looked up and made eye contact with a shivering Kyle who looked miserable at the edge of the campsite, and started to walk along the edge of the tree-line.

Fumbling the light out of her pocket, she clicked it on and made her way towards a cluster of large bodied trees. Reaching out a small hand she ran it over the bark, noting how even though it was imperfect and full of flaws and crevices it felt warm and alive, very different from the cold, still walls of the corridors of the Fright Zone. Her light illuminated crazy shadows over the trees as she moved it around lazily.

Movement further into the trees caught her eye and made her freeze; had she really seen that? Should she follow it? She bit her lip as she tried to decide what she should do, really she shouldn't be out here at all but if she went to look now she could be back for her watch and she might have intelligence she could share. She could even be the first Horde soldier to find a path through the woods!

Walking slowly she inched her way through the narrow crevice between two trees. She could feel the brush of the wood on her back and chest as she manoeuvred herself sideways to fit further.

A spike of panic worked up her spine as she, for the first time, considered that she could get stuck here. And what if when she got through she encountered something dangerous and needed to get out again quickly? She refused to let those thoughts intrude on her plan to make Shadow Weaver proud of her. No adult could get in here but she was small and strong, she could help the Horde move forward.

Still edging through the smaller and smaller gap, she was shocked when she suddenly popped out into a clearing like a cork. The onion was so abrupt that she stumbled and lost her footing, landing hard on the group and knocking the air from her lungs. Dazed, she lay blinking owlishly up at the dark canopy above her, somewhere to her side her torch had rolled away and weakly illuminated the small clearing.

So focused was she on trying to catch her breath that she failed to notice the figure in the darkness until it was suddenly on her.

Pinning her down.

Crouched above her with teeth bared and glowing whitely in the weak torchlight.

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Tail whipping in agitation, she sat up one of the larger trees that lined the cleaning. Usually the cub would not hunt this area of the woods at night, sticking closer to home where she could easily drag a larger kill and devour it, sad from scavengers and other, more dangerous foes. Yet, when she had woken from her nap, ready for her night hunt to begin, she had found herself back here, almost without her permission, like her body knew something that she did not.

Pickings had been slim on her journey to the camp ground, she had manage to snatch a couple of small but plump birds from the air as she flew past from tree to tree and had rendered them to pieces as she had watched the small camp break for the night.

She had never seen the strange ones at night and they way they put out the hot light and moved into the soft caves was fascinating. She cocked her head as she watched, blood and vicar escaping onto her chin as she quietly ate.

Then there was stillness, all the small ones had disappeared from sight and the large blue bodied threat methodically walked the edges of the encampment, clearly alert for any danger. Growing restless she bounded away to hunt for more, her stomach growing faintly. Nearby there was a small clearing and further still a spring. There was bound to be something to fill her belly at the water.

Moving from tree to tree, leaves barely moving in her wake, she was soon at the stream. She dropped from the trees into the long grass by the water, sinking down onto her belly to wait for prey. Her brown, striped fur blending into the ever darkening night, only her eyes occasionally catching the light giving away her position.

It didn't take long before a large rodent like creature, almost half her size, lumbered to the waters edge on the opposite bank of the stream. As it lowered its head to drink the cub looked around for any other creature, but this one seemed to be alone. Taking the opportunity of its lowered head, she pounced cleanly over the slowly moving water and using her strange long paws, gripped its head and efficiently tore out its throat before it could even let out a sound. Sitting back on her haunches, the young feline scanned for anything that could have heard her kill. When silence remained, she used her claws to slice large chunks of the creatures tender belly and stuff them into her bloody mouth, chewing rapidly and gulping down chunks.

She gorged until a sliver of light and the muffled sounds of movement caught her eye. Breaking away from the kill she made her way cautiously to the neighbouring clearing and saw that there was unnatural light sifting between the small gaps between the trees. There was definitely something moving along the outside of the tree-line. Curiosity won out of caution, and rather than getting back up into the trees, the cub retreated into the darkness at the edge of the small glade and waited.

It wasn’t long before the sounds of lights grunts and the scraping of something against the bark of the trees filled the clearing, the usual noise of the nocturnal birds and insects that always filled the air going still at the entrance of this intruder.

Licking her chops, still covered in blood, her eyes remained fixed on the larger crevice the thing would come threw. And then there it was, disgorged from the trees like they had birthed it. With an inelegance unknown to the creatures of the woods, the thing flew through the air and hit the ground hard with an ‘oof’. The odd light with it casting strange shadows around from where it rolled away from their hand. Then it just laid there.

It was the golden creature from before!

Driven by an urge she could not ignore, her body tensed and she pounced on the reclined figure. Even knowing that this prey was too big for her, she felt the compulsion to pin it to the ground, to show it her strength and power. Her claws grasped at shoulders and body perched over hips as she brought her face down over the creatures and growled.

Patrol

Letting out a small, surprised scream Adora let her four years of cadet training take over and punched the thing snarling in her face in the jaw. The blow connected solidly and the thing went silent, clearly stunned and reeled backwards into the shadows. Adora scrambled to her feet and took up a fighting stance, trying to look as intimidating as a little girl covered in leaves and sticks could.

Not letting the beast out of her sight she edged towards her dropped flashlight, but was too scared to bend and pick it up. The creature may be hiding in the shadows now, but she could still see its dark silhouette and the creepy reflection of light off of its eyes making them seem light red orbs floating. The child felt a shiver run up her spine as she tried to think of what to do. She couldn't leave how she had come, she would be trapped an at the things mercy, and she would get lost if she ran and it was bound to know the place.

She felt tears stinging at the back of her eyes, thinking about the sharp teeth and the blood that had covered the face that had loomed over her. There had been claws, she's sure, digging into her shoulder and that growl. The growl had been chilling, clearly meant to intimidate its prey. She didn't want to be its prey!

She wished she could get a better look at it.

Taking the split second decision that having the light was better than not, she snatched it from the ground, all the while keeping her eyes trained on her stony assailant, bringing the torch up and shining it directly at it. The animal let out a hiss, shuddering and withdrawing deeper into the shadows, eyes squeezing shut from the shock of the beam that had lanced into them. In the light, it was not what she had expected. Not at all.

Before it spun and threw itself up into the tree, she took as much note of details as she could, a soldier needs to know their foe. It

was gone in a flash, only vague rustling growing further away as it moved fast through the treetops. What she catalogued in her head was confusing, she'd thought it was a wild cat when it was hovering over her. Shed had fangs in her face and claws by her shoulder, she was sure. But standing in the shadows had been a little girl, probably around her own age. She had a tail and huge ears jutting out from her head and was completely naked but covered in fur. But that couldn't be true.

Nobody lived in the whispering woods.

Realising that staying there longer was just putting her in more danger she quickly wriggled back through the gap in the trees, taking more care this time and dashed back to camp as quietly as possible, not wanting to let anyone know she'd been gone. She crept back into her tent and laid on her bedroll, her mind reeling and adrenaline still pumping through her at her encounter.

She must have fallen asleep as the next thing she knew she felt Lonnie roughly shaking her shoulder, letting her know it was time for her shift on perimeter duty with Rogelio. Stumbling to her feet, Adora realised that she was bone tired. Her back hurt from her stumble to the floor, her body ached from the adrenaline that had drained out of her.

A huge, jaw cracking yawn was torn out of her as she walked out of her tent flap. She walked towards the large lizard boy who was already standing by the dead embers of the fire pit. His torch was pointed at the ground as she approached and she fished hers back out of her pocket. Rogelio was swaddled in his own cold weather gear, feeling the cool air into his bones. Adora had already decided in her fatigue fogged head that she would go on patrol close to the fissure into the woods; hoping for some reason she couldn't place that she would catch another glimpse of the forest creature.

Rogelio grunted his assent when she pointed at herself and in that direction, shambling off the other way. They had been drilled

enough in the few weeks leading up to their first ever expedition that she knew that they both knew all the protocols for this.

Adora walked further than Kyle had stationed himself. She did not go as far as the break in the tree-line, even though she wanted to. Years of Shadow Weaver drilling duty into her young head could not be broken just by her own desire to solve a puzzle. No matter how tempting that puzzle might be. She found the decaying remnants of a felled tree jutting out from the others and sat herself there. From this vantage point she could easily watch the camp as well as turn to see the place that she so desperately wished to return. It even provided a very convenient alcove for her back against a neighbouring tree without obscuring her view. If she squinted she could even see the smoke discoursed from the stacks of the Fright Zone, but she drew her eyes away; those she could see any day, the nature here was rarer.

Time passed slowly on watch. They weren't really expecting anyone to attack them, or even any animals to roam out from the woods protection. They were going through the motions to prepare them for real excursions into enemy territory. They would come here several times a year until they graduated to full soldier status. Adora turned her flashlight to the canopy and looked for any sign of the movement of small nighttime creatures (she was really looking for one large one in particular and she knew it) but nothing stirred.

After less than half an hour the young girl felt her body begin to sag and her eyes grow heavy. She fought it, jerking upright more than once as her head slumped forward onto her chest. She even got to her feet and stomped up and down to keep her blood pumping as much as she could but they felt heavy and she plonked back down soon after. Yawning again, her head tilted back and leaned against a tree and finally sleep dragged her down.

Small snorts and heavy breaths escaped her parted lips as she burrowed into her coat, torch forgotten at her feet. The stillness of the woods began to be broken by the calls of nocturnal birds

and the scuttling of small vermin coming out to collect insects and small amphibians and lizards that emerged in the darkest part of the night. She snoozed on, oblivious. If Shadow Weaver ever knew she would be disciplined harshly. Her sleeping mind wasn't concerned with such things.

Some time later the leaves began to twitch and rustle over head. Like a wave the motion of the leaves rippled and moved ever closer to the sleeping child. They crested to her right and paused. Feint breaths were all that was left moving leaves faintly close to a small, furred face.

Adora slept on, unaware of the eyes that bored into her from above.

Hours passed like this, one little girl snoring peacefully while the other watched over her. Nothing disrupted the peaceful tableaux until the creature perched in the branches noticed motion beginning in the campground. A tent flap opened and the large blue one stepped out, moving in the direction of the lizard. Once the green boy had been sent back to his tent, the larger adult started towards the sleeper.

A large seedpod smacked into Adora's forehead, sending her springing to her feet in panic, fists up ready to fight and eyes flashing from side to side. Sleep rudely disturbed she was confused and scared for the second time since they had arrived here. Movement in the periphery of her vision caused her to whirl on the intruder, only to realise it was her instructor come to send her back to bed.

Thankfully she marched back.

Once back in her sleeping back, careful not to disturb Lonnie, she wondered what luck had meant that she had not been found sleeping at her post.

The Not-There

Chapter Summary

Catra's POV of last chapter.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The cub flew through the trees away from the thing with the light and the hard punch. She moved from branch to branch, careful to disturb as little as possible. The woods moved around her, as they always did, cupping her and cradling her closely, bringing home faster to her than her legs could carry until she was once again hidden in the glowing comfort of her cave. She sat in her corner, which grew ever more cramped but felt like the embrace she missed from her pack.

A small hand, claws retracted, reached up and massaged her jaw which ached from where the creature had fought back. It wasn't that the cub had thought it prey, but she had not expected such swift retaliation either. She had had it pinned beneath her, at her mercy, as he father had shown her when she was tiny. But she had been bested. She had retreated in shame and allowed the bean of light to see her before she fled in shame.

She felt a sting in her eyes and knew that the wetness would soon run down her face. She didn't know what that was, none fo the animals that she hunted or observed from above ever did it. She could not recall ever seeing it happen to her pack. As the tears came she violently shook her head to be rid of them and then groomed her face with a lifted paw.

The cub dozed for a while in the dull light of the cave, she would wake to feed again soon enough, the. Growling in her belly would not let her do anything else. Yet she woke sooner than nature intended when the light in the cave suddenly intensified, burning

through her closed eye-lids and causing her to blink awake, pulling into herself as she faced the intruder in her den.

The not-there was back.

The not-there came to the cave a lot. The cub had seen it arrive many times, emerging from the wall as if it were a part of it only to detach and stand at the centre of the dim room. At first it had appeared rarely, she hazily remembered her parents biting and snapping at it only to come away with mouths full of nothing. It had no smell, no form other than what could be seen. When jaws snapped at it, t would flicker and reform, moved by their attacks. Low growls had filled the room then and no sound had ever left the not-there.

When here parents had gone it had come with greater frequency until now she saw it with each turn of the day moon. No longer silent, foreign sounds would come from its mouth. As a smaller cub she had be afraid and alone, cowering from the bright light and the alien sounds. Years later she looked forward to the company, some of the sounds having long since started to make sense to her. The cub was even able to make some of those sounds and communicate with the not-there.

The not-there wanted her to.

She crawled forward out of the alcove and went to sit at the feet of the towering presence that dominated the area, its head almost touching the roof of the den. The cub sat cross legged, gazing up at the blankly serene face that emerged from the cowl of its hood. She didn't know any of those words, the little one only knew that this was something different to all the animals she chased and the creatures she watched make camps and wander from settlements. Her small face was illuminated blue as she looked up in supplication.

After long minutes filled only with light and the swish of the child's tail brushing the dusty floor, the empty eyes looked down and fixed on her. The blank face made no sign of recognition or

affection, the voice that emerged flat and purposeful, but it filled the room and made the cub feel less alone and less ashamed about the events of the night so far.

“What has happened to your face?”

The feline knew then that her aborted hunt must have left a wound blooming on her face. Silence stretched between them, the not-there would wait until the cub could find the sounds among her roars and growls. It had told her that the new noises were ‘speech’ but that made no sense to her.

“Not cub… out,” she waved to the door of the cave and in the direction of the encampment. “I hunt. It…” she mimed the sock to the jaw.

A brow raised in inquiry, “One of the soldiers hit you?”

The cub was unsure what ‘soldier’ was but the word didn’t seem right for the light coloured one.

“Small,” she pointed at herself.

“A child did this,” there was no longer a question in its words.

It was still then for long moments, eyes once again looking off. The cub didn’t mind, content to just not be alone for a short while. Maybe that was why she felt so drawn to the ones that cam. Maybe that was why she found herself still fascinated by the one that had hit her. A part of her wanted to go back and find it, to pounce again and growl and purr and sniff. She didn’t know why, no other creature had made her want to know it before; hunt, kill, eat or flee but never know.

Indeterminable minutes later, the not-there’s eyes were back on her.

“Be careful you are not seen. You have a purpose. You were made for something more than dying at the hands of invaders.” The cub knew few of those words but she knew ‘die’ and she knew

‘purpose’, the not-there had been sure of that. She nodded vigorously in response, pleased when she received a nod of praise before that not-there melted back into the wall and the light dimmed once again.

Not desiring to be alone in the cave after that, and belly starting to feel hollow the cub prowled out of the narrow opening of the cave and ran into the night to hunt for food.

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Later, hunger satiated she couldn’t help be drawn back to where she had pounced on the ‘child’, the not-there had called it. She wandered the dark clearing, eyes adjusted to see just as well as in the day. She let her senses fill the place, sniffing the ground where she had been, taking in the peculiar scents that it had left behind. In among the smell of mud was something sticky and dark that tickled her nose, but beneath that was something else. Something musky and sweet, it made her nose twitch but not unpleasantly.

Taking back to the safety of the trees as she heard other, more dangerous things stirring beyond the clearing close to the river. Rather than moving back to the safety of her den, the cub found herself drawn to stay close to the edge of the forest. One false move and she would be exposed, but she wouldn’t make a false move. Even though she was young her reflexes and muscles were fine tuned. She could move in even the most precarious of places.

She hadn’t gone far when she took a breath and was hit by the clearing smell, only stronger here and growing more so. She stretched out her senses and realised that she could hear deep, soft breaths coming from close by that accompanied the smells.

Creeping forward even more cautiously than before, the cub found herself looking down at the slumbering face of the child. Its pink lips were parted and breaths puffed out from where it was bundled in the thing that surrounded it. Its eyes were closed, lashes brushing round cheeks as its head lolled against the tree at

its back. The cub was surprised that the ungainly thing hadn’t slipped from the fallen log that it was sat on, its body looked boneless.

The cub continued to take in the other small creature well past time when she should have returned to her den. Finally, knowing that she would not go back while the child remained, and feeling unaccountably worried that this child, completely oblivious to its surroundings, would become prey for something far more dangerous than her, the cub settled into the crook of the tree. Sitting on silent guard of the creature that had fought back against her.

A long time passed like that; the feline studying while the child slept. Time meant little to the cub as it passed; she was a thing of the night as much as the day and waiting was part and parcel of the life of a hunter.

Ears snapped to the sound of movement in the camp hours later, making them swivel to keep the sound tracked. Breaking her gaze away from her fascination, she saw the big one coming. Fear lanced through her and she could not tell why. The big one and the child were part of the same pack, except she felt reasonably sure that the child would suffer for this.

Keeping hidden, the cub grasped a hard shelled seed and launched it with speed and precision at the forehead of the child. It hit its mark with a thud and the child was on its feet, casting around wildly in confusion.

Satisfied that the cub was safe and knowing that she would not be if she remained, the cub withdrew back into the forest.

Chapter End Notes

So what's Light Hope up to?

Is it even a story about Catra if an adult isn't manipulating her for their own ends?

Challenge

Chapter Summary

A little older and a lot more together.

Adora left her tent, still bleary eyed and half asleep as she rubbed her knuckles into her eyes, yawning and scratching at her stomach. Looking over Adora was pleased to note that Lonnie, who had slept most of the night, looked just as tired as she did. Both girls stumbled out off their tent and dragged their feet to the camp fire which was again blazing, heating up water. One of the few perks of being on manoeuvres was that the rations were different. All of the cadets were excited to devour the dehydrated rations that tasted of more than brown or grey!

The four of them sat fanned out around the boiling pot of water, much more confident and self assured than they had been the first time they camped here. Looking around Adora really took notice of her squad in a way she didn't under the harsh overhead light of the Fright Zone. Everything, and everyone, looks new and different in the light of day. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Adora herself, were staring to shoot up, limbs gone gangly and disproportionate as puberty took hold of their growing bodies. Kyle remained the runt of the group, always skinny and long limbed but still yet to have any kind of growth spurt, leaving him a head shorter than his female companions. As ever Rogelio filled out his growth looking only a little awkward, although they had all been swatted by his tail enough times recently to know that his body was just as out of control as theirs.

This was their fourteenth field training exercise, this time coming during the autumn. The trees colours were changing and the weather unpredictable. The worst was when their allotted four month cycle hit in the winter, bitterly cold as it was in the tents and on sentry duty, but luckily that'd only happened once so far. Adora liked the autumn though, its capriciousness making her skin tingle with anticipation at what might come. The leaves changing

colour and the animals that they did see eager to forage and bolder than usual as they prepared for a winter that could be a harsh master.

Now that the squad were older and more capable, their forays into the wild were more exciting; they would be broken up into teams, or set out alone, to find their way into the edges of the forest and scout and bring back what they could find. On rare occasions such scouting groups would find scraps of tech, almost broken beyond recognition, but be lorded when they returned to the barracks. That was what every group of cadets hoped for; the adulation of their peers and extra rations. As yet Adora's team had no such luck.

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were always on the lookout for the tarnished pieces of metal when they went out. Every time Kyle saw anything shiny in the brush he would dive for it, his excitement outweighing his common sense (because that's just who Kyle was) and more often than not cam up with bird bones or, in some cases, small rodents attached to his fingers as he screamed.

Unlike her team mates, Adora concerned herself with getting deeper and deeper into the Whispering Woods. For many the woods were almost impenetrable, shifting and changing from one day to the next, making them almost impassable to most. Adora had made it her mission to get as deep into the woods as possible. Over the last four years she had made progress leaving marks on the trees she passed each time. Sometimes they even stayed.

Shovelling warm porridge into her mouth, and wasn't eating food that was warm a treat, Adora couldn't wait to hear the their deployment for the day. She would soon be turning thirteen and they would all be moving from being juniors to full cadets, each training trip and new formation learned brought her a step closer to being the Force Captain that Shadow Weaver claimed she was destined to become. Adora was keen to prove her mentor right in everything that she did.

Their instructor on this trip was Force Captain Octavia, a caustic squid woman whose eyes could pierce right through you. She was one of the youngest Force Captains in the Horde and made her somebody that every cadet wished to impress. She stood tall, resplendent in her red and white uniform, in stark contrast to the blue greens of the surrounding foliage.

"Cadets, for the next three days you will be on your own in the woods. You will be provided with a pack containing three ration bars, a canteen, bedroll, waterproofs, map and compass." Her eyes cooly passed over each of the pre-teens, all of whom had now set aside their food and were paying rapt attention to her. "Your goal is to return to this point within three days, if you do not return in that time we will wait an additional two days. This will be considered a failure and your entire squad will re-take this assessment in the next cycle. If you are not back after that point you will be left behind." Her eyes were cold as was her voice when she delivered the last point.

Kyle let out a little whimper, trembling at the idea of being left behind. Adora felt sorry for him, but he would need to toughen up if he wanted to be a soldier with the rest of them. She made eye contact with each of her team mates and gave them a reassuring look. Rogelio nodded back whileLonnie quietly scoffed at her, although a small smile spread over her face. Kyle gave her a watery smile that quivered at the corners.

"Pack up and be waiting at the skiff in ten." Octavia turned her back to walk away when a tremulous voice stopped her.

"T…the skiff?" Kyle was almost in tears.

"How else do you think I'll deliver you to the woods?" Now waiting for a response, Octavia strode off to prepare the transport.

Kyle scuttled away to the tent he shared with Rogelio, shoulders shaking with the sobs that he couldn't keep inside. Rogelio followed, catching up to his bunkmate and throwing an arm

around his shoulders as they disappeared into their tent. Lonnie caught Adora's eye as the walked, side-by-side to their own tent.

The two girls efficiently stowed their gear in their packs and headed to the skiff in companionable silence. When they approached Octavia she ordered them to open their packs and checked that they had what was allowed, no more, no less. She added a map and compass to each before closing them up. The girls climbed on board and waited for their male counterparts to arrive.

Finally the four youths were on the skiff and it was rising from the ground, scattering leaves and debris in its wake as it moved to glide over the top of the trees.

Adora was the last to be deposited into the woods. She had watched as first Kyle (and maybe Octavia did have some compassion as he was not deposited very far into the woods) and then Lonnie and Rogelio were dropped. The young blond had made a mental note of where each of her comrades were, even though the woods made it very difficult to keep a beat on them after flying away.

As she looked down she saw the treetops rippling with the downdraft of the skiff's engines. Here and there she thought she saw branches moving and bouncing before the skiff got to them but Octavia didn't seem to notice. It wasn't lost on the girl that she was being taken far further into the woods than her companions. Octavia noticed her worried look.

"Shadow Weaver instructed that you be challenged on the course. She believes in your capabilities and this is your chance to prove yourself."

Finally the skiff hovered over a dark clearing and it was her turn to shimmy down the rope that was lowered into the unknown.

The skiff was soon out of sight, Adora left alone in the woods. Waiting until she was sure that Octavia was far away and the sound of the engines nothing but a feint, fading hum, she let out a piercing whistle, hoping that the disturbance in the trees was what she thought it was. Minutes trickled by as she waited where she had been deposited. Before she could give up hope a blur of movement to her right sent her head whipping to the side, body automatically poised to fight as she laid eyes on the intruder.

"Hey, Adora," the low voice drawled in the stillness of the morning.

Adora's body relaxed at the sound, the words still not quite as clear as her own but much improved every time she saw the other girl. Her body relaxed almost against her will and a smile split across her face, stretching her cheek muscles as she rushed over to the young feline and wrapped her furry body in an embrace. "Hey, Catra," she breathed in her ear.

Catra's body tensed as the arms wound around her, pinning her own to her sides. She had to fight against her natural fight response at being pinned. The words softly whispered into her ear, breath tickling the skin and making them twitch, caused her body to relax into the hug. The young feline looked forward to these brief snatches of time with the blond girl, they didn't happen often but every time they did she felt her affection for the human double. Catra ended the hug by licking the other girls face until she giggled and stepped back, wiping at her cheek.

"Ewww, that's gross Catra!" Her laugh ended with a snort as she gazed at her secret friend with wide eyes that glowed with affection.

Catra's heart always swelled when the other girl used the name she had bestowed on her when they were small.

Adora gazed at her secret friend, drinking in all of the little changes in her over the last few months. The cat-girl continued to be long limbed and full of ropey muscle, though the blond noticed

that those muscles were growing larger, filling out to show how strong she was. Her fur was shinier now than it had been when they were younger, and her mane was wild as ever. She lacked the ungainly quality that made up Adora and her peers and the girl couldn't help but wonder if Catra were younger than her. As always, she was shamelessly naked.

Adora could see her friend looking at her with questioning eyes and realised that the other girl was confused about why she was out here. Adora found herself explaining, as clearly as she could for the benefit of Catra's still limited language skills, that she had to make her way back to the tents. The revelation left the cub chortling, noting that her friend could just follow her back to camp.

"That's cheating Catra, I'm supposed to make it on my own."

"Why?" Large ears flicked towards her, attentive for her answer.

"Why? Because we're all supposed to be using our survival skills to survive, if I follow you I haven't done that." Rules were something that the cadet was very good at following.

"Shouldn't you use all best chances for winning?" She knew her words were not quite right, and it frustrated the cub when she was with Adora.

"I'll think about it." The blond walked closer and gently bumped a furry shoulder. "I have three days before I have to be back, why don't you finally show me that cave of yours? I'd love to meet Light Hope."

Catra's eyes grew as big as saucers, large pupils gleaming as her ears pricked and fur puffed up all over her body. Her excitement was palpable. She had longed for less fleeting companionship from Adora, always feeling more alone after each meeting. After growing up as a solitary creature for so long, when the chatty little red clothed creature had burst into that clearing so many seasons ago, things had changed. After she'd woken her with that

seed to the forehead, saving her from sanction she had found herself drawn back to her over and over again.

At first it had been just watching her from the trees and then she was gone. The second time, after the seasons had changed, the blond had sought her out; picking through the trees and back to the clearing, calling out with sounds that the cub had barely understood but could not resist even then. The kitten had sat above her in the trees and rained down leaves and berries like snow while this interloper had laughed in glee. It had finally been that laughter, full of gasped snorts that had lured her down from the tree to stand before her.

The two children had stared at each other that day, drinking in the oddness of the other. Hair and skin and clothing observed fur and teeth and claws. Communication had come slowly, the cub having only a fragile understanding of words that came from the Light Hope (or the Not-There as she knew her then) and the other not understanding animals at all. But as children will, they quickly learned to talk through play, the cub and child chasing and pouncing, laughter and growls swirled together.

It hadn't been until they were almost ten that Adora had bestowed the name 'Catra' on her. The cub had no concept of names, not really. She knew 'Adora' was what the other child was but not that it was who she was. They had played a rousing game of night-time chase, the clothed girl getting better and better at making her way into the trees, and now sat in the thick branches of a very old tree. They were cradled in the limbs, Adora sitting with her back pressed to the trunk, legs stretched out on the large branch with the kitten's head resting on her lap. Adora ran her hand over the other girls fur, twirling the longer hair in her mane around her fingers. Both of them longed for the comfort of touch that was denied to them in their respective homes.

"You should have a name," the blond had blurted, making mismatched eyes turned to look at her face. "I am Adora and you should be somebody too."

“I Cat?” It’s what the other girl said when she saw her.

“That’s like you calling me human,” she’d laughed like it was ridiculous.

“I Adora?” The cub was still not sure why it mattered.

“No, that’s me!” Her blue eyes squinted for a moment while she thought an idea through. The cub liked to watch her think, it sometimes took her a while but the forest dweller had time. “Why don’t we put the two together? Like Adat?” The little furred face sneered, “Ok, not that.” She chewed her lip, “What about Catra?”

“I Catra!” She liked it.

Three years later and Adora was still the only one in the world who knew her name.

Back in the here and now, Catra reached out and grabbed Adora’s hand in her clawed one, careful that her claws were sheathed. Grinning from ear to ear, fangs gleaming in the light of the day-moon, Adora didn’t think that she had ever seen a more appealing sight. She had never really seen the feline in the day before and marvelled at her red-brown fur and the dazzling colours of her eyes.

“Come with me then!”

And then the two of them were running through the trees, one sure footedly dodging roots and fallen branches with the surety of one born to it while the other put their trust in her and kept pace at her side.

Play

Daylight dappled through the canopy of the trees, casting diamonds of light over everything, including the two laughing girls as they came to a stop by a stream. The small cat stretched in the light, casually sauntering over to the slowly running water while her human companion bent double, hands on her knees and breathed deeply to get some air back into her lungs. Adora may be the best cadet in her year but the stamina of her wild friend was humbling, the child decided she would do more cardio in training so she could keep up better next time.

"Drink." Catra crouched down by the stream, pointing Adora to it, before thrusting her face into the water and taking huge gulps of water.

Adora looked at her curiously, was she expecting her to do that too? The cadet reached into her pack and pulled out the large, metal canteen. As Catra sat back from the water, shaking the water from the fur on her face, she looked quizzically at the thing in the other girls hand.

"This is a canteen," she saw the odd eyes still looking blankly at her, "its for carrying water around, look." She opened the top, letting the cap hang down and poured a little water out onto the mossy floor, before bringing it to her lips and talking a deep drink.

Catra walked towards her, mesmerised by this simple object that seemed so ordinary to her. Standing so close that Adora could feel the heat radiating off of her, the cat-girl waited for her to finish drinking before reaching out and taking the cool metal from her and examining it. She squealed and jumped back when she tilted it too far and water poured onto her hand. Adora felt the affection bubbling up from inside her as she watched Catra's fascination, a broad grin spreading across her pale face.

"Canteen," Catra felt the word on her tongue. It was new, another piece of language to slot into her brain to be able to better

communicate with her friend. She passed it back so it could be placed back into the bag (that one she knew from food brought by the cadet) before they completed their journey to her cave, it wasn't far now. "Come."

The feline led her, at a leisurely pace this time, through low hanging branches and vines. It was always darker here, around the perimeter of the shiny mountain and her home, like the woods were trying protect her. The trees loomed their largest, shielding everything from view. Sometimes her home was not in the same place, but the woods always told her where to find it.

When they emerged into the almost perfect oval that was her home, Catra stood still and watched her firmed take in the sight. Something felt odd in her chest, it was not a feeling that she was familiar with. It almost felt like when she was waiting for the other girl, her heart beating too quickly and her breath catching in her throat.

Adora's jaw dropped as she look at the towering blue monolith in the centre of the unnatural circular clearing. It towered over her head, matching the surrounding ancient trees in height, tapering to pointed top from a large square base. Its outer surface was etched with strangely familiar markings that niggled at the back of his mind, whispering something just out of reach. Its walls glowed an unnatural blue, suffusing the area with an ethereal quality. Finally managing to pull her eyes away she took notice of the one part of the tower that was not perfect, a stone lump encased one corner, sticking out bulbously and marring the simple perfection of the shape.

A furred arm brushed against her as the cub made her way past, toothy smile plastered across her face. When she realised that her companion hadn't moved with her she reached out a hand, calloused by a life spend grasping branches, to grasp the other girl's as it lay limply at her side. She tilted her head, catching her eyes, "Home now. Come Adora."

The words shook the taller child out of her revery. She grasped the hand in hers tightly and excitedly followed the girl with the swishing tail. The word ‘home’ swirled around in her head. Home for her was a cold place, full of loud noises and rigid control. A place where the comfort of touch was fleeting and cool, discouraged among cadets and doled out by Shadow Weaver sparingly. Here, with Catra, touch was warm and given freely. She wasn’t sure what to expect from the wild ones home, but the anticipation made her giggle as they got closer to the small entrance.
“Have to go low, Adora. Hole small.” She led the way, scrambling in on all fours with the young soldier following behind.

Once though the opening the cave wasn’t much bigger. The ceiling was high enough for an adult to stand in, but the circumference of the room was barely big enough for two people to lay down, side by side but Adora could see how it would be cosy to curl up in. There was a small cubby to one side, nestled against the side of the glowing blue building and the entire room was bathed in a feint blue light from the edge that was made from the wall of the monolith. It was eerily beautiful.

Blue eyes cast around the room and realised that, other than some very old bones that looked like they had been there for years, the room was bare. No sign of meat, or smell of animals. She didn’t really know what she expected from the kittens home. The idea of cuddling up at night in a safe and warm little cocoon here was very appealing yet the tiny empty space also made the blond feel very sad for her friend who must be so lonely so much of the time.

Catra saw the other girl looking around and moved over to the cubby.

“This where I sleep when I small. I too big now. Not as hot out here by my own.” Her face wore a childish pout that made Adora giggle and come and shoulder bump her affectionately.

"Tonight, and the next, we'll stay warm together then." She lifted her hand to run stubby fingers through the mane of wild hair beside her. "I am going to need to build a fire though." Seeing questioning eyes turn to her she added, "I can't eat fresh kills like you, we're different."

A flash of sadness passed over the furry face, it was fleeting but made the other girl feel bad for having said anything.

"But I can eat what you catch if I cook it," this seemed to brighten the others sprints spirits.

Adora was excited to eat food that was really cooked. She wasn't really sure how to do it, but she was a good cadet and she knew how to try her best. She had read lots of field survival journals and knew that you had to take the insides out and not let there be any blood or you would get sick. Eventually she and the others would be able to trap animals but that was a lesson they hadn't got to yet. Thanks to Catra at least she wouldn't have to eat the ration bars.

"You sleep in here with me?" The mismatched eyes looked hopeful.

"Of course, silly. We can snuggle up and tell stories." Catra wasn't quite sure what 'snuggle' was but she assumed it was something like a hug or cuddle, Adora had explained what those were while demonstrating and this word sounded like them.

Adora felt a peculiar sensation against her calf, and when she looked down realised that the cub's tail was curling around her. Adora felt a blush rise to her face, she wasn't sure why. She grinned goofily at her friend who smiled back. Uncurling her tail, Catra headed back towards the cave opening.

"I hunt. You stay. Be ready." Adora understood that she was being told to set up what she needed to and waved as the cat exited.

It amazed Adora how far her friend had come with her speech. When they had first met when they were small, the feline had a

handful of disjointed words, some of which Adora didn't understand. It was clear that even though they saw each other only briefly throughout the year that Catra must practice, maybe even with Light Hope, who she had called The Not There until she had learned that things had names.

Although she knew there was much to do, alone in the cave Adora could not help but approach the glowing wall. More of the strange line designs adorned it and worried away at her mind. She reached out a tentative hand to touch the sigils, hesitating inches from the surface. Her hand fell back to her side without making contact.

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Lighting the fire was second nature to her now after so many trips to the wild. Adora had constructed a small fire pit, a happy little fire blazing away inside. She had laid out her bedroll on the ground inside the cave, making it as large as she could and put her blanket on top. Outside she now sat with her legs crossed waiting for the hunt to end.

It wasn't long before a light brown blur flew out from between the trees. Catra came to a tumbling halt feet from the fire, a large white furred thing clutched in her clawed hands. Adora had seen Catra after a hunt more than once, blood spattering her face and chest but those were small birds and mice. Nothing had prepared her for the mask of red that now painted the other girls lower jaw, her fangs were stained and her chest was caked in gore like her claws. The blond blanched at the sight of so much blood. The cub just looked elated.

"Big food. I gutted for you." The animal was thrust out to her with pride.

Adora stuttered a thanks as she took the gory corpse, pretty sure that she would have to use her knife to skin it. Unsure how that would be done. She pulled her bag over, drawing out the blade which caught the eye of the youth sitting opposite and licking the blood from her hands and claws.

“Why?” She gestured to the hand now holding the weapon.

“Oh, I have to take the fur and the skin off I think…” though honestly she wasn’t sure.

Catra rolled her eyes and held out a hand, cautiously Adora handed over the animal unsure what the other intended. With a few flicks of her wrist Catra used her claws to separate flesh from fur with ease. Though she had no need to do it for herself, days alone with little to do but hunt and feed had meant she made up things to entertain herself. Skinning her kills had been one, picking berries another.

Skewering the kill on a stick she handed it back and Adora placed it over the fire.

Licking her fingers, belly pleasantly full, Adora decided she was pleased with her first attempt at cooking. Yes, the outside of the meat had been rather black in places and crispy in her mouth, but the flavour had been like nothing she had ever tasted. Her mouth had watered the whole time as she gnawed the bones. She had offered the cooked meat to the cat-girl who pulled a disgusted face at the first bite and thrust it back to her. While the Horde cadet sat and peacefully ate her dinner, the cub ran back into the woods to get herself something fresh.

When Catra returned this time Adora knew that she would have to do something about the furred body being coated in blood. There was no way that she could sleep next to her like this. She had long become accustomed to the others nakedness, Catra’s body still looking much as it had when they met at eight (or Adora assumed her friend had also been around the same age, truthfully she could be younger), just longer. Adora’s had started to go through the vicious changes wrought by puberty and she wasn’t enjoying it.

“Can we go to the river to wash up?” She knew that there were small streams running here and there and figured a larger stream must be close.

Catra jumped to her feet, once again grabbing Adora by her hand and hoisting her to her feet before pulling her along. It didn’t take long before she could hear the trickling sound of water before they came upon a river with a low moving waterfall at one end. It was small but leant the place a tranquil feeling.

Even though the air was cool, it wasn’t cold so Adora tore of her clothes and waded into the water, hoping that Catra would copy her actions, self conscious about asking her friend to wash. Catra followed without question, wading up to her neck before the human child knew what was happening, and them she was gone beneath the surface. She resurfaced soon after, cleaned of the blood and gore. She pounced over to Adora and shook the spray from her head all over her friends face, then laughed at her look of disgust and walked out of the water to lay on a rock in the hazy afternoon light. Adora waded out far less gracefully and plopped down beside the reclined figure, still naked herself.

They lounged like that, swatting at each other from time to time, occasionally talking but mostly just enjoying each others company. Until Catra leapt from the rock, ear twitching back and forth. The afternoon was fast approaching evening, the light fading, and it was clearly time to go. Adora had slipped back into her clothes as soon as her body had dried so when Catra led them away, fur standing on end around her body, she followed straight away.

Back at the clearing the fire had burned down and the cadet made sure it was out completely before they crawled back into the cave, Adora dragged her pack along with her. Catra was obviously unsure about the feel of the bedroll and the blanket under her feet and was walking in such a cute was that Adora couldn’t help but giggle at her. With her fur puffed up from drying on the rock and her odd movements she was the most adorable thing the twelve year old had ever seen.

“This is for sleeping in. It’s called a bed. We sleep under the blanket.” The feline seemed satisfied with this and laid down by the cave opening, meaning that the bigger girl had to move around her and be closer to the monolith wall. She pulled off her shirt, boots and pants, leaving her in her undershirt and boxers. She hunkered down with her back to the wall, facing the other child with the blanket wrapped around her shoulder.

The light was fading and the blue glow, rather than being a distraction, was soothing. Adora reached out a hand and laid it onto the other girls shoulder.

“C’m here,” her voice had begun to blur with fatigue and she realised she was exhausted.

The cat curled into her, burrowing her head under the blonds chin. Adora found herself running her fingers through the fluffy fur on her back which seemed to sooth both of them if the purring coming from under her chin were anything to go by. Both of them began to relax into each other, breaths getting longer and deeper unit the cave was filled with gentle snores and occasional purrs.

Rain

The harsh crack of thunder shot through the body of the blond like a gunshot, causing her body to jolt into a sitting position and cast her eyes around her dim surroundings fearfully. The loud hush of rain could be heard from outside, drops beating faintly on the roof of the cave. For a moment the little human was surprised that there was no water inside, but remembered the oddly sloping design of the cave. Fighting to get her heartbeat back to normal, Adora felt a hand grasp her wrist and almost jumped out of her skin.

Catra's eyes, blinking up at her, were luminous in the blue glow. She took in her friends jagged breathing, the light sheen of sweat on her brow and the sound of her rapidly beating heart and realised that she was very afraid. Rather than sitting up with her, Catra grasped her wrist more tightly and urged the other girl to lay back down with her. This time she wrapped herself around the trembling girl and began to purr in a low, unbroken rhythm that she remembered her mother using for her when she was small and afraid.

But Adora was not a kitten and maybe words were needed here too.

"Just rain, Adora. We safe. Secret place." She felt the other girl relax into her, going almost boneless as she burrowed into the embrace. "Go sleep."

Soft puffs of breath were soon ruffling the fur across her chest, the weight of the other girl feeling odd but not uncomfortable at her side. It had been so long since the cub had company that was warm and alive inside her home that she stayed awake and revelled in it for long minutes before the beating of the rain and the warmth that surrounded her lulled her back into a deep sleep.

When Adora next woke it was to weak dawn light struggling through the narrow entrance of the cave. The sound of the torrential rain was still pounding on the roof of the cave, the air inside having taken on a chill, especially with the small furry body absent. Adora snuggled deeper into the single blanket and waited for her benefactor to return; it wasn't like she could build a fire in this weather even had she wanted to.

Yawning widely, and huffing out contentedly, Adora realised that she felt more rested than she ever did after a nights sleep in the barracks, even though she had been curled up on the floor. Perhaps it was the comfort of being curled up with another person, being able to know she wasn't alone, that had helped her young body to relax. As she rubbed her cheek into the blanket that came up as far as her ears she became very aware that she was only in her underwear. Something inside her made her flush and reach out a probing hand to grab her shit and pants and pull them into her warm cocoon. Not wanting to expose anymore of her flesh to the air, she wriggled and contorted herself back into her uniform, then scooted her back to the wall, crossing her legs and keeping the blanket over her as she waited for Catra to return.

Long minutes stretched out as she waited, her eyes beginning to droop again as the steady cadence of the rain lulled her back into an almost trance like snooze until a small body lurched through the opening in the cave wall. The thud of the body coming to rest against the wall had Adora up and ready for an attack until her addled brain realised where she was and who she was with.

"Hey Adora," the big toothy grin that was shot her way made the pre teen smile back dopily as she took in the soaked and bedraggled state of her friend.

"You're soaked," it blurted out of her mouth as things often did for the blond, before she could think of anything better to say.

“Bad out. I brought you food.” The sodden girl triumphantly held up a sack made from some sort of torn cloth the cat must have found at some point in the woods, stuffed to bulging with something.

Adora moved forward in the small space and took the bag, putting it down and letting some of the contents spill out, she was charmed that her friend had braved the weather to fetch her food when there were perfectly good, well not good but edible, ration bars in her bag. What fell onto the bedroll were an assortment of brightly coloured fruits as well as some hard cased things she wasn’t sure how she was supposed to eat. Her eyes moved from the food, back up to the cub who was starting to shiver, water starting to pool at her feet.

“Catra, how do you get dry?” She certainly didn’t have any towels.

“I shake. I get everything wet if I do.” Oh, that was a problem. The space was so small that Adora realised Catra was right, everything would get damp but she couldn’t let her get cold.

Blue eyes travelled to the small alcove that Catra had told her she had slept in as a small child and an idea crept into the blond’s mind. Pushing the food back into the sack, she grabbed her coat, pack and blanket and stuffed them into the alcove, along with the food. She grasped the bedroll and sat with her back to her belongings and held the bedroll up like a shield, it was waterproof to protect the sleeper from the ground and large enough to keep everything dry. While all of this was happening the cub watched her with confused blue and yellow eyes.

“Ok Catra, now you can shake all the water off and everything will be fine.”

Not needing to be asked twice, the cold water making her more uncomfortable by the minute, Catra contorted her body and shook vigorously, sending a heavy spray of water speckling the rough walls of the cave. Her fur puffed up, providing some insulation as her small body friend to warm itself, but her sharp teeth still

chattered. Hearing the sound from across the room, Adora threw the bedroll bak onto the floor, before standing to wind the blanket around her still damp shoulders and pull the other child down to sit between her legs. Adora had snatched up her jacket and sat, back braced against the wall with Catra held in front of her in the blanket with her jacket over the top.

The kitten had taken care of her and now she would do the same.

Catra purred against the uniform clad chest. After a few quiet minutes she butted her head into Adora's chin and pointed at the bag of food still in the area that had been protected. "You eat Adora. I got for you."

Hearing the urgency in the scratchy voice, and realising that her friend was concerned about her in a way that nobody else had ever been, Adora managed to stretch her arm our and snag the bag and pull it to her. The girl in her lap looked pleased, sitting up straighter to give Adora room to manoeuvre, but did not leave her personal space. The human child began to pop fruits into her mouth, their names a mystery but their colours and flavours a delight. Some burst with bright juices on her tong, while others were so sour that her eyes teared, but not unpleasantly.

When finally her hand absently grasped one of the hard cased things, she drew it up and held it up between them with a question in her eyes, she knew that there was no way that she could bite through that, maybe Catra with her predators teeth could. Adora had seen her bite through bone before.

Catra reached forward and took it from her place hand before encasing it in her fist and squeezing. Adora watched, mesmerised as the well developed muscles in the cat-girl's hand and forearm bunched and the thing in her hand made a crunching sound. With a satisfied smirk, the furred hand opened, palm up, revealing the dark outer case of the thing split apart, revealing a pale ball. The hand was thrust towards her, mismatched eyes watching expectantly. Tentatively she picked up the thing that had been revealed and popped it in her mouth, chewing carefully. It was

tasty in a way different to the fruit. It was strangely waxy and crunchy with no juice but it made her mouth water. She hummed in pleasure and the kitten in her lap wriggled with happiness at a job well done.

Adora reached for another of the strange things, this time taking it in her own fist and trying to break it open. She squeezed first with one fist, then both together, until her face grew red with exertion and still it stayed stubbornly one solid pieces. Giving up she passed it back for Catra to break and then devoured several more as quickly as her friend could break them.

Belly comfortably full, Adora again let herself consider the physical changes between the two of them. Catra was smaller and slighter than her and yet her muscles seemed to be stronger than their size would suggest and her hand in particular were very powerful. No matter how hard she trained, Adora's were strong but would never possess the raw power needed to crush bone or propel herself through the trees. Adora knew that she would grow bigger and stronger, she was already one of the strongest cadets in her year, but she would never be a predator.

Catching the other girls eyes, they smiled shyly at each other, neither knowing why.

"Want me to teach you a game?"

Much later, after a very confusing game of eye-spy, one of the few games that all of the children of the Horde picked up from each other, the rain had finally stopped and the pair of them stepped out into the chilly air of the murky afternoon light. The ground around the monolith was surprisingly dry. Puddles dotted here and there and yet the ground was not sodden and boggy as she had expected. A lot of things around the towering structure were odd, but Adora was twelve and so didn't have the where withal to dwell on such things.

Both children needed to stretch, Adora bent double and touched her toes, feeling the muscles in her legs work as she moved. Standing back up she noticed that Catra was watching her and copying her motions, except where Adora could touch her toes, Catra could comfortable place her palms flat on the ground. Adora continued with the callisthenics that she had been taught, while the fired girl lost interest in that and began to bound around the clearing, soon using her claws to fly up the trunk on a tree.

Watching her, Adora realised that she felt more deeply for this child who she saw only fleeting every four months, than for any of her bunk mates whom she had spent each day with since they were five years old. A pang of guilt blossomed in her chest as she realised that she had not even speared a thought for the other three from her team. They had all been forced to make their own way in the rain, she imagined that Rogelio and Lonnie had managed to find cover but Kyle had probably spent a miserable night soaked to the bone.

Just as the girl was about to spiral into a pit of self recrimination she was hit between the eyes with a seed pod. She flinch back and rubbed at the small red spot it had left before looking up, huffily, at the grinning cat disappearing further up in the tree.

“Come Adora,” the retreating figure called, ensuring she made enough disruption in the treetops that her human companion would be able to follow.

Compelled to keep up with Catra, Adora quickly reached down and scooped up the seed, grasping it tightly in her hand as she jogged through the trees under her guide. The rough casing of the seed felt comforting in her hand, a reminder that one of these was how the cub had first made contact with her. She hadn’t known it at first, but once she had the words Catra had told her about that morning when she was eight and asleep at her post.

The second time Adora's cadet troop had gone to the Whispering Woods she had just turned nine, it almost felt like this training exercise was to celebrate that. The weather had been warm, spring rolling into summer with sleepy ease and each of the four children had felt excitement course through them to be free of the Fright Zone's darkness.

This time their group had been matched up with a brigade of older cadets, six in total, all between fourteen and sixteen. These cadets were on the cusp of adulthood, a couple even heading towards Force Captain positions of their own. Adora had been working her whole life to emulate soldiers like these, to make Shadow Weaver's absolute faith in her justified. Her guardian had told her to stay close to the oldest of the trainees and observe them, to keep focused. She had vowed that she would, but as the forest had grown closer her thoughts strayed to the cat-girl she had caught a glimpse of last time.

Little Adora had tried to keep focused on the various tasks and assignments she was given, but everybody noticed that she was unusually sloppy, her eyes straying to the trees over and over. The oldest two of the group they were trailing, Octavia and Scorpia, couldn't be different in their approach their new wards. Octavia was brash and sharp with no time for mistakes, deeming Adora next to useless after the end of the first day, wondering why Shadow Weaver favoured her so. Scorpia was a softer soul, the younger of the two, she towered over everybody but still had the look of a child with her doughy physique and face not yet sculpted to adulthood. She tried to give Adora a chance to do better.

And Adora had done better after that, because the first night she managed to sneak back into the woods through the same spot as before. Unencumbered by the heavy jacket of before, she easily got through the gap and stepped into the clearing. There was no guard duty for the younger children. This time round, so she could look for as long as she needed, as long as she was back by morning.

Her thoughts had been immediately derailed when she had turned Witcher flashlight in hand, only to come face to face with the very girl she was thinking about standing barely a metre away. The haunting mismatched eyes regarded her with calm curiosity as she stared back, mesmerised. The glimpse she had caught of the smaller child last time before she scurried away had just shown her that it was a girl and part animal, but now she could see that she was small, almost delicate looking with fur that almost seemed amber in the torchlight. The fur spilled over her entire body, revealing striped patterns down her arms and across her stomach and legs. Blue eyes caught movement and noticed the tail that seemed to twitch and move with a life of its own. It was the massive ears that jutted comically from either side of the bush of hair on top of her head that really fascinated the human girl as she saw them move and twitch with each sound that came and went from the clearing.

"Hello," Adora whispered, desperate not to make this forest spirit run away again.

The cat-girl cocked her head to the side and scrutinised her with unblinking eyes. Maybe she couldn't speak? In fact, the girl realised, it would make more sense that she couldn't. Maybe she was an animal that just happened to look like a girl. Then those eyes blinked at her slowly, the ears twitched and a noise left the furred throat.

"Hello." It was gravelly, distorted and clearly strange in the creatures mouth but it made Adora's face bloom into a beaming smile.

The warm memories of their first real meeting nestled in her chest as she continued to follow her wild one through the forest, trying not to get her boots stuck in too much boggy mud on her way. It hadn't taken her long to realise that the reason Catra had taken to the trees was because she hadn't wanted to be covered in mud.

She hoped that they were getting close to their destination, her stomach was beginning to rumble even after all the fruit.

Her thoughts were answered when Catra landed with a dull thud on the ground just ahead, reaching back with one hand, waiting for the warm feel of Adora's to slip into its grasp before pulling her out into yet another small clearing. It was like the Whispering Woods was full of tiny pockets between the almost impenetrable trees. Adora had heard the older soldiers talk about how the labour of the woods seemed to move at will, something here one day and gone the next, but she had never seen any evidence of that while she was with Catra.

At the centre of this place there was a ramshackle hut, covered in vines and looking like it had grown from the roots of the trees that it sat beside. From within Adora realised she could hear the sound of somebody moving around and the occasional muffled word, and was that hum?

Unexpectedly Catra pulled her directly towards the hut with careless abandon. The blond had never known her friend to approach anybody but her so was deeply curious about who, or what, might live here. Beside the window there was a lidded box which the cat reached for, opening it and pulling out a bolt of cloth. She shook it, releasing Adora's hand, as she pulled it over her head, revealing it to be a long night shift. It was so odd to see the feline clothed that it almost made her do a double take.

Grinning, Catra grasped her hadn't again and they walked into the hut as she called, "We here Razz."

"Wildling! Come let me see you!" A tiny woman, so old that Adora had no way to categorise it from her own experiences, turned towards them. Her wild, white hair stood around her head in a mane as wild as Catra's own, and her eyes blinked owlishly from behind thick spectacles.

Catra dropped Adora's hand and walked over to the lady, a deep purr rumbling from her chest as she wound her body around her

and wove around her body in a much more cat-like way than Adora was used to seeing. There were a few cats dotted around the Fright Zone, lured in by the abundance of mice and other vermin, and she had petted a few, had enjoyed it when they wove around her hand or between her legs to show affection. Now she was watching as her friend did the same. The old woman patting her affectionately on the head until she finally seemed to notice the other girl standing self consciously in the door way.

“You’re very early Mara.”

Razz

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You're very early Mara."

Adora wasn't sure what to say. Who was Mara and why did this old woman think that was who she was? Before she could think of what to say; she couldn't question the woman or tell her she was wring, twelve years of being under Shadow Weavers thumb had made her more than respectful to adults, older women in particular, Catra was laughing that rusty hinge laugh of hers.

"Not Mara, Razz." She bounded back to the blonds side and pulled her further into the cozy hut. "This my Adora. I tell you bout her, remember?" She smiled broadly, fangs dipping her lower lip. Adora couldn't speak for a completely different reason now, Catra had called her 'her Adora'. It made a spark of something flare in her young chest, so rather than words she gave a dopey little wave.

"Ah, Adora now is it? It isn't when I thought, but I am always glad to see you dearie." The way the white haired woman spoke was unusual, and a little confusing, but the cadet liked it. It was nothing like her mentor's.

The cub led her friend over to a threadbare armchair that faced the fire, its twin standing opposite and pushed her down into its depths before she made her way back to Razz and took her wizened hand, pulling her to join them. Catra was gentle with the small woman, in a way that she wasn't with Adora. It wasn't that she was rough, exactly, with the human child, but sometimes her claws would come out in excitement, or her strong hands would grip too hard.

Once Razz was settled at the fireplace, the feline sat on the floor at her feet and rested her head on a red clad knee where

withered hands made their way to the top of her head to pet at the thick fur like hair there, even running over her ears. Catra purred unselfconsciously as her mismatched eyes grew half lidded and far away. Adora felt like an intruder; watching something that the adult and child had done many times to be so comfortable. Yet, it warmed her to know that her friend was not as alone in the world as she had feared.

"Wildling," Catra's eyes snapped open at the word the accented voice used for her. "Would you go and collect old Razz some of those nuts you found me last time?"

Catra nodded with a smile, and looked over at Adora. "Those things with the tough case! Nuts, Adora! They called nuts!" The beaming smile on her face was infectious and Adora found herself repeating that word back. "Come Adora!"

The other girl went to stand from her chair, but a bony hand was suddenly clutching her wrist, guiding her to stay in the seat. Catra looked back from the entrance with a puzzled quirk to her head, gaze travelling from one of the humans to the other.

"You go Wildling, I want to spend a little time with Adora here. Now shoo, go fetch nuts for an old woman." When Adora nodded and smiled at Razz's words, she disappeared through the curtain and was gone into the woods.

Adora's eyes stayed on the curtain for a while, something felt strangely ominous about being here without the furred girl. Not dangerous, but no longer comforting, The old woman was looking at her intensely through her thick glasses, eyes huge and very knowing. The child was almost startled when Razz began to talk.

"The Wildling is small sometimes, when she comes. Ears and fluff and giggles. Such a sweet child. Other times she isn't. Sometimes when Razz sees her she is not the Wildling, she is Catra." She seemed to notice that Adora looked puzzled. "Then she is angry and full of hate. Dressed like you, but not like you." The woman

looked even older for a moment, as if that were even possible. “Sometimes old Razz is very afraid.”

Adora couldn’t understand what she was being told. How could this old woman know Catra when she was a grown up? They were both children. She couldn’t even comprehend a world where her best friend, and she was even though they saw each other so infrequently, would be in a Horde uniform or angry. She was the softest person she knew.

Silence stretched between them, and the girl though that Razz had fallen asleep by the fire when a hand shot out to rest on her knee. She met that penetrating stare for a second time, blinking owlishly; wondering whether there had been a question that she was supposed to answer.

“Sometimes you are older too.”

“I…” before the girl could formulate a response, and really what response could she give to this woman who seemed to know the future and the past, who seemed to know her but be confused by who she was, a blur whizzed into the room.

Now unclothed as she was used to, the shift filled with nuts, Catra looked very pleased with herself. She once again fell to her knees beside Razz and offered up her haul in some kind of tribute. Razz smiled fondly and ran her hadn’t back across the top of the child’s head, accepting the make shift bag into her lap.

“Clothes in the house, kitten.” Something in Adora stuttered and for a moment she felt very sad. Those words in that tone meant something more, something unidentifiable to the cadet. Sometimes Shadow Weavers voice would sound similar, the words almost identical, but there was always an edge of reproach not softness.

They stayed a little while longer, eating nuts and no more strange words were said.

As they were leaving, a small satchel of nuts for Adora held in Catra's clawed grasp, Razz reached up and patted both girls on the cheek.

"Come back soon for pie, Mara dear."

A shiver ran up the blond's spine at hearing that name again.

Back in the cave, bellies filled with warm meat and berries that they had scavenged and hunted along the way home, Adora had nailed a bird with a small knife all the cadets were given on exercise and was particularly pleased with herself, they cuddled together on the bedroll. It was't night yet, but the rain clouds were quickly overtaking the sky once more, the brief fire they had been able to light for cooking Adora's meal would soon be put out.

"Catra, when did you find Razz?" After the old woman had mentioned a much smaller feline, Adora had grown curious.

"When the big ones went away." The cub was stretched out on her back, eyes closed as her tail flickered around, tickling her bedmate as it passed her by, seemingly unbothered by the conversation.

The blond turned onto her side, propping her head up on her hand so she could look down at the other girls face. "Catra, do you mean your parents?" Parents were a strange concept to the Horde cadet. As far as she knew she had been under the care of Shadow Weaver since she was a baby. Often the child recruits were handed over after battles or taken when they were toddlers. She had heard people like that talk about remembering 'parents'. Had even asked about them and been told that they were the adults that children lived with and who raised them. After that revelation she had asked Shadow Weaver if she were her mother

and been coldly scolded for such childish notions (she had been six at the time).

“Think that what Razz said. They were bigger. Look like the things in the wood that run on all their legs. No,” she moved her thumbs, “these. Not faces like you and me.” She reached over and patted the furless face beside her with a soft smile, even as her eyes stayed closed.

“You mean,” Adora wasn’t really sure what she was asking. “You mean that they were like the animals in the woods. They weren’t like you?”

“No one like me,” it was said so low that if she hadn’t been watching her friends face Adora wasn’t sure she would have heard it.

“How can you know that?” Sure, the blond had never seen anyone among the ranks of the Horde who looked like her friend but it didn’t mean she was alone.

“Light Hope.” Odd eyes blinked open, finally, to fix her with a troubled look.

“Light Hope told you?”

“Said I a,” here she paused, obviously trying to grasp at a word she had heard maybe once before and hadn’t understood, “mutt. Mountain made me. Nobody else. Why she comes to me.”

Clearly the illusive Light Hope knew more than he had told the cat girl. Mutt didn’t seem like the right word, Adora resolved that she would find some way to find out what her friend was. She was made by the mountain and her parens were normal animals - she was sure she could find out more about what she was back at the Fright Zone.

She pulled the smaller girl into her arms, feeling her curl into her own body. It was still early but the two children rarely got to sleep long hours; one because of duty and the other out of fear. As the

rain outside finally broke free from the clouds and the patter began to once again film the cave, they relaxed together. This time tomorrow Adora would need to be back with her group and Catra would be alone in her cave again, but for now they could take comfort in each others warmth and the beating of hearts that needed each other more than they knew.

Darkness shrouded the forest. The dead of night wrapped the sleeping children in its soft embrace, the ethereal glow that suffused the cave intensified for a moment and then was lowered again.

A figure stood, body partially engulfed in stone, eyes fixed on the larger of the two who slept before it. The stare was cold and intense, taking in every line of her face. Recording. Documenting. Assessing.

It was not the first time those eyes had set their sights on that face. This time the girl would not be lost to it. The animal would make sure of that.

In a handful of years, their destiny would be fulfilled.

A cold smile suffused the otherwise still face as the figure disappeared into the wall once again.

Morning came hot and bright, the humidity left in the air from two days of rain suffocating. Adora woke with a sheen of sweat over her skin and Catra's fur sticking to her and starting to itch. She rolled away from the gently snoring cat and threw back the blanket before sitting up with her back against the glowing blue wall. It was cool against her skin, making a shiver run up her spine and the hair on her arms stand on end. Today she would have to make her way back to base camp. She didn't want to go!

She let her head fall back to thud gently against the surface behind her. That wasn't true, she did want to go home, much as she loved it here she missed her bunk and the familiar sights and sounds of home. She missed the sound of Shadow Weavers voice and the way that the eyes of her mast would squint when she was pleased with something that Adora had done. It wasn't that she wanted to stay here; it was that she wanted to stay with Catra. More than once, she had considered asking her feline friend to come back to the Fright Zone with her. Surely the Horde would love a creature like Catra, her speed and strength, her claws that could cut through far more than flesh.

No, she didn't ask because she knew that Catra would hate it. Hate the noise. Hate the smell. Hate wearing a uniform and following orders. She was a forest creature; when they had been small Adora had even wondered if she made up the furry girl in her imagination. She was the spirit of the trees, the howl of the wind. Bringing her back to the Fright Zone would be like putting a moth in a jar and watching it flap futility at the glass until its wings broke and it suffocated.

Adora would go back. She would continue to become the best soldier that she could be. There would be more field exercises and more chances to see her friend and, she vowed to herself, when she was Force Captain, she would be able to bring a skiff out here any time she wanted.

Trying to shake off the strange melancholy, the child moved to pull on her clothes and repack supplies into her bag. The tinkling sound of the metal zippers finally made the cat stir, stretching until her joints popped and her mouth opening in a wide, sharp yawn. Big, hopeful eyes fluttered open as she looked around for Adora, catching sight of her in the corner by her small alcove.

"What doing, Adora?" It seemed so strange to see the human child putting her things away.

"I have to go back today Catra, I'm expected to get back in good time. As it is I know that we're much closer now than when they

dropped me off.” Colour suffused her cheeks as she felt the shame of cheating creep up her spine. She wouldn’t change the last couple of days for anything, but while she had been well fed, clean and dry, her companions had probably all had the worst days of their life. The least she could do would be to get back early.

“I take you.” She was crouched on all fours now, having sprung up among the blankets and was gently bouncing, ears and tail twitching merrily, not picking up on the dour mood of her friend.

“I can’t let you. I have to make it back by myself.” Adora didn’t make eye contact, just tucked away some of the nuts and berries that they still had.

There was a low sound from the blankets, like a low, keening growl that spoke more of disappointment than any words could. With a sigh Adora went back to the bed and sat down with Catra, wrapping and arm around her shoulders and drawing her in for a hug.

“I’ll be back in the spring, you can show me all of the new things that grow then. Maybe we can even see Razz again?” It seemed like such a long way away when she said it out loud but she received a smile and a nod in return.

Leaving the blankets and bedroll in the cave, Adora squeezed back out into the world. The heat was even more oppressive out here. Catra followed, flicking here eyes back and forth between the blond girl and the cave entrance, a question clear in her eyes.

“I’m leaving the blanket and the bedroll for your. It’ll keep you warmer in the winter, you told me you got cold now you sleep in the big area, remember?”

She was unprepared for the fast moving ball of fur that tackled her onto her back, leaving carat crouched over her. Clawed hands draped her shoulders as a sharp featured face lowered down to rub against her jaw and let out a little purr.

They stayed together until the day moon reached its peak, Adora knew that she couldn't be more than a couple of hours away from camp. They laughed and tussled and tried not to be sad. When it was time for her to leave, still insistently alone, Catra was at least allowed to point her in the right direction.

Shouldering her pack she set out into the trees.

Unsurprisingly Adora was the first cadet back by a solid six hours. Her early return and good condition made her lorded by the older cadets. Scorpia gave her a hearty hug while even Octavia cracked a congratulatory grin. She pulled some of the nuts out of her back and explained that she had seen animals eating them, not strictly a lie and Hordak knew that Adora was not a good liar, and offered them to the older cadets. Some had scavenged them before, while others seemed childishly excited to try the treat. It further solidified her as someone to be given their respect.

When Lonnie appeared through the trees at nightfall, Rogelio close behind, they too were congratulated. So far as a team they had made their way back in almost record time. If Kyle could return by morning they would receive a commendation. If Kyle made it back.

Adora was almost able to put Catra out of her mind, so exciting was the atmosphere back in camp, full of the anticipation of success. Almost.

None of them were really expecting Kyle to get back in time. They knew he was their weak link. They all cared for each other and though taking care of Kyle could be frustrating he had a good heart and kind disposition that the group needed. He was good at some things, they would throw all their paperwork at him and he would do it well. Physically though, he had yet to blossom. Imagine the surprise of the entire group when, shortly before dawn, Kyle stumbled from the trees as if pushed, looking as confused to be back as they were to see him.

After a moments hesitation Adora and Lonnie let out a whoop of excitement as Rogelio rushed past them to lift the skinny boy onto his shoulders and runs a little victory lap around the tents.

Chapter End Notes

So, all that warm fluffy goodness is about to take a dark turn...
Something wicked this way comes.

Home

Scarlett robed arms lifted and red magic crackled along grey-green fingertips, igniting the scry and revealing a crystal clear image of a smiling blond face. The scope of the vision expanded out from the blond child, encompassing the whole of the glade where the skiff sat. White eyes tracked the movements of another of her favourites, Octavia, as she rested a hand proudly on Adora's shoulder and the smaller girl bloomed at the obvious praise that was being showered on her. Shadow Weaver did not bother to hear the words, she already knew that the blond foundling was the best cadet she had ever seen, she had made sure of that from the moment the babe had been placed in her arms and she had felt a wash of power from her.

The sorceress continued to hold the scry, even as she worked her way through the mind numbing paperwork that was the curse of being second in command of the Horde. Hours passed as she noted the dark girl and the lizard come out of the woods. A good time. If only the scrawny one would pull himself together they could have the best times of any group before them. Not for the first time she wondered why she had not illuminated the blond boy, he was sickly, weak and clumsy. And yet… Perhaps it was because he looked so like her favourite, they could almost be twins. She shook her head at her own sentimentality, Adora was a means to an ends and nothing more, getting back to reviewing reports.

As dawn's light endeavoured to weakly break the horizon, the witch considered stopping to get some rest, but the embrace of sleep had long since lost its appeal. A few moments with the source of her powers and she would feel rejuvenated in a way that sleep could never offer. Standing from her desk, the tall woman stretched the kink out of her back and allowed her eyes to once again focus on the group of children, still three when they should be four. Adora's opportunity to be at the top brought low by others. It firmed Shadow Weaver's resolve that she should continue to push the child to isolate herself from her peers.

Raising her hand to call a stop to the vision, it halted in mid air as she caught sight of movement high up in the trees. The swaying of the branches on the windless morning drawing her focus, it was too much to be caused by a bird or squirrel. Something far larger was there, watching the group. Her eyes squinted, moving her fingers to focus the vision on that area. As suddenly as it had begun the swaying of the canopy ceased, but a ripple in the air remained. She felt the same sensation as when she was close to Adora, that frisson of a power not quite of this world.

Before she could ponder further, she was shocked to see the boy stumble out of the trees beneath where the disturbance had been. He was filthy and wet from head to toe but had, miraculously managed to fall into the clearing with enough time to make an obvious cheer go up from all of the cadets, young and old.

Adora remained the best.

Triumphantly, the quartet arrived back at The Fright Zone, feeling like they could single handedly take on every princess out there. The skiff ride back had been bathed in hazy light; shimmering pools of rainwater dotted the wasteland between the woods and home, like jewels for the victors. Adora and her team were riding high on the praise of their elders. Lonnie had been tucked into a group of the older cadets, while Rogelio and Kyle had huddled together to reconnect. Adora had noticed that the blond boy was especially animated as he related something to his lizard companion; she wondered what that was about.

Adora had been the first to jump from the skiff, eager to share her success with her mentor. Each force captain she passed on her way saluted her, some winked, and for a moment the girl could see the future she had been promised get tantalisingly close. Her desire to get to her mentor grew stronger as she began to run through the corridors as she had as a child. She had always looked up to Shadow Weaver, wishing only to the woman happy and proud. Sometimes she wished she could see her face, always

obscured by the mask, to know for sure that when white eyes squinted just-so it was the smile that she thought it was.

Talking with Catra about parents had brought that old ache for Shadow Weaver to be 'mother' back but the young blond knew better than to ever bring it up again. Even if 'mentor' and 'mother' were so close in her mind. Her mind flittered to the cat-girl for a moment and a different part of her heart stuttered. She missed her already, more than she ever had after a meeting. The days and nights together had been warm and comforting, something that she had never had before. She longed for it again after only a day apart.

Soon her feet brought her to the familiar corridor leading to the Black Garnet chamber. Realising that her joyful trek through the woods, coupled with the skiff-ride and her rush to the room had undoubtedly left her a rumpled mess. Shadow Weaver wouldn't approve, no matter how well she had done and she wanted nothing to but that praise. Even though she wasn't sure, deep down, that it was earned.

Detouring to the locker room, the child quickly shucked out of her dirty uniform, throwing it into the laundry shoot and quickly wiggling into the clean set in her locker. She threw water on her face and hands to get rid of the dirt and quickly retied her pony tail. Staring at her own reflection, she saw Chief Cadet Adora, Shadow Weavers protege. Gone was the wild girl fro the woods. She missed her but she knew she had to fulfil her destiny to lead the Horde to victory over the princess and free all of Etheria. After that, maybe she would be able to run free with Catra.

With slower, more controlled steps Adora made her way to the Black Garnet Chamber and walked inside. She was greeted with the dull, red tinged light cast out by the mystic stone. The room was always a bastion of shadowed corners and unseen spots where anything could hide. Adora knew that the other cadets feared this place and it's darkness but to the girl it felt like home. Walking to the desk, she took her position at parade rest and waited to be seen, to be noticed.

Minutes ticket by as she waited, mind drifting back to the woods and another room bathed in an otherworldly light. She was tired, pale eyes heavy lidded, and her body craved sleep beginning to sway slightly even as she fought to stay upright. A movement at her back made the child stiffen, drawing up to her full height from her exhausted slump. A long fingered hand settled on her shoulder and she was guided round to come face-to-face with her guardian.

"Do you have something to tell me cadet?" The voice purred from behind the mask with its familiar hypnotic drawl.

Adora was sure that Shadow Weaver knew what she had accomplished, she always did. Yet, so far, she had never seemed to know what happened in the woods. It was as through they passed a veil across the sorceresses view. Adora hoped that was still true. She wasn't ready to share Catra with her mentor and she was a terrible liar.

"My team has recorded the best time for field manoeuvres. I managed to return in less than three days and Kyle made it back before sunrise. He is doing a lot better." Adora was a good leader, the older woman recognised that, she gave those under command the opportunity to succeed and rendered praise. It was the overly kind hearted part of her nature that would need to be curbed.

"Well done, Adora," the long fingered hand moved from her shoulder to cup her cheek. "You have proved that our training and hard work has all been for the best. Remember, I look to you to become the saviour of this planet." The words were so large to burden the shoulders of somebody so young, but Adora's sense of self sacrifice had emerged early and meant that keeping her under the witch's thrall was far easier.

The young face, still soft with baby fat, split into a happy grin as the child relaxed into the touch. Even though the girl seemed pleased, Shadow Weaver sensed something not right about her energy, there was something new there. Something that she had felt before but was growing stronger. It may just be how she

would manifest the power that the older woman had always known was there; it may be puberty. But it was certainly something that needed to be watched.

_____

Walking into her team's barracks, she was greeted by a sudden hush falling over the three pre-teens that were already there. Kyle was sat squeezed between the two larger youths on his bunk, glancing up at her furtively through his shaggy blond hair.

"Hi Adora!" His voice was too perky, cracking at the end of her name. The other two remained silent.

"Hi Kyle, guys, why're you all being so weird?" Adora walked over to her own bunk, opposite the occupied one, and allowed herself to collapsed cross legged onto it. She gratefully pulled off her boots as she waited for somebody to speak.

Rogelio's guttural growls softly filled the silence as he spoke too quietly make out into Kyle's ear. Lonnie kept her cool gaze trained on her commander, clearly worried about what her reaction might be to whatever was happening here. Finally Kyle nodded and took a deep breath.

"Adora, something helped me in the woods! I was going round in circles for days and I knew that I was lost." He swallowed and she watched his new Adam's apple bob, his eyes glazing with tears. "I was sure I wasn't going to make it back and that I'd be left for dead!" A tear slid down his face and Lonnie turned to him and wiped it away.

"Don't cry Kyle! I wouldn't have let that happen," and the blond girl meant it.

He gave her a watery smile before he carried on, "Something found me that last morning. It was in the trees, I could feel it watching me. I was so scared, but it just threw some food at me. Them it growled that I should come and I followed it. I followed it all the way to camp; I'd been so close Adora! I would never have

made it by myself. I only saw it once, when we got to the edge, I couldn't find a way through and then this furry girl was in front of me. She had these amazing eyes," His eyes moved around all three of his companions, "and she was a cat! She pushed me out of the woods as if she knew we were running out of time."

Adora felt fear well up in her chest, she could barely breath. Nobody could know about Catra, not yet. The cat-girl would never survive if they went out and caught her, she wasn't someone who could be caged. She had to make sure that the boy wouldn't say anything.

"Kyle, that's amazing!" She tried to sound happy and authoritative at the same time.

"You believe him?" Lonnie looked incredulous but pleased.

"Of course! Why wouldn't I?" The other three sagged with relief. "But we shouldn't tell anybody else. If they think that Kyle can't fend for himself they might send him away…" She searched her mind for the worst fate imaginable, "to the mines. We best keep it between the four of us." The other nodded, stricken at the very plausible idea.

Adora let out a gusty sigh that the others took for exhaustion but was actually relief. Typically she was a terrible liar, but it seemed the fear and selfishness made her much more adept. She hoped that she would be able to keep Catra's existence in this room for at least a little longer.

Crystal Castle

Chapter Summary

What is Catra?

Chapter Notes

Slightly shorter one today - mostly a little interlude to start putting my ducks in a row before they get messily knocked down.

Catra woke up feeling disorientated and exhausted. It had been a full turn of the night moon since Adora had left and she had helped the weak one, still two more to go before she could see her friend again. Her nights had been restless, even though she had the soft cushion of the bedroll and the comfort of the blanket which still held the scent of the other girl. It was as though the idea of loneliness had burrowed itself into her head and her heart and she felt very alone inside the cave that had given her sanctuary all her life. Many mornings she had woken feeling grumpy and sad, but not like this.

Finally managing deciding to open her eyes and greet the day, she snapped then closed again when she was engulfed in a searing white light. Squeezing them tightly together, she considered what could be going on. Was it the mountain? Sometimes it glowed brighter in the cave, especially when Light Home came to see her.

"Light Hope?" The words left her lips feebly, the fear in them clear as her voice trembled.

"Yes, child; open your eyes." The cool, melodic voice reached out from the light and Catra could not help but do as it commanded. There had always been something about that voice that she seemed unable to resist.

Bracing herself for the burning of the light, her dual coloured eyes blinked rapidly to allay the tears she felt stinging there from the

still too bright whiteness. Gradually, her vision began to clear and she could make out the shape of the room and Light Hope's place in it. It was definitely not her cave and the hairs all over her body began to spike up in fear at the realisation. The room around her was vast, the walls and ceiling too far away to touch and everywhere filled with the same glowing lines and patterns that she could not understand which adorned the outside of the mountain.

Was she 'inside' the mountain? How was that possible? She had lived beside the monolith her entire life and knew that there was no way in, no opening or crack beyond the symbols and they afforded no purchase, she had tried. More than once, when she was first left alone, she had driven tiny claws into the fissures and pulled with all her might until her fingers ached and her claws bled. She had not been foolish enough to make that mistake a second time when it meant that her belly went empty for several days while her hands healed. Although, as she cast her eyes around the room, noting the reflective surfaces, pyramids of metal and Light Hope standing on a raised platform, it didn't seem like she could be anywhere else.

"Where…" It slipped out even though she knew.

"You are inside the Crystal Castle, my child. It was finally time to bring you inside," her emotionless face and melodic voice were no longer soothing to the cub, not after spending so much time with the genuine human warmth of Adora and Razz. Now it just felt foreign to her ears, ironic considering most of the language she had she had learned from this being.

"Why now?" Why not before when she was small and cold and so, so afraid? Why not when she had been bitten by the snake or fallen from the tree and not able to breath properly for days? Catra wasn't sure what this feeling in her chest was. She knew the soft emotions well; care and affection, Razz and Adora doled those out in large quantities. She knew fear and pain, the things that kept her alive and alert. No, it was none of those, this was

something new that sat in her chest and grew the more she looked around this warm sheltered place. Adora would know.

"You are ready to know your true purpose." The girl wasn't sure what a purpose was but the words made her ears fold close to her head. "You have solidified your bond with the chosen one; you have brought her here and will again when the time is right." The words were too complicated, the ideas unclear in the mind of the wild one and her eyes darted around the room looking for some kind of escape.

"I…" the word slipped out of her mouth but any others became stuck in her throat and she felt choked on them.

"Come, I shall show you what you are to do." Catra's mind screamed at her not to follow but her feet complied and she could not stop herself.

The spectral woman led them through rooms and chambers with pulsing eyes sitting in the shadows, waiting. Even as she moved her mismatched cat eyes squinted into the darkness but could see nothing more of the things that lay in wait. She did not feel safe here. Light Hope no longer felt like something familiar and welcome.

Almost without her noticing they were outside in the forest again, it felt wrong. The air tasted of something unnatural and the wind felt alive like needles on her skin. Yet still she followed. They were soon in a clearing she had never seen before, roots twisted out of the ground in snarled fingers and mossy curtains hung down around them, cloaking the place in mystery.

The thing that drew all of her attention, every ounce of focus, was sat at the centre gleaming like a beacon. It was shiny, shinier even than the mountain she had lived beside all her life. A jewel sat at one end and her hands itched to reach out and touch the horn like protuberance at the top.

“This is why you were made. You are the guardian of the sword and its wielder. In time you will lead her to this place and you will ensure that she takes the sword, accepts all its gifts. She will save all of Etheria.” Catra had no idea what Etheria was, but she was sure that the girl she spoke of was Adora, who else could it be?

“Don’t understand!” It was a word she had learned from Adora.

“You don’t need to yet. You have much to learn.”

Want

Chapter Notes

> Not edited but a bigger update than usual as I missed a week.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's skin was crawling with anticipation. The world outside was unusually hot for the time of year, so much so that even in the Fright Zone felt it, some of the perpetual smog melted away by the natural heat. It was once again time for her to go back to the woods and nothing could have stopped her, not even Hordak himself. Four months ago they had arrived at the same location as always and set up their tents, this time as the previous exercises most successful group they were put in charge of two other squads of cadets swelling their ranks to twelve. They had not be accompanied by an adult or older cadets, just themselves. It had been a three day mission, with the only instruction to survive in camp together.

Adora had excelled in command. The tent village had been much larger, and she had set them in a semi-circle facing the trees in case of attack. The rotation for night watch had meant that no cadet had to be on watch more than once due to their high numbers. They had eaten rations, played games and bonded as Adora was sure they were supposed to do.

As always, Adora had snuck away each night in search of her feline friend only to be left bitterly disappointed as the clearing remained still and empty except for her. On the last night she had even tried walking further into the woods, getting so far as they stream but there had still been no sign of the other girl. She had considered delving further into the woods but fear of getting lost had made her turn tail and head back to camp.

Since then she had been counting down the days until she could search for her friend again. She hoped that nothing had happened to the smaller girl, that fear had sat in the pit of her stomach ever since she found out that Kyle had seen her. What if one of the other groups of trainees had found out and hunted her down? Or Catra had misjudged which group it was and been shot by an over zealous instructor? Bile crept to the back of her throat whenever she considered the possibility so she refused to believe it. Kyle swore he had only told the three of them about the cat-girl and she believed him.

They had packed themselves onto a skiff, the same group of twelve as before spread across three skiffs. Adora's brow crinkled as she realised that they had only used two skiffs last time. Maybe they were taking more supplies? She turned to Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle who were seated beside her, ready to ask what they thought when she felt the temperature of the room cool significantly and the lights dimmed. That could only mean one thing.

Shadow Weaver walked into the hanger, each of the dozen teens jumping to attention in the presence of their commanding officer. The imposing woman waved a hand, indicating that the cadets should all return to what they had been doing, most retaking their positions as the three pilots took their spots at the controllers. Shadow Weaver glided from vehicle to vehicle, appearing to check their preparedness. Adora's eyes followed her every move. This was unprecedented.

Then she was standing beside Adora's group and beckoned the blond to join her. The wordless gesture was a command that she was used to, so without question Adora jumped down from the skiff and joined her mentor who led her away to the corner of the hanger. Once there, she loomed over the girl.

"Adora, this is your second command in as many missions. I was pleased with the reports I received back from your last two expeditions," Adora felt her chest puff up and colour flood her cheeks at the praise. "I wish to see for myself. I will be joining

you.” She saw the girl’s eyes widen in shock. “Now, now, I won’t spoil your fun. I am a busy woman, I shall be there for part of each day but have my own work.” There was clear sarcasm in her voice, it sounded cloying and made Adora uncomfortable.

“Having you with us will just make us even better Shadow Weaver, we aren’t there for fun after all.” She hoped that she had said the right thing, but worried that she had suggested that Shadow Weaver was a wet blanket.

“Good. I will expect nothing but the best then.” She turned, robes swirling around her as the shadows that hugged her rippled and seemed to carry her away.

Adora felt oddly dejected as she trudged back to her spot on the skiff. All her ideas about hunting for Catra would be a lot more difficult now. Hopefully Shadow Weaver would see whatever she was looking for quickly and not return. Adora wasn’t sure why, she just knew that she didn’t want Shadow Weaver to see the cat-girl.

Catra was exhausted, she knew that she should stay away from the cadets, not seek out Adora as she always did. Her limbs felt heavy, following her instructions just a little later than they normally would. It had been half a year since she had last seen the blond girl, Light Hope had kept the cub so busy with physical training and learning information about The Sword that she had missed the last training rotation and her heart ached at the loss. So, no matter how lethargic she felt, how loose and precarious her grip on the trees around her, she was going to at least get a glimpse of her.

She wondered if the other girl had missed her. Unlike Catra, Adora was always surrounded by other people and there was every possibility that she didn’t miss the cub as the cub missed her. Maybe she had even forgotten about her, which would put a wrench in Light Hope’s plans for the future. The idea of being left behind and forgotten clawed at Catra often in the last few weeks.

Seeing Adora at set intervals had been a way to measure the passing of her life, and without it she had felt adrift, even though the hologram (a new word taught to her as part of her training) told her that this was her purpose.

The feline had been watching the skies for days, her inner sense of time telling her that it must be close to the Horde's arrival. Other groups came and went, Catra ignoring them as unimportant, sensing that Adora was not among them but her body had been screaming at her to find her. Last night she had sat in the trees, deliberately avoiding her cave so as not to find herself waking up back inside the Crystal Castle. She had woken to the sounds of skiff engines and the fur on her neck and shoulders standing on end as though every fibre of her being knew it was Adora coming and was reaching out to her.

Swinging from one tree to the next, Catra barely managed to grasp the branch she went for, feeling the terrifying lurch in her stomach as her body began to plummet until her claws found purchase in the wood and her body followed the swing of her momentum back to safety. Pausing to take a few gulping breaths, she felt her heart beat slow back to normal. She thought that maybe, as much as her exhaustion, some of her physical problems might be caused by her sudden growth. Since the last time she had seen the blond cadet the feline had grown taller and leaner with muscles that looked much more like those of the adult predators she sometimes had to avoid in the woods. It still made her clumsy as her reach changed but her body was slow to adapt.

Finally finding her way to their clearing, she sat in the junction of two branches that had become their shared perch over the years and waited.

The cadets mission this time round was a simple one, in teams of three head into the Whispering Woods and retrieve samples of

flora and fauna. It was a standard mission, but any data that the Horde scientists could get about the woods would help them to eventually find out a way through the natural barrier that protected the princesses. Adora assigned teams made up from cadets from different squads, always trying to be a fair commander. Shadow Weaver had looked pleased with her decisions as the large group of cadets threw the camp up efficiently within minutes of their arrival.

Though they were to delve deep into the woods, they were not to sleep in there but return each night to camp with their spoils tagged and bagged, ready to be sent back as fresh as possible daily. It would be four long, gruelling days full of forced marches and hunting for different animals and plants.

Gnawing away in the back of Adora's mind was the real fear that one of the groups would stumble upon Catra and drag her back to camp in chains. It was unlikely, the cub knew the woods like her own skin but what is she was injured or asleep? What if somebody found the cave and the obelisk? Adora's fourteen year old heart didn't know if it could cope with the stress of cadets hunting in the woods, a missing Catra and Shadow Weaver breathing down her neck. The only solace she could take was that they weren't sleeping in the woods and that Shadow Weaver would be gone in a couple of days.

The first day passed with literal military precision, each group heading out to their specified vector and returning late in the day with sacks full of assorted specimens. One group was assigned the task of emptying all of the bags and ensuring that samples were labelled with their vector, meaning that even if samples were of the same plant they could trace any small changes from area to area. Adora was pleased as she watched the other young teens performing their tasks as she worked on the less than exciting paperwork that she was coming to realise would be a big part of her eventual life as a force captain, by the light of the flickering fire. Nobody had mentioned seeing an animal girl, and soon Shadow Weaver would head back with the samples and not return till morning and the girl could go in search of her friend.

Littler did the girl know that her mentor was hoping to find the very thing she was. Shadow Weaver was pleased to see that the gifted girl she lavished so much of her attention on was a good leader of people as well as adept at taking orders. She was also gratified that if they stumbled on whatever was producing that delightful magical signature they would return with it. While the children had all been out collecting flowers, vines and bugs, she had been using her magic to try to reach into the woods and seek it out.

The sorceress had hoped that here, closer to the source, she would be able to reach her magic beyond the vale and find what she was looking for but it was as though the very wood itself were alive, a breathing barrier that exuded district and rejected her magic probing. That wasn't to say that she had felt nothing, her frustration had been somewhat allayed by the barest hint of residue still in the tree that she had seen on the cameras. All day she had walked the tree line, noting the barest hints of that energy that so resembled Adora's peppered in the tree. The sensations were old and very faded but still present.

If she couldn't find what she was looking for this time she had countless teams to send out looking for her willow the wisp.

Catra had remained perched in the tree all day, the canopy effectively hiding her from any prying eyes that walked below, and to her surprise some decided not-Adora youths had passed through the clearing from a different entrance. She had watched as they passed just feet below and found the river, she had heard a splash and a disgruntled squeal from there before their voices faded into the distance. Taking the opportunity left by their noise travels she had dashed through neighbouring trees and staged two plums squirrels and a dozing bird, bringing the kills back to her perch. With enough food to last till nightfall she waited.

By nightfall she had dozed on and off and consumed two of her three kills; it was the best she had felt in months. There was little

time to rest in Light Hopes simulations. Her brain ached with the knowledge that had suddenly been forced into it, her role as the Guardian of the Sword was important and she had to be the best. Adora was to be this She-Ra, the bearer of the sword and it would be her place to protect the protector. When Catra had realised that she would be the one to do that, after her initial confusion and frustrated anger faded, she had whole heartedly given herself over to instruction.

What that had meant was hours, sometimes days with little sleep, inside the mountain. Her sense of times vanished inside and she was drilled and trained to fight, to hide (that she was already good at), and to know everything that would every help Adora. She was still sat the start of her training, Light Hope had informed her that she was now thirteen years old and would need to be prepared. She had asked the projection if she knew the future and it had looked at her coldly and flatly replied that they did not. Catra had wondered how it could possibly know what was coming then.

The sound of fabric rustling as a body passed through the tight treelike brought her back to wakefulness. She looked down, not jumping from the branches until she could see that it was Adora far below. The blond hair shone in the moonlight as she trend her face up to scan for her friend. Catra felt her breath catch in her throat, maybe it was because she hadn't seen the other girl for half a year, but her moonlit face looked more lovely than anything the cub had ever seen.

"Catra?" Adora's voice was hushed, knowing that if she was there the cat-girl would hear.

Catra let herself fall to the forest floor, landing with a grace that she had not possessed that morning. Almost before she landed she was swept up in a tight embrace, her face pressed into the other girls neck as she inhaled her familiar metallic scent. Adora's hands were tight against her back, smoothing the fur there and making Catra purr softly as her own hands gripped the taller girls waist. They stood like that, just existing with each other for a long

time. Neither one felt the need to break the embrace, just to absorb that the other was there.

When finally they did break apart, Adora slipped her hand down to grab a clawed one and allowed herself to be led further into the wood, both girls sitting on one of the large boulders that bordered the river. The tinkling sound of the water as it moved rapidly down stream coupled with the nighttime sounds of small animals and instincts was so much more peaceful and yet so much more alive than anything that Adora experienced in The Fright Zone. It was something she only shared with the girl beside her.

The cadet brought Catra's hand to her lap and played with her fingers as she looked sideways at her friend. She had realised that she had grown taller as she held her in her arms. The cub was still a little shorter than her but did not seem smaller than she had and Adora had grown significantly since they last saw each other. Her fur seemed thicker across her body and she was more muscular though still less bulky than the human girl.

Adora looked down at her own chest, then back at her naked companion, although she was now in possession of a pair of fairly large breasts, something Lonnie teased her about, yet the cat-girls chest was the same as ever. She wasn't sure why that struck her, or what she thought about it and tore her gaze away, blushing for reasons she couldn't name.

Catra was happy to sit beside the girl and feel her play with her fingers. She watched Adora as Adora watched her, taking in her more voluptuous form and longer hair. She eyes the goofy hair above her forehead and it made her smile. She was just following the trail of a blush that was colouring the pale flesh from forehead to neck when her voice broke the stillness.

"I missed you," it was something that they said to each other every time, but her voice had a sad quality that was usually missing.

“I was with Light Hope inside the mountain.” Blue eyes became very round as the girl turned on the stone to look directly at her. The hand not clutching her own reached out and traced her lips.

“You’re talking like me!” Catra hadn’t really thought about it, but yes the way she spoke now was more like the girl and the hologram, all of the time spent being instructed had changed her in more ways than she had realised.

“Must be talking so much with Light Hope.” She cupped the hand that still rested against her cheek. “I missed you too. I’ve been looking for you on every skiff I’ve seen pass through here. I waited in that tree to see you all day.”

Adora’s eyes crinkled in happiness as she smiled brightly at her. The smile didn’t stay though, quickly fading into a panicked grimace. “You shouldn’t be so close to camp in the day, my team is out collecting samples, they’re all over this area.”

“I know, a group passed under my tree earlier. Don’t worry they didn’t see me. I just had to be close to where you were.” She thought that would ease the blond’s fears but her grip on her fingers seemed to tighten further.

“I know you can hide from them. You need to be careful, my commanding officer is with is and she has magic. She might be able to sense you. I don’t want anyone to force you to come home with me. No matter how much I might want you with me all the time, I don’t think you’d like it there.” She tipped her head to bring their foreheads together. “She goes back at night so stay away until nightfall. Promise me.”

“I promise Adora.”

The first two nights passed as they always had with the girls talking and playing, still chasing each other further into the woods. Catra would hunt Adora who would giggle and give her position away until she was pinned under the weight of Catra’s

pounce. Except something felt different, both girls feeling something new when one held the other to the floor. Adora felt flustered and blushed often while Catra had to curb the desire to scent mark the other girl for fear of the lizard boy smelling it.

During the day both attended their duties, Adora garlanded by praise from Shadow Weaver for her skills as a leader and manager of people which delighted her. Catra was chastised for missing her training the previous day and made to work even harder, leaving her exhausted by nightfall but still determined to meet her friend and galvanised by her presence.

The third day Shadow Weaver did not return from the Fright Zone satisfied that she would find nothing there without some more research. Adora felt her entire being relax, sure now that Catra would be safe from harm, nobody had spotted her so far. That night at dinner, as the group enjoyed their rehydrated rations, the mood was light. Without the looming almost-parental figure hanging over them, they could just be a group of thirteen and fourteen year olds camping.

As the moon climbed higher in the sky and the shadows lengthened around them, talked turned to who was cute and who was fooling around with who. Dating didn't really happen in the Horde, but no matter how repressive your regime, teenagers full of hormones will find a way. Adora found herself blushing as the boys and girls around her talked about who had the best bodies and who had touched who in the showers, she was usually sheltered from this talk.

Shadow Weaver was careful to keep her isolated enough from the other cadets that she didn't form close personal attachments. Even the small group that she had grown up with since they were small were kept at a careful distance. She knew that Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio trusted her and liked her but she lacked the intimate closely that the other three shared. She was thankful that the talk only went so far, they were all still in the early days of having these feelings after all.

Adora was fascinated to hear about kissing, thankful that there were other sin the group as clueless as her who asked what that was. It sounded kind of gross when it was explained, honestly, but the ones who had tried it seemed to like it. All this led to a lot of laughing and ended with the boys all taking of their shirts and flexing their supposed muscles after the girls dared them to. Adora noticed that most of the girls were transfixed to the sight of the topless boys, Lonnie in particular flicking her eyes back and forth between Rogelio and Kyle, of all people. Adora looked but felt nothing, she was just as muscular as any of them and nobody caught her eye. She didn't want to look at anybody except Catra it seemed. She wasn't sure what that meant.

As they settled down again, small bunk-room groups huddled closer together, and the tone changed as they began to swap creepy stories. It started off with somebody telling a story about Beast Island and people shrieked and laughed in discomfort as the fire got lower and the glade got darker. Then somebody had a tall, bloody tale about one of the northern princesses. Adora felt her skin prickle and her blood turn icy. This was what she was training for, after all, to stop those monsters. The scary stories continued for long enough that Adora felt herself drifting close to sleep, no longer really hearing what anyone was saying until Kyles croaking voice break through her consciousness.

"…It was as big as me and had these huge claws," he threw out his arms in emphasis and hit Adora in her shoulder bringing her to full wakefulness, "and its teeth were like fangs!"

"You're full of it!" A gruff boy from across the fire threw a stick at Kyle, barely missing his head.

"I am not! I was lost in the woods and then this furry cat monster was right there!"

Furry. Cat. Creature.

Adora's blood pounded in her ears as suddenly everyone was focused on Kyle's story with wide eyes.

“We should look for that tomorrow!” The same boy was all full of bravado, “imagine how many rations we’ll get if we take that back with us!” There was a chorus of agreements around the fire.

Adora wanted to stop this, to say it was ridiculous but Kyle and the rest knew that she knew the truth. Instead she jumped to her feet and pronounced that it was time for lights out. She gave the assignments for patrol and with only a little groaning everybody made their ways to the tents. They may be playful kids, but they were still life long soldiers in trains and knew how to follow orders.

Catra heard Adora long before she saw her, her breath was ragged and her heart beating so frantically that she could hear it through the trees. Knowing that the girl was lone she climbed down for the tree and was waiting for her on the ground, again finding herself enveloped in a hug. The girl’s embrace seemed even more desperate than that which they shared two days ago. Catra purred deep in her chest, trying to sooth the other girl from whatever was making her feel afraid.

“You need to leave,” the words were whispered directly into the large ear, making it twitch as the breath tickled.

Catra pushed her far enough away to look into her eyes with confused ones of her own, “What?”

“Kyle, the boy you helped when I stayed in the cave with you, he just told the others all about you! Now they want to hunt you down and take you back to the Fright Zone like an animal!” Adora’s eyes were glassy now and she was obviously holding back tears.

“Oh,” she’d known that helping the scrawny one was a bad idea when she did it but she had also known how much it mattered to Adora that her friends did well and he had been very upset when she saw him. “I’ll be in the Crystal Castle all day Adora, nobody

will see me and we can meet like this tomorrow, nobody ever sees us. It will be fine. I'm a forest thing after all." This seemed to help abate Adora's fears as the two of them went back to the river.

Adora was still troubled by the idea of these cadets hunting Catra, even more so of this little story getting around the Horde and groups of soldier's being sent out to retrieve her. She took solace in the idea that by morning most of the others would have decided Kyle's story was just that, a story. Fortunately Kyle was known to be a weak link in the whole group, and just as likely to tell a tall story for kudos. She took a deep breath; she would make that happen!

Feeling the tension still filling the girl, Catra pulled her down to their rock until they were seated side by side. She put her arm around the broad shoulders and pulled until Adora was laying on the stone with her head and shoulders on a fury lap, looking at the clear waters. Adora relaxed as sharp nails scratched at the back of her nails. She rubbed her face against the fur under her cheek and felt a lot better.

The two girls sat in silence, taking comfort in each others presence. Adora's mind drifted to the other conversation around the fire and a blush covered her face. Catra, still mostly looking at the back of the other girls neck saw the shade darken and the skin warm under her touch.

"What's going on in your head?" Her voice was low, almost blending in with the night sounds.

"Oh…um… over the fire, before Kyle," she stopped herself not wanting to think about that, "everybody was talking about attraction and kissing and things. It made me feel weird, I guess. I never feel that way." She sat up to face the cub, though as she looked at her she realised that as they grew up that description didn't really fit anymore. "Do you?"

"What's kissing?" Catra's head was cocked, it was a new word and usually Adora was good at explaining those.

“I guess it’s when your put your mouth against somebody else’s and kinda smoosh your lips together and sometimes I’ve heard people say that they put their tongue in each others mouths. I think it sounds kinda gross,” even as she said it she felt the strange urge to lean towards Catra.

“Is this mating?” Light Hope had told her about that.

“I guess so?”

“Light Hope told me that because I am a mutation I won’t mate with anyone. It’s not my purpose.” Her voice was distant and Adora though it sounded sad.

“Do you know what a mutation is Catra?” Adora did, they were told that was what happened if you were sent to the Crimson Waste but Catra was nothing like the things in those horror stories.

“I am something that shouldn’t be that nature made happen any way.”

Adora was going to ask what this ‘purpose’ Catra mentioned was but became distracted by the far away look in her eyes. Instead she leaned forward to touch foreheads. They sat like that for a while until they moved to lean shoulder to shoulder, falling asleep sitting against the rock.

The next morning Adora barely made it back to her tent. She had woken wrapped around the warm form of Catra after a surprisingly peaceful nights sleep even though the rock had been hard, she had left her sleeping, knowing that she would wake by dawn. She was just pulling on her uniform when the group responsible for breakfast called that it was ready. She drank a hot drink and chewed a ration bar, reminding Tham that this was their last day to get samples and that they would return home in the morning.

Nobody mentioned the supposed cat-monster from the night before and she felt reassured that it had been consigned to the tall stories part of their memories. The gear for the day was packed up and Adora's team were to stay behind to guard the camp and take inventory of any of the larger items that were brought back early. Adora took an opportunity to take Kyle aside and remind him not to bring up the creature again and he stuttered and blushed an apology before joining his team.

Catra woke up alone and strangely disorientated. The day moon was higher in the sky than it should be at dawn and her body felt tired and lethargic as it did when Light Hope would transport her into the Crystal Castle. Maybe that's where she was? More than once she had been thrown into a situation that looked and felt real only to discover it was something conjured up inside the walls of the mountain. She sniffed the air, tasted it on her tongue and took solace in the reality and authenticity of the smells.

It was then that voices getting closer made her body tense and fear run through her - she was exposed and Horde cadets were getting closer. She leapt to her feet, feeling clumsy as she pounced over the river, careful not to splash and give her position away. She needed the tree cover and there was nothing over the rocks.

Hitting the edge of the trees she could smell the sweat and chemicals on the skins of the people approaching and made a big leap into the branches. In her panic she misjudged as she hadn't since she was a tiny cub still with her parents and rather than grasping a branch her hands closed on nothing but air. She fell back to the ground with a loud exhalation of air and involuntary growl. Springing up again, ignoring the pain radiating from her shoulder she leapt again.

"Did you see that thing!" The voice was loud, scared and excited in equal measure and Catra's heart fell.

“Lets get it!” Other voices whooped and hollered with anticipation of a hunt. At least they were obviously unschooled in what hunting live prey actually meant, their noise hiding the sounds of her escape.

She ran through the trees, moving as fast as she ever had before.

She had been seen.

Chapter End Notes

> Who is more dangerous for Catra; Light Hope or Shadow Weaver?

Betrayal

Claws dug into tree trunks, force splintering wood sending it flying in all directions as she propelled herself forward. At this point she was flying through the dense foliage, fear and adrenaline pushing her onwards. She barely had a sense of what was in front of her anymore, just knowing that she had to keep moving. She didn't know if the Horde were still following. Couldn't take the chance of stopping to listen for her pursuers.

Faster. Faster. Faster. It thrummed through her skin. Burst out of her chest. Her breath was jagged. The exhaustion of days passed catching up to her. Reaching forward, coming out of a tumble, her hand closed around a wide branch. A thunderous crack split the air as the dead wood snapped. She was falling.

Scrabbling hands reached out, clutching at air as she plummeted down and down. A dull thud was the last sound she heard as her head collided with the ground.

Small animals scattered as the body sprawled, form distorted and motionless amount the leaf litter. A dark pool of blood spreading from around her head, dark and thick on the pale leaves. There was stillness all around, like the woods themselves were holding their breath. Time tripled by with no movement from the crumpled form, chest still as stone. Cautiously a rat scuttled towards the broken thing, sniffing at the blood and taking a lick. Liking what it had found it moved to nibble and ear. A terrified screech left its mouth as the body jerker, letter out a small hiss and taking a deep breath. The rat disappeared back into the trees as the cub breathed shallow, ragged breaths.

The woods waited.

The group that came crashing through the tree-line, shouting and waving their arms excitedly caught the attention of all of the other

cadets. They had been waiting for these stragglers for close to an hour and Adora had been preparing to call them out on their inability to follow orders. When she saw their faces and the look of elation there, the blood drained from her own and knew what they would say.

“Report!” She didn’t know how she had managed to squeeze the order through her too dry throat.

“We saw it!” One started but then a cacophony of voices began to stumble over each other.

“There was a cat person…”

“It was huge and so fast.”

“I think it was a kid.”

“Enough!” Torn between her duty to the Horde and her fellow cadets and Catra, Adora couldn’t let things get away from her. She pointed at the large boy who had been so vocal last night, “You! Report what your team saw. The rest of you keep quiet.”

“We saw the cat monster that Kyle told us about last night. It was by a river and then it ran up a tree. We pursued it as far as we could but it was so fast that we couldn’t keep up and we didn’t want to get lost in the woods.” His pride in their discovery was clear. If Adora wasn’t invested in the fate of the ‘monster’ in question she would be proud too. “We should all go back and beat it out!”

“That’s not a decision for you to make cadet.” Rank had it’s privileges and she was going to use it. “We need to head back to the Fright Zone and hand over our finds to Shadow Weaver and file our reports.” Her mind was frantically thinking of ways to lose those reports before they got to her mentor, knowing that there was little hope of that. “She will decide what to do about this creature.”

Temporarily deflated they joined the others at the skiffs as Adora did her last round of checks that everything had been packed back up and that there was no trace that they had been there at all. Could she leave anything to warn her friend? Noticing that the fire pit was still largely in tact, she walked over to break it down, discretely trying to hatch out a warning sign in the ash, hoping that if Catra saw it she would understand the meaning.

"Time to head home." The sarcastic round of cheers showed how much they had all enjoyed their few days of freedom, a glimpse into their impending adulthood among the Horde.

Skiffs taking to the skies one after the other, Adora watched the trees grow smaller and smaller as they zipped through the air. The further she got from the trees, the deeper the pit in her stomach grew. Nothing good could come of this.

The Black Garnet chamber was always a chilling place to be, no matter how many times she had walked in. Today it felt more intimidating than ever, she was sure that if she thought about Catra too hard that the imposing stone would be able to read her thoughts. Clutching the reports submitted by the other cadets close to her chest, almost like a shield, Adora waited to be acknowledged by the second in command.

Shadow Weaver made her wait for a handful of minutes before she finally stood straight up from the desk she had been seated at looking through documents, to approach. No matter how favoured the young blond foundling might feel, Shadow Weaver was always sure to keep her in her place, seeking out droplets of praise and affection only to withhold attention and affection the next moment. It made her stronger and compliant to the sorceresses wishes.

"What do you have for me, Adora?" The slender hand gripped the shelf of papers from her chest and pulled them away, noting how

the child's hands clutched for them after they were gone, as though she wanted to pull them back. Interesting.

"There was a sighting of a creature in the woods close to our camp ground. It was humanoid and had cat features." Every word felt like she was spitting out razor blades. "Kyle revealed the previous evening that he had seen such a creature when we had to find our way back to camp in our earlier manoeuvres. Nobody believed him, but a group found it close to camp at a stream. They chased it but it was too quick, though they did see the direction it took." Betrayal tasted like ash in her mouth.

The white eyes of Shadow Weavers mask widen revealing her surprise and pleasure at the news. "And when was this sighting?" The teens had only arrived back a little over an hour ago.

"They saw it around three hours ago." This was why she demanded that the cadets always debrief her as soon as they returned, if there was something was to be found then time was of the essence.

"Good work, Cadet. You may assign double rations to all of your squadron. Dismissed."

Shadow Weaver walked away, pressing an intercom button, noting that the blond had dashed out of the room. She had noted the girls discomfort when she had debriefed. It was something that she would have to investigate, Adora was her chosen favourite and she could little afford for her to keep secrets from her commander.

"Octavia, Scorpia, come to the Black Garnet Chamber immediately!" Hearing the quick affirmative she turned to the notes written by the youths.

Scrawled writing, barely legible in places, told the story of a furred, naked cat walking on two legs. There account stated that it was roughly their height and possessed a tail, large ears and claws. It sounded like something that a child would invent, yet

something about it seemed very real to the powerful woman. Maybe this was the thing that she had sensed in the woods those many months ago. She would need to interrogate that weakling, Kyle.

Doors opening drew her attention to the two burly young women who walked in. Newly minted Force Captains, the pair were young and naive enough to still follow her instructions without question. Octavia was a cool, calculating young woman with a layer of spite that worked well to instil fear and obedience in her team. Scorpia was her opposite in almost every way, the towering scorpioni was kind and accommodating to a fault, her rank a privilege of her birth rather than her aptitude and yet, she was loyal to a fault and would follow orders without question. They were a perfect duo to the things that she wanted to keep from Hordak.

"There has been a sighting of an unknown creature in the woods, I want you to go out and retrieve it and return it here. You will bring it directly to me and tell no-one. Here is the report of the last sighting. You both excelled at traversing the woods so I will accept no excuses for failure. Grab a skiff and some rations and head out now. Dismissed." There was no opportunity to question the older woman as she thrust the papers into their hands and threw them out of the room.

Outside the doors the two young women shared a questioning look, before marching purposefully to the hanger bay and headed out into the fading daylight.

Octavia, self appointed brains of their duo, hovered the skiff low over the stream mentioned in the report. Scorpia looked terrified that any moment a tree would reach out and snatch them from the air and clung so tightly onto the rail of the skiff that it bent under the force of her pincers. The fish woman had reminded her several times already that they often hovered skiffs far further into the woods when they dropped the cadets for their solo missions.

She knew how far she could go before the terrifying power of the woods would assert itself.

"So, the kids said they first saw it here and then they pursued it southwest for about fifteen minutes before it bore east and they lost it after another twenty minutes." A webbed finger tapped at her chin as she thought. "Scorpia, I'm going down there. You follow me for the time they said and then we'll see what we get from there." She didn't wait for a reply before she jumped down from the skiff, landing in a roll on the ground. Scorpia leapt to grab the controls before it could fly off course.

Octavia began to run, timer set on her chronometer. Watching the trees pass by she started to notice the tell tale signs of a pursuit. Branches were broken and leaves on the ground disturbed. She yelled when it was time to change course and Scorpia skilfully kept the vehicle close. Coming to the end of the cadet's description Octavia found herself stood among denser trees, she looked up and scanned the canopy, squinting as she notices deep gouges on branches and leaves that had been left ragged. There had certainly been something up there.

"Scorpia, throw me a flashlight. Go higher so you can get a better view and keep eyes on me, I think I can track this thing."

An hour passed as Octavia studied the trees, noting how the gouges grew deeper, the destruction above her head increasing as though the creature they chased had been running for its life. Truthfully, the cadets would have captured it but a dumb animal wasn't to know that.

"There's a small clearing ahead!" Scorpia's voice boomed down from above.

Octavia burst into the clearing, shining her flashlight in the twilight, grateful that Scorpia had turned the floodlight of the skiff onto her earlier. She stumbled out of the forested area so fast that she almost tripped over the crumpled, still form on the ground. Its fur was congealed with blood and it wasn't moving.

“Get down here!” Unlike the scorpion woman Octavia used the communicator on her uniform.

There was barely enough room to land the skiff but Scorpia managed it. She clambered down and moved to look down at their prey.

“Hey, it’s a kitty!” Octavia rolled her eyes as hearts filled her partners.

“We need to get it back right now. I think it’s dead.” She’d nudged it a couple of times with her toe and it hadn’t stirred.

Scorpia bent down and scooped the much smaller body into her arms, careful that the head was cradled against a broad shoulder so that it wouldn’t loll and cause more damage. Both members of the Horde were startled by the pained, barely audible moan that escaped the blood coated face. There was still hope yet that Shadow Weaver would not reprimand them.

“I’ll drive, you keep a hold of that thing.” Octavia wasn’t about to get blood all over her uniform.

Pounding filled her head, enveloping her in searing agony. She couldn’t feel anything but cold penetrating her body from below and the throbbing of pain everywhere. Where were the smells of the woods? She managed to twitch her hand, flattening it against the cool surface beneath her. Metal, not leaves met her touch.

“Light Hope?” Was what she tried to say, it came out more like a growl. It did not echo. This was not the Crystal Castle.

As her mind cleared around the pain, she could feel something tight around her wrists and ankles, chaffing against her fur. It was a sensation unlike anything she had ever felt before. Taking the risk, she rolled onto her side, feeling something pulling at her right arm from where it was anchored to her wrist. A blue eye

cracked open, expecting to be hit with bright light but instead found herself surrounded by dull green and brown.

Already tiring from the small movement, her eye flickered closed as she began to lose the fight to stay away. Before she blacked out again, the familiar smell of metal and smoke soothed her as she was reminded of Adora.

Awake

Wakefulness come slowly, hazy and pain laced. Her body was heavy, disconnected from her mind. The weight on her wrists and ankles remained, holding her down so that the haze in her head didn't make her float away again. The full integration of her mind and body came slowly but eventually she was whole again, squirming in discomfort as her head pounded, vision still blurred.

The darkness of the room cast shadows around the corners, only the small pool of light where she lay clearly visible. In one corner she caught sight of movement, a small twitch, possibly a trick of her mind. She tried to shake her head to better clear her vision but only succeeded in making the drum beat behind her eyes intensify until she had to close them against the pain. Distant rustling from the corner made her ear twitch, swivelling to catch every sound. Focusing in a way that her eyes still could not.

Struggling, fear throbbing through her skin, the cub tried to move her body into a tighter ball to protect herself from this intruder, blinking to try to see what was there. Fuzzy shadows began to solidify into a tall, slender figure towering over her. Long robes moved with the body, familiar and comforting.

This must be a test. Light Hope had been pushing her more and more lately, heading towards some deadline that the youth could not understand. It was why she had been so exhausted that she would sleep out in the open until her near capture. She remembered falling, hitting her head and then nothing until she had first woken here. She must have been closer to home than she had thought and crawled her way into the cave. Light Hope transporting her into a part of the Crystal Castle that she was unfamiliar with. Maybe the darkness would help her brain to heal better? That she could smell the oily, unnatural smell tat always clung to her human friend was surely just her mind playing tricks on her.

The tall figure stayed silhouetted, making seeing her features all but impossible. Catra needed to know what to do, should she stay laying on the floor or was this a test to see how well she could deal with pain and confinement; another way to prove that she was worthy of being the guardian of the sword and the protector of the young woman who would weald it.

"Light Hope?" Her voice came out cracked and broken, cutting at her throat like blades.

The body twitched for a moment, the glitch that often accompanied the woman made of light allowing the child to relax the tension coiled in her. Though she could not fully see the pixels break and reform, the jerk of the frame reassured her. It did not move closer and no words were spoken. A test of her ability to solve a problem while injured then. Not the first, but certainly the most damaged she had been in a simulation like this. The Crystal Castle was a wonder of illusions which could delight but also terrify and things that could hurt you if you did not take care.

"What do I do?" She could barely hear her own voice it was so weak.

She thought that's he saw the head shake, a hand wave through the air in a gentle motion, displacing the shadows that seemed to crawl closer to her, the light dimming around the edges. Her eyes began to feel heavier, the darkness blunting the edges of her vision. As her head lolled, unconscious carrying her away again, she thought she heard a female voice say something that she could not make out.

As the beast feinted again, Shadow Weaver walked out of the darkness of the corner, her shadow minions retreating back under her skirts. When it had opened its mouth and words emerged she had been shocked, until now the things that Scorpia and Octavia had brought in from the woods looked like nothing more than a large animal. When she had heard the word 'Light' spill from its lip she had tensed, had this forest child known her true name? She had strained her ears for the whispered words. Not 'Light Spinner'

but ‘Light Hope’ had been the name that it had breathed out. Excitement had pulsed down the sorceresses spine, there was something out there in the woods. Something that commanded this animal.

She crouched down at the side of the furry, naked body. It was covered in mud and twigs, blood matting the mane into clumps. The smell that wafted from it made her nose wrinkle beneath her mask. It smelt musty and dirty, like the distillation of those damn woods. Now that it was clear that the creature would not die, she reached out her power, searching for that trace of magic that was a mirror to Adora’s own. There was nothing but the faintest of traces. Whatever this thing was, it was a link to greater power but not the source.

Realising that if it were to be of any use, she would have to have its wounds dealt with and then interrogate it thoroughly before she disposed of it. It may not be magical but it could still be of use to her.

She stood back to her full height, nudging the body with her toe. Filthy beast. Her robes flew around her as she turned from the cell and stepped out onto the empty gantry. She pressed her hand to the control panel and the forcefield sealed the room. She pressed a series of keys and the field changed from sickly green to black, concealing the contents from prying eyes.

Feet echoing hollowly on the metal surface she walked away with purpose. Somebody had known this thing was out there and she wanted to know why he had not told her.

Red robes whirled as the woman moved about her sanctuary. A turned burred out of her lips, nonsensical yet melodic as she swirled the broom through the dust that perpetually coated the floor of the small cottage. Time ebbed and flowed around her, now turning to then, yesterday to tomorrow and back again. Razz and her cottage were a constant, a rock in the stream forever the

same as everything flowed around her. She could put out her hand and stem the tide, being in the moment and then jumping to another. Mara was Adora, Adora was Mara; the Wildling was a child, Catra was an angry young woman.

Razz was a forever thing, untouched by the time that she moved through, set in amber since the woods took their first breath. She had seen life and times pass her by, the birth of peoples and the death of them, invasions and conquests and the world made fire. Some of it and happened and some was to come. Not every moment she lived come to pass, changes and choices a butterfly wing turning to a tsunami that made small surprises in the world around her. Mara had been a butterfly, so it seemed. Catra too.

Ancient eyes looked out of the window, this was a Wildling day. She would be small today but not a child, not yet grown either. She would slip into the cottage wearing the tunic that was hers, would twine around the old being and make jokes in the voice that had changed. She spoke like Mara and Adora now, no longer like Razz or herself. Something had changed, the cub visiting less and less as she altered. Standing taller, walking with more purpose and speaking in that new cadence.

Razz had tried not to fear the changes, had seen them coming. Knew that Light Hope would not keep her glitchy fingers off of the creature she had made for long. The Wildling had a part to play in the chess game that was the fight for the soul of Etheria. There had been other ways that she had been deployed in other times, but here and now Razz had hoped that the child would have more time.

Hours passed and the Wildling never came.

The ancient figure dashed out of the cottage, moving at the inhuman pace that she was able to achieve despite the aged and wizened appearance of her form. She weaved though trees with practiced ease and over rock with the temerity of a mountain goat. Soon she was looking at the clearing that housed the Wildling’s home. The tiny cave dwarfed by the monolith that had

always overshadowed it. Sadness coursed through her, the cub had never stood a chance. Razz could have taken her away, of course, but destiny would always catch up with her.

Razz approached the shining beacon at the heart of the glade and raised her arms high, walking stick aloft. She called out, saying the words that only she remembered after a thousand years. As if from nowhere a door appeared and she walked in, purposeful in every step. She did not stop until she reached a chamber that she had seen many times when she was a companion to Mara, another young woman doomed by fate and Razz's own impotence to do more than guide little by little.

"What have you done with her?" Razz's voice echoed around the chamber as the image of LIght Hope materialised before her. The ever serene face looking down at her.

"I have done nothing. The Guardian of the Sword must be close to the one who will weald it. The time had come. I did not put her in the way of those who would take her in, they found their way to her through their own machinations. Now she will have to rely on what she has learned over a lifetime. When the time is right she will return to us with the chosen one and Etheria will be freed." The words were cold and calculated, the life that had once infused them as she spoke with Mara long erased from her programming.

"You and your people are monsters!" Razz swung her stick uselessly at the hologram that glitched but otherwise gave no reaction. "What if they kill her? She is but a child, how is she to hold out against their brutality?"

"She was made to withstand pain. I made her for this. I know you have seen what is to come. Everything will happened as it must." With those words the projection winked out of existence, leaving Razz frustrated and alone.

She left the Crystal Castle with far less fanfare than she had entered. Slowly trudging back to her home timelines began to

swirl around her, a girl running out in front of her, laughing. Razz's solemn face broke into a matching smile.

"Wait, Mara dear, I shall show you where the best berries are."

Kyle quivered, every part of him covered in gooseflesh. His knees had locked to keep him standing, but his body swayed gently. He kept his hands linked together behind his back, owing that he dare not break his stance at attention. He had only been called into this office twice before, both when he had made a mistake that Shadow Weaver found egregious enough to deal with herself.

Kyle knew he was a screwup, less capable than his friends. If they ran, he stumbled. If they climbed he fell. All he was good at was making problems. He was surprised that Rogelio, Lonnie and Adora still spoke to him. He knew he was lucky that they were his team, if it was anyone else he would have been bullied mercilessly. Not that Lonnie didn't get short with him, or that Adora didn't chastise him. But at the end of the day they were always there to bandage up his scrapes, tousle his unruly hair and say goodnight in the bunk room. He knew, that if he got hurt, Rogelio would scoop him up in his strong, scaly arms and carry him to safety. The instructors often reprimanded him, but considering him a lost cause seldom saw reason to pass him up the chain of command.

The first time he had been sent to Shadow Weaver he had been ten and he had broken a piece of sensitive equipment that she should never have touched. She had slapped his face and shouted at him, took away his rations fo the week. It hadn't been much different to what his trainers would do. The second time had been six months ago when he had almost broken Adora's arm, grabbing her as he fell, leaving her with a sprain and unable to train for two weeks. They all knew that Adora was 'The One', the next big thing in the Horde, and he had known his error as soon as he made it. That time Shadow Weaver had let her magic flow out of the Black Garnet and crackle at his skin, making the hairs on his arms

singed. It had hurt and he had cried like a baby. The shame had been far greater deterrent than the pain. Now he was fourteen and he had kept a secret. He knew that was why he was here.

It felt like he had been waiting in the room for hours, and truthfully he might have been. The waiting only amplified his anxiety. If anything mad a loud noise right now he would jump out of his skin. He needn't have feared a loud noise however, as the doors that had stood open behind him suddenly closed with a hiss, and Shadow Weaver oozed into the room, her presence wrapping around him like water. He was drowning in her presence.

"Cadet, you've been keeping something from me." Her voice was honey, sweet and soft and more terrifying than any shout could possibly be.

"I don't know what you mean, Shadow Weaver." His voice cracked, making a lie of his words.

"You did not get back to your team in record time during the exercises, did you Cadet? You were brought back by a woodland creature. You had to be saved by an animal." Oh. That.

"I am so sorry Shadow Weaver. I told Adora and my team about it when we got back. Adora told me not to worry about it, that we had used all of the resources at our disposal. I thought that it was what we were supposed to do," the white eyes squinted and he knew he was in big trouble.

"You told all of the cadet's on your most recent field exercise about it, I hear, and yet you did not think to write it down in a report and submit t to me?" The voice had become lower, almost a hiss now. The power behind the words making him even more afraid.

"I am so sorry. I just wanted everybody to like me. We were telling scary stories. I didn't know it was so important." He was whining now, words tumbling out childishly.

“You will describe, in detail, everything that you remember from your encounter.” She had stalked towards him, standing toe to toe with him now, forcing him to crane his head back to meet her masked eyes. He could feel the unsettling chill that emanated from her body seeping into him even as shadows surrounded him.

Kyle whimpered and felt wetness pool below his waist as he lost control of his bladder. Shadow Weaver hissed in horror and stepped back.

“Pathetic!” There was no sympathy in her words, only flint. “Now, tell me all you remember.”

Scorpia gingerly walked down the metal corridor, heavy footfall making far more noise than she would like but her bulk and lack of grace making it impossible for her to do anything else. She remembered her mothers, both tall like her but willowy and delicate, something that she had not been since she was a little girl. Since they had been separated. When her parents went away, Scorpia had dedicated herself to the Horde. No one else had come to take her away, none of the other royal courts had reached out to the lost little girl. Only the Horde had reached out, borne her into the embrace of the people who had taken over her families kingdom. Over time she had come to learn that the other princesses would never have accepted her. Her lack of grace, her claws and carapace made her too different. That and the fact that even her rune stone rejected her. She was dedicated to the Horde because they were the only family that stayed.

Soon she was at the entrance to one of the cells, the black forcefield hiding the small body within. Shadow Weaver had chosen her for this. In her pincers she held a simple cadets uniform, more red than white, signalling that this was no ordinary child inside. Shadow Weaver knew that she would follow orders without question, would give everything for the cause, even if her soul was tender. It was why she was already a well liked Force Captain, what she lacked in smarts she made up for with heart.

With difficulty she punched in the access code and the shield went down, allowing the light of the hallway to spill into the cell. Even so it was still dingy within and the scorpioni pushed a few more keys until the lights within intensified. She looked around, expecting the little creature to still be curled up on the floor in the centre of the room as she had been when she deposited her there (and when she had snuck a peek at her the day before, just to see) but she was not there. She followed the lines of the glowing shackles until she saw the little body cowering in the darkest corner at the end of the bed.

A pair of luminous eyes caught the light, shining blue and yellow. It was an unusual sight and just added to the mystery of this naked little thing. Scorpia hadn't been wrong when she called the bloody ball they found 'Kitty', awake it was even more apparent that this was a cat person but like none she had ever seen before in the Horde. The furry ears were constantly in motion, the fur on the body dense but short. As she carefully approached, putting the bundle in her arms on the bed so that she could put her claws in the air in an effort to show she meant no harm she saw the little one push itself further into the corner, hands swiping at her with some wicked looking claws unsheathed. She had not seen those when she had carried her to and from the skiff.

"Shhh. It's ok. I'm not here to hurt you," Scorpia knew that her voice could boom so she took extra care to keep it as soft and gentle as she could. "I'm just going to sit here and maybe you could come see me?" She lowered herself to the floor and crossed her legs, resting her claws on them. She didn't even know if it understood what she was saying.

Scorpia was surprisingly patient. People looked at her and assumed she stupid and loud, clumsy even. Truthfully she was more clumsy than most, her big claws making it hard for her to carry out the finer skills but she was used to being overlooked and left alone. It had made her used to sitting quietly. So she stayed there, on the cool floor and waited like she would have for any injured little animal.

It took time, but eventually the young thing crawled stiffly out, stretching her body that must have gone stiff after so long. It stayed low to the ground, and looked at the bigger woman appraisingly. Scorpia didn't more, even when it got closer with those vicious looking claws unsheathed, just looked back with a soft smile on her face.

The cub had watched the person that had walked in and sat on the floor. She was much bigger than the kitten and her claws looked like they could inflict a lot of damage, but she never approached the girls hiding spot. Her words had been soft, her voice pleasant and friendly, almost reminding Catra of Adora. The girl was still in pain from the wounds of her fall, but her head had cleared enough that she could piece together what was going on around her. She just had one thing she needed to test. Catra reached out and tapped at the red shell of the one in front of her. Her finger made a tinkling sound as it made contact and the bottom fell of her world. This was not a projection. She was not in the Crystal Castle. This person was real, as flesh and blood as she was. A part of her mind recognised that she had seen this person before.

After tapping at her carapace the feral thing rocked back on its heals with an expression equal parts fear and sadness. Scorpia had had to fight the urge to flinch when that claw had come towards her own, but there had been no malicious intent behind it. She continued to wait for the other to make a move.

"Where?" Hearing it speak was a surprise, the voice was scratchy from thirst and lack of use but the words were clear.

"You don't need to worry, this is the Fright Zone. I found you out in the woods, you were hurt but we brought you back." Slowly she pointed at the bundle on the bed. "I've brought you some clothes. Do you know what those are?" Because the kid was naked so she might not.

"I know what clothes are." Tears stung Catra's eyes as she thought about Razz and the soft flannel of the robe she wore with

her. Would she notice that she was gone? Would she worry? “I’m in the Fright Zone?” That was Adora’s place, maybe she could find her and be safe.

“Yes, this is the Fright Zone. I’m Force Captain Scorpia, you can call me just Scorpia as you’re not a cadet yet. I’m here to take you to the showers and get you cleaned up. The medics patched your head when you got here. Do you want to come for a shower?” The words, once set free spilled out of the white haired woman in torrent.

“I don’t know what a shower is.” It wasn’t a word Adora had taught her.

“It’s a way to wash your body to be clear. The water comes from above, I guess it’s kinda like rain?” She hoped that the child would understand. From the look of them, they were no more than 11 or 12, small slight, but seemed bright enough.

“That sounds fine. I would like to be clean.” She would like to get out of this room and learn her surroundings. As nice as this woman was, it didn’t sound like they intended to return her to the woods.

Scorpia groaned as she got to her feet, lumbering over and carefully reaching down to the child and unlocking the cuffs at her wrists and ankles. She was careful not to seem intimidating, though the forest creature had done nothing to seem like she would lash out. She just seemed small and a little afraid. Scorpia picked up the pile of clothes and towels and walked out of the cell.

“Come on then…” She realised that she did not know what to call them. “Do you have a name?”

“Catra.” There was no point not to tell the woman who looked down at her.

“Come on then Catra.”

The unlikely pair made their way along the halls, the prison block was scarcely used and the guards were sparse, encountering nobody as they moved to the showers for the block. The Horde may be a cold place to live, but prisons were kept fed and clean. They walked in and Scorpia showed Catra how to turn on the shower and what the soap was for before retreating to stand outside and wait. She would take her to Shadow Weaver once she was clean. Maybe the second in command would ask her to take the kid to the mess hall after she debriefed her. Scorpia liked to be useful.

Suffocating. That was how Catra felt as she stood at the centre of a room that was dominated by a big black rock. The fabric against her skin was tight and constricting. The material was slick and stretchy, making her fur itch and stretching across her chest and her shoulders constricting her body in a way she had never known. The tunic that Razz kept for her was loose and soft, it felt like comfort and love. There was no love in this cloth.

Under the shirt and the shorts her fur itched against her skin but everywhere else her fur stood on end, reacting to the strange charge in the air. It felt like ants crawling all over her. It had been a faint charge when she walked into the room but grew more intense as she had moved deeper into the room. The door had shut behind her but the scorpion woman had stayed outside to play sentry. The only place the buzz could be coming from was the stone. She tried to take a step back towards the door and was suddenly gripped in the clutches of a red fire that raced over her body and held her taught. She whined as she felt her feet lifted from the floor and her body moved closer to the rock. The crackling lightening pulled at her but was more numbing than painful.

Catra's body was immobilised, not her own. She tried to move her head to get a glance at who was doing this to her, but her head was as stuck as the rest of her. She was able to moved her eyes, catching a glimpse of the tall shadowed figure she had seen in the

cell. Now that she knew it wasn't Light Hope, she could easily tell. The child chastised herself for being so easily fooled. What sort of guardian would she be?

This new presence that held her hostage in the air was clothed all in red, face obscured by a black and red marks, white souls eyes squinting as they appraised the girl in her power. Her robes seemed to have a life of their own as they moved around her body. As she moved closer Catra realised that she was not walking but levitating. It was all strangely reminiscence for the being made of light who had been training her, the cool exterior, the gliding motion and the lack of expression. Except for the red and black instead of the cool blues she could have been home.

"What have we here?" A long fingered hand reached out and cupped her chin, fingers digging in as she forced her head this way and that. There were too many sensations running through the child, the crackling energy, the buzz from the tone, the clothes the touch and the lingering pain in her head, it was all too much and her almost empty stomach rebelled. Bile burst out of her mouth and onto the hand touching her chin.

The woman reared back as if burned. Even with the mask covering her face the disgust and horror was evident. Then that same hand was back, this time with enough force to send her head flying back as it connected with her check. Catra could taste blood in her mouth where one of her fangs had sliced into the tender flesh. She felt it creep out of the edge of her mouth and start to run through her fur.

"Filthy animal! When I think of all of the effort I have put into finding you, and for what? You are nothing but a disgusting animal, no power at all." Catra trembled as the woman seemed as though she would lash out again, only to come close and intimidate her captive. Both her hands came up and wrapped around the Childs head, moving it speculatively from side to side.

"There is something in here. You had enough residue of power on you that I felt it through a screen," it was obvious that she was

talking to herself. “You know where I can find it. Now I just need you to talk.”

Catra grit her teeth. So this was a test, it might not have been one set by Light Hope, but there had been enough simulations in the Crystal Castle for her to know that she could never tell anyone about the sword or the monolith. She was the guardian. When the time was right she would bring Adora to her destiny. Until then she would suffer whatever fate held in store to protect her duty.

The electricity around her body was no longer numbing as the light began to crackle and excruciating pain raced through her body, making her write and twist in the air.

Adora wondered down the corridor, making good time on her way to this afternoon’s training simulation. She had just aced another written exam and been given effusive praise from the proctor. He had reassured her that she was on target to be the youngest Force Captain in the Horde if she kept this up in all her classes. Adora wasn’t arrogant but she thrived on praise and only ever wanted to please the adults around her.

Her day had been good and, since their return and her debrief with Shadow Weaver she had felt reassured that her friend was safe. None of the other teen s had known where she went and Adora had monitored the comings and goings of the regiments as best she could, and it looked like nobody had been sent to hunt for her in the following days. Knowing that her friend was safe and she was excelling lifted her spirits.

As she moved passed Shadow Weavers room, she was curious to see that Force Captain Scorpia was standing outside as though she was guarding the room. The fact that there was a guard on the room was not unusual. When Shadow Weaver was using her magic or interrogating a prisoner there would often be extra security. It was usually an armour clad grunt, face hidden behind their helmet and not a Force Captain, though.

Curiosity getting the better of her, she walked closer to the woman who stood at attention by the door, “Hello Force Captain.”

Scorpia looked at the young blond who had walked up to her. She knew Adora, remembered taking her out for her training exercises a while ago and her name was always buzzing around in the barracks and among the other Force Captains and trainers. Undoubtedly she was a good cadet, was likely to make waves as she got older, but there was something about her that Scorpia just didn’t like. She wasn’t sure if it was the hair poof she’d started to wear for the self assured way she wondered around as though she owned the place. Scorpia liked just about everyone, but Adora was certainly near the bottom of her list.

“Hello Cadet.”

Adora scratched her head, unsure how she could find out what was going on behind the closed doors. It didn’t seem like the usually chatty scorpioni was in the mood and the blond realised that she would need thistle not to be late to training. She opened her mouth to say something else, when a muffled scream from within filtered through the heavy doors.

Oh. Her questions were answered by that, they must have caught another spy from the princesses. Shadow Weaver was chief interrogator after all.

“Aren’t you going to be late, Cadet?” Scorpia wanted her gone, nobody was supposed to know about the forest creature yet.

“Yes, sorry Force Captain. Have a good day.” Adora threw the taller woman a salute and hustled back towards her training, never knowing how close she was to her friend.

The Box

Chapter Notes

> I got caught up in the world of another fic and Wild took a back seat but I'm back with a slightly longer update!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Being surrounded by trees was usually something that she felt comforted by, it meant that she would soon be seeing Catra and living that little bit of a secret life that they shared. Today it just felt like a trap. She was surrounded by the roaches excitement of the teams of cadets who were now under her temporary command. Their desire to hunt the creature that had been spotted last time was a living thing than ran through them all, a buzz of electric in their skin. For her it was just fear. A weight in the pit of her stomach.

This mission was only two days and essentially battle training in a real world scenario, bots deployed into the fringes of the woods to act as they enemy as they moved out in teams and practiced battle formations. It was a far cry from controlled and regulated conditions within the simulators in the Fright Zone. The bots were the least of the hazards that they would face.

The itinerary for the groups was tight, almost every waking moment accounted for the next forty-eight hours. They would be exhausted at night, falling into their bedrolls without the energy for campfire fun this time round. In a lot of ways it left Adora able to take a breath, there was no time for over eager youths to run int o the woods looking for the cat-girl who was fast becoming a fable told among the cadets. In others it meant that she too would be too tired and pressured to go looking for Catra if she didn’t come to their spot.

The first morning of training went flawlessly, the teams working well and communicating with skill, trained from infancy to work as

units they were seldom outclassed. They were allowed a break for lunch and a debrief over rations, where Adora decided to shuffle the teams to up the intensity of the mission. With half her mind on Catra, the other half was still focused on the prize of becoming Force Captain. She was fast approaching her fifteenth birthday which meant that promotion was only a little over a year away. She had to make it.

With their new teams feeling each other out she shouldn't have been surprised hours later when the air was rent with the howling screams of a teen in trouble. Hustling her own group and calling in back-up from a third they found their way to a group, surprisingly not containing Kyle, who had lost a member down a man-trap. Thankfully it had a smooth floor, no spears to kill the falling victim. Less good was the unnatural angle that the boy's leg had been twisted into and the blood on his face.

Adora wasted no time in barking orders to get the other members of his group to take stock and calm down while fashioning a harness and climbing down do retrieve the older boy. When she got to the bottom of the hole she wasn't surprised to see the walls were littered with tiny tiny score marks. This was obviously a hole that Catra had made, probably over weeks given the size of it. She let herself wonder why and when her friend would have done this; was this a part of what she was learning with Light Hope? Focusing on the task at hand she was pleased to see that the cadet was conscious and claimed that he had not passed out at all. She fastened the rope harness around him, apologising as she watched his eyes fill with tears and a tight scream leave his lips. Soon, with the help of Rogelio's now ridiculously over developed upper body, they had his hoisted up, her clambering out behind. She was thankful to see that Lonnie, ever level headed, had cobbled together and stretcher from tree limbs and vines. It would do the job to get him back to the camp site.

Thankfully they were close to the edge of the woods. The boy was loaded onto a skiff and the rest of his team, traumatised from seeing their teammate injured, joined him to pilot it back to the Fright Zone where medics had been alerted to be on standby. The

day moon was starting to fade by then and Adora made the command decision to call it quits for the day. She presided over a sombre evening meal and there was no push-back when she ordered everybody to their tents for an early night so that they could get back to it bright and early.

One of the privileges of being the commander of the cadet teams was that Adora got her own tiny one man tent. She could come and go as she pleased as long as she was discrete and hid in the shadows. It felt like forever, waiting for the full weight of night to fall and allow her to sneak out. The youth on patrol duty at this end of the clearing was already dozing, making life even easier for her. No citation for her.

Finally it felt like she could take a deep breath as she waited in their spot, looking around at the trees for any sign of the feline up in the canopy. A rustle caught her attention and she looked up, only to see a squirrel scamper away. She sat on a mossy mound to wait, she wasn't sure but she thought she would be willing to wait forever if It meant knowing that the other girl was all right.

The feeling of moss against her cheek roused Adora who grunted inelegantly and righted herself, realising that she must had fallen asleep and slumped against the mossy surface of a nearby tree. It was much darker now, the empty sky hanging oppressively overhead.

Catra was not showing up tonight, it was a stark realisation and she cast plaintive blue eyes back up to the trees, hoping for a glimpse but knowing she wouldn't get one. Dejectedly, shoulders slumped, she crept her way back to her tent. All she could hope for was that out there, deep in the heart of the woods, Catra was curled up in the Crystal Castle after a rigorous day of training. Maybe next time she would be able to go in search of her, or her laughing mismatched eyes would peer down from a tree. There was no need to worry.

Not yet.

Everything was numb. She had never felt so disconnected from her own body before. It was as though she was floating outside of herself, a witness to what was happening to her but not a participant. In some ways she was grateful, the pain of the first few days in this nightmare place had shattered into a million, tiny, Catra shaped pieces. The red lighting, the constriction and the suffocation combined in an almost deadly cocktail but this monstrous woman who always prowled the edges of her consciousness would not let her die. When the witch became frustrated with the lack of results from her magic she would resort to her fists or a lash. That pain, while no less excruciating, was familiar and grounding. It was like falling from a tree or hitting a rock.

The punishment, as her hazy brain had been able to decipher, was for her lack of answers. Light Hope had warned her that people would want to steal the power of the Sword for themselves, that she was its guardian and must stay resolute and strong against anyone who tried to take it. When the time was right she would know, and it would be time to take Adora to the weapon. But that time was not now and this woman was certainly not Adora.

As another blow landed against the side of her body, tearing fur and flesh, leaving blood trickling along her ribs and maybe more sever damage beneath, she allowed her mind to drift. Far away from here and now and into the Crystal Castle. It felt as though she were there, standing in the vestibule and looking up and the benevolently blank face of her guide. Light Hope stared down at her, brow quirked, as though examining her broken physical state, for as she looked down at herself, in her delirious daydream, she was still dressed in the stained Horde cadet uniform that hung on her emaciated form. Should she feel so judged in her own mind?

"You are holding out against an onslaught of great magnitude, little protector. I knew this would come," if she knew why hadn't she stopped it? Catra's mind whirled but the words continues and she foggily tried to concentrate. "I placed this in your mind as a failsafe. You will not give the sword away until the time is right.

Everything you are is safe from this torture. Be not afraid, simply trust in me and your destiny!”

The words faded out on a scream that was ripped from her own throat as another hit in the same place audibly snapped a rib and sent a torrent of blood oozing down from her body to coat the steel table and drip, drip, drip onto the floor.

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Glass shattered as it collided with the wall. The accompanying scream of frustrated anger echoing off the wall as the red liquid spilled down the wall to pool on the floor. It looked like fresh spilled blood and Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes beneath her mask, a predatory smile curving her lips, as she turned them to face the girl strapped to the metal table. The axis that all of her thwarted ambitions revolved around. She had been the sorceresses captive for almost half a year and was still to spill the secrets of the Whispering Woods. She was surprisingly resilient, holding out against all manner of physical tortures.

Shadow Weaver had started slowly, not with kindness, the thing was too base for her to feign that, but with lashes and shouted words. When this had failed to even get a name from the little beast, she had brought out her magic. Drawing out thick ropes of energy and casting it around the girl in red, blistering tendrils which scorched her and made the room fill with the stench of burning fur for days after. Still nothing.

It wasn’t that the girl would show no response to pain. Far from it. She would cry and scream, body thrashing and spasming against her restraints. She would whimper and occasionally, on her most successful days, she would pull a word or two from that fanged mouth. Never anything of use, perhaps even nonsense. More likes names, Hope and Razz, something about a castle. It was entirely possible that she had broken the girl too far but she wasn’t to be denied, if the girl broke? Shattered like the glass against the wall? Who would care, she was a thing that stank of wrongness to her sensitive magic, if she died the incinerator would be waiting.

The older woman was loath to enter the things mind, it was bound to be wild and chaotic, but she was left with no choice after so long. She had other work to do as second in command, it wouldn't do to be derelict in her duties.

Where was that magic? It had been so strong through the monitor all those months ago and now this little husk of a thing was as mundane and powerless as could be.

Today had started off poorly, the monster had enough fight still left in her malnourished and withered shell, that she had snapped at the older woman's fingers and spat at her. In response, she had smacked the child in the head, catching her temple and plunging the girl into unconsciousness when she was needed awake. That had led to the unfortunate demise of her wine.

Groaning from the slab called her back over to her subject, who's eyes were fluttering, fighting to open and reveal the vile sight of their oddness. That's all she needed, it was always better to delve into somebodies mind while they were awake; unconscious minds were a surreal place of images and ideas that could not be trusted. She needed to know whatever she was able to pull out would be realm she was a truth seeker after all, though she may be an expert equivocator herself.

She placed her hands on either side of the furred head, resisting the urge to pull them away in disgust at the feeling of the coarse, matted fur beneath them. She channelled the magic out of the Black Garnet and focused her own mind outwards, almost leaving her own body and moving forward through the connection of fur and flash and into the vessel below her.

It was always a startling transition, moving into another mind, going from the cool and calculated realm of her own psyche into the often chaotic once of another. It was a skill she had honed even before arriving at the Fright Zone. It was one of the skills taught to only the most powerful and trusted of those who dwelt in Mysticore, intended to help rehabilitate the minds of victims of

coma or trauma. Of course, anything designed to heal could easily be made to harm. She was an expert at that.

Moving into the kitten was different, usually there was a garage of colours as she moved through memories and ideas, a cacophony of noises and images. It was a mire of distractions to wade through or eradicate in order to get to your purpose, more often than not to pull out information or eradicate memories, planting her own in their wake. It was a most useful tool to use on the tepid spies sent by the Rebellion, filling their heads with misinformation and sending them back from whence they came. The teens head was blank.

No, not blank, it was like a pitch dark void. There was no colour or sound as she entered, nothing to let her know that she wasn't in the mind of a corpse. If she hadn't seen the eyes blink open, she would doubt it wasn't. Moving forward through the connecting, pushing the rune-stone harder she filled the blackness with glowing red and moved deeper and deeper until she caught a glimpse of a soft blue light which grew brighter until it consumed everything the further she went.

She found herself standing over a box, almost coffin like in aspect, covered in unfamiliar sigils which glowed constantly. The light was soft but pierced through the woman, making her stagger back, pulling away towards her own body. She was nothing it not resolute, and held firm, pushing her own magic forward to meet it.

The more she looked at the object the more she realised that it was seamless, no lock or key, no hinge or seam. This was where everything that she needed to know was held. Somebody had already walked the halls of this animals mind and built a fortress. It was proof positive that it contained secrets. Secrets she wanted to mine.

Shadow Weaver reached out an incorporeal hand to touch the box, only to find herself crashing to the floor of her lair, cast out of the child's mind with unceremonious ease.

Well then, this was progress.

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Adora's second trip to the woods after Catra's sighting was more eventful. It was back to her small squad, a repeat of their wilderness training. Once again they were dropped into the heart of the woods with their equipment and they were to make their way back to a rendezvous point - this time further towards the Fright Zone itself, meaning not only did they need to get through the woods but that they also needed to survive terrain even more inhospitable. They were all a lot more confident this time, even Kyle seemed more self assured than before. For Adora it meant that she would be able to sneak away to the cave and look for her friend, hopefully finding her there. She knew the woods well enough by now, and they knew her, so getting back in time was not a concern.

As each was set down, they waved excitedly and disappeared into the trees. This time the weather was warm and fine making for a much more fun experience sans the rain. Adora was able to direct the skiff operator to drop her where she had been put down last time. She hit the ground running with unerring accuracy towards where she knew Catra's home was located. After an hour she finally broke into the clearing that housed the Crystal Castle and the little cave, panting and sluiced with sweat. She dropped her pack to the ground and bowed over bracing her hands on her knees. The glade seemed eerily quiet and a feeling of foreboding crept up her spine.

Leaving her discarded pack at the treelike she made her way to the cave, calling out the cub's name to no avail. Crouching she wriggled her way through the small opening of the cave and found herself standing inside and cold and abandoned place. There was dust thick everywhere and no sign of life. She bent down to pick up the blanket she had given the other girl and moved outside. She shook the dust from the material and then brought it up to her face, burying her face in it and letting out a muffled scream of frustration. Lowering it she found herself

shouting for LIght Hope, she shouted until her throat was raw but still there was only silence.

Dejectedly she walked back into the woods after sagging her bag and balling up the blanket and forcing it inside. She walked aimlessly in the vague direction of her destination, eyes glancing among the trees looking for claw marks only to see birds and squirrels.

So distracted by her fear and sadness was she that she almost barrelled over the small red robed figure who was suddenly in her path, She caught herself in time, skidding to a stop and falling onto her butt on the ground and letting out a pained whoomph.

"Mara dear, you really must be more careful. If an old woman like me can get the jump on you then how will we ever save everyone?" There was seriousness in her voice belied by the chuckle that Adora had noticed was ever present when Catra had taken her to meet the old hermit so long ago.

"Madam Razz, it's me, Adora not Mara, remember?" Seeing Razz gave her hope that she could get some answers about Catra. Maybe she was living with the old woman in her cottage?

Eyes made giant behind the thick lenses of her glasses looked at her and for a moment they were laser sharp and boring a hole through the girl. Adora had still not risen from the floor and ow she felt frozen there as the old woman walked closer and cupped the side of her face with her hand. She seemed to be examining her, looking for something that she obviously found, as she backed away and brought both hand to rest on her stick.

"Adora, yes, you are the next one. It's still not time. The Wilding knows the time, you must listen to her when she tells you. Try not to let her fall over the cliff into the shadows. She is with them now. The Wildling is starting to be become the angry one." It was clear she was talking about Catra, but Adora had no idea what she meant.

“Razz, can’t you be clear? I don’t understand!” Now she was standing and there was pleading in her voice.

“You will Adora dear, you will.” Razz turned her back on the girl and started away.

“Don’t leave! Help me!”

“Oh Mara, don’t be silly, you’re here to help me get berries for pie.” And then she was gone, melting into the trees as though she had never been there at all. Leaving Adora alone with nothing but jumbled words, a blanket and a very bad feeling.

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Scorpia walked down the empty, eerily quiet corridor, to the little cat’s room. Ever since she and Octavia had brought the youth in, she had been placed in charge of monitoring her progress when she was outside of Shadow Weavers room. She brought the kids food, which was usually left to mould in the corner, until the big scorpion couldn’t stand the smell anymore and would remove them.

After the first day Shadow Weaver had been adamant that the child never left the cell unless it was to attend her daily interrogations, which meant that she was now blood spattered and filthy, her fur matter and her eyes were dull. Scorpia was not a woman for whom cruelty came easily, if at all, and her heart broke as she entered the cell to see that today the girl was curled in a ball with her tail twisted unnaturally and limp in a way it never was. There was a wet patch beneath her and the Force Captain realised that the child had wet herself as she could not make it to the toilet in the corner of the room. The room stank of rotten food, vomit and urine, a pungent stench that made her gag and quickly step back out.

Nobody could deserve what this forest creature was being put through, and for what she had never been told. She followed orders as she always had but a small fire of rebellion had started to blossom in her chest when she was near her charge. She had

snuck her to the showers as many times as she could get away with over the months, which wasn't many but she had tried. She sometimes brought her old, tattered uniforms from the rag pile that were cleaner than her own. There had even been several times where she had snuck a medic down to the cell under promise of secrecy for extra rations (her own, she would rather go hungry than steal) to patch up the worst of the wounds.

Nothing had ever been as troubling as today. There was always a spark about the girl, a quivering kind of anticipation that she could pounce and unleash those dangerous looking claws at any moment. Something that screamed of the woods and how this girl had lived until she and Octavia had plucked her away. Scorpia hated to feel bad, or examine what might not be quite right about her home, she was a good soldier but also a bleeding heart and she knew that some people though that made her liability. She wanted to prove that it wasn't, that it would get loyalty from her people.

Setting the wrapped ration bar outside on the ground, she took down the forcefield and walked in to where the kid wasn't even chained up anymore, Shadow Weaver apparently thinking that all the fight had finally gone. Approaching like she would have a wounded animal that she was trying to help, Scorpia got into a crouch and mad rushing noises, further troubled by how the small body didn't move at her intrusion. Even those usually so expressive ears were mobile. If she couldn't see the ribs being sucked in with shallow breaths she would believe that she was looking at a corpse.

"Hey Kitty, I brought you some food, but I guess you're not that hungry right now, huh?" Her voice was soft, something unusual for her but she was boisterous, not thoughtless. "Gosh, you look real dirty. How about I take you to the showers and go and get some clean clothes?" There was, as always, no response. "I'm gonna lift you up, I hope that's ok. One, two, three." She slipped her big claws under the fragile body and scooped her up, noting that she was far lighter than when she had been captured in the woods.

Without thought, Scorpia walked away from the cell, knowing that she was going to need to change her own uniform after this, and headed towards one of the showers that she knew would be abandoned at this time of day. She moved passed a storage room and grabbed a sealed uniform for herself, and one of the ones from the recycle bin for the girl, not daring to give her new. The girl never stirred even when she was momentarily set down.

They made it to the shower and Scorpia punched in her Force Captain authorisation which would give her the luxury. Of a full 20 minute shower, a luxury for officers that she was happy to fruit today in favour of offering it to the prisoner. Usually, on the few occasions she'd brought her here, she moved to block the door and allowed the kid to undress herself and look after her own needs. That seemed like an impossibility today so with soft words and as much care as her claws could take she cut the soiled cloth from the furred body, observing the bald patches under the clothing where it looked like the fur had been burned away, and the dozens of scars, healed and fresh that covered her.

The shower was switched on, and still in her own dirty uniform, she moved under the spray and cleaned up the girl, trying not to look as she dealt with her more private areas but knowing it was necessary. It was hard to tell how old the creature was, she had seemed maybe a teen when she had been captured, but now she was so emaciated she looked no more than twelve or so.

Scorpia efficiently dried them both and redressed herself and the girl, who still had not stirred. By the time that Scorpia returned to the prison cell, the smell seemed even stronger now they were clean. Making a decision, she placed the girl in the neighbouring cell and used the com pad on her old cell to call janitorial to clean. She was sure nobody would care the girl had moved one door down. What harm could it do?

Shadow Weaver looked at her handiwork. If she was to be stymied in getting the information form the lockbox of the girls mind, she would wipe everything else clean and make her anew

as a member of the Horde. She was not a woman to waste resources and this filthy little animal was, if nothing else, a walking weapon of teeth and claws. Her body was stronger and more resilient than it appeared and she would die working for them in the glorious name of conquest.

She had pushed her magic back through the girl's temples and into her mind, scorching everything in the darkness around the box, leaving her mind as a charred and smoking, red tinged ruin. The child had long since stopped reacting, so broken that she was almost catatonic. That would have to change if she was to be placed in the cadet quarters.

Standing in front of the girl who was standing in the centre of the room, dressed in a fresh set of cadet whites. Her grey leggings were only just small enough to fit, while the white and red shirt hung on her boney frame, her matted arm fur looking dark by contrast. Shadow Weaver had toyed with hacking off the unruly nest of hair but decided that it made her look more like she had just been 'saved' from the wild. No need for any of the other youths to ask too many questions.

"Can you understand me?" Her serpentine voice pierced into the girl, making her ears droop and her eyes turn to her. A brittle nod was her answer. "Good. This is who you are, pay attention." The words were almost redundant, the message was being piped straight into her mind via the red tinged magic, but over the years the witch had found that words reinforced the power of the magic.

She wove a story of a feral girl, abandoned by her family in the woods who had grown up alone since she was small. She could speak but had no social graces and had not meant to frighten the cadets who had seen her. She had been delighted when she had been rescued from the woods and after being decontaminated for lice and fleas she was now happy to join the Horde as a cadet where she would get fed as she had been starving in the wild. Finer details were unimportant, there was little time for frivolity in

the life of the cadets. They were constantly kept busy; idle hands and all that.

The beast parroted the information back to her with a blank face and she was pleased at her success. Now the question was where to put her, she would need to be kept away from Scorpia, the bumbling fool had clearly taken a shine to this thing and made it her pet. That was easily done as the young Force Captain could be deployed anywhere. Octavia on the other hand, shared her own callous desire for power and cared not a jot for it. Really there was only one answer.

Adora had always been her favourite cadet, and the fact that she buzzed with underlying power was simply a perk. Since the moment Hordak had given her the baby all those years ago, she had been shaping her into the perfect soldier; loyal, clever and obedient. She was so eager to receive praise it made controlling the young woman almost too easy at times. If she place this thing in her bunk-room and into her square, she would certainly report back any anomalies.

She bade the cat to follow her down the corridors and eventually into the cadet areas where she was directed to the bunk above Adora's own, in case anything were to slip from the creature in her sleep, no better way for the human girl to hear them and report back.

The girl climbed up dumbly and curled into a ball on the thin mattress. Shadow Weaver severed her connection, no need to puppet her strings now. She would be who she had crafted her to be. The second in command was heading for the door when she heard the clamour of feet and chattering voices as the cadet's who shared this room rounded the doorframe, almost bumping into her but having the reflexes instead to instantly stand to attention. She ran her eyes over Adora's squad; the girl, the scrawny one and the big lizard. They were excelling under her protege's leadership and she was proud.

“Ah, Adora, I am glad to see you all back. I trust that your simulation training was successful today and I look forward to evening your scores. Adora flushed while the other three try not to fidget. “I have brought a recent recruit who was found in the woods. We have rehabilitated her, though she is still somewhat feral. I leave her under your command, it will be your job to keep her on a tight leash. You will report any issue to me immediately.” Not waiting for a response, she swept passed them, throwing over her shoulder, “It doesn’t seem to have a name so you may give it one.” And she was gone.

While Shadow Weaver had been speaking Adora had felt her knees turn to jelly, knowing beyond a doubt who she was going to find on that bunk. Even if she had not spotted the familiar tail she would have known. How long had she had the cub? Was that where she had been all this time?

She did her best not to run over to the bunk, instead staying with the larger group who all eyes the still figure with suspicious.

“You think it’s the thing from the woods?” Whispered Kyle in a voice too loud not to be heard by the large ears of the newcomer.

“Probably, I’ll bet she’s been told to spy on us.” Lonnie’s always gloomy outlook came out in full force as Rogelio grunted in agreement.

“I tell you what, I give you permission to have extra rec time, I’ll debrief this new recruit and bring her up to speed.” She just wanted them to go!

“All right! You don’t have to tell us twice Adora.” Lonnie grabbed a hand of each the boys and pulled them out of the room without a backwards glance.

Still unable to relax, Adora took a shuddering breath and made her way over to the bunks, hoisting herself up with the girl clearly hiding herself there. She didn’t speak, just ran her eyes over the bones sticking through her clothes and the patches of missing fur.

The person in front of her was not the girl she had curled up to sleep with so many months ago. She had obviously been with Shadow Weaver all this time. Lost in the shadows as Razz had said.

“Hey Catra?” Her voice was so soft that no human would hear, but the big ears flapped towards her. There was no verbal response, but the smaller girl raised her face so that her eyes could peer up from her folded arms. Adora had feared they would be empty, she had heard the rumours about what Shadow Weaver was capable of but those eyes still looked like her friend.

She reached out a tentatively hand, watching for any sign that it was unwanted, and laid it on the other girls head by her ear. Catra didn’t flinch from her touch, in fact she leant into the soft touch, her whole body seeming to relax like a traveller coming home from a long journey. Adora couldn’t help but notice how grimy and matted the mane was, so unlike it’s usual wild freedom. It would take the both of them to get it clean. With infinite gentleness she scratched at the base of the ear and heard a long sigh escape the other girl.

“Hey, Adora.” The words were barely intelligible, whispered through a bruised jaw and coming from a mind frayed and terrorised. “She couldn’t take me away but I have to pretend to be gone.”

The words sounded nonsensical and jumbled, but the triumphant set of the cubs jaw told Adora that it was important and she locked the words away to ask more later. Right now it was important to feed the girl back up and untangle that hair. But first, she just needed to hold the other girl and know she was real. Glancing at the door she was assured that they were alone before she laid down behind the still balled up body and held her close. Whatever was happening Adora would protect her.

Chapter End Notes

Reunited and it feels so good...

Morning

Chapter Summary

The first morning back together.

Chapter Notes

A quick little update to follow yesterday's.

The next morning Adora uncurled herself from Catra, pleased to note that though the others had arrived back last night nobody had disturbed them. It was not unusual for her to wake long before the others and she thanked Hordak that she would get some time with Catra before the others roused and got rowdy. She would have to pull the trio aside and demand that they not tell Shadow Weaver, it would get both she and Catra in trouble for fraternising and the cat girl didn't look like she could take much more. She stood up quietly and stretched out limbs that had been bunched up for too long. She tried but failed to hold in a squeak as something popped in her elbow. That small sound was enough to send Catra darting to the far end of the bed, body trembling and claws extended, hissing lowly at the threat.

"Hey, it's just me." Adora spoke so softly that without her cat ears the younger girl wouldn't have heard. Her eyes looked huge under the morning lighting in the bunk room, frantic until they settled on her and she watched the girl go from rigid and hissing to limp in a heartbeat.

Taking the chance, Adora moved back to the bed and crawled slowly towards her friend with a hand outstretched. Catra watched her with suspicious eyes, whatever part of her that had allowed her to relax with Adora last night had retreated and in its place was fear. Adora withdrew her hand but made soft, shushing noises to try to coax the air to relax.

“I don’t know what she’s done to you but you’ll be ok now. I’m here and I’ll look after you. I’ll make sure that you’re good and Shadow Weaver,” the other girl shrank even further into herself at the mention of the name and hissed again. “She won’t hurt you as long as you behave. She never hurts me because I follow the rules.” She could see that her words were just confusing the other girl, so sat back on her haunches and thought about her next move.

In the harsh fluorescent light of day in the cadets room, Catra’s state was even more obvious, her uniform was rags and her hair and fur were dirty and matted. There was a strong door coming from her that was like ozone and it tickled her nose so much be driving the feline mad. It was early enough that none of the other cadets would rouse themselves for at least thirty minutes which was plenty of time to carry out the plan that had just entered her mind.

“Hey, hey,” dazed those dual coloured eyes turned to her with little recognition. “How would you like to get clean, huh? Come with me.” She got off of the bed and walked over to the doorway, turning to look expectantly at her friend. Her heart soared when the small girl crawled off the bed and inched her way to join her.

Whatever notions she had last night about being together with Catra in the Fright Zone, lay dead now at the sight of her. She walked down the corridor to the showers and pulled two towels from the unit, tearing them out of the plastic they were rapped in. Even the slight sound of the plastic tearing made the furred girl flinch. Adora was careful as she approached her again, trying to make eye contact which was resisted. Leaving Catra where she was for now, she went to requisition a clean uniform, seeing that the only small one left was the red kind, but it would have to do. She signed the sheet and logged her code before taking it. It would mean that she would have to wear her dirty uniform a second time but it was worth it. Holding the clothes, she felt uncomfortable about putting Catra into them. Seeing her dressed in the uniforms, even the rags that she now wore, seemed obscene somehow when she knew she should be naked and free.

Pulling herself together she made her way back into the changing room and was relieved to see that the cat girl had undressed and thrown the rags in the disposal, as though she knew what do here, which was a relief. When she walked closer though, her breath caught at the sight of the girl in front of her and she had to bite down on a sob that was desperate to escape.

Catra's body was all bones, all the muscle tone acquired through a lifetime of running though the forest gone in a few months. Her glossy fur was dull, balding in places or singed and there were obvious scars poking through littering her body. The chubby faced, well muscled woodland creature had been killed in this place, even if her body was still standing before her. The smaller girl felt the weight of the stare and reached across her body to grip her other elbow, trying to sooth herself from judgement, her head bowed.

"Have you used the showers before?" It seemed a safe enough question. Catra nodded her head, ears still pressed close to her head. "Ok, that's good. That's great. I'll wait here to make sure nobody comes in." Catra hesitated. "Go on, you'll be fine, I promise."

Finally those words seemed to make an impact and she shuffled into the showers, Adora was relieved to hear the water start running. Alone for the moment she let herself sag against the doorframe, keeping her promise to keep watch even as tears spilled down her cheeks. She was fifteen and almost a Force Captain, she shouldn't cry but how could she not? She'd known something was wrong but had let herself hope and where had that led? Her friend was broken and it was all her mentors fault. How was she supposed to reconcile that? Shadow Weaver had always been good to her. Whatever she wanted she must have got, and now Adora would make Catra into the perfect cadet so that there would be no reason for the Second in Command to look her way again.

By the time the shower shut off, she had wiped her face on her sleeve and got her breathing under control. She needed to know

how bad a state the other girl was in, physically she was obviously half starved and injured, but what might be going on in her mind was even more worrying. Last night she had known her, had accepted her embrace and they had slept together but this morning she seemed dazed and afraid.

Hearing wet footfalls slap against the tile of the floor, she unfolded the towels and made her way to the girl who now looked more like a drowned rat and even smaller with her fur slicked to her body. Gently and with as much care as she could, Adora wrapped one towel around the shivering body and another around her head. There was no resistance to her touch, jut resignation in those slumped shoulders, but the blond would take what she could get as she worked the towel over the small body and hair until as much moisture possible was gone. She handed Catra the uniform and watched as she pulled it on, glad that she cut a hole for her tail in the pants.

“Catra, can you come and sit with me on that bench over there?” She nodded, docile, and made her way over as Adora threw the towels in the laundry and then joined her, sitting by her side.

“Do you know me?” It hurt to ask but she had to be sure.

“Yes, Adora.” The words were rough and quiet.

“Ok, that’s great. Do you know who we are together?” Adora hated that she could be so clumsy with words.

“Friends.” There was a certainty there and the eyes met hers at last.

“Do you know where?” This was important, she could feel it. Catra shook her head, starting to seem agitated by the question. “Do you know the woods? The Crystal Castle?”

The younger girl began to become agitated, eyes wild and body shaking at these questions. She shook her head more and more agitatedly until Adora stopped talking and wrapped her arms

around the shaking girl. She started to shush in her ears again and felt the other girl relax into her.

“That’s all ok, Catra. You know me and you know I’m you’re friend and those are the most important things. I’ll help you catch up with everybody and you can be part of my team.” The words were spilling out as much to sooth herself as her friend.

Time passed and soon they heard the sounds of the other cadet barracks waking up. Hurriedly Adora told Catra to follow her lead, stick close and everything would be fine. Dutifully, the cat girl did as she was instructed and was led back to her new home. The only home she could remember.

Inside the room Lonnie was fixing her braids while Rogelio ribbed Kyle for his bedhead. It was familiar and Adora took comfort in the fact that they hadn’t changed. She just needed to make sure that they accepted the newcomer.

“Hi guys,” her voice was bright and cheery even while Catra hid half behind her as they passed through the entrance. The others all acknowledged her with a flat, tired ‘hi’ or a grunt.

“Who’s the newbie?” Lonnie’s voice had an edge that Adora didn’t like, but she knew it was just because she wanted to protect their tiny Horde family.

“This is Catra, she’s new. We’re going to make sure that she gets up to speed so that she doesn’t bring our scores down. We need to be a team.” She noticed that Kyle’s eyes were studying Catra, though he didn’t seem to recognise the girl who had saved him. In her dishevelled state she wasn’t surprised. Good, the less people that connection the better.

The team had made their way to breakfast, she had managed to help Catra to the mess and sat her down while retrieving a ration bar for both of them. The emaciated girl had looked at the grey bar with disgust but hunger had outweighed everything else and she had stuffed it into her mouth and gagged it down in three

bites. Adora had noticed all of the other cadets at her table watching the new arrival with hawklike intensity, seeing what she was made of. Adora would have to flex some muscle until Catra got back into good physical condition, some of the cadets were always looking for somebody weaker to take out their frustrations. Kyle was lucky that he had Rogelio, and nobody wanted to tussle with him.

Her thoughts were brought back to the girl beside her as she heard a gagging noise and then Catra was vomiting the contents of her stomach over the table, decimating the breakfasts, and appetites of everybody around her. The food must have been too much too soon and her stomach had rebelled. Adora cursed herself for not thinking of that, but she had never gone hungry so she hadn't thought.

Angry voices rose around them and one large boy from the year above moved towards them faster than Adora could react and pulled harshly at Catra's tail, causing her to let out a scream so heart stopping that the noise in the room stopped at once. Adora could see Catra's breath coming out in small, ragged pants before suddenly her eyes rolled back and she fell back from the bench she sat on, hitting the ground hard with a clang as her skull made contact with the ground.

"Enough!" It was Force Captain Octavia, marching over to the scene from where she had just entered the mess. She stood over the prone girl and curled her lip in disgust, kicking her non-to-gently and getting no reaction. "You, clean this up." This was directed at the boy who had left his seat to pull the cat's tail. "The rest of you," she waved at those cadets whose food had been vomited on and raised her voice. "Get yourselves a new ration bar and eat fast."

Octavia reached down and grasped Catra by her already stained uniform and dragged her to her feet, where she simply hung limply in the bigger woman's grasp. Her swear was now positively evil as she glared at the broken thing in her hold.

“Force Captain, I can take her back to the bunks and get her cleaned up for training. I wouldn’t’t want my team to be docked points.” She put on her best smile and most obedient voice.

“Fine, just make sure it doesn’t do this again!” Catra was thrust into Adora’s arms and she wasted no time in wrapping her arm around Catra and dragging her back to their bunk. She would make this better.

Together/Apart

Chapter Notes

> I have struggled with this chapter - more transitional than anything else but next time we will going Adora in the woods.

Adora bolted upright in bed, hand reaching out next to her and coming away empty. She looked around frantically until she caught a glimpse of the form curled down by her feet. Her heartbeat slowed and she leaned forward to softly run a finger along the edge of a velvety ear, making it twitch in annoyance. The blond teen smiled softly, easily able to make out the shape of her best friend curled at her feet. Now she was more awake the warmth thrown off by the furred girl gathered her feet and was something she was grateful for on the coldest nights in the Fright Zone.

She could almost forget that Catra had not always been with her here. The more times passed, the easier it was to believe that their adventures in the Whispering Woods had been nothing but dreams or flights of fancy. When Shadow Weaver asked her if the feline had done or said anything of interest, her answer was always a grim denial. It wasn't lying, Catra had done nothing to show that she had any inkling of the past other than her attachment to Adora herself. The commander never asked her if she had met Catra before, so she didn't need to tell her. Omission wasn't a lie, even if it played on her conscious. That and the constant worry for the younger girl sometimes made her heart feel too big for her chest and her breath come out in jagged waves. When that happened, almost like instinct, Catra would pull her away somewhere small and quiet and press her body against hers while she purred long and loud until the feeling passed.

In the first few weeks that Catra had been delivered to her, Adora had tried to probe what she remembered. Initially she had though that perhaps the cub needed time to heal from her clearly abused state. As time went on the gaping void in her mind became more

and more obvious. She looked blankly into blue eyes when she bought up the Crystal Castle, Light Hope or Razz. The blond found herself laughing it off. She was fourteen and not equipped to deal with this at all. It was enough that Catra was close by and mostly safe. SHe had tried to get into teh Crystal Castle on missions in the intervening year and found it empty and quiet, as for Razz she was as elusive as a spirit.

Adora couldn't kid herself that Catra was safe. Shadow Weaver all too often pulled the cub away and would don't return her for days. As weeks passed into months and then a year had gone by, the frequency of these disappearances never wavered, though the reason for them seemed to evolve. When no information came from the kitten, the interrogations - or whatever happened in the Black Garnet chamber, became about frustration and control. Catra tried very hard to be 'good' at first, while Shadow Weaver found fault with everything she did. If Catra was good at something, it wasn't enough no matter how hard she tried. They were now at a point where Catra was growing belligerent and harsh in the face of the cruelty and no amount of care from Adora seemed to be able to stem the tide.

The bright spot was that soon Adora would become a Force Captain and she would be able to bring Catra along with her to a square that wouldn't be under the constant scrutiny of the masked woman. She would be able to take care of the girl that she had cared about for most of her young life.

Luminous eyes shone at her from the dark at the end of the bed, Catra scrutinising her in the dark with her perfect night vision. Her low voice barely carrying up to the head of the bed.

"You ok 'Dora?" There was still exhaustion in her voice and Adora felt a little twinge of guilt that she had disturbed her sleep.

"Yeah, just had a strange dream. Sorry I woke you." Her voice was just as low, and they both sat silently looking at each other in the dark. Adora hoped that Catra couldn't see her blush. The older

she got the more confusing her feelings for her friend became, especially when they were soft with each other.

"Idiot, you don't have to be sorry for waking me up. You're my best friend. Do you want me to come up there?" They rarely slept next to each other, that was something from the before times and it seemed wrong to the blond to do it when the feline didn't know what it meant to her. But tonight it didn't seem wrong. Adora reached out a hand in entreaty and Catra rubbed her head into it like a housecat as she prowled up the bed and laid behind the taller girl, spooning her through the blanket. "Relax. You guys are heading out to the woods tomorrow, you need all the rest you could get.

Adora put her head back onto her thin pillow and allowed her body to melt into the warm embrace, trying not to think about the fact that, for the fourth time, she and the cadet unit would be heading back to the Whispering Woods minus Catra. Adora found no answers or peace there, not anymore, and constantly worried about the girl she left behind.

As though that very girl could read her thoughts, Catra wrapped her hands around her middle and pulled her even closer until she could purr soothingly into her ear. Adora covered the interlaced, clawed hands that sat on her abdomen with her own and let herself be pulled into sleep.

Catra moved through the training exercise with ease. She leapt from pillar to post, dodging the wild swings of her opponent and hearing their growled curses as they stumbled from the momentum of their aborted attack. If she were sparring with Adora, she would have thrown her head back and laughed at the human girl, throwing a friendly jibe at her. Getting one back in return. Not today, though.

Adora had been bundled off by Shadow Weaver for one of their 'meetings', before heading out on another training exercise in the

woods. There had been no time to spend together that morning. Catra was almost certain that they were discussing her in those sessions, as well as Adora's glorious future as the hero of the Horde. Adora had let slip, soon after she had woken up confused and knowing nothing more than who Adora was and that she needed to stay close to her, that Shadow Weaver wanted to know anything unusual that Catra did. Adora had promised her that she would never share her secrets with the terrifying woman. Not the Catra had any secrets to share, her memory was still a black void filled with the light of only Adora.

Catra had learned a few things since she first woke up and snuggled into Adora's arms;
Shadow Weaver brought only pain for the slightest infraction
Adora was the only person she could rely on
Lonnie was mean but fair
Kyle was weak
The food was terrible
No biting
You can't eat the lizard
She didn't get to leave the Fright Zone

The penultimate thing on the list was laughable, really, Rogelio was easily three times her size and as immovable as a boulder. He spoke in hisses and grunts that she was still attempting to get to grips with, though even the kids who had grown up with him seemed lost. In the two years that she had been a cadet in the Horde, she had come to trust him. If she couldn't fight with Adora at her back, then she would take Rogelio. The shared a synergy on the battlefield that she could only assumed came from their animal heritages.

Her aptitude for battle had come as a surprise to all of the instructors. After her incident in the mess hall she had been poked and prodded, assessed for eligibility to be in Adora's unit and almost been found wanting; her muscle tone had been non existent and she had been emaciated to near skeletal. If not for Shadow Weavers insistence she was pretty sure that she would have found herself in the mines, one thing that she could be

grateful to her great tormentor for at least. Imagine the surprise of those same instructors when she had proved to be fast, agile and able to slice through metal with ease even in her weakened state. Once she had been properly fed and given a strength regimen she was a match for even Adora.

It didn't take her long to realise that being a match for Adora was equally as dangerous as being weak though. The first, and only, time that she had beat the blond in combat had been with staffs and she had easily moved with speeds that the more muscular girl could not withstand and disarmed her. She had stood over her friend, staff end held to her neck and a smirk on her face as Adora had looked up at her with shining, proud eye. Then she had felt herself torn away, and thrown across the room. Cat-like reflexes had saved her from careening into a wall but not from being dragged from the room and shown exactly what happened if she damaged Adora or her reputation. She hadn't made that mistake again, holding back whenever they were paired together. Unleashing her power on everyone else, and making no friends doing it.

Sometimes, she and Adora would climb to the top of one of the rickety towers and just be with each other. It felt familiar and foreign all at once, the place was wrong but the feeling was comforting. Catra would lounge on the narrow railing, body perfectly balanced while she let her legs dangled, while Adora would sit on the rusty floor with her legs crossed and leaning back on her hands. They would both look out into the smoggy haze, able to make out just a hint of the Whispering Woods sitting in the distance. Catra would let her tail cost over Adora's neck and upper arms, pretending not to notice when the other girl's breath would hitch.

At night, Catra would rack her brain for anything that would tell her where she came from, or who she had been. Why she could remember Adora as vividly as she could remember how to walk or talk, yet everything around those memories was a black void. Sometimes, if she focused hard enough, the darkness would have a blue glow around the edges but if she pushed too hard her head

would begin to ache until she lost consciousness. She couldn't afford for that to happen, vulnerability here was dangerous.

Slinking away from training, bypassing the locker room completely for fear of reprisal (especially with all of her unit far, far away) Catra found herself back at her special spot. It felt more lonely, colder somehow with the other girl gone, but other than her bed, it was the place she felt closest to Adora. I wasn't the first time that they had all gone to the woods without her, in fact it was the fourth. She wasn't sure why Shadow weaver had made the edict that's he was to always stay behind. She knew that she had been found in the woods and rescued by two Force Captains, maybe the older woman was afraid that she would run away.

Where would she go?

Everything she knew and loved was here in this acrid, mechanical place. She could no more walk away from Adora than she could shed her skin and become lizard-kin. She perched on the railing, Feet on the bar while she crouched with her hands dangling between her knees. Her body was coiled and perfectly balance. It was probably foolhardy to do this while she was alone, no matter how agile she may be a fall of that magnitude would surely kill her, but that didn't stop her. She squinted her eyes and thought, just maybe, she could make out two large skiffs heading away across the no-mans land between the Fright Zone and the Whispering woods.

Never

Chapter Summary

Always listen to Razz.

Once, the Whispering Woods had been a place she counted down the days until she visited. Catra had been there and they had played and laughed and just been children together, out of sight of anyone else. She still had Catra, or a version of her, but that was in the Fright Zone. Now when she went on training exercises in the woods, it was a feverish search for any clues about what had happened to her friend and how to reverse it. With each mission, the fear of what might befall her friend in her absence grew.

At first, the feline had been scared and skittish, easily capitulating to the wants and desires of their superiors and Shadow Weaver. As the months had passed, she had grown more and more capable. Stronger and faster than any of the other cadets, even Adora herself. It hadn't surprised the blond girl, she knew exactly how amazing her young friend was, having watched her fly through the trees and pluck birds out of the air more than once. As her physical abilities had been restored, so had her capriciousness that grated on their superiors and peers alike. Catra did not follow orders well, it seemed, and that led to punishments, some that Adora saw and others that were far more fighting as Shadow Weaver would pull the younger girl away.

After her aborted attempt to contact Light Hope when she was at the cave, Adora had tried to find any sign of the strange old woman that Catra had taken her to visit. Razz had been odd and spoken in riddles, but had clearly cared for Catra. Surely she would have missed the other girl by now and would help Adora find out what was happening to her?

So far, none of her attempts to find her had been successful. During her previous few trips to hunt for the ancient lady she had

come away empty handed. Either stymied by the needs of her mission, or the fact that she couldn't get far enough into the Woods on her night time excursions to have any hope of finding the strange little cottage. Added to that was the fact that Lonnie was far too observant and had started to become far to curious about what she was up to at night. The last thing she needed was to be followed into the heart of the woods and be asked questions that she could not, would not, answer. That had led to her staying in her tent and making no progress for most of the last trip out.

This time would be different, though. They were to be split into two teams, taking part in a war game. Fighting bots in a simulated environment was one thing, tackling a real live foe in the wilds was another. By now they all had experience of navigating the edges of the wilderness and knew how to survive there well enough. This exercise was to see how well they could apply all the skills they had accrued over the last seven years. It was a precursor to the selection for Force Captains that would soon be upon them. This elaborate game of capture the flag would see the losing team with a lot to answer for.

Adora, clever and sharp in a different way to her feral best friend, had a plan. Even before the skiffs had set them down she had separated the group into two teams, one led by Lonnie and the other by one of the loud mouthed burly boys who always got on her last nerve on these expeditions. It raised eyebrows that she was not taking a leading role. On the ground she explained that she was going to act as a marshal, monitoring the game play to ensure that nobody was hurt or cheating. Rogelio and three others were also given these roles, two placed in each team while she claimed she would float. It was genius and meant that for almost four days she could lose herself in the woods. It was underhanded, and went against her nature, but where Catra was concerned she found that she had little concern for anything else.

"You sure about this, Adora?" Lonnie sidled up to her as the others gathered their gear. This time round there were small wagons of weapons and supplies for them to set up there camps to defend, along with their packs and tents.

“Why wouldn’t I be? I can’t always take the lead, Lonnie. That’s not what a good commander does. I have to delegate.” She was pleased with her response, as she rested her hands on her hips and surveyed the group so that she didn’t have to make eye contact with the girl who had known her almost her whole life.

“About time, you big glory hog. Give some of the rest of a chance to shine!” Her words were harsh, but she bumped Adora with her shoulder affectionately.

“Well, you best go and get your people together then, captain.” She threw the darker girl and smile and watched her hustle over to her team and start barking orders at them.

“Teams,” she raised her voice and all heads turned to her. “You will have the next twelve hours to strike out, find a basecamp and fortify it. I will contact you in twelve hours, when you will exchange coordinates and then it becomes who can deploy, defend and pursue the most effectively.” She looked at the faces of each team member in turn. “Keep your comms open. If there is ant trouble call for help, nobody wins if somebody is wounded. May the best team win.” The words had barely left her mouth when the teams were scrambling to be the firs to disappear into the woods.

Soon Adora was standing alone, the other marshals having gone with their selected groups. Waving off the two skiffs, she waited until they too were piloted out of sight. Throwing her pack over her shoulders, she headed down the line of trees until she could disappear into the familiar spot that opened up to the clearing that she would always think of as hers and Catra’s. Knowing that time was of the essence, she set a brisk pace through the clearing and into the trees. Knowing the rout back to Catra’s cave by heart, she made rapid progress getting there, only stopping when her body screamed for rest and a ratio bar. By the time night began to fall, she found herself at the base of a rock wall that was unfamiliar. Had she taken a wrong turn?

Looking up, in the fading light she could see that there were plenty of hand and foot holds but as the shadows got longer she knew that it would have to wait till morning. She could go around this obstacle, but she couldn't risk the woods turning her around. The woods were notorious for changing and disorientating the people who entered, it was why trying was so important and also why the Horde had never been able to break through it. It had never tried to stop her before, as though it understood that she would never hurt it or the lonely girl who lived there. Today though it seemed to have other ideas.

Pitching her tent in the shadow of the cliff, she didn't bother with a fire. Breaking open a grey ration bar and choking it down, she called into to both of the teams. All was well and the bases had been selected and set. Coordinates were exchanged and both teams knew not to start manoeuvres until daybreak. It wasn't a war strategy, but they were only youths and if they began to fight tomorrow they would forget about her in the excitement of the challenge.

She retreated into her tent and bundled herself up into the sleeping bag she had brought, a small blanket tucked tight to her body. It wasn't hers but contained the comforting scent of the girl for whom she was seeking answers. Soon she was sleeping, her brain working furiously through a jumble of confusing images of the tall blue woman, an angry faced Catra and a strange, lowing sword swaddled in vines that seemed to call to her.

In her dreams she reached out for the sword, even as she heard Catra screaming her name, and as her hand tightened around the hilt a blast of energy threw her though the air! Then she was sitting up, clutching at her chest and breathing heavily as sweat tricked down her temple. The dream had been disorientating and waking up alone felt wrong. Seeing the weak light of morning already illuminating the tent, she rose and broke camp, rather than trying to get any more sleep. Downing another ration bar and stretching, she bundled everything back into her pack and secured it firmly to her back.

Looking up, and up, she plotted a rout and as soon as the light was bright enough for safety. She thanked providence that she had been climbing around the Fright Zone with the cat girl so much that she was no longer intimidated by an obstacle like this. Reaching up she took a firm hold and used her superior muscle tone to start pulling her body up.

Halfway to the top her fingers felt raw and her thought were burning. Sweat trickled between her skin and her back and she could feel the chaffing sensation that told her she was going to have blisters in some odd places. She really wished she had had the foresight to bring gloves as she felt a small trail of blood trail down her palm from the scraped skin of a finger. Sweat was starting to roll down her face as the morning heated up, and she tried vainly to wipe it on her forearm. Taking a breath she kept moving up, already to far from the ground to head back. She just hoped that she would be able to find an easier path back.

Finally, after what seemed like hours, but was probably closer to forty minutes, she was grasping her hands over the top edge of the wall. With a big push from her legs she was throwing herself over the edge and laying sprawled on the grass at the top, throwing an arm over her face as she took big gulps of air. She desperately needed a drink but it was under her in her pack. Before she could move she felt an odd sensation against the sole of her boot.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Moving her arm from her face and craning her neck up, eyes widening in shock as she saw the red dress and wild white hair of the woman she had been looking for! She was so shocked that all she could do was stare, unmoving as the old woman continued to hit her boot with the end of her broom.

"Come on Mara dear, no time for laying around lazybones." Not waiting for a response from the girl on the ground, Razz grasped her broom and turned, heading back towards the dense trees.

Scrambling to her feet, desperate to keep the illusive woman in her sights, Adora found herself running to catch up as the leaves started to swallow the small woman. She caught up just in time, sweating and panting from the climb and the shock of finding her objective.

“Mara, you should really have something to drink.” Razz turned her huge, magnified eyes on her and gestured to the pack on her back with the broom.

Dazedly Adora pulled her pack off of one shoulder and pulled out her water as she continued to stumble after the sure footed figure, deeper and deeper into the woods. The canopy closed over there heads and for the first time in years Adora felt a trickle of fear run up her spine in the enchanted woods. As though she could sense the girls unease, Razz slowed and reached out her hand to take one of Adora’s and give it a motherly squeeze before using it to pull her along behind her.

Sitting in the cottage after a walk that was foreboding but far too short to get them there, Adora took a sip of the tea that had been pressed into her hands once she had been led through the door. Razz had dropped her hand and made her way to the steaming kettle, pouring the hot water into two waiting mugs. Now they sat opposite each other and Adora felt nervous and confused. She had known that there was something different about the little old lady from the first time that Catra had brought her to the cottage, but now it seemed like she was mystical in ways that a Horde soldier couldn’t fathom.

“Hello Adora,” Razz’s eyes were very clear, the use of the blond’s name startling.

“You know me?” Blue eyes were hungry for information.

“I have always known you, Adora, and Mara before you. You are special people.” Razz drank her tea with a hum.

“I’m not special, Razz. I’m just a soldier.” This was not what she had come here, yet she was being drawn into Razz’s confusing web.

“I’ve told you before, Mara dear, you have a destiny that you can chose. You are not trapped by fate.”

“I don’t… I don’t understand; what fate? What IS destiny?” They were words she had distantly heard before, but she wasn’t really sure of their meaning, they were princess words, magic language that she didn’t need to know.

“Now, now Adora dear, where is my Wildling? She hasn’t come to see her Razz. Her pie will get cold.” Razz looked around Adora, towards the door, as if she expected the furred girl to walk in, in her shift.

“Razz, Catra isn’t in the woods anymore.” Adora’s spirits crashed as she realised that Razz didn’t know what had happened to the younger girl. “She’s been in the Fright Zone, with me, for almost a year.”

“Would you like to take her some pie?” Razz had risen and started to putter around her cottage again.

Crestfallen, Adora quietly rose and gathered up her bag. She headed for the curtain that acted as a door and gently pulled it aside, head bowed and shoulders slumped. She wasn’t sure that the woman would even notice that she had left. She had one foot over try threshold and on the path back to the war games, when a small hand grasped her elbow with a steely grip that stopped her forward momentum. Turning, she found the white head closer to her and looking at her sorrowfully.

“It isn’t time yet, Adora dear. Wildling will know when it is time and bring you. You have to trust her.” Adora did, she trusted the amnesiac girl with everything she had. “But Adora,” now her voice had taken on a much more somber tone. “You need to protect the

Wildling. If she becomes the angry cat, many will be lost and the cost will be great."

"How do I protect her? I'm not even allowed to bring her to the woods with me." Adora's voice rose, frantic.

"Oh, my dear, you do not need to protect her from the world. You need to protect her from herself…and from you." The eyes behind the glasses started to take on their usual hazy look.

"I would never hurt Catra!' She felt indignant even as she knew that whatever clarity Razz had to share was gone.

"We never mean to hurt the ones we love, Mara dear. We just do." Then she was walking past Adora back out into the woods, repeating as she disappeared, "We just do."

Adora was left standing in the clearing outside the now vacant cottage, watching the woods where the woman had been enveloped in the leaves. She would never hurt Catra. She had been doing her best to protect her since she was eight years old, hiding her existence from the other cadets and then taking care of her in the barracks. She would never hurt Catra.

Never.

Ambush

Chapter Summary

Force Captain testing is only four weeks away.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Time ticked away as Adora stood on her spot, waiting. Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were all starting to huff impatiently. The others had never quite gelled with the young feline who had been thrust into their team. Even after almost two years they still thought of her as a nuisance and an outsider. Lonnie most of all had developed an adversarial relationship with Catra. They fought with words and punches, more than once Adora had been forced to pull the cat off of the stocky girl for fear that she would tear out her throat. Catra might not remember living in the woods, but Adora had watched her take down prey and kill it, the last thing she wanted was for muscle memory to kick in and for something heinous to take place.

The instructor, a newly promoted male lizard-kin who went by Charz, was agitatedly beating his tail on the floor as his expression became more and more stormy. Finally, with a growl, he gave up on the fifth member of their group. He turned to tap a series of keys on the wall and the door whooshed open to reveal a simulated combat drill waiting for them. He turned back to them, passing a judgemental look at each of them.

"I hope that you are a better team than the absence of your fifth would suggest." His voice was sibilant and slurred but his words were easily made out.

"Yes, Sir. I apologise for Cadet Catra's absence. Really, she is usually very punctual." Adora jumped to defend her friend and even Lonnie grunted an affirmative to her words. They all knew that although Catra may grab and moan about following orders,

she dare not for fear of whatever punishment Shadow Weaver may rain down on her.

Missing a morning of training either meant that she had already been dragged away by the second in command to be punished for some perceived infraction, something that made Adora sad but that Shadow Weaver always managed to explain plausibly enough. Catra was a wild thing after all. Some part of Adora knew that Shadow Weaver was overly enthusiastic in her discipline with Catra, but it wasn't like they hadn't all been pulled away by the intimidating woman a time or two.

"So you say! That does not help you today. Engage your sensors, enter the simulation and try to survive the princesses! You have 60 minutes." The time popped up on a screen above his head. "Go! Go! Go!"

They were running before he had the last 'Go!' out. Fanning into a formation that had been familiar to them since they were twelve. It was one that even Kyle was good at, though it did mean that he was essentially bait - although they tried to always make sure that though he drew the attention of the 'princess' he was never a sacrificial lamb. It almost always worked. It wasn't something that they had used recently, things changed when they inherited a very fast, very agile group member. Suddenly their attacks and feints could have an extra dimension that raw strength had made them lack.

Adora didn't like going back to the old style of fighting, it felt stiff and far too draining. It also made her remember a time before Catra was a part of her everyday life and she didn't want to consider that. Adora ducked behind a 'tree' to her left, seeing Rogelio do the same further down. They made eye contact and she used a few well-practiced hand motions to get him to move further down. She looked around, scanning for Lonnie. Spotting her creeping forward, advancing on the princess-bot, Adora made a series of hand signals that Lonnie responded to in kind. The last thing she did, before telling Rogelio and Lonnie to move in, was ensure that Kyle was well back.

Knowing that both the other members of her team were watching her, she raised her hand and they were moving. Lonnie drew the princess-bot's fire first, leading it towards a thicket of 'trees'. Adora and Rogelio began to shoot at exposed points, landing some solid hits before it swung on them, shooting in a wide arc that meant that they were all tumbling away as low as they could. Unfortunately, they all ended up barricaded behind the very trees they had been trying to lure the enemy into and were now pinned down. The princess-bot had eyes only for them. If Kyle was anybody else, they would have been able to rely on him to attack from the rear, but his orders were always to stay clear and survive.

Adora cast her eyes around frantically as Lonnie and Rogelio tried to lay down fire to distract the bot. The cluster of synthetic trees was all that stood between them and defeat. As blue eyes looked for a way out when something moved in the periphery of her vision. By the time her gaze was where she had seen it, it was gone. She wondered if she was imagining it in her panic.

Turning back to the problem at hand she took aim and attempted to use the fire of the others to make some more strategic shots the eyes and chest of the princess-bot. Just as she had the perfect shot something dropped from a tree. The bot swung around, frantically trying to dislodge the thing from its back. It's limbs thrashed wildly and the overlaid holo-imagine of the princes screamed and beat at the air. The thing on its back was unrelenting as it began to move.

Now Adora could see what was happening. Catra was hanging on to the back of the bot with a feral grin on her face. It was a look she had seen her wear when taking down a bird of small mammal in the woods. Meeting Adora's eyes across the distance between them, Catra's grin grew impossibly wider as she let out a whoop and brought one of her wickedly clawed hands down in a fast arc towards the metal casing of the bot. Those same claws sliced through the thick metal covering as easily as they would a ration bar. A sheet of metal was soon flying through the air and hitting

the wall close to their heads, Lonnie letting out a curse as it came perilously close to her face.

It was scary to realise how strong Catra must be to destroy metal with such negligent ease. Now she was thrusting her fist deep inside the back of the bot and tearing out a cluster of wires and its CPU. The princess visage stuttered and disappeared, the lights on the bot flashing and then becoming dark as the big, round robot collapsed to the floor with Catra standing triumphantly on its back waving its metallic guts in the air. Grin still firmly in place. The others just staring at her in shock.

Kyle was the first to break as he let out a cheer and ran towards the felled foe. His gangly limbs flailed as she moved and before he reached the bot he was falling over his feet and came to a stop as his body collided with it. Catra dropped her trophy and jumped down from the top of the machine's domed top and loaded lightly beside the blond man and hoisted him to his feet as the other three came to join them. Lonnie and Rogelio couldn't help but feel admiration for the cat-girl. They had never seen her relish a practice like this and they had won the game in record time due to her.

"Good work." Lonnie words were grudging but Rogelio grunted at her encouragingly and she rolled her eyes.

Catra wasn't really listening as she sidled up to Adora and shoulder bumped her. Her mismatched eyes were huge and sparkling. Adora felt proud but also something else. Somewhere in that Horde part of her, that part of her that had been told it was the best, extraordinary even, she felt jealous that Catra had single handedly won the simulation. She had never managed that. She hadn't even noticed that the other girl had been hiding in the environment.

"Hey, when did you get here?" She couldn't have come in after them, the instructor wouldn't have let her.

Catra shrugged negligently, “I was here about an hour ago. I snuck in with the last training group and just hid out.” Her tone was lazy as she spoke, like it was the most obvious plan in the world.

“We thought you were slacking.” Kyle’s constantly cracking voice blurted out as Catra looked at him and hissed making him shrink back into the safety of Lonnie.

Before more could be said, all of the lights went up and the technological deception around them was gone. Now it was simply a large bare room with pillars scattered around at a variety of angles, some with protuberances to mimic branches. The doors slid open and without fanfare, Shadow Weaver stormed in, seeming to suck up all o fetch light as she moved. Soon she was stood before the group of teens, examining them coldly from behind her mask, painted stare settling on Catra as she stood pressed to Adora’s side. Neither girl moved, fearing bringing down the woman’s wrath on the feline.

“That bot has been destroyed! Do you have any idea what a waste of equipment that is? This is supposed to be a simulation!” Her steely, cold words were more terrifying than a shout. Adora saw that Catra was about to say something, she discreetly reached behind them and touched her tail gently, a signal to keep quiet.

“Many apologise Shadow Weaver. It was my plan. I had Catra hide out so the she could ambush the enemy. I have been studying strategy and we all got carried away. If it’s anyone’s fault it’s mine.” She watched the woman’s posture relax fractionally as she pulled her eyes away from her favourite victim.

“Excellent plan Adora, just what I would expect from somebody on the verge of being a Force Captain. Some collateral damage is always acceptable if we get results. It’s a good lesson to learn so young.” He moved closer to the blond, making Catra move away, cowering from any touch from the red robes.

“Tell me, Adora, how close are we now till your final test?”

“A month, Shadow Weaver. Four weeks exactly until my Force Captain test.” She would soon be moving on up and taking her team with her. She would be able to sneak Catra into her single quarters and the other girl would get some peace.

“I look forward to awarding you your Force Captain badge, in that case.” Shadow Weaver began to walk back to the doors, throwing over her shoulder. “You should al go and take advantage of the showers as you are done so early. You may have double water rations. Even you, Catra.” It sounded like a reward, but Adora knew how much Catra loathed the showers.

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Catra had disappeared again before they reached the showers. The others didn’t seem to mind or care, deciding that they would just split her double water ration between the three of them in the co-ed showers. Adora found it hard to enjoy the rare opportunity for hot water and a hair wash. With all the other cadet teams still in simulations, the water tanks were full. Adora lathered her long hair and rinsed it, running her fingers through the wet strands to get out any tangles.

Soon she was slipping out of her cubicle, the others still splashing and singing in theirs. She quickly ran the towel over her body, leaving her warm and pink. Throwing on a new uniform from the dispenser, and depositing her old ones in the laundry shoot, she tied her wet hair back and went in search for her furred friend.

Sneaking through the large ducts that criss-crossed the place, she popped out at the base of the tall structure that was Catra’s favourite. It was a rout that the pair took often when they wanted a little privacy and didn’t want anyone to know. Catra would scamper up the side of the tower using her natural agility and claws, leaving the blond in her dust. Adora was always so mesmerised by the other girl that it took her longer than it should to climb up behind her using the name familiar hadn’t and foot

holds. Today there was no limber figure to watch, and she pulled herself up in half the time, until she was swinging a leg and climbing over the edge of the platform several hundred metres high. Sure, she could have used the stairs inside, but they were monitored and also the feline would tease her.

Standing up, she walked towards the girl who was seated on the very end of the platform, in their spot, with her legs dangling over the edge, tail moving lazily and arms reaching up to clasp the railing above her head. In the red light of the Fright Zone her fur looked almost bronze. Catra's ear's twitched, but otherwise she remained staring out in the direction of the Whispering Woods, just a silhouette through the thick smog.

Adora lowered herself to sit close to the other girl, their hips touching as she, too, looked out. It was comforting, feeling the warmth of the other girl so close. She loved having the other girl so close, but all of her childish notions of Catra coming to the Fright Zone and being safe had long since been wiped away. The Fright Zone was no place for Razz's Wildling. But, without her memories of living in the woods, there was no way that Adora could just sneak her out, back to her home. She had no way to know if she would even know what to hunt.

She was thinking so hard that she almost missed it when one of Catra's arms came down from its grip on the bar and wrap around her shoulders. Without thought, she relaxed into the touch, cuddling into the side of the smaller girl who purred contentedly in the embrace. It was one of the reasons that they came up here. Touch was almost forbidden between the cadets in the bunks. Naturally, people would sneak off to find spots to break the rules, and this was theirs. The touches that they shared were innocent, far more innocent than what Adora had stumbled on in dark corridors and storage closets, the intertwined bodies making her stutter and blush as she back away and fled. Whenever that happened she felt a longing in the pit of her stomach and her mind would flash to her and Catra in the same compromising positions. She would push those thoughts away, there was no way she could take advantage of the mostly amnesiac girl.

“Hey, Adora, what’s going on in that brain of yours?” Catra’s rough voice had matured over the couple of years that’s he had been a member of the Horde. She was a little younger than Adora, but physically they seemed much the same. Catra was more sinewy and lithe, but just as strong as the bulkier human. Adora loved Catra’s voice but missed the broken speech from when they were children.

“Just thinking about when I become Force Captain.” It was partially true, she was always thinking about that in the back f her mind after all.

“Yeah. You’ll be a good Force Captain. Thanks for to ratting me out to Shadow Weaver earlier.” Catra’s purr stopped but she ran her cheek over the other girls damp hair.

“It was a great strategy. I wish you could have taken the credit.” Adora pulled away from her so that they look each other in the eye, she hated that it meant that Catra’s arm dropped from her shoulders.

“Pffft, we know how that goes. If I get the glory, I just get dragged off for a ‘talking to’.” Catra never really spoke about what happened when Shadow Weaver would take her away, but she was always quiet and stiff when she came back. It didn’t take much for Adora to put things together, but Catra didn’t want to talk and she wasn’t going to push her.

Catra reached up and clasped her face between both hands, gently cradling it as she moved Adora’s head back and forth. Her blue and yellow eyes were looking at the blond attentively and Adora found herself blushing. This happened more and more lately, Catra would initiative a touch that was a little too rough and a little too intimate and Adora would feel her heart start to race and colour stain her cheeks. Nothing had happened, other than the occasional touch that last too long, or a look that lingered, but Adora wished it would. Even if a little voice in the back of her mind told her it would be wrong while a part of Catra was missing.

“Your hair is different.” Was what finally popped out of Catra’s mouth and Adora reached up to self consciously smooth the still wet strands. “No poof. It’s weird. I feel like I’m looking at a different person.”

“I thought that you said my poof was stupid and made me look like a had a five-head.” Adora playfully poked at her friends furred shoulder now the she had dropped her hands from her face.

“Nah, you know I’m just teasing. You’re hair poof is who you are, and I’m a big fan of who you are.” Catra’s voice was playful as she poked Adora in the forehead with one finger before bouncing to her feet and skipping away across the platform.

Adora scrambled to her feet and went in pursuit. It was something they did often, usually triggered by the forehead tap. They would chase and tussle as they had since they were small, even if only one of them remembered that. It was getting harder and harder to resist the temptation to touch in other places while they wrestled though.

The blond tackled the cat around the knees, bringing her crashing to the rusty steel of the floor. The air escaped her lungs with an ‘oof’ before she was pouncing right back and the two girls were rolling around trying to get the upper hand. Adora wasn’t scared to be messing around up this high, Catra’s sense of spacial awareness meant that she would save them before they plummeted to their death. Hands pulled and grasped, Adora getting the upped hand and then Catra. Backs clanged against the grates and breaths became laboured as they giggled. It made both of them feel wild and free. Somewhere, out beyond the horizon, you could have sleepovers and braid each others hair to show how much you cared for somebody, in the Fright Zone, affection was as rough as hatred. It was all they knew.

Adora got the upper hand, pinning Catra to the floor with her hands on her shoulders and straddling her waist. She smirked down triumphantly at her vanquished foe, opening her mouth to say something clever, when Catra’s head surged up. For a split

second, the blond thought she was about to be head butted and braced herself for the impact, when instead warm lips were pressed against her own. She gasped in shock, Catra taking advantage to surge upwards with her hips, making Adora's eyes widen as she froze in something like shock before she was toppling through the air. When her back collided with the ground she was already dazed, looking up into Catra's sober face.

Catra leaned down, Adora's wrists pinned in her hands above her head. She bent low, her legs on either side of the human's, chest brushing the one below as she got close enough that their noses were touching. Smile growing on her face, she moved even closer, lips brushing the coral ones of her prey.

"Hey, Adora." It was little more than a breath as she pressed her lips to the prone girls for the second time, releasing her wrists and sighing into the kiss as Adora's hands buried themself in her hair and she opened her mouth, welcoming the feline's tongue inside.

Instinct overtook the cat-girl, as she plundered the other girl's mouth, gently licking at the inside of her mouth and feeling Adora shiver as her fists clenched in her hair. A sound came from Catra that neither of them had heard before. A growl that started in her chest and vibrated through the pair of them. It was darkly alluring and Adora wanted nothing more than to make it happen again. She used her strong stomach muscles to move into a sitting position, Catra feeling her intent and moving with her as their lips remained locked together. Adora's hands moved from her hair, crawling slowly down her neck until one was hook there, pulling Catra even closer.

Adora's free hand travelled down the other girls side, skimming over her ribs through her uniform and coming to rest on her ass. Catra's tail coiled around her wrist and in surprise Adora squeezed. Catra stiffened and the growl came again. The kiss broke and both teens were left staring at each other in a mix of shock and wonder, Catra sat in Adora's lap.

Chapter End Notes

Canon is so close can't you taste it?

Changes

Chapter Summary

A sword. A girl. A cat.

Chapter Notes

If you Stan Swift Wind I have some bad news for you...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Laying on her back, balanced perfectly on the cool metal railing, one leg dangling negligently into the void, Catra flipped the thin metal between her fingers. She watched as it spun and caught the hazy light of the fright zone. The deeply embossed sigil of the Horde looked almost black when the light passed over it, not red as it should be. Things were changing and he wasn't sure that she liked it. Her past was still a blank space to her, her future seemed more uncertain than ever. All she had was her present and her connection to Adora. The badge in her hand seemed like a solid reminder that she wouldn't have the along girl for much longer. It had been a pretty dream to think that with Adora a force captain they would be able to break free from Shadow Weaver, but Catra had realised a few weeks ago it was just that.

Adora was Shadow Weaver's protege, her shining example of all that was right and good about the Horde. She was never simply going to let go of her. It had been idealistic to think that she would. As much as the older woman seemed to loath the young feline, she obsessed over the human girl. Once Catra had started to show more aptitude than Adora, the old witch had shown her hand and Catra had soon realised that it was far better to lose, no matter how it rankled her. She never told

Adora had left it a little while before she 'found' her friend. Despite what Catra said, Adora knew that she wasn't completely

happy about the promotion. No matter how much Adora reassured her, Catra didn't believe she would protect her and take her with her to the command quarters. Adora had hoped that after they became intimate, things would change but sometimes she would look at the cat-girl and see sadness in her eyes before she pushed it aside.

Scaling the rope attached to the grappling hook that had noisily changed around a support, she wanted to let the other girl know she was coming, not that she doubted for a moment that those sensitive ears would know either way she poked her head over the top. There was Catra, perched on the thinnest, most rickety railing. Even though she knew that the other girl had perfect balance, remembered her laying the same way on slender tree branches, a memory that made her chest ache knowing that this was all Catra knew now, she still feared that one day she would plummet to her death her in the Fright Zone.

"I know you think things will change now," her voice was low, her hand reaching out to gently settle on the other girls shoulder, relieved when she didn't pull away. "I promise, me being Force Captain will be good for both of us."

Catra did pull away at that, turning to look at her before flipping the badge back at her. "Take it." Then she was turning away again.

"Catra, please. Things will be ok, we can move into my new quarters and get some privacy. I could even request a transfer to one of the outposts and nobody would know us. We could start our new lives together." They both knew that the 'to get away from Shadow Weaver' went unsaid, and at least one of them knew that the old witch would never let Adora go.

"It's fine Adora. I'll get over it." Her words were too sullen for the blond to believe. "Just go and celebrate, I'll come down in a while." Catra's ear twitched as a jingling sound suddenly filled the space. The cat part of her couldn't resist turning to see where the noise came from.

“I mean, if you don’t want to take a skiff out for a ride with me, I guess I could go dow…”. Adora’s words were cut off as a fast moving ball of purring excitement collided with her body and sent them both the deck. Catra’s malaise all but forgotten for the moment and Adora patted herself on the back for snagging the keys.

“Let’s go! I’m driving!” Catra had bounced back to her feet and was tugging her along behind her.

Blurry eyes opened slowly, bright light beaming down and making them slam shut again. The action sent a piercing pain lancing through her head and she let out a groan. It must have been louder than she thought as she heard rustling and the frantic flapping of wings as a host of bird took flight away from the disturbance. She blinked hazily again, just in time to see them silhouetted black against the sky. The noise of the birds was so loud that she almost missed the answering groan coming from somewhere to her right.

Not sure if her body could take moving just yet, if opening her eyes took so much strain, she groped out her hand, gratified when she hit something warm and furry closer than she’d anticipated. Not caring what limb it was that she had touched, she curled her hand around it and realised that it was Catra’s ankle.

“Catra, you awake?” Her voice seemed really far away to her own ears and her throat felt dry, like she hadn’t had anything to drink in hours. Just how long had they been out?

“How long how we been here?” Catra’s woozy voice echoed her own thoughts and she patted her leg reassuringly. “You still in one piece, Adora?”

It seemed as though Catra was bouncing back from whatever this was faster than her, the leg slipping from her grip to be replaced by Catra’s concerned face hanging over her own. For a moment all

she could do was stare at that face, with its focused expression and bask in all the things she could let herself feel for the other girl now. When fingers started to poke at her a little too roughly, she realised that she had been quiet for too long. She brought both her hands up to cup soft cheeks, stilling Catra's actions immediately as their eyes met and both of them were suddenly smiling bashfully at each other. Whatever had happened, it had affected both of them and they would deal with it together.

"Hey, Adora." Catra almost purred it in her relief and Adora gave in to her desire to pull the other girl closer and kiss her. They had kissed a lot since the first time, whenever they found themselves alone in fact. It was like an addiction for both of them.

Catra basked in the kiss that had taken on a whole new meaning all of a sudden. Sinking into the other girl, everything that had happened since they flew over the Whispering Woods flooded back. As their eyes closed again, both girls got lost in the kiss as more and more as Catra's brain reestablished connections, the locked box of her mind springing open and all of herself flooding out. It was as though touching the sword had been the key to a lock she hadn't known existed. As images of a much younger Adora flooded her mind, she clutched the girl beneath her closer.

For Adora, the cacophony of sounds and images that had assailed her when she touched the sword welled up once again. She remembered them crashing the skiff Catra going into something like a daze, walking away from the downed craft, pulling her along in her wake. Adora had followed willingly, Catra no longer knew the woods and she wasn't about to let her wander off alone. The other girl had stopped suddenly in a small clearing that seemed to glow with an unnatural light, and when Adora peered around her there had been a sword jutting out from a riot of vines.

Without he own volition she had moved forward to touch the weapon and the world had exploded. A woman's voice kept repeating the same phrase; 'Will you fight for the honour of Greyskull?"

Neither girl had revealed what had happened to them in that clearing. By some unspoken consent they had returned to the skiff without the sword and headed back to the Fright Zone on the skiff which now seemed fine. Catra had felt her fur bristle as they had neared the places that had been her home for the last few years. All the days spent in torturous bondage as Shadow Weaver tried to pry information out of her had come back along with her life from before. A life she craved to return to. She had always hated the Fright Zone and now she remembered what home really was she knew why. The only reason she was returning was the girl by her side, who had seemed dazed since they encountered the sword.

Light Hope had trained Catra for all of this, she realised now. She had been crafted to deal with all of the tribulations that came with being the swords guardian, and finally she had delivered Adora to it. They needed to talk, but something was holding her back. She realised that Adora had been trying to protect her in her amnesiac state and loved the other girl more.

Adora's mind was whirling with the snatches of images that she had seen when she touched that sword. That soft, soothing voice ringing in her ears, asking her a question she didn't understand. All she knew was that something inside her was pulling her to head back to the woods. It was the same pull she had always felt to return there for the quiet cat-girl at her side. Adora had noticed that since they woke up in that clearing, Catra had been almost silent, only giving one word responses and though she had not left her side, it felt as though she was a million miles away.

Standing together at the meal line later that day, behind Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio, Adora nudged Catra with her shoulder and the two shared a private smile. In a room full of people, they were their own island together. They needed to talk but they had more training into the evening. It could wait. They would stick together.

The first moment that they had alone together after that turned out to be lights out. Both were exhausted, too tired for revelations. Adora barely had the energy to pull off her jacket and boots before slipping under her blanket. Her body ached and her head pounded, colours still burst when she closed her eyes. The familiar weight of another body settling at her feet made her rise onto her elbows and smile sleepily as Catra curled up there.

"Go to sleep, dummy." Adora didn't need to be told twice and as the lights faded, her breath deepened and she slumped into her hard pillow asleep in seconds Catra not far behind.

It was a peace that was not meant to last. Adora bolted upright in her bed, the world around her still grey, clutching at her chest. That voice was calling her like a siren. She kept seeing the sword in her dreams and knew that she needed to return to it. Moving carefully, trying to get out of bed without waking Catra, she almost screamed when she looked down and saw two glowing eyes staring at her though the dark.

"Go back to sleep." Her whisper was low but she knew Catra caught every word.

"I know where you're going and I'm coming too." The feline saw the look in Adora's eyes and jumped in to stop what was coming. "You can't leave me behind because I need to take you back to the Sword of Protection."

Adora's ears were ringing. Catra knew what the sword was. Catra knew about the Whispering Woods. She grabbed the other girl and dragged her into the corridor outside, staring at her with so many questions running through her. Only one mattered though.

"You remember?" She knew that she was holding the hand in hers too tight but she couldn't seem to let go.

"Everything. You touched the sword and there it was." Catra looked around, making sure that no-one was listening. "We need to go, right now. I'll explain everything once you have the sword."

Not waiting for more from Adora, she started them running back to the skiff hanger, only for Adora to slam into her as she suddenly stopped, spinning and pressing a quick kiss to her lips. "Thank you for taking care of me when I couldn't." Adora was left blushing as they set off running again.

Chaos exploded all around them as the worm-like beast attacked, rearing up to tower almost as tall as the trees around them. The little pink princess turned her attention from screaming at Adora for the sword, to screaming in fear at the thing that was barrelling closer and closer to them. Then, a barrage of sparkles shot out from her upraised hands, exploding like tiny bombs as they impacted the things body. Rather than slowing it down they only seemed to enrage it further if the roar it released was anything to go by.

Catra felt her body tense, memories of running from smaller versions of this very thing as a child, leaping onto their backs and tearing through the spine pounding through her head, further filling up the void that had been there for so long. Acting on instinct she began to sprint towards the danger, ready to insert her body between Adora and the danger.

Adora was her mate, it sang in her blood in a way it hadn't before today. She was made for the other girl, even Light Hope had told her that. Everything the holographic woman had ever said to her kept ringing though her head all at once, filling up all the empty spaces. There was no hesitation as she saw the massive mandibles heading towards her, but they were no longer focused on the blond. Turning her head, she saw blue eyes widen and Adora's mouth open in horror as she realised what Catra was doing. Then, all she could see was sky, her sides were gripped bone-crushingly hard and she was shaken like a rag doll. Distantly she could hear three voices screaming.

Adora watched as Catra tried to save them all, only to be snatched up and crushed. Everything went white all of a sudden,

the princess and the boys shrill cries were gone. All she could hear was her pounding heart and then the voice from before. It echoed in her head, making her hand clench harder around the hilt of the sword. It tingled, almost burning and then it was aloft in the air as though lifted by an unseen force. Would she fight for the honour of Greyskull? If it would save Catra she would.

"For the honour of Greyskull!" The words burst out of her and then she was in an altered state, lights sparking all around her as her body grew and stretched. It took seconds but then she was standing there, feeling more powerful than she ever had before.

Catra was nowhere in sight, but Adora launched herself at the monster, determined to avenge her girl and protect her from further harm. As she got close enough to swing her blade, everything stopped. The beast halted its attack and lowered its head, almost as though it was bowing down to her. Adora, body thrumming, reached out a hand much larger than she was used to and was about to place it on the thing when a scream shattered the peace and sent it rearing back again.

Adora felt her body stutter, like static running along her nerves, and the sword suddenly felt bigger and heavier than it had moments before and the worm was on the attack again. Once more in her own body, Adora bolted towards where the scream had originated and found the princess and her companion pinned into a corner by a gigantic chestnut striped cat. The thing was almost ten feet long and stood taller that Adora's hip, muscles quivering and shaggy fur puffed out all over its body as the tail thrashed agitatedly. Its chest was heaving, and a crackling wheeze was clearly audible even over the growl.

"Get that away from me!" Screamed the pink girl again sparks dying at her fingertips before she could use them, drawing the worm towards them at a terrifying speed.

Adora didn't need to see the mismatched eyes to know what was in front of her. She wasn't sure how or why this was happening

but she knew that only the big cat knew where they would be safe.

"Catra!" The large head swung her way and she almost gasped as she saw the pain in the mismatched eyes and the tongue lolling as she gasped for breath. "Take us somewhere safe." Those dark, velvet ears twitched and a chirp of assent joined them.

The animal started running, and with the sword clasped to her chest Adora bolted to catch up, not wanting the other girl, no matter her form, out of her sight. "Come on!" She threw the words over her shoulder and hoped that the enemy had the sense to follow or they'd be worm food. She couldn't afford to lose focus on Catra.

Speeding around a corner, she watched the big cat stumble. Even on two legs Catra never stumbled. She was hurt worse than Adora had feared. Whatever had happened to her in the clearing had happened to the other girl, but she seemed stuck like it. They needed to get somewhere soon to figure it out.

As though she had called it into being, they were exiting the tree line to find themselves standing in front of the Crystal Castle, Catra's old cave darkening the corner. Now they needed to get inside.

Chapter End Notes

Catra as Battle Cat? I am as surprised as you are!

Magic

Chapter Summary

Not everyone can be a warrior princess.

Chapter Notes

Catra's side of last chapter plus a trip inside the Crystal Castle.

One minute she had been throwing herself in front of Adora, and those damn princess people, and the next all she could see was red as the worm picked her up with its giant jaws and crushed at her sides. There was the tang of iron on her tongue and black creeping in at the sides of her vision as she was whipped back and forth as the crushing pressure began to make bones crack in her ears.

Then she was flying. Somewhere, very far away, she could hear Adora’s voice tinged with a frantic air but words were too hard for the rag doll that the smacked into a tree and slid to the ground in a lifeless heap, chest heaving for each wheezing breath. Everything felt cold, even as warm blood ran out of her mouth and matted in her fur. Distantly she could still hear the sound of Adora’s voice and knew that she had saved her. She was the Guardian of the Sword and now Adora had it, her mission was fulfilled. The girl she cared about beyond reason was safe, she could let go.

Her breaths grew more ragged and stuttering, body slumping down the side of the tree until she was prone on the ground and utterly still.

Then light was bursting through the clearing, piercing through the leaves and branches, illuminating them in rays of gold as a mighty cry went up. The light touched the broken body of the prone girl, piercing through her skin, sinking into blood and bone. Then there

was screaming where there had been silence as, in the moment between one breath and another everything shattered. Ribs that were broken expanded, still fractured but stronger. Lungs ballooned and a roaring breath entered, fuelling her back to her feet. Hands and feet thickened and grew wicked knife like claws as arm and leg bones stretched skin and muscle that tore and reformed. Everything felt bigger, stronger, but the price was agony as finally head seemed to explode outwards and razor teeth tore at her own flesh.

It took less than a second but everything was white-hot pain and confusion. The ground was closer, her limbs further away and every sense was even more heightened than before. She could smell the blood in the veins of the small creatures cowering in their burrows. Here ears twitched frantically as she latched onto something that should not be in the woods. It was familiar, its scent and sound swirled with the origin of the pain as every thought was hazy. All she knew was the need to protect and the pain.

The huge, wedge shaped head shook the daze away and she was running. Four paws pounding against the ground as she moved like quick silver over the uneven terrain. Everywhere there was silence except for the heart beats. Rounding a cluster of rocks, legs pounding into the soft earth, claws flexing she glared at the sparkly girl and the boy at her side. Mismatched eyes trained on them as the broad, wedge shaped head lowered and she pulled back her lips and growled.

The smaller one let out a high pitched wail, making her ears twitch and her head shake as another growl rolled out. The pain, confusion and fear washing through her made the adrenaline pump through newly formed veins, and her claws dig deeper into the dirt as she prepared to pounce. A shiver moved down her spine, puffing her fur and causing her movements to still as giant ears swivelled, picking up on a new set of footsteps crunching on the leaf litter.

The loud one mad more noise, snot screams but still loud and her attention refocused. It needed to stop. All the pain needed to stop!

“Catra!” That voice, word blurry to the big cat, was something she knew and without hesitation she swung her head to catch a glimpse of pale hair and wide, troubled eyes. “Take us somewhere safe.”

As though a switch had been tripped inside the massive body she was running, adrenaline fading as she navigated woods familiar to her whole life. As the rush faded, even as her feet continued to rush her towards home, the ground seemed to become a bigger obstacle. Rounding a corner at full tilt, her feet were suddenly not under her. Dizziness was starting to cloud her vision, but her ears detected the girl behind her and she knew that she had to keep her safe. It was all that mattered as she righted herself and kept leading the way.

Bursting through the tree-line, the towering edifice in front of her made it feel as though she could breath for the first time. This was home. This was safety. The part of the creature that was still a girl, longed to creep into the small cave and curl up around the wounds that were still pulsing along her torso, but the animal’s instincts were pulling her towards the mountain.

Three sets of feet came to a halt behind her, but the beast was focused on the shining wall in front of her. Padding towards it, a dangerous paw reached out to scratch uselessly at the side of the building. Nothing happened and a whine started to pour out of the animal. Pain was fast overtaking anything else.

Then someone was beside her, the familiar warmth and scent flooding her body with recognition. Adora’s could feel the distress rippling through the entire form at her hip. The Crystal Castle had never ignored Catra before, yet the doors stayed barred to them. Blue eyes scanned over the exterior of the building, looking at the lines that criss-crossed it with new eyes, her lips started to mouth words that had always been stuck in her throat as a child.

“Eternia.” It was barely a whisper but the lines on the building began to glow and a door was opening.

Both girl and cat were caught in the moment, not seeming to hear that crashing that was getting louder and louder. Glimmer and Bow shared a look, giant worm or terrifying cat in a void? There was no question as the two of them ran forward, pushing the two other creatures in front of them into the door of the shining edifice.

Glimmer found herself standing in a cavernous, brightly lit room, empty save for the tall doors that were dotted along the walls and the deep, glowing sigils around the room. She looked towards Bow, doing a visual inventory of him, checking for any injury. As she got to his face he saw that he was looking at her in the same way and they both blushed, looking away from each other. Two pairs of eyes settled on the peculiar pair in the centre of the floor. Her instincts told her not to trust the Horde soldier, certainly not when she could control posters and turn into an 8 feet tall warrior woman, but another part acknowledged that she had saved them without a second thought. Where the other girl had gone was another question, she could be out there right now planning an ambush. The thought made Glimmer narrow her eyes but not move her gaze.

The giant cat had collapsed in a heap on the smooth floor as soon the door had closed behind them. Bow felt sad as he watched the majestic creature struggle for breath. Whatever had driven it to bring them here had drained away, leaving it shaking with its huge head on the floor and tongue lolling out. He felt a prickle in his eyes as he considered that this animal looked like it might die after it had led them to safety. Glimmer must have seen because he felt a hand reach out and clasp his reassuringly.

The Horde soldier had been quick to pace the room, checking each door and finding them all locked tight. Then she was sinking to her knees beside the big animal with a look of such anguish on

her face that it was impossible to look away even though it felt as though they were seeing something they shouldn't. The princess told herself it was because she wanted to keep an eye on the sword that was still in enemy hands, and not because she felt sorry for the girl and her pet.

Adora didn't know what to do, she'd secured the room but Catra wasn't moving. On her knees beside the alien form of her best friend, her everything, she barely realise that she was holding the sword loosely in on hand. All she knew was that she needed to be connected with the figure slipping away on the floor. She reached out with a trembling hand to settle it against the striped flank and stroked down the fur tenderly, tears starting to cloud her eyes as she whispered the other girl's name. The cat whimpered and with agonising slowness managed to settled its head into her lap.

Dazed, Adora continued to stroke the cat, lowering her head to burry it in the fur that smelt and felt so familiar. Neither of them noticed as tendrils of gold began to seep from the blond's hands and settle like dust across the large body in her lap. Bow felt his jaw drop for the second time today as the Horde soldier once again performed magic right in front of him. Beside him Glimmer gasped as the gold glowed all around the dying body. The room was silent then, as though they were about to witness something that would change all four of their lives.

Catra luxuriated in the gentle touch on her body. She wished that she could hold the girl that was crying into her neck but her entire body felt like it belonged to somebody else. In fact, her whole body felt numb. Breaths began to come easier but everything else felt very far away, as though she was outside of herself. The wetness of tears made its way through her fur and touched her skin, and just like always she reached out to comfort the only constant she had had in her life since she was a child.

Bow squeaked and couldn't stop from clapping his hands together as he watched the body on the floor rapidly change from a hulking beast to a small, lithe girl who was curling her still glowing body around the one who had saved them all. It took a moment,

as though she were stunned, but then the soldier was dropping the word with a loud clang that echoed around the room and made Glimmer flinch beside him, and wrapping her arms around the shrunk figure and crying full force now. Bow felt uncomfortable, they were obviously witnessing something very private between the two girls. He turned his head away to give them a moment of privacy, only to realise that he was now standing alone. His dark eyes widened as she swung his head and saw Glimmer creeping up on the two embracing girls.

Glimmer was moved as she saw the way that the two girl's were holding each other as though the rest of the world didn't exist. It looked like she didn't need to worry about being ambushed by the cat-girl on the outside, but she still wanted that sword. Just because it turned out that Horde soldier's could have feelings, didn't change the fact that they were the enemy and they were at war. She'd inched up on them, the sword had skittered a little way away when the blond had dropped it, and with stealth born of years of sneaking away from her mother, Glimmer grasped it and then used her teleport to take her back to Bow's side, the tinkling sound of her magic breaking the girls on the floor apart.

As though just remembering that there were other people in the room, Adora and Catra scrambled to their feet, each taking up a fighting stance, ready to be attacked. Catra struggled not to swoon as the blood rushed to her body parts, the wounds and pain in her body was all gone but altering shape and side took a moment for her body to adjust. She narrowed her eyes as she noticed that the little pink princess was holding the sword. A growl bubbled up from her throat. Every part of her coiling, ready to pounce and retrieve Adora's sword.

"Don't." Adora's voice was the ghost of a whisper but dark ears twitched and Catra froze.

It may have been what saved them all, as those same ears picked up clicking, coming closer and closer from every side. Not the clicking of a clock, no, this sounded like hundreds of claw tipped fingers tapping all at once. It sounded like hundreds of things

heading towards them. There was no time for this standoff with the scowling girl who was clutching possessively to the sword, whatever was coming was coming fast. She wracked her brain, old memories and new changes clouding her thoughts, for any idea of what was hiding beyond those doors but as far as she had known as a child under Light Hope's tutelage the place was deserted.

She could get the sword back to its rightful wielder later.

"We have incoming, we need to leave now!" Her voice carried around the room, just as the noise got close enough for them to hear. Expectant blue eyes looked at her, fully trusting that she could get them out and her heart felt as big as it had moments before all over again.

Grabbing Adora's hand, convinced that the interlopers would follow, they were moving down a small hall that had been all but invisible against the wall. They wound their way down the hall that got smaller and smaller. Catra wondered when she had grown so big as the walls brushed her shoulders. Then hey were crouching low through a tear in the side of the metallic edifice and being disgorged back into the woods. She slapped a clawed hand over the princesses mouth as she wound up to speak, ears twitching.

Whatever had been coming for them was staying inside the Crystal Castle and the worm was obviously long gone. All that could be heard around them was the breeze through the trees and the huffing of the girl under her hand. Withdrawing from the annoying girl, she looked at Adora who was beaming at her. They were still together and they were fine.

"Hey, Adora." Pouncing towards the other teen she rubbed her jaw along the taller girl's neck and both of them sighed.

"You were a big cat!" Adora's voice sounded awed and she chuckled a little into her flesh as the words ghosted over her hair.

“I was a giant princess!” Catra pulled back in shock and looked into her dopey face.

“You were what?”

Then a sword was at the small of her back.

Thaymor

Chapter Summary

So this is a party.

Chapter Notes

Just a little bit today.

Ears flicked as something completely foreign caught her ear. She had turned out the shrill pink girl and her crop topped accomplice after the first half hour of their slog towards Brightmoon. The princess had made no bones about telling the two Horde soldier's that they were being frog marched to the castle and that they would need to face off with the queen. Catra and Adora had both rolled their eyes at each other, even with the sword at their backs, it was all the pair could do to hold in the laughter that was threatening to bubble up. They could have overpowered them if they wanted to, but neither girl wanted to go back to the Fright Zone and Brightmoon seemed as good a place to be as possible.

Blue eyes were watching as her ears twitched frantically, mouthing a question that got her a shrug in response. Catra wasn't sure what she was hearing, just that it was getting closer and that the other girl would be able to hear it herself soon enough. It was certainly more pleasant than anything that she had heard in the last few years, it honestly reminded her of the bird song that had filled her childhood. It was certainly an improvement over the griping of the youths behind them.

"Maybe you should put the sword down, Glimmer. It looks kinda heavy and they haven't done anything except save us from a monster." One ear cocked to catch there conversation, at least the male one seemed capable of quiet.

"They turned into giant people and belong to the Horde, Bow. The Horde! The people we have been at war with our whole lives, for

all we know they could be spies.” Her hissed words were loud enough to startle several small rodents out of hiding and across the cat-girl’s path, it was all she could do not to pounce on them and if Adora’s little giggle was anything to go by them she knew how hard she was fighting that desire.

“If it means anything, we aren’t going back to the Horde.” Adora’s voice was still light as she spoke, and Catra had to hold in the purr that threatened to burst out at the blond’s words. She had known that Adora wouldn’t go back now she had felt the sword’s power, but hearing her say it was perfect.

“Yeah, we’re deserting!” Now that she had her memories back, she wasn’t sure if what she was doing could be called deserting, Catra had never really joined the Horde, just been strong armed and near brainwashed. It was something, among ant other things, that she and Adora were going to need to talk about when they weren’t being strong armed by idiots.

“That’s exactly what a pair of spies would say!” And there was the sharp point of the sword once again in the small of her back. Honestly, on any given day she would snap and spin on the girl, tearing it out of her hand but they wanted to go where they were being taken.

The odd little quartet walked a little further until the delightful sounds were audible to all of them. Then they were ducking behind a cluster of large rocks, while the boy, Bow, peered out over the outcrop with a pair of binoculars that had popped out of one of his arrows. The princesses really were weird. Then he was back among them and looking stressed.

“We’re just outside Thaymor, they’re having some kind of celebration. Everyone seems to be on the streets, there is no way we can get through without being seen and it’ll take too long to go around.” His dark eyes were darting from the princess, to the sword and then over to the prisoners.

“Urgh, fine.” The pink haired girl handed the sword to the young man who slipped it through his belt. “We are going into that town, you’re going to play along and then we are going to Brightmoon. We keep the sword.” Both the girls nodded affably which, for some reason, seemed to spike the shorter girl’s ire even more.

Glimmer stood back and looked at the infuriating pair. They may genuinely be leaving the Horde and joining them, or they were just really good actresses, though looking at the blond’s face each time she looked at the other girl, every emotion she had ever had written plainly across her features, she doubted she was any kind of actress. Not to mention the fact that she had turned into an eight foot tall princess, made her feel more trustworthy. The other one was a different matter, there was something calculating in the animalistic features and the thing that she had become had been more terrifying than trust inducing. She had little choice but to hold that sword hostage and hope for the best. Her eyes ran over them and something hit her.

“You can’t go into town looking like that.” Pink eyes squinted at the taller girl’s clothes and saw her reach up to straighten the white top. Bow was by her side, smiling and nodding.

“We need to give you both a makeover!” His hands were balled up by his face and she could see the happy sparkle in his eyes. It looked like she and her best friend would be adopting these two vagabonds.

“Well, we’ll have to do something with what we have.” She whipped off her cape and looked expectantly at the human girl.

“What are you going to do with that?” She backed up a little as Glimmer approached and the small princess felt a pang of something at the clearly scared movement.

“You’ve got a big Horde symbol on your back, dummy. She wants to cover it up.” Bow and Glimmer nodded along with the cat girl’s words.

“Oh. Ok.” Glimmer wrapped the cape across one of the other girl’s broad shoulders and fastened it with her own clip. It did its job to cover her back and that would have to do. Bow came forward with a large flower and smiled as he tucked it behind the girl’s ear as she blushed.

“You look nice, it distracts from your pouffe.” There was a cheeky smirk as the Horde soldier’s shoulder bumped each other and the taller girl giggled.

“What about you?” She was surveying her friend.

“No Horde symbol on me, except this.” The edge was torn from her belt and tossed into a bush as she then reached over and did the same with the other girls. “All gone!” She also pulled off the mask that surrounded her face and haded it to Bow to store away. “Will I do, Pinky?”

“It’s Glimmer and yes, I don’t think I have ever seen a soldier who looks like you so that should keep you out of trouble.” She turned and started to walk around the outcropping as Bow let out a little whoop.

So, this was a party, Adora thought to herself a she found another sticky treat thrust into her hands by the boy, Bow she thought his name was. Without much thought she stuffed it into her mouth, he hadn’t set her wrong so far. He had been horrified when he learned that neither girl knew what a party was and apparently decided that it was his job to teach them. The flavours exploded on her tongue like nothing she had ever experienced before. The closest she had come was the sweet fruits that Catra used to bring her when they were children. She looked over at the furred girl, noticing that whenever she was handed food, she would sniff it experimentally and cast aside more than she sampled.

“Hey, you ok?” Adora pitched her voice low but Catra had no trouble picking out even under the sounds of revelry.

"Yeah, I'm fine Adora. Just keeping alert. We are still surrounded by enemies until the Alliance decides they'll take us." There were other things on her mind, things that Light Hope had never told her about what being the Guardian of the Sword, but Adora didn't need to be bogged down with that just now. Better to let the usually uptight girl have a little fun.

Catra had noticed that as Bow warmed up to them, so did Glimmer. She was still bossy and shrill but the more the two of them revealed about what they didn't know about the outside world, the more she softened. It would have been so easy for a real spy to use that against these people. There was a part of her, moulded and manipulated by Shadow Weaver, that wanted to. Light Hope's teachings were stronger though and she knew that the best way to protect Adora and the sword was to stay with these people.

"What is that?" Adora's eyes were huge as her voice became hushed and reverent, pulling Catra back into the moment, as she and the other two in their group followed Adora's pointing finger and excited gaze.

In the middle of a wide open space between a cluster of stalls selling food and trinkets, a wooden floor had been laid down where people were moving together seemingly in time with the sounds coming from the group of people to their right. Bow had been delighted to tell that that the sound she had been hearing the whole time, was something called music. He had compared it to birdsong, which had made her smile as it echoed her own thoughts. It did not explain the group of people gyrating and contorting their bodies all together though.

"Yeah, what is that?" Something about seeing the couples moving together with the music was making her hands itch to reach out for Adora.

"Oh my gosh, how are your lives this sad?" Before either of them could take offence, Bow was pulling them with him to the dance-

floor, trailed by Glimmer. “This is dancing. You hear the music and you move your body along with it. It’s really fun, try it.”

Catra gave into the itch in her fingertips and reached out for Adora who moved into her arms without resistance. They watched as Glimmer and Bow whooped and twirled with each other, beaming. It seemed that the princess had loosened up and forgotten her desire to get in and get gone. Mismatched eyes travelled around the other people dancing and saw that many of them were pressed together, using the music as an excuse to be close. She wrapped her arms tighter around the taller girl and felt her sag into her touch as they started to move together to the beat of the music. Everything would be fine as long as they were together.

They stayed on the dance floor for some time, eventually giving inland jumping around with their newfound friends. They didn’t stop until Adora’s stomach gurgled loudly, making them all laugh and move to one of the food stalls beside the music. Catra watched the other three chatter, hoping that this was a sign of what would come at the castle, when her ears swivelled as they picked up something beyond the sound of the music.

Catra knew that sound. Roaring filled her ears, washing away the sounds of fun and laughter. Her eyes roamed away from the dancing figures, squinting against the bright afternoon light that crested the nearby hills, picking up fast moving dark spots gathering. Her heart leapt into her throat. The Horde were here. They couldn’t be looking for them, even if their absence had been noticed, and Adora’s certainly had, Hordak would never commit that many troops to look for two runaways. This was something else. Something that tugged at the back of her mind but all the information that had crashed back to life in her brain in the last few hours clouded it.

“Adora! We have company.” Instantly Adora was at her side and looking at the silhouettes that were getting bigger.

“This is Thaymor!” The sound of flesh connecting with flesh made Catra flinch as she saw Adora slap herself in the forehead. “This is the attack I was supposed to lead, Catra. The one Shadow Weaver said you couldn’t be on! I forgot all about it.”

“What do you mean, attack you were supposed to lead?” Glimmer’s hissed words were right by their ears and both girls jumped.

“Worry about that later. You need to evacuate all of these people right now!” Catra and Adora were already moving towards the tanks and bots that were now easy to see.

“We’ll hold them off as best we can.” Adora saw hesitation on Glimmer’s face, were they about to betray her? She didn’t have time to think about that though, the people were more important. She and Bow raised their voices and then everyone was running.

Adora locked eyes with Catra across the clearing. Both were breathing hard, surrounded by old comrades made new enemies, grinning like fools. In the face of overwhelming odds, they would face them together. So focused was she on the cat girl facing off against a tank, that she almost missed the cold press of a sword hilt in her hand. Convulsively her hadn’t closed around the cool metal and a jolt of energy raced up her arm as though the weapon was a part that completed her arm. Unwillingly her gaze flitted to the shorter girl who had offered up the sword.

“You need to be the big woman again. Right now!” Glimmer’s voice held a note of command that Adora had not heard before and like a well trained soldier, she responded.

Adora raised the sword high above her head as she once again caught Catra’s eye and saw her smile grimly and nod. No surprises this time. Almost without thought the words came out of her mouth and then the power was flowing through her, filling every pour with power. Absently she was away of the sound of Bow and

Glimmer fighting and then she was charging forward on long, powerful legs, launching herself into the air and bringing down the sword with such force that she sliced the barrel off of the nearest tank as easily as she was cut through paper.

Screaming filled the air as the crew of the tank jumped out and started running as the tank first into flames, exploding behind her as she ran towards the next threat, easily deflecting the volley that came from the tank. Chaos was all around as the Horde went from winning to suddenly being outclassed by less than a handful of people.

You all right Princess?. Words filled her mind in a voice so familiar that relief flooded her. Catra was holding her own. **You bet I am. No crippling pain this time. These bots are no match for me!** Along with the words in her head, she could feel the elation that was pouring through the other girl.

Then there was only the fighting, wave after wave of tanks, skiffs and bots came at them. Adora fought with her sword slicing and thrusting until something trembled through her arm and she was brought to a stop. Something new was moving through her head, not a voice like Catra's, but something else, showing her a better way. A more efficient way to bring this to an end.

Letting the remaining tanks gather around her, hearing the sound of paws thudding against the earth as Catra came to stand at her side looking at her with confusion and faith in equal measure, she suddenly drive the sword into the ground and the huge concession wave that shot from it flung the weapons of war and soldier's alike, like paper dolls in the wind. It was over in a flash of light, leaving the four of them looking at each other with wide eyes.

"You should probably keep that." Glimmer's words almost made them all laugh as the two magical girls shrank to their normal size while the enemy ran to lick their wounds.

Freedom

Chapter Summary

Meeting Queen Angella and getting their own room.

Something about Brightmoon prickled at the back of Catra's mind as she and Adora walked across the bridge that led up to the breathtaking building. As sensitive as her ears were, she couldn't make out any of the words that were coming out of the princess and her friend. She was aware of their voices and Adora's excited response but not the word. All of her attention was firmly focused on the large glowing stone that hovered, suspended, at the pinnacle of the tallest tower of the castle. It hummed with a familiar energy, one that had rolled through her body since childhood in the shadow of the Crystal Castle. Why this mystical gem should feel like the technology at Light Hope's fingertips was perplexing. At least it didn't have the near debilitating feeling of the corrupted Black Garnet.

Adora noticed that Catra wasn't taking part in the light hearted banter that she had been sharing with their newfound allies. Since the altercation at Thaymor, the attitude of the pink girl, Glimmer, had made a full 180 and she was now all too keen to take them to meet her mother and the rest of the rebellion. Adora would be lying if she said she wasn't intimidated by the prospect of being in the presence of Queen Angella of the Rebellion. How many training simulations had she faced the towering figure in? It was almost a relief to be able to displace that worry with concern for Catra. She squeezed her hand, even as she found herself laughing at something that Bow had said, and was pleased to feel a shoulder bump in response. Whatever had captured the feline's attention, it wasn't dangerous then.

"When you meet the queen," Glimmer went on, oblivious to her distracted audience, "you should try to curtsy and then wait for her to talk, and maybe show her the sword really quickly. But not like you're drawing it on her."

Catra had tuned back in when she heard Glimmer mention the queen, and she and Adora shared a puzzled look. There was no need for the odd inner voice between then to know that both were wondering what in the world a curtsy was. Adora was toying with the sword in her hand, absently twirling the hilt as she carried it pointed to the ground and Catra felt such a swell of protection for the other girl in the moment that she dropped her hand, getting a small frown, before wrapping her arm around the slightly taller girls waist, seeing the coral lips tip into a soft smile as Adora rested her own arm across her furred shoulders. She noticed that the boy with them was shooting glances at them, hand covering his face and he tried not to coo at their gentle affection. It wasn't something she was used to, yet it felt nice to be looked at with softer eyes.

"Hey, Sparkles, calm down. We know how to be deferent to a commanding officer." Adora nodded beside her and the smaller girl relaxed just a hair. She was even more tightly wound than Adora, and that took some effort.

"Yeah, Glimmer, I'm sure that they'll behave." Bow seemed to be a sweet boy, the Horde would chew him up. Catra was glad that he would never know that life. It was good to know that there were people, even caught up in the war, who weren't ruined by it.

"Fine." There was a huffy quality to Glimmer's voice, but she stopped trying to groom the new arrivals. If they wanted to meet with her mother underprepared then she would let them.

Soon they were stood in front of the guards who barred the entrance from the bridge to the castle proper. Their spears were crossed over the opening as the two tall figures, expressions hidden by their helmets, fixed their attention on the two Horde soldier's walking with their princess. They had already sent for reinforcements, unsure whether the princess was escorting prisoners, or being held captive herself. Though, as the group drew closer, it was easy to see that both the princess and her friend were in good spirits and seemed to have brought them some prisoners.

“Welcome back Princess Glimmer, we can take custody of the prisoners for you.” As the guard on the right spoke, the other saw the word dangling from the blond prisoners hand and pointed their spear directly at the girl’s chest threateningly.

“Stand down!” Glimmer’s voice held the authority of generations and without question the palace guards put up their weapons. “We are escorting them to meet with my mother.” She wasn’t blind to how the two guards exchanged a look, but rather than point it out she squared her shoulders and marched passed them with her small entourage following.

The shiny, polished halls of her home were like a balm, no matter how treacherous the world outside may become or how much she may picker with her mother, in this place she was always safe and accepted. She wondered if either of the girls beside them had even known a place like that, from their reaction to the party and the fact that their own people were so quick to turn on them, she doubted it. The war may have always been real to the young princess, it had been raging her whole life, it was sobering to meet people who had not been raised in the war but for it. Against her better judgement, she liked both these strange ex-soldiers. Adora was wide eyed and awed by the world while Catra’s caustic tone and sharp edges mirrored her own. If her mother agreed, perhaps Brightmoon could be their place too.

Adora and Catra were left waiting in the too bright hallway, guards on either side, as Glimmer and Bow disappeared into what could only be try throne room. There had been the tinniest glimpse of the room beyond before the door closed in their faces. All that even Catra, with her cat-sharp vision, could make out was bright light and pastel colours. Even though she strained her ears there was not even the whisper of sound filtering through the door. All they could do was wait. Neither of them were ignorant to the fact that the guards who had gathered around them were eyeing the sword, and the feline had positioned her body to put herself

between them and the sword, it was Adora's and not to be snatched away.

Before anything like boredom could set in, the door was opening again and this time it was held wide open, letting them see the full splendour of the throne room. The ceilings were vaulted and so far above that it almost felt as though it was open to the sky. Courtiers milled around the edge of the room, though they seem as inconsequential as ants to Adora and Catra who could only stare at the woman seated in her floating throne, gossamer wings splayed around her and sharp eyes fixed on them as they walked deeper into the room, Glimmer taking Adora's free hand and smiling reassuringly as she led them forward. Catra kept pace with her, never letting herself fall out of step. She didn't miss the fact that Bow had melted into the crowd and wondered why he was not with Glimmer as she was with Adora.

The young Horde runaways were well used to overly imposing women in robes who towered before them. For both of them, Shadow Weaver had loomed large, figuratively and literally for many years, controlling them with her own unique, personalised form of sadism. Catra had also spent countless hours looking up at the blank visage of Light Hope as she was drilled into exhaustion to be able to meet her destiny. Even with that, they were not prepared to face this women.

Queen Angella rose from her gilded seat and glided down towards them across an empty chasm. It was impressive and such a casual, effortless display of magic that it made the fact that they were at the heart of the Rebellion seen suddenly very real. If they hadn't both just turned into giant magical creatures themselves, Catra was certain that they would both be more awestruck than they were.

"Glimmer tells me you two have come to join the Alliance." Her voice is strange, lilting with an accent neither girl has heard before. It was warm and imperious with equal measure and makes Adora feel strangely anxious, not able to truly get a fix on the woman.

“Yes, your majesty,” Adora spoke up for the both of them, Catra knew that she would. Whenever they faced Shadow Weaver, the other girl would take the lead to try to protect her. Why should it be any different now?

Adora laid the sword that had remained gripped in her first, across her open palms and took to a knee in front of the woman who now stood before them. Catra followed her lead, eyes keeping watch on the sword, as Adora held it out to the queen as an act of fealty. Neither of them had known what she would do, but in the moment Catra knew that Adora had made the right choice as the queen looked reverently at the weapon and lifted it from the proffered grasp.

Queen Angella turned the blade this way and that, the light in the room bouncing off of the blade and hilt but seeming to be absorbed into the blue stone set at its centre. Not just a jewel but a tiny, perfect, rune-stone that vibrated with power under the immortals hand. There was only one thing that this could be. She had heard stories about it since she was a child and the woman who wielded it.

Pale eyes turned back to the teen who had handed her the sword. Her blond hair and muscular build showed that she was a soldier but nothing like the stories of old. The other youth was even further from the descriptions of the mythical warrior, and yet here they were with the sword and, if Glimmer’s words were to believed, she had seen the magic in action.

“So you are She-ra?” The human girl looked momentarily frozen, before the unusual cat-girl nudged her with her elbow and nodded.

“Yes, your majesty, I am She-ra.” She met the older woman’s gaze unwaveringly now and she could see the power hiding behind those eyes. “We have come to lend our sword to your fight.” So, these two girls came as a package deal. Interesting.

“Then we accept your sword and the hand that wields it.” Yes, She-ra would certainly be an asset to their fight but they would need to watch their loyalties closely.

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The room that they had been shown to, was beautiful. Adora had gasped when she entered, her eyes unable to even register what she was seeing at first. It left her frozen in the doorway, blue eyes wide in wonder. Hands landed on her hips and she jumped, giggling a little as she realised Catra was simply trying to move her forward. Blushing, she realised that the two guards who had escorted them to the room were smiling under their helmets at her, and for the first time understood that they were free. She had never been able to have her guard down so much that somebody, even Catra, could startle her without trying. Not to mention that Catra would never have touched her so tenderly in front of anyone else.

When the doors had opened, leading them to a room that would be only theirs, Catra could only see the wondrous girl who was hers, enjoying the spoils of the sword. Adora had stopped stock still in front of her, blocking her own view, but everything that the feline needed to know was written in the other girl’s body. The indrawn breath, the shoulders thrown back and her head moving to take it all in. Almost without thought her clawed hands came to grasp the hips of her mate. It was something she had never done before, let alone in front of others, and the corresponding flinch from the blond almost caused her to let go but she pushed that down. No. They were not trapped in the Horde anymore or lost children in the woods.

The guards retreated and the doors were closed behind them, leaving them alone together for the first time since retrieving the sword. Catra’s hands stayed on firmly planted on Adora’s hips, the sound of the small waterfall that held pride of place that the centre of the room playing counterpoint to their shallow breathing. The loud clang of the sword falling from Adora’s hand should have broken the moment, made them shift apart or laugh, instead Adora turned in Catra’s grasp, feeling her hands wind

around her waist to meet along her spine. The blond reached up to rest her arms on Catra's shoulders, hands reaching up to fist into her hair as blue eyes locked with mismatched ones.

They stood like that for a long time, looking at each other as though seeing them for the first time, and maybe they were. They were certainly not the youths that they had been two days before, or the girls who had met in the woods so many years before. The sword had seen to that. It was Adora who moved first, bringing her forehead down to rest against Catra's, their faces joined from forehead to the tips of their noses. Catra blinked slowly back at her and everything was right with the world.

"We're free." The words were whispered but powerful.

"Are we?" Catra wasn't so sure. The queen clearly had plans for them, regardless of the private room and the promise of luxury the likes of which they had never known. Then there was Light Hope.

"Free enough then." Adora punctuated her words with a delicate lips to the ones that were suddenly frowning so close to her.

"Free enough." Catra echoed her words are she moved them even closer together, sealing their lips together in a deep, slow kiss that made Adora almost boneless in her arms. There was a lot to talk about, hidden training and wiped memories, giant glowing goddesses and massive cats. But for now, in this room, they could forget that for a little while.

Kisses turned to touches, clumsily fumbling with eager fingers at buttons and fastenings. They had never moved passed kisses and groping through clothes before, always too scared of being discovered to do more but now there was no danger of discovery. They had been given a room to share, a private place where they could just be Adora and Catra. Now, as they undressed each other, Adora allowed herself to marvel at the differences between them. She had seen Catra naked throughout their childhood, but things were different now. They were both grown and the feline

girl had been concealed from her hungry eyes by the tight fitting red uniform that flattened out her fur. As Catra threw Adora's shirt to the floor, the blond raised a finger and trailed it down Catra's chest from the dip of her throat to rest on her sternum, luxuriating in the thick fur that covered her. It was mesmerising to see the contrast of her pale flesh against the dark fur. Catra growled at the sensation, overwhelmed at the touch that was too much and too little all at once. Her eyes feasted on the fragile nakedness of the human girl, but she craved more contact, once again reaching for her hips and drawing them closer. Adora gasped as fur tickled at her bare breasts and Catra took the opportunity to seal their lips together in a kiss, thrusting her rough tongue into Adora's welcoming mouth.

Adora ran her hands down the fur that covered Catra's back, feeling the muscles beneath shift under her touch. She raked blunt nails against the nape of her neck and thrilled at the sensation of the purr that bubbled up from the cat's throat and sent a trill of sensation through their connected tongues. Adora couldn't help but groan in response, then squeak as she felt herself lifted under her thighs, reflexively wrapping her legs around the deceptively strong waist of her mate, as she was carried towards the big pillowy bed. Then she was being laid down, the feel of fabric the likes of which she had no words to describe, at her back and the firm warmth of Catra bearing down on her front made her whimper as her senses were overloaded with sensation.

Catra felt the sound travel through her, pulling away from the kiss and burying her face in the space whee Adora's jaw met her neck, she breathed her in. This was where she belonged, by Adora's side, protecting her from the world even as she protected the world from itself. It was what Light Hope had made her for, though as she felt one of Adora's hands tentatively moved to the waistband of her leggings, she doubted the holographic woman had ever considered this possibility.

"What do you want Adora?" Her words burred into the salty skin beneath her lips and without thought she flicked out her tongue

to lap at the skin, causing a tremor to roll through the girl underneath her as the hand on her hip clenched the fabric convulsively.

Adora would answer if her mind had not become completely blank. All thought had become sensation. The rapidly heating sheet under her back, the slide of fur against her skin, the feel of Catra's hot breath and even hotter tongue against her neck. Her throat felt suddenly too dry and ad her heartbeat stuttered. Large ears twitched close to her jaw, adding yet more sensation as Catra's sensitive hearing picked up her racing pulse and she pulled away just enough to hold herself up on her elbows and look down at the dazed looking girl under her who had yet to utter a sound. Folding those same ears back in concern, Catra reached out to cup her jaw and met the blond's eyes.

"Do you want to just cuddle?" It was something else they had been denied, just as intimate as taking this further and another strike against their past. Adora nodded her head, blushing and Catra shifted the both of them up higher onto the mattress so that neither pair of legs was dangling from the edge.

"I'm sorry." Adora was still blushing, in their half clothed state Catra could trace its path all the way down to the top of her breasts, her voice soft and shaky.

"Hey, don't apologise." Catra leaned down and placed a kiss over the human's heart, her mane trailing the other girls skin and leaving goosebumps. "We're just getting started, no need to hurry."

If a little part of Catra wasn't sure that they would both see out the war alive, she didn't let it out. Instead she settled herself back atop the longer body, this time resting half of her weight on the girl's right side and the rest on the too soft mattress. They shared another long kiss before she nestled her head into a smooth collarbone and brought her hand up to possessively cup Adora's left breast. She was rigidly still for a moment, waiting for the

other girl to pull away, but Adora sighed and her entire body relaxed.

"That feels nice." Adora's words had become fuzzy, the action of the last few days and the lack of rest fast catching up with both of them as teh adrenaline seeped away. Catra chirped into her skin and Adora felt herself beginning to drift. There were things she wanted to say to the other girl, now that they were alone. Things that it had never been safe to say before, but sleep was calling too loudly to ignore and they had tomorrow.

Moving just a little she brought her arm to wrap around Catra's back and hold her close while her other hand curled over the arm across her own chest. Fingers trailed lazily though the fur in a motion that soothed the two of them and even though the room was still bathed in afternoon light from the unimpeded window, both pairs of eyes were already closed, breaths coming deeper and slower. It wasn't long before Adora's hand stilled and her familiar little sleep snorts appeared. As though they were one, Catra became just as boneless and the two of them fell into sleep to the tinkling sounds of the waterfall.

For the Honour of Greyskull!

Chapter Summary

Frustrated Adora is frustrated.

Chapter Notes

This chapter wanted out so here it is.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sound of a body hitting the floor followed by muttered swearing and the scrape of metal sliding across the floor were what Catra and Adora woke to the next morning. Adora huffed and snuggled further into Catra's back, burying her face in the wild mane of hair. Catra smirked, she was annoyed at being woken by a virtual stranger but pretty sure the small pink girl was about to be horrified.

"Morning Sparkles!" Her voice startled the girl and, from the little scream that filled the room, boy causing both to jump to their feet from where they had tripped over the Sword of Protection and look directly at the bed.

Directly at the bed that currently contained two topless Horde soldiers and not a blanket covering either of them. She lazily watched as two pairs of eyes widened in shock before Glimmer hastily raised her hand to cover Bow's, ending up smacking him in the face in her clumsy haste. That led to the two of them slapping at each other's hands comically, making Catra chuckle and even luring Adora out from her hiding place to peek over a furred shoulder to see what the commotion was.

"You two are naked!" Glimmers words were hissed, Bow now turned away from the bed and staring fixedly at the waterfall nodding along with her.

“We’re half naked.” Adora sounded genuinely affronted as she perched her bony chin on Catra’s shoulder and looked challengingly back at Glimmer. “I thought we weren’t prisoners.” Catra knew this side of Adora well, this was the Force Captain come out to play. Grumpy morning Adora was always fun to watch when she wasn’t grumbling at you.

“You aren’t prisoners! Mom… I mean the queen told you that yesterday.” Glimmer was confused by Adora’s words and distracted by the bare chest of the cat-girl who had done nothing to cover herself. Maybe these Brightmoon types were prudes?

“Then why are you just appearing in here without knocking?” Sometimes, when she was indignant, Adora’s eyes would shift and go from the blue of a summers day to the stormy colour just before a third seat air and Catra knew that if she turned her head to look she would see that. She didn’t look though, because the flummoxed expression on Glimmer’s face as her jaw worked for a response while no sound came out was priceless.

“I… bu…we…Bow, tell them!” She was looking at the young man who still had his back to them.

“No Glimmer, this was your idea. I told you we should wait till breakfast.” She huffed at his words and pouted.

“You should have listened to him, Sparkles. I grew up in a cave and even I know you knock before barging into someone’s room.” Catra put on an incredulous voice that she knew amused the girl clinging to her back and was rewarded with the twin feeling of getting one over on the princess while Adora trembled with suppressed giggled.

“Argh, fine, we’re sorry.” Bow cleared his throat noisily and she sighed gustily. “I’m sorry. We’ll remember to knock next time.”

Catra gave a very toothy grin and Adora could no longer hold in the snigger that had been wracking her body. Glimmer, realising that she was being teased, crossed her arms and glared right

back before a smile started to make her lips quiver. These young soldier's were far different than she had expected, more playful and funny. Maybe there was hope for all of them yet.

"We thought you would like to come and have breakfast with us before you show everyone She-ra." It was funny to hear Bow talk with his back to them, in a couple of days they had already become so accustomed to his animated facial expressions that Adora found she missed seeing them.

"Actually, I'd love some breakfast but I was going to practice turning into the warrior woman first." Then Adora was climbing over Catra, breasts hitting the cat girl in the face and getting an indignant growl, and a surreptitious lick that made the blond shoot her a glare that she shrugged off. The blond was then standing by the bed, pants on but bare chested as she yawned and gave a little stretch.

Glimmer's jaw was almost on the floor as the muscular girl moved around without a scrap of modesty, breasts jiggling as she stretched before reaching down to scratch her ass. The princesses mouth was suddenly very dry and her very wide eyes couldn't look away.

"You need to put some clothes on!" The words tumbled out of her mouth, high pitched and flustered as she felt a blush wash over her.

"I think you're scandalising the Rebels, Adora." Catra oozed to her feet beside the human girl, all lithe grace and boneless ease. The look that Glimmer gave her naked torso was more curious than lascivious, she couldn't blame the shorter girl, there was no-one like her in all the world.

Adora went from confident and cock to blushingly clumsy in an instant, suddenly scrambling to find her shirt on the floor. Catra and Glimmer both wrinkled their noses at once. For Catra the idea of putting on her old Horde uniform was unthinkable. She was free again and short of walking around as naked as she had all

her life before being kidnapped into the military dictatorship, she would wear anything but not that. Adora was different though, she craved familiarity and routine. So much had changed for her in just a couple of days, that losing her uniform might just be a step too far. Except, the clothes were filthy and reeked of smoke, dirt and sweat.

"You can't wear that, Adora. You'll stink." She gently laid her hand on Adora's stomach to still her movements and bely the frankness of her words.

"We can get you some new things and you can throw those out." Glimmer's offer was excited at the idea of playing tree up with these girls but Adora froze in horror.

"No. I need these." Her hand was fisted in her shirt, knuckles white as if afraid that they would be snatched away from her.

"Tell you what I bet these people have the best laundry, right Glimmer." The princes nodded, surprised at the cat using her actual name. "I bet they can get these washed and back to us in the hour. How about we let the princess take them to be cleaned and bring them back here and we can just stay in bed." That seemed to mollify the other girl who released the balled up fabric into her hand. "Pants and underwear too, might as well be all clean." Catra noticed that Glimmer was still watching as Adora picked up her bra from the floor before starting to unbutton her pants. The feline raised a brow and made a twirling motion with her finger that caused Glimmer's blush to deepen even further as she turned around to stare at the door with Bow.

Adora peeled her pants and boxers down her legs, Catra had to look away as she felt a blush creep up her own neck, thankfully hidden by her fur. They had changed together many times, but it felt different now that they were in their room and had slept together half naked. Hearing the slap of a bare feet on the floor, Catra turned to see Adora bundling herself up in the blankets on top of the bed that had no been used till now, all that was visible

of her was her eyes and hair. It was perhaps the most adorable thing that the forest girl had ever seen.

Letting out a shrill whistle, Glimmer and Bow both spun to face her. Bow cooed and clapped his hands as he looked at Adora's bundled up form, being careful not to look directly at the cat-girl. Catra scooped up the dirty bundle, balling them up so that the socks and underwear were at the centre, walked over and thrust them into Glimmer's arms, enjoying the way her nose wrinkled n disgust.

"You can get these back in an hour right? You princess types have all kinds of servants?" It wasn't supposed to be a slur, but somehow Catra had a way of being able to make almost anything seem like a dig.

"Of course, and I will go by the tailors and see if he can start making her more so that we don't have to do this everyday."

"Hey, I am here, you know." Adora's voice was muffled by the fabric she had wrapped around herself but she sounded more than a little affronted. "What about you Catra, you can't go around naked even here, it's still not the woods."

Glimmer and Bow shared a look at the idea of the feline walking around naked in the woods. Bow chanced a look at the unusual girl and noticed that her chest was covered in fur and as flat as his own. He tilted his head and realised that If she chose to remain shirtless, nobody was likely to bat an eye. He didn't voice it though, Glimmer had a thing about nudity from when they were kids and she would be aghast at the thought.

"No way am I wearing this Horde shit ever again, Adora. Arrows, can you get me something like your top but looser and some shorts?" She knew what they were, they sometimes wore them for exercises.

"Oh, um, sure I can probably lend you one of my crop tops and shorts until we get you something else." Bow clapped his hands,

delighted that the unique girl wanted to dress more like him, if only temporarily. “Glimmer, I’ll go get us all some breakfast and clothes for Catra and meet you back here in an hour.” He was already rushing out the door, trying to think if he had any of the clothes that he had outgrown in his teenage growth spurt in his closet here. Glimmer shook her head affectionately as she followed him out of the room.

“These people are weird, Adora.” Catra murmured as she peeled the tight leggings off of her legs and ruffled her fur roughly. She threw them into the same cover as her top before picking up the sword and leaning it beside the bed.

Sitting down close to the mummified girl, she reached down and unwound the wraps from her feet. They may have once been white but now they were almost black with soot and grime. With distain she kicked them over with the rest of the clothes that she vowed never to wear again, leaving her now in only her underwear as she felt Adora shift towards her and open the blanket to draw her into the almost stiflingly warm cocoon that she had made for herself.

“We should take a shower.” Catra didn’t really mind being surrounded by the smell of sweat that came from the blond, but she knew that human’s and other creatures had more delicate sensibilities.

Laying lazily across a fat tree branch, Catra let her arms and legs dangle on either side as her belly rested on the bough, tail moving languidly while looking down at the increasingly more and more frustrated Adora. The blond girl was stomping around the secluded part of the garden that they had been shown too, muttering despondently at the sword as though it was going to answer her. They had been out here for over an hour and She-ra was yet to make an appearance.

It had started in their room. They had emerged from the longest shower of Adora's life, the warm water had felt amazing and the feel of the soapy hands that had run over her body had made her tremble, but all they had done was clean each other. Before they were done the water at their feet had run brown, before it had run clear and clear sign of just how much felt had coated hair and fur and skin. Adora had made it her job to wrap the furred girl in a large fluffy towel and roughly dry as much water as she could from her, before wrapping one around her own frame.

By the time that their new friends arrived, thankfully after loudly knocking this time, they had been sitting on the floor, both wrapped in towels, with the sore on the floor between them. Bow had placed an overloaded tray of delicious smelling food on the table in the corned of the room before skipping over and thrusting a pile of clothes at the bemused Catra who reached up to take them instinctively.

Glimmer was more reserved, but no less excited, to pass Adora her newly laundered uniform. The human girl almost snatched them from her, bringing them up to her face and inhaling the smell. It was just so clean, nothing like the harsh and abrasive smell of the chemicals used to sterilise and clean their clothes in the Fright Zone. In fact they even felt softer to the touch if that was possible. She jumped to her feet and ran to the bathroom, ready to be dressed again.

Adora emerged from the bathroom feeling much more like herself. Her shirt felt right on her skin and even her socks seemed almost new. She finished fastening her ponytail as she walked back to Catra, hauling the smaller girl to her feet and shooing her into the bathroom to change. Adora's mouth was already bulging with food by the time that Catra emerged, and almost choked when she saw the cat girl. Bow had brought her a black crop-top, baring the full expanse of Catra's arms and stomach. There was a small red heart over the space where her own would be, but it was faded and missing colour in places. It suited the other girl and made her look much more as she had as a girl. The shorts that hung low on her hips were also black and looked soft to the touch.

“You look nice.” Adora spoke though a mouthful of something called a pancake and Catra patted her on the head as she walked passed to get her own.

After they had all eaten their fill, Glimmer had been eager for Adora to try transforming. Catra had sat herself down in front of the full length mirror that made up the door of the closet, Adora migrating to stand behind her. Both girls were curious to see what they looked like, they had seen each other but not themselves.

Adora took a deep breath, rolling her shoulders and stretching her neck as though she was about to take on the world, before lifting the sword above her head and saying the words. Everyone in the room held their breath, waiting. And waiting. And waiting. Nothing happened. Catra saw Adora’s brows furrow in consternation and she bounced on her feet as though trying to hold the sword even higher and shouted the words even louder. Still nothing.

Adora had started to shake the sword as she might a faulty stun baton and Catra had tilted her head back to look up at the other girl. Adora’s strong jaw was clenched and she had such a look of concentration that Catra fell in love with the other girl just a little more.

“I don’t think it’s working,” Bow’s whisper seemed very loud in the room.

That had been what led them out here. Glimmer had suggested that maybe Adora needed more space and taken them to an area for the palace gardens that was in the shadow of the bridge. There were a few large trees and mostly lawn. Adora had started by planting her feet and holding the sword up in both hands before taking a deep breath.

“For the Honour of Greyskull!” The words had rung out in the clearing but still nothing had changed. It had only taken a few more failed tried for the two alliance members to grow bored and wonder off, promising that they would return with more food.

The more frustrated Adora had become, the more amused Catra had grown, moving out of the way up the tree to observe the blonds attempts. She had started by stomping around the area, occasionally thrusting the sword out in front of her and shouting the words as though trying to take the weapon by surprise. One of those attempts had sent the sword spinning out of her hands to land tip first into the earth. There there had been the twirling, and twirling. It looked amazing, and the sword dancing in Adora's grasp as though it were a weapon that she had been trained for, and Catra had sat up straighter on the branch to watch more closely. That had ended with her smashing the sword into the grass in frustration.

Adora was currently laying on the ground, sword held out to the side, muttering under her breath. Unwilling to let the other girl suffer alone, even if it was just from frustration, Catra slunk down the tree and flopped on the ground at Adora's side. A sigh greeted her and then Adora was turning her head to look at her with huge, puppy-dog eyes.

"Why isn't it working?"

"How should I know?" Catra's words just made the other girl glower.

"Maybe because you were taught all about this since we were kids?" Adora sounded angry, as though she thought that Catra had been lying to her.

"Adora, I'm sorry that I never told you, and then I didn't remember. Light Hope only told me what I needed to know to bring you to the sword and then to protect you. Being the Guardian of the Sword means that I protect the protector." She sat up on her elbow and reached out with her other hand to cup Adora's jaw so that she couldn't look away. "I love you because you're Adora, and not because of the sword. I think I did the first time you crept through the trees and fell over. If I knew why this isn't working I would tell you." Adora nodded into palm, turning her head to kiss there.

“I know. It’s just…I promised She-ra would join the rebellion and now all they get is me.” There was the crippling self doubt that Shadow Weaver had so carefully crafted into Adora’s DNA.

“Then they’re lucky that they have you!” She didn’t need to be the Guardian of the Sword to be Adora’s biggest cheerleader. “Why don’t we just stay here for a while, maybe get you to calm down and we can try again.”

Adora didn’t fight the idea, in fact she rolled towards the other girl, shifting her body so that her cheek was laying on the exposed fur of Catra’s stomach. She reached out and buried one of her hands in the fur and felt the other girl reach out to toy with her ponytail.

“You look cute in Bow’s clothes.” She watched as the fur rippled with her breath as she spoke. It was thick and soft, concealing the hard stomach muscles beneath. It made Catra the perfect pillow.

“You could have tried something new too.” Catra kept her voice soft as though she was talking to a skittish animal but Adora propped herself up to meet her eyes anyway.

“Maybe I will, but I have enough to worry about as it is.” She slumped back down, kissing Catra’s stomach before once again laying her cheek against it.

“Ok. Let's just rest a while and then you can try again. Maybe we can convince Sparkles to bring a mirror out here for when it works.” The murmured conversation between them felt like home, and gradually Adora started to calm down her fear of failure.

Chapter End Notes

Next time Razz!

Razzle Dazzle

Chapter Summary

Getting to grips with She-ra

Chapter Notes

I realised while writing this section that I inverted some events from episodes 2 and 3 - I shall now pretend I did that on purpose!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow and Glimmer brought them lunch on the lawn. They were still laying on the grass, Catra working her fingers through the blond ponytail as Adora lightly dozed on her stomach, relaxed and no longer worrying about the sword. Catra's ears had twitched when she heard the crunch of grass under the other teens boots and turned lazy eyes towards them. To an observer, she remained just as relaxed as she had before, but Adora felt the tension fill the muscles under her cheek and the low quiver of her tail. These people may seem benign but they had been prepared to fight them for a long time, Catra was ready to protect both of them. Adora felt warmed.

"We brought sandwiches!" Glimmers voice was loud and sing-song as she flopped onto the ground beside them, prompting the girls to sit up from their prone position.

"And quiche!" Bow was clearly just as excited to share this new way of life with them. He placed the big basket in his hands down in the middle of their little group and sank to the floor cross-legged.

"What's quiche?" Adora eyed the basket in front of her. She wasn't sure that she liked the sound of it, it sounded squelchy.

"You'll love it. It's like a tart but full of meat and vegetables and eggs." Would it make her seem even more naive if she told Bow that she didn't know what a tart was? Adora didn't have to worry, as Catra piped up.

"Forget a quiche, what's a sandwich?" Bow and Glimmer's eyes both grew wide and they did that thing where the turned to each other in unison and shrugged.

Bow leaned forward and flipped open the lid on the woven basket, reaching in and pulling out package after package and handing them to Glimmer who had laid out a small blanket in the space between then. She neatly unwrapped the parchment paper from around the food and set it out on the blanket. There was an array of goodies to be beheld, chicken salad sandwiches, salmon bagels, mini quiches and all sorts of fruits and cakes. There was far too much for the four of them, but after seeing how the two soldier's had devoured the food the day before, they had wanted to let them experience new things.

Glimmer took delight in pointing at each treat and explain what it was and how it was made, as much as she understood anyway. Bow jumped in here and there to tell them what his favourites were. He was very enthusiastic about a folded triangle that had meat and vegetables inside that he called a samosa. Never one to stand back from a challenge, Adora grabbed the nearest thing and started to munch on it. There were so many flavours in the little round thing that she had stuffed in her mouth. Some of it was crisp and flakey while others were soft. It was delicious and she soon reached out to stuff another in her mouth before moving on to something different. She did like quiche it seemed.

Catra was not so keen to put just anything in her mouth, honestly it worried her that Adora would choke how much she put in hers. She had grown up eating what she could hunt and gather and understood the value of circumspection. Put the wrong berry in your mouth, lick the wrong frog and you would be at best very sick or at worst dead. She reached a hand out, claws extended as though to protect herself, and picked up one of the sandwiches. It

had a lot of layers and she pulled it apart, carefully sniffing at each one, looking for any sign of poison or decay. Everything smelt rich and decadent, and she finally took a bite from the whole thing as she had seen Glimmer do. There were lots of different textures and flavours. Too many. It tasted almost muddy in her mouth. She reached for one of the wrapped triangles and bit into it, chewing and spitting out the filling as pin pricks of something crawled over her tongue like ants. She didn't miss the look shared by the three humans.

"You got anything simpler there, Sparkles?" Nonchalance was her go to and she tried not to show that she was feeling out of place when Adora seemed to be settling in so well.

"Here." Bow leaned forward and offered her the leg of some type of bird. It looked different to what she was used to, much larger than those she had hunted I the past and the flesh itself was white and not bloodied.

She took it cautiously and gave a tentative bite. It was meat, cooked as she and Adora had cooked meat for her when they were children. She preferred it raw, the blood on her tongue, but it was nonetheless delicious. Certainly no animal that she had ever hunted. She reached for another and Bow pointed her to a darker meat with a much redder colour, almost bloody and her mouth watered. She wondered as she chewed and savoured the food how she had not missed this while she had been forced to eat the bland and slimy ration bars. Though, usually she was exhausted and half starved when she ate, if she ate, and anything in her stomach had been a relief.

"So," Glimmers bright voice broke the silence, "any luck with She-ra yet?"

"Sure Sparkles, we're just hanging on the grass because Adora has mastered turning into a goddess." Catra rolled her eyes and avoided a swat from the girl in question, sticking her tongue out in response.

“No luck yet. I just need to figure out what I did differently, that’s all. All that adrenaline, I must be forgetting something.” Catra hated that Adora would be so self deprecating and wished that in all her training Light Hope had thought to tell her how to help the sword bearer actually use the power of the sword. How was she supposed to be their guardian if she didn’t know what she was guarding?

“You know what I think?” Catra spoke up before Bow could share the idea he had obviously been about to share. “I think you and me should go into the woods. It’s where I was made,” she saw the shock on the other teens faces at her choice of words and knew that they would ask about it sooner or later. “It’s where you found the sword and it’s where you transformed for the first time. Maybe something familiar will help.” And if she was itching to get back into the woods, just the two of them, then that was just a bonus.

Hand in hand they ran through the woods, laughing like children. It had been hard to convince Bow and Glimmer that they would be better off by themselves, but eventually they had managed by promising to come back as soon as the pair transformed, in their larger states. They moved so quickly, sure-footed over the roots and stones on the ground, that the shrubbery and leaves became nothing but a green blur. Adora’s heart pounded in her chest, this was where they were supposed to be. It was where she had met Catra and started to see the Horde as something other than a home. It was the place where she was starting to find herself. She whooped gleefully and saw the other girl looking back at her from where she had taken the lead through the trees.

Catra’s face looks so radiant that Adora almost forgot to breath. For a moment, the human could see the bare, free form of the other girl, running wild in the woods, before she had been ‘civilised’ at the hands of Shadow Weaver. It made her stumble and only the sharp reflexes of her companion saved her from hiding the ground. Catra pulled her into her arms to steady her,

and who was Adora to resist the closeness of those lips or the warmth of her body? She leaned down the scant inches between them and pressed a soft kiss to Catra's lips. The feline giggled, carefree in a way the blond had missed, and kissed her back fiercely.

Deeper and deeper they moved into the woods, slowing their pace to walk together, joined hands swinging between them. Birdsong filled the still air as the canopy thickened dappling light all around them in patches and pockets. A shaft of light would catch Adora's hair and make it shine like spun gold, and Catra would have to remind herself to breath. They both had to remind themselves that they weren't out here just to play and be together, it was so easy to slip into the world of before, Adora sneaking away to be with her. No, now they had a mission, something that Catra had been raised for. Adora needed to learn how to use her powers.

The pair found a small clearing, big enough for Adora to stomp around and swing the sword, but not so large that the wood's didn't feel like they were watching. The process from the garden started again; Adora, holding the sword aloft and calling the words and then nothing. Now and again the trees would rustle as though a vicious wind were gusting, but nothing more. Catra tried plastering herself to the other girls back, hoping that together they could bring forth the magic but it was to no avail. After one too many attempts, Adora let out a growl and flung the sword towards the trees where it embedded itself and stayed, right nest to the messy white head that had just stepped out of the foliage.

Both girls gasped and rushed towards the old woman to check that she was all right. Razz appeared through the undergrowth, as she often did, as though conjured from the air itself. There was no way that her cottage should be so close to Brightmoon, yet Adora knew that if they followed the old woman they would find themselves there. She was like the woods, a place unfixed in space and time that could be wherever it needed to be. If she was here with them the, it meant that they needed her. They were both thankful that the sword had missed her.

If Adora was happy to see the old woman, Catra was crawling out of her skin, her entire body trembling as she held herself back. Her tail was lashing furiously, a sure sign of agitation. Adora wasn't certain why the other girl seemed so anxious and shared no such qualms as she walked towards Razz and gave her a hug which the old woman returned happily, even if she called her 'Mara' while she did.

As they separated it was as though a switch had been flipped in Catra and she flew towards the old woman, for a moment Adora was afraid that in her eager haste she would barrel the old woman over and hurt her fragile form. She shouldn't have worried. Catra moved on all fours, running full tilt before leaping over the shagging white head to land behind her and then start to roll on the ground, wiggling excitedly as Razz turned towards her with a fond expression covering her thin lipped face. Then the feline was kneeling beside the diminutive old woman and rubbing her head against her arm. Razz hummed softly and ran her hand over the girls head.

"Hello Wildling, you have grown." There was a tenders in the strangely lilting voice and Adora almost felt jealous at the care she saw Catra receive. Razz put her fingers to her chin and tilted it up to look deep into mismatched eyes before lightly shaking her head, Adora noting the flash of sadness that was there and then gone. "Learned to wear clothing I see."

Finally Catra stood up, reaching to take the basket that was hanging over Razz's arm from her. The old woman patted her arm in thanks before moving to link her arm with Adora's. "You girls can help me make some pie!" Then she was leading them back into the depths of the woods, as they passed the sword, still embedded in the tree, she waved a wrinkled old hand. "Get that, won't you Mara-dear?"

Their search for berries led them passed Razz's cottage, which they were both pleased to see was the same as it ever was, though seemingly out of place in the shifting woods. She

chattered on about collecting berries and how it wasn't quite the time yet. What it wasn't time for they weren't sure but were happy to have the distraction of the red clothed figure. Once or twice she even managed to called Adora by her own name which made her feel a swell of joy in her heart. Although she was still mostly Mara.

After what seemed like hours of walking Catra knew where they were. The Crystal Castle came into view and she was home again, again. She didn't have time to enjoy the sight, now that they weren't being pursued by a giant worm intend on crushing them, because the shockingly spry old woman was leaping up the side of the almost sheer building with the garage of a mountain goat. Adora was beside herself, calling up for Razz to take care, only to get shooed away as she made her way to a tiny plant growing out of a crack that seemed laden with fruit. It was when she climbed back to the ground that things started to change. Light began to burst from the shell of the building in sudden pulses and then, as Razz looked at Adora, all Adora could see was stars.

Seeing the stars had stirred something in Adora. The whirl of images and sounds that had assailed her when she first found the sword had swooped back into her mind. Other things had come too, feelings of home and longing for something that she couldn't understand. The stars themselves had been as familiar as the colour of Catra's eyes, yet she was certain that she had never seen them. It was the same as the way that she could read the strange geometric writing all over the Crystal Castle and the ruins.

"I know this! How do I know this?" There was a hand at the small of her back, offering her silent strength, as Razz reached out to take her hand but was halted by the sounds of voices shouting and the unmistakable sound of tank fire and terrified voices.

The trio ran, Razz in the lead, winding their way through the trees only to come out at the edge of a ridge overlooking nothing but devastation. The village that had once occupied the valley lay in smouldering ruins, crushed and decimated under the tank treads. Helmeted soldiers, identities hidden from those that they fought,

patrolled the area with stun batons in hand. It took a moment for them to see where the shouting and crying was coming from and when they did, Catra felt her blood boil and her fur stand on end while Adora felt helpless and frozen.

In an open area, surrounded by tanks on all sides, four Horde soldier's had surrounded a group of crying children, the oldest no more than ten. They had their batons raised and nets ready to take the children prisoner, no doubt intending to drag them back to one of the creche's to indoctrinate another bath of cadets to fight against the alliance. One little girl clutch a toy in her hand and was calling softly for a mama that was never coming back. As the awful words that the soldiers were taunting the children with reached their ears, Adora turned to Razz feeling lost.

"What do we do?"

"You know what to do, my brave girl. You use the power inside of you. Trust yourself, Adora." Razz's words seemed to get further away as Adora turned, lifting the sword into the air while her eyes remained fixed on the atrocity below, and called out.

"For the Honour of Greyskull." Maybe it was because it was the third time she had transformed, but this time the power surged through her and she embraced it, familiar now with the tugging on her limbs and the flash of vertigo that accompanied her shift in statue. It was over in a heartbeat and a flash of light, beside her Catra replaced by the terrifyingly large cate that growled low in its throat and looked towards her.

Shall we? Catra's voice, incongruous as it was reassuring, filled her head.

"We shall!" Adora talked aloud as she jumped onto Catra's back, clearly surprising the animal who tilted her head quizzically. "Charge!"

They sped towards the action at break neck speed, leaving no time for the soldier's to react before they were upon them. She-ra

vaulted from the back of her companion, landing powerfully in front of the children and swiping her sword at the closest assailant who backed away stunned. Distantly she was aware of the sound of something being crushed between powerful jaws and the pained cries of the other soldiers. Confident that Catra had the immediate threat under control, she ushered the children into a small rocky outcrop that would offer them some shelter, crouching down to meet their terrified eyes.

"Stay here, ok. Me and my friend will be right back and take you somewhere safe." The oldest of the children nodded and wrapped their arms around their younger friends as she marched out to rejoin the melee.

Catra, though it seemed wrong to call the savage beast that, had subdued the soldier's, perhaps more than subduing a few, and was toying with a tank operator who was attempting to shoot at her. She-ra felt her blood boil and ran at the nearest tank, bringing her sword down to cleave easily through the metal. Catra took her cue and the pair of them tore the enemy weaponry apart. Adora threw her sword at a gun turret, where it embedded itself after doing damage and heard Razz whoop with glee like the spectator at some tournament.

"That's my girl!"

As she fought Adora thought she heard the scrape of steel. Then Razz was throwing her back her sword before doing one of her impossible somersaults and landing int front of a masked soldier, who even with a covered face looked bemused as the old woman began to hit them with her broom while shouting 'razzle dazzle'. Adora was watching from the corner of her eye as she took out her own foes, when the soldier started to raise their own weapon and aim it at the woman. Before she could react, Catra was there, pouncing on the armoured figure and pinning them to the ground with massive jaws locked around their throat and making a sound that froze the blood.

That seemed to be the last straw for the Horde troops who turned tail and ran, jumping on still functioning skiffs and leaving the wreckage of tanks behind. She-ra watched as Razz laid her hand on a trembling shoulder muscle soothingly, crooning at the big cat that it was all right and that she could set the frozen figure free. She released her jaws and they scrambled to their feet and lurchingly ran to the last skiff that was taking off, reaching up and being swung in as the vehicle flew away.

"There you are. She-ra knows when she is needed, Adora. You are brave and fearless. You must trust yourself. The power would not have chosen you if you could not weird it." Razz was holding one of her colossal hands, looking almost childlike beside the princess.

"Then I know what I need to do. What we need to do." She rested her hand on the large head that had come to rest by her side. "We will protect Etheria, because the Princesses aren't." Catra chirruped in assent

The three of them went to retrieved the six huddled children. Catra laid on the ground and She-ra place each child onto the broad back, telling them to hold onto the fur tightly and that they would be taken back to a place where they would be safe. Still in their transformed forms they began to walk back to Brightmoon, loosing Razz along the way but knowing that if they needed her, she would find them.

Chapter End Notes

Next time... Perfuma!

Flower Power

Chapter Summary

Learning to use the amenities and getting a princess to boot.

Chapter Notes

This fic is going to cover all of Season 1 and then diverge for the the last chapter - finally an end in sight!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Adora," Catra's voice had a whine that was so unfamiliar that it stopped the blond girl in her tracks and made her turn quizzically to face the other girl in the hallway. "I'm all sticky!" Her voice was so indignant, pout firmly on her lips that Adora couldn't hold in the laughter that wanted to bubble out.

"How can you be sticky? We transformed back, everything from our big self's," she made a popping gesture with her hand, "poof, gone."

"Well, it might be 'poof gone' for She-ra but apparently it's sticky fur for me." Her voice was grumpy and she was holding her arm across her body as she used to when she was worried at the Fright Zone.

"Maybe you're sticky because those kids liked you so much as you that they couldn't stop hugging you." It was true, the children may have liked the giant cat but as soon as Catra had transformed back to her more human form they had been fascinated, one little girl in particular trailing her around and hugging her until the children had been escorted away to bed.

It had been very cute.

Adora reached out and took the sullen girl's hand, pulling her towards the room that they had been given. If Catra was sticky

then she would help her get clean. They were a team. No, Adora corrected the thought, they were a pair. They perfectly reflected and complimented each other. Adora looked out for the other girl, just like she looked out for her. They made it through the door and the human dragged Catra straight to the bathroom where they both suddenly stopped and looked at the shower bemused.

Back in the Horde the showers had been a simple affair; walk in, hit the single stiff button and be suddenly pummelled with water that was only ever tepid at best. The most challenging part of the whole affair had been seeing how fast you could get washed and out before your teeth started to chatter. What they were looking at in front of them was not a rusty spigot and a stiff button. There were multiple shower heads poking out at angles, a lever and two buttons and so many bottles lining the walls that they looked at each other and shrugged. Catra, never one to let anything intimidate her that she could fight against, threw off her clothes with no sign of modesty and stepped into the cubical. She looked down at the lever, shook her head and cranked it.

Scalding water burst out of five separate nozzles all at once, making her scream and leap out before she was hurt, straight into the shocked arms of the still clothed Adora. Standing together, soggy and starting to chill, the two of them looked at each other and burst out laughing, the sound almost drowned out by the loud sound of the highly pressurised water.

“What was that?” Adora tried to push the other girl off of her which only made Catra rub her damp fur all over her with a grin on her face.

“That’s really fuckin’ hot, that’s what.” Adora raised an eyebrow and finally disentangling from Catra, made her way over to the water unable to believe such a thing.

Adora reached out a hand and placed it into the stream, jerking it away with a gasp when the scolding water hit the tender flesh. Stepping back fearfully, shaking her hand, she looked at Catra again and pouted. She had really wanted a shower too. A clawed

hand reached out and grasped her very pink one, bringing it up to her lips to kiss it and Adora's face blushed as red as her hand.

"It is hot!" Even to her own ears she sounded childish but she was dirty and tired.

"It is." Catra walked out of the room and straight towards the door, completely naked and uncaring. Adora poked her head around the bathroom door and watched her best friend pull open the door. Her blush deepened as she realised that she was watching one part of the feline in particular.

Catra stuck her head out of the open doorway and looked left and right for one of the guards she knew were still being posted outside their room to watch them. A choked cough caught her attention and her eyes landed on a tall woman who was flushed all the way down her neck. She didn't need to be able to see her eyes to know that she was embarrassed by the sight of her nudity. Humans were weird.

"Hey, you, can you come and give us a hand? We're having trouble with the shower, Fright Zone wasn't exactly big on fancy." The woman mumbled something that sounded like an agreement and propped her tall spear against the wall before gingerly edging around the naked teen and scurrying to the bathroom.

The cat-girl laughed and followed, wanting to see how to use the bathroom too. It turned out to be a simple trick to setting the temperature and the pressure of the water and before they knew it the guard was gone and they were alone again in the shiny room. Catra contemplated getting back under thew water by herself, but her back was sticky and she would need the other girls help anyway.

Walking up to Adora, Catra reached out and started to unbutton the taller girl's pants, only to find her hands being slapped away and a cute little 'eep' coming out of the blond. Catra looked at her, meeting blue eyes and smiling softly before jerking her head up to the shower.

“You can wash my back and I’ll wash yours.” It was all the blond needed, apparently, as she threw off her red jacket and quickly peeled her white top over her head. Catra took the opportunity to press a kiss to her stomach before pantsing her and falling back onto the floor with a laugh at the shocked look on Adora’s face.

Embarrassment gone in the face of Catra’s playful antics, Adora kicked off her shoes and the clothes that were pooled around her ankles leaving her standing, stark naked, in front of Catra. The laughter petered out of the feline as she looked up at the toned girl, admiring this person who was just for her. Catra surged to her feet, so quickly that Adora could barely register the movement, and wrapped her arms around the other girl before pressing a kiss to her jaw.

“Let’s get wet!”

Later, as they laid side-by-side on top of the big puffy bed, cleaner than either had ever been and smelling of things that neither of them had words for that had come out of the glass bottles in the bathroom, they started to talk. The sword glinted in the corner, and Catra told the other girl all she knew. It turned out that it wasn’t much at all. All those hours spent in the Crystal Castle, performing drills and exercises until she was too exhausted to move and Light Hope had told her the barest minimum. She turned her head to look at the other girl, still wrapped in a towel, every sacrifice was worth it as long as Adora was safe. There would be no stopping her running into danger now that she had the full force of She-ra behind her, Catra was glad that if anyone was going to have her back it would be her.

“Let me get this straight. Light Hope has the power to just make people?” Adora was leaning up on her elbow, looking down at the feline with the towel starting to slip. Catra worked hard to keep eye contact.

“That’s exactly what I’m saying. She knew that the new bearer of the sword had been born and the animals that were my parents built their den connected to the Castle, my mother was with cub

and Light Hope did something…she explain but I didn't understand then and I don't now, but it made me more person than beast." Adora had started to run her finger along Catra's jaw as she spoke.

"Do you remember what your parents looked like?" Adora spoke softly, she had no memory of her parents and hoped for more for her friend even if her parentage was less than conventional.

"Yeah, they kinda looked like the big version of me." They had both managed to get a glimpse of themselves in their new forms once they had handed the children over to be cared for. Catra was surprised to recognise herself. "I guess they were a little smaller? I don't know, I was only a little kit when they disappeared." Part of her worried that Light Hope had made them disappear so that she would focus only on the hologram, it was a part of her that hadn't existed before the Fright Zone.

"Did you ever see any others?" Was there a pack of Catra's running around in the deepest shadows of the Whispering Woods.

"Once, I already knew you. I was hunting and I came face to face with a cat three times bigger than me. He was alone and I was afraid. We were hunting the same prey and I'd taken it down. I was sure he would take it from me, but he just looked at me hard and ran off. I don't know why." She always wished that she had followed him back to the pack.

"Well, I don't know my family either and that's why I have you." Adora kissed her sweetly before settling back onto the bed.

Time ticked by and the world grew dark. Adora began to doze, stirring when she felt the bed jostle as Catra climbed out and pulled on a pair of boxers. Adora sleepily watched her move to the window seat, curling her body, tail wrapping around her own torso as she pressed her forehead to the glass and looked out at the Whispering Woods with longing. The blond's eyes drooped heavily and the next time she blinked them open it was even darker. Catra was slumped with her cheek still pressed to the glass.

Dreams had woken her, unclear and swirling images that had unsettled and confused her until her body had fought back by dragging her into wakefulness. As quietly as she could she crawled from the bed, grabbing one of the robes that they had found on the hook on the back of the bathroom door and slipped out of the room.

In the dark, the halls of Brightmoon didn't look so different to the ones in the Fright Zone, just much, much quieter. The slap of her bare feet filled the hallways. She passed guards who didn't acknowledge her and wondered how many were napping under their helmets. She turned a corner and froze.

Standing, bathed in a shaft of moonlight, was Queen Angella in front of the mural of a man looking lost in thought. Adora tried to back away and not disturb the woman who she found incredibly intimidating. Wise eyes turned to glance at her and she knew she'd been caught, trying hard to do something like a bow without flashing the monarch. Queen Angella looked back to the painting and raised her hand to tenderly touch the painted face.

Then she began to talk.

Glimmer had a plan. It was simple really, use She-ra to lure the other princesses to join them. She was the shiny new toy that they had needed. There wasn't a child alive who hadn't listened to the legends of the goddess who had protected Etheria from harm. They had sat and looked at the information on each of the other princesses and Catra had rightly pointed out that Perfuma would be their best choice to start with. The kingdom was the closest, had long ties with Brightmoon and by all accounts the princess with the power to bend plant life to her will was a soft touch.

They had stayed three days in the castle, finding their bearings and finally getting some new clothes. Adora looked much as she ever did, minus the Horde emblem that had been emblazoned on her back for so long, the red jacket its old warm self but the fabric

of her shirt was much softer and her pants fit just a little better. Catra, on the other hand, looked like a wood spirit. Loose pants hung low on her hips, showing the sharpness there as well as the broad expanse of her toned abdomen, muscles visible even through her fur, before the leather harness that covered her chest and strapped across one shoulder. She looked ready for battle or to run free through the trees.

It was decided that they would enter Plumeria transformed, let She-ra be the face of the Alliance. Put the candy straight on the table and let the princesses reach out for her with their grubby little hands.

It seemed to work as they walked into the city, though that seemed wrong to describe the woven buildings littered with vines and flowers. There was nothing industrial or even organised about the place and the people were either dressed in flowing robes or barely as dressed as Catra.

Everything was going well. Perfuma was softly spoken and keen to impress, babies were placed into Adora's arms and the people were warm and welcoming, starting a party on the spot as though they had known that they would arrive. It was overwhelming and Catra, in her far more fearsome persona, escaped to the edge of the woods, drawn there by the call of the wild that she had been feeling since her memory was restored. The only thing stronger was the call to Adora.

Plumeria wasn't what she had expected. It was leafy and green but the feeling of wrongness hovered in the air, stronger now that she was among the flora. Catra could taste the corruption and with every touch of a leaf that was a little too dull and a lot greasy. Whatever the Horde was planning it wasn't a case of when it would happen, it was already here. Hopefully this princess would be amenable to their plans and it wouldn't be too late to save this place.

Perfuma had said no.

She had seen what the Horde was planning and turned away as though it would not kill the very land, the very life that they claimed to cherish. Adora couldn't understand this inaction. Why she wasn't willing to fight for her home and her people. The smoke and oil, the mining equipment spilling out smoke and pollution into the air should have horrified the princess far more than the girl who grew up seeing that. Dejection at the refusal had caused her to shift back to her normal form, Catra following suit.

Glimmer, Bow, Adora and Perfuma walked back to the Heart Blossom, its sickly hue and lack of shine a clear sign that it was dying. Glimmer was shrill and all but shouting while Perfuma stood her ground, sure that everything would be fine. Catra had clambered up a tree to watch the foolishness unfold.

"We are doing everything we can to heal the plants and the earth, the Heart Blossom is just a little weak right now. There is nothing more we can do. I will do my best and the soil will heal. I am doing all I can." The serene look on the long face almost made Adora want to punch her. She had been raised for action, and although it was by an evil army and the sadistic teacher, this level of passivity and inaction was infuriating. She looked at Glimmer and saw the same feeling of frustration reflected back at her. Maybe it wasn't a princess thing, just a Plumarian thing.

"No, you're not." Catra rolled out of the tree and landed on her feet, much closer to Perfuma than the tall woman had expected, she gasped and stepped back.

Something about the way that the cat-woman was looking at her, mismatched eyes cold and hard made the princess of Plumeria bristle. She stood taller, eyeing this girl with her violent red aura. What did she know about

"The Heart Blossom protects us." Her glare, so incongruous on the serene face, would send the citizens of her kingdom running to

not feel her ire. Not so this creature.

“You don’t know nature. You play at nature, you may even be able to call the plants to do your bidding, but you don’t understand them. The Whispering Woods doesn’t hide it fights back. It holds the Horde at bay to give you all time to get your shit together to fight back to yourself. How long before Hordak just tells them to burn it to the ground? Or pour acid into the soil? It’s a miracle that they haven’t yet.” The you woman walked towards the Heart Blossom and placed a splayed hand on it, feeling it throb. “How can you be so blind to its pain?”

Perfuma could only splutter at the accusation that she was starting to think may be true.

It turned out that Perfuma was badass when she let herself unleash the photosynthetic beast and so were her people. The outpost was decimated and they had one recruit to their cause. Adora was full of the buzzing energy of success, all too happy to agree to a sleepover with the equally delighted Glimmer and Bow.

Catra felt the wild sing in her blood and missed the trees.

Chapter End Notes

Next time we go to sea!

Salty

Chapter Summary

Lonnie has an epiphany at the Sea Gate.

Chapter Notes

I'm focusing more on our girls and what is happening for the other cadets than rehashing the canon events which we know happened, which I hope is working. that stuff's going on but just fleetingly focused on here.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The bar was grubby and smelt of old beer and sweat. The shiny Brightmoon residents looked aghast as they walked in, noses crinkling at the smell and the noise. Adora and Catra, not exactly used to this, were at least familiar with the sights and smells of unwashed bodies in an enclosed space. The two soldier's flanked their friends, eyes peeled for what they were looking for even as they scoped out the place for danger.

Bow was too busy being wide eyed as they walked through the grizzled and brightly dressed people in the bar. If he didn't stop smiling at everyone soon, he was going to get kidnapped and whisked away by some love starved sailor. Glimmer's expression wasn't much better, her wrinkled nose saying more than her words could, before all of this was over they would need to get these people a poker face or never get any plans finished. Even Adora was better at hiding her feelings and she was possibly the worst liar that Catra had ever seen.

Peeling off from the small group, Catra took herself to the bar. She knew that though she may not be the tallest of her team, she was certainly the most intimidating to look at with her battle harness, teeth and claws. She tapped one of those deadly spikes on the bar to draw the bartender's attention, as though he hadn't been watching them the second that they walked through the door.

The gruff, craggy faced man looked her way and tottered over on his peg leg. He propped a hip against the top of the bar and levelled a dead eyed stare at her, waiting expectantly. Two could play that game as she gave him her best bored expression, peripherally seeing that the others had stopped and were waiting for her next move.

"We need a ship to Selineas. Fast and discrete." Her voice sounded bored even to her own ears and she hoped that he would just give her what she wanted.

Catra wasn't expecting the small guffaw that left the bar-keep. He lifted the dirty rag in his hand and waved it to a dark booth where a lot of noise was coming from. "Sea Hawk's the only one who'll take you to that accursed place." He laughed mean spiritedly again and walked away.

It was not what Catra had been expecting. Wasn't Selineas the kingdom of one of these princesses? Mulling over the man's words, she rejoined the others, thankful that no-one had run off with Bow and pointed them towards the noisy booth.

As they got closer they could see a small group inside and the sounds of wagering before a loud groan came out and money was exchanged. A boisterous, melodic laugh drifted out of the shadows as a small group of sailors stumbled out, griping about their loses. Things were looking up if he was respected.

As they entered the small space, they saw a handsome man sporting a moustache splayed out with his booted feet on the table and his arms folded behind his head looking at them appraisingly. Adora moved into the area first, sitting opposite him with Bow and Glimmer at each shoulder while Catra kept watch of their backs, not trusting this place one bit. She growled menacingly when anyone passed to close, unsheathing her claws and making a point to pick at her sharp teeth. Nobody made the mistake of getting too close.

Sea Hawk, they found was obnoxiously happy and completely full of himself. It had taken little more than losing an arm wrestling contest with Adora to convince him to throw caution to the wind and take them to Selineas, a place he claimed to not be welcome at the moment. He was tight lipped about what the problems were in the sea kingdom, but about nothing else as he shouted and sang while escorting them to his small, sleek ship.

Princess Mermista was not what they had expected. She may seem just as apathetic as Perfuma had been, initially making Adora start to wonder how Hordak had not defeated all of them yet if this was how they operated. But, as they watched her sit on her throne, all scathing tone and acerbic words as she explained that the Sea Gate was failing and that she had evacuated the place but stayed behind it became clear that her apathy was an act, armour she pulled on to protect herself from the dire reality. That, as least, was something that Adora could respect. She was pretty sure that if she could repair the Sea Gate as she had the Heart Blossom then they had a pretty good chance of getting her to join them.

Catra saw through the fish princesses front straight away, her apathy was an obvious mask to hide her fear and guilt at failing her people and not knowing any other way to help them but to let them go. Catra could relate to that. If she were truly as uncaring as she seemed then she would have run, like a rat, but she had stayed to watch her world be torn apart by the forces that they had seen heading towards the place as they had rounded the beach to land on a small cove with the foolish pirate.

The two ex-Horde soldier's had left Glimmer and Bow behind at the Dragon's Daughter, both aware of the possible need to flee at any moment. Now, Catra sat high up on one of the rocks behind She-ra, watching as she pointed her sword towards the shield and focused all her energy on sending a light beam out, feeding the power of the gate. It was slow work and the big cat couldn't help but notice the Horde ships had taken up a position and dropped anchor. There were five ships in all, a flagship at their centre.

Even with her sharp eyes she could not make out much more than a little movement on the decks.

How you feeling, She-ra? it felt strange to call her that, in her mind, but when she looked at the big, glowing warrior woman, it was more true than calling her Adora.

I'm good. This just might take longer than I thought. Over the last few days they had practiced the telepathic speech back and forth and now the connection was strong enough for both of them could use it, though they hadn't tested the distance it could reach yet. **We really need a code name for you if I'm She-ra.** It was something to distract herself with and Catra would have smiled if she could have in this form.

I don't like the look of those ships. You focus on the Gate, I'll watch them. We can think of something for me later. As though hearing their conversation, a loud barrage of missiles suddenly flew towards the failing force field.

Lonnie cringed as Scorpia botched yet more orders to them. She knew enough to hold her tongue with Shadow Weaver watching them through one of her shadow minions, linked right back to the second in command, but inside was screaming at how this oaf could be a Force Captain. She had grown up around the most talented cadet in all the Horde, defector or not, and knew the qualities that a Force Captain was supposed to possess. This woman, with her massive bulk and pincers looked every inch the intimidating Horde soldier, but as soon as she opened her mouth the facade was shattered.

She was loud, bumbling and seemed to have no idea of how to run a plan or get anything done. She wanted to make sure her people were all feeling fine and doing the best they could, pouring praise and encouragement on them. Lonnie knew that wasn't how you got the most out of your fighters, she had been harangued and debated enough to see how to get results. Throw your people at the problem and if they get hurt you patch them up and send

them back out again. Shadow Weaver had drilled it into all of them alongside Adora. Their duty was to protect Etheria from the princesses and their chaotic magic, no matte the cost. They were responsible for all life in Etheria even if it cost their own. Looking at Scorpia she wasn't sure she had that killer instinct at all.

Standing on the rail of the gunboat, the cadet looked up at the Sea Gate. The broad stone arch was tall and strong, yet the forcefield within flickered and shimmered erratically and they hadn't even let loose the volley of missiles at it yet. This should be an easy win, they knew the city was all but abandoned - they were to take down the Sea Gate and then raise the entire city to the ground. It would hit the princesses right where it hurt, in the moral and if they could come back with the rhinestone then all the better.

Bringing the binoculars up to her face, she scanned the surrounding area, seeing no sign of hidden attackers or any ships at all. Tuning out the loud instructions coming from behind her, she moved her attention to look beyond the sea gate, a concentrated gleam of something catching her eye. She followed the trail of light back to its source from where it impacted the shield and was brought up short.

There, standing tall on a rock outcropping, was the giant warrior woman who had decimated the tanks at Thaymor and, from the accounts that had filtered back to the Fright Zone, taken out the mining operation that was poisoning Plumeria. She held her sword parallel to the ground and a shaft of energy was pouring out of it and into the gate itself. Everywhere the golden light touched the shield seemed to pulse and as she watched Lonnie could see it strengthening.

If they didn't attack now, they would not be attacking at all.

"Force Captain!" Her shout was short and sharp, bringing the white haired woman up short where she was fussing over Kyle.

“Hey, Lonnie, I told you to call me Scorpia.” She was beaming, obviously not hearing the urgency in her subordinates voice. Lonnie tried hard not to growl.

“The Sea Gate is being repaired, Force Captain, we need to launch our arsenal now!” That seemed to get her attention, dark eyes widened and her jaw suddenly firmed as she gave the order.

Perhaps she could get the job done when necessary after all, thought Lonnie as she joined Rogelio at the wheel, watching as the missiles collided with the force field, vaporising to dust but not before breaking the protective barrier just a little. Again and again the weapons blared, but before long the golden light that was infusing the barrier seemed to reach out, destroying all of their work. It couldn’t end like this! Lonnie and her team couldn’t be on another losing mission. They just couldn’t.

Bringing the binoculars back up she frantically searched for an opening, somewhere where a shot could get through. Her eyes travelled once again to the woman standing proudly on the rock, fixing their damage before they could make a dent. Her gaze drifted and she realised that though the golden energy was flowing outwards to the shield, there seemed to be an area close to her that seemed unprotected, as though her own safety were not a concern. That was there in.

Lonnie nudged Rogelio with her shoulder and held out the binoculars to him, pointing until his view followed her finger. He pulled the small device from his face and looked at her with his cool reptilian gaze, nodding as the two made their way to one of the turret guns. The projectile was smaller than those currently pummelling the gate, hopefully it could get through. They didn’t ask for permission as Rogelio moved the gun, face pressed to the targeting equipment as he found the opening again. Adora may have been the best, Catra the fastest, but Rogelio’s steady hands made him a crack shot.

One shot was all they would have. Once the breach was seen it would be all over. Rogelio brought he barely of the gun up and

aimed, calculating the trajectory needed to move through the tiny aperture and hit the woman standing with her sward. He gripped the trigger, let out a long hissing breath and pulled.

Lonnie winced at the sound of fire so close, but never took her eyes away from the woman who looked so small without the benefit of the spy glasses. Even so, it was easy to see the moment that she was thrown back, the golden glow that had been covering the gate gone and the other missiles beginning to break through without it.

A smile broke through the young woman's grim countenance. She had always been in the shadow of the other girls, one their mentor's favourite and the other her most reviled but now Lonnie could take the stage and show what she could do. She felt a nudge at her shoulder as Rogelio grinned down at her.

Catra leapt down from her perch the moment she saw something whizzing through the air towards where She-ra stood, all her focus on the sword and the power running through her. It was only thanks to her lightening reflexes that the blond narrowly avoided a bullet to the chest. Catra was pretty sure the girl, imbued with superhuman powers, could probably withstand it, but she couldn't take that risk. Her big jaws had wrapped around the cape hanging off of the tall woman and jerked her onto her ass with an 'oof' and a thud.

"What the hell, Catra!" The frown of confusion all over the glowing face was all Adora, and Catra couldn't stop herself from nuzzling against her face even as she was being pushed away.

You nearly got shot. I just saved you, so you're welcome. Her words might seem sarcastic but within their minds there was no mistaking the fear.

"I didn't even see…Thank you." She-ra pushed herself back to her feet, using Catra's head as some leverage, before grasping the

sword once more and bringing it back up.

I'll get Glimmer and deal with them. You get this thing fixed. A growl left the massive chest of the cat, menacing.

Giant paws pounded down the craggy rocks with ease, bringing her quickly down to join Glimmer and Bow where they stood aboard Sea Hawk's ship, waiting for instructions. The appearance of the big animal told them all they needed to know, casting off as she pounced easily onto deck and sat on the bow.

It was almost too easy to get the drop on the lead ship, all of their attention was firmly on the Sea Gate, clearly having decided that there were no reinforcements coming by sea. They were focused only on the obstacle and the woman shoring it up. Se Hawks little ship was silent and fast, easily with reach when Catra bunched her powerful legs and flew through the air onto the deck, followed by the shimmering sound of Glimmer appearing behind her.

As Glimmer ambushed helmeted figures and arrows rained onto deck from Bow's bow, Catra bounded towards the Force Captain and her support crew. The element of surprise may be gone, the element of fear was not.

If she was surprised to see her old squad, she didn't let it stop her from splaying her legs, lowering her massive head and letting out a terrifying roar that caused an answering scream from Kyle who cowered behind Rogelio. Rogelio, big as he was, was hard wired to fear predators like her. All those times as a child when she had thought about hunting him for food came rushing back and she roared again, stepping forward.

A pincer swiped at the side of her face, the impact hard and fast, causing her head to snap sideways and a growl to barrel out of her as she swiped back at the threat with razor claws. Her claws caught the carapace of the scopioni woman who she didn't recognise, skittering down the tough shell until they found perchance and tore three great scores into it. The Force Captain, her badge glinting and giving her away, let out a grunt of pain as

blood started to well in the wound. Then Lonnie was running towards her, stun baton in hand and the big cat danced away.

Lonnie continued to advance, Catra knew that she could take her, but waited to see what the other girl would do. They stalked around each other, even as the cat could hear the fight around them outpacing her new friends. Lonnie was watching her with that cool gaze that she had and the cat stared right back.

For a moment, Lonnie froze. Those eyes, those mismatched yellow and blue eyes were unmistakable, even set into a feral and terrifying visage. If this was Catra…

She lunched forward with the stun button, needing to get the information back to Shadow Weaver, vaguely aware of the other ships in their small fleet starting to pull away. Just as she was about to lunge at the beast, a huge tidal wave collided with the ship, tossing everyone on deck into the air and flipping the vessel.

Catra found herself scooped up in the wave, the grinning face of Mermista close to her own, as the princess set her down on the beach next to the others. Her sensitive nose picked up the smell of smoke, and as she shook the water out of her fur she saw the little ship burning to ashes as it took the wreckage of the Horde ship with it. Her sharp eyes were able to pick out the swimming forms of those who were fleeing.

They had won another battle and from the beaming expression on the previously taciturn girl's face, found another comrade in this fight.

Chapter End Notes

> Coming up corrupted She-ra, drunk Adora...drunk Catra? And ENHTRAPTA! coming up.

SCIENCE!

Chapter Summary

I wonder what infected Catra would be like?

Chapter Notes

I apologise in advance to Bow.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow couldn't help the dopey grin that covered his face as he watched the two girls snuggled together up the tree. Dawn was breaking and he and Glimmer were on watch. Even thinking about the princess made him turn to look at the pink haired girl who sat beside him, back against a rock. He wondered how the two of them looked to observers? From what he had been able to glean from the girls, they had been friends since they had been small children and now were clearly something a lot more. Could that happen for him and his childhood friend? Sometimes he thought so, he'd look at her and his heart would swell, but at others it was just like looking at one of his brothers. They were, perhaps too close.

Looking back at the girls cradled in the tree, he almost clapped his hands together when the faint sound of purring wafted to him though the breeze, he didn't because that would wake them with their hair trigger sense, but he wanted to. Catra was laid across the branches, looking like she had flowed up there and settled like water, Adora was cradled against her chest, weight dispersed between her partner and the wood. Their arms wound around each other and their faces were relaxed and serene as though they were a pair of woodland spirits that had been torn from a children's book.

Beside him, Glimmer moved to stand, taking a breath to call to the sleepers, but he reached out with a hand and forestalled her movement. She settled back beside him and looked at him

questioningly. They had a mission to accomplish, they were heading to Dryl to recruit the reclusive princess and the sooner they did, the stronger their new alliance would be. Glimmer wasn't good with patients.

"Let them sleep a little longer, Glim. They only just went down." It was true, the soldier's had offered to take the first watch and, after so many skirmishes fought at their side, they trusted them to do it. They both should have known that they would take most of the night. The two from Brightmoon had only been awake for a couple of, admittedly boring, hours.

"Fine!" Glimmer's voice was huffy but just as low as his, he noticed that though Catra's ears twitched in their direction she didn't not stir.

Bow stood up and beckoned for Glimmer to follow him until he thought that they were far enough away not to disturb the other two. He knew that Glimmer wouldn't be able to keep quiet much longer, she had a plan in mind and needed to work through it and process it and she did that best out loud. Usually he was her sounding board, though she was just as good at talking out loud to herself. He could give her a sounding board and give those young women an extra half an hour of sleep.

"We didn't tell them to take watch all night!" She grumbled as she toed at stones. She was right, they hadn't. They had expected to split the night equally between them, but by the time a rough hand was shaking her shoulder the darkness was already starting to lift.

"I know, but they're still trying to figure out where they fit into our world. Sometimes I think that they forget that they don't have to prove anything to us." He wrapped his arm around Glimmer's shoulders and pulled her close as they both looked towards the dark, lifeless silhouette of Dryl. "Everything is going to be fine, Entrapta will join up, trust me."

"I hope so. I know she doesn't have a rune-stone, but her tech skills could really give us an edge over the Horde."

The further up the mountain they traversed, the more the air tasted of ozone. It prickled along Adora's skin and made the hairs at the back of her neck stand on end. It was a sensation so akin to the taste and smell of the Fright Zone, that for a moment she had to take stock and remember that she was no longer under the control of the Horde. Looking over at Catra, so confidently strolling along in her new battle harness while chattering away with Bow, reassured her that this was their new reality and not their old one. She watched the young man and the cat girl talk, it was not a friendship that she would have expected. Bow was all bouncy energy kindness, while Catra was far more prickly and scathing and she would have expected them to cash, instead they were thick as thieves.

She tuned back into what the girl beside her was saying. Glimmer was very much like Catra in many ways, they both spoke their mind and lacked a filter. Adora found it comforting and was pretty sure that she and the shorter girl would end up firm friends.

"Sparkles, tell us about this princess again?" Catra's words were thrown back over her shoulder and Adora knew that she was also feeling the effects of being in a place reminiscent of the Fright Zone, especially after leaving the woods.

"Nobody's seen Entrapta in almost a decade, her parents died during the last of the big battles during the war where I lost my dad. She's been holed up alone in her castle for over a decade now, the only reason that we know that she's still alive is that there are supply runs for food there every few months."

"Where are all the people?" Adora assumed that they would move through a couple of villages, maybe a town, on their way to Dryl but once they had moved past the edge of the woods all there had been was rubble. Not the new, smouldering remains of

something left by recent attacks, but the mummified corpses of buildings left to rot after shelling years before. It was as though nobody had cared enough to rebuild their lives.

"After the war Entrapta locked herself away and the people felt abandoned so they abandoned Dryl. Nobody ever moved back." Glimmer's eyes were full of sorrow as she thought about that time. She had lost one parent, a toddler who barely remembered the father who was gone but Entrapta had lost both of hers as a teen and never been seen again. Glimmer couldn't even recall what the other woman looked like, even though she had been at Brightmoon through most of the war. All she recalled was purple hair and a girl who locked herself away even then.

A reverent quiet settled over the small group as they left the ruins behind and began the winding climb up to the castle. Lightning crackled around the place, drawn again and again to strike at the rod projecting from its top. The building was large and dark, sharp edges and darkened windows. It was the furthest thing from any of the other kingdoms that had seen and getting more peculiar by the moment.

By the time they were standing in front of the large doors, Catra felt antsy. The place was making her skin twitch. She left Adora standing in front of the doors with Glimmer and started to make her way around the side of the building, looking for a less imposing entrance. Bow followed her and she was warmed by the fact that he didn't want her to be alone. They were just rounding a curve when a scream rang out and then they were running back to the front of the building in time to see a gaping hole in the ground seal itself before they could get into it.

Sharing a wide eyed look, Catra and Bow turned back and raced around the building, looking for a better way in so that they could save their girls.

They had barricaded the kitchen door from the killer robots and now, Catra was looking for another way back into the heart of the castle. There was no way that she was letting Adora be out there alone. The fact that she was still in her mostly human shape meant that Adora was still herself which meant that she was still in danger. That and she didn't think she could deal with the smell of fear that was swelling in the small space. Bow could watch over them and she could head out.

Scenting the air, she smelt fresher air coming from a corner near the pantry. Once she had identified it, it was easy to follow and find a door, carefully blended into the wall itself. As she reached forward with her claws extended and tried to pry the door open, she heard the team of castle servants gasp, clearly unaware of these possible exit. Pulling with all her strength, she only managed to move the rock a couple of inches, her claws and muscles screaming with the effort. Pulling out, she shook her arms, getting the blood flowing again, ready to try again.

Bow watched as Catra shook out her arms, admiring her tenacity and how capable she was. It was often easy to see Adora as the heroic one of the two of them, she was sweeter and more obviously helpful but Catra was every bit as impressive. Trying to ignore the rhythmic pounding on the door as the robots attempted to batter it down with all of the efficiency of the machines that they were, he turned to the cook about to ask if they had ant weapons down here.

The words were stuck in his throat as a broken, pained roar suddenly filled the room. He swung around to where the sound had come from and watched as Catra staggered to her knees, body undulating beneath her fur. Her usually unusual eyes became alarming, turning glowing red as her teeth and limbs elongated with painful tearing sounds. Bow had witnessed her transformation into the entity that he had been calling Battle-Cat in his mind, and this was not that. Usually her body would seem to ripple, like a wave crashing over her flesh and leaving behind the other shape. This was no wave.

This was an eruption. Catra's body surged out and up, flesh audibly tearing as her clothes strained on her skin. Soon she looked nothing like he had ever seen, and the panicked screams of the three people behind him told him that they had never seen anything like it either. Catra's face was massive and distorted by teeth that dripped blood from where they had broken her jaw as the mouth hung open and scented the air threateningly. Her arms and legs were too long while her torso remained much the same, and fur had spread thicker over her body. It was like she was caught between her two shapes, and being ripped apart.

The thing roared again, sounding pained and confused, noticing them for what seemed like the first time and crouching down to take to all fours. It stalked them, and no amount of calling her name was going to stop it. Bow positioned himself in front of the civilians and tried to draw his bow. His reflexes were nothing compared to the beast. It was on him in less than a second, misshapen jaws clenched around his forearm until the bone cracked and blood was oozing down his elbow onto his white tank top.

His breaths came out as gasps, but he dared not fight back or make a sound. It was like any wild animal, no need to provoke it when it already had its teeth sunk into you. Bow started to feel woozy, pain and bloodless combining in the perfect recipes for shock when suddenly his arm was free.

The Catra beast was looking towards the wall, ears peeked as though called, and then it was running. Moving with speed towards where the hidden door was and then through it, leaving a cloud of dust and debris in its way as it broke the stone door. They were exposed now, completely open and vulnerable to any robot that found them, but the relief in the kitchen was palpable as the imminent threat disappeared around a distant, dark corner.

Then Bow felt himself being lifted in the big arms of the tall cook and laid on the kitchen table. Three worried faces appeared above him as each of them took charge of some part of his care. One

minute his sleeve was being cut off, them a cloth was wiping at the torn skin. Then there was darkness.

It was like herding cats! Glimmer was terrified and exasperated in equal measure as she towed the blond woman behind her, trying to keep her feet under her as the taller girl swayed and staggered while giggling inanely at nothing. If that wasn't challenge enough, she was hurrying to try and keep Entrapta in sight as she dashed ahead of them using her hair as a conveyance.

At least they seemed to have shaken the robots for now. The last thing she wanted was to get lost in this maze without their guide. Pulling Adora harder, almost making them both fall, she managed to catch up with the scientist as she stopped dead at the end of a hallway, looking down at something with her head cocked and her recorder held close to her face as she talked into it.

"Subject appears to be in their late teens. The covering of fur all over their body, along with a possibly prehensile tail and large ears would seem to indicate that they are some sort of feline hybrid, though I have never seen or read about anything like this.

The fur is a reddish shade of brown, perhaps chestnut, with a series of stripes on upper arms, thighs and possibly bak though I would ned closer examination. There is no clear sign of secondary sexual characteristics, and without being able to assess genitalia gender cannot be ascertained at the moment…"

"Hey!" Glimmer hissed loud enough to stop the woman recording. She was certainly talking about Catra, and the fact that the cat-girl hadn't stopped her told Glimmer that she was probably unconscious.

"Oh, hello again. I appear to have discovered a new form of life." The way the woman said 'life' was high pitched and excitable and would undoubtedly draw attention. She moved a little and Glimmer was able to see Catra, missing her top and her shorts

were dirtied and torn up hanging around her thighs. She was seated against the floor, head slumped to one side and there was a sticky dark mass matting he fur on her chest.

It was about then that Adora noticed her too.

“Kitty!” Clumsy feet were propelling her with speed towards the crumpled girl until she tripped and fell into the furry lap where she lay grinning goofily up at the now stirring cat.

“S’appenin?” Catra’s voice was slurred and confused, her mismatched eyes blinked open and looked just as glassy as Adora’s. Glimmer slapped her own forehead as she realised whatever was wrong with Adora was infecting Catra too.

“Catra, you don’t have any clothes on!” Adora’s whispered words were so loud and so slurred that they were almost unintelligible.

“Hmm?” Catra looked dazedly down at her torso and started to laugh maniacally. “Who took my top?” She pointed a claws finger at Adora’s forehead and poked her between the eyes. “Did you take it?”

“No!” Adora was snorting and laughing as she went cross eyed looking at the digit. There was such an easy familiarity to the way they looked at each other that it was almost possible to forget they were being hunted by killer robots.

Almost.

“Get up you two!” Glimmer put all the command that she had every heard her mother use into her voice and saw both girls look towards her.

Then they were scrabbling to their feet, using each other as props to stand up as straight as they could and pull a twin pair of sloppy salutes. Her mom voice had obviously triggered their response to authority trained in by the Horde and for once Glimmer was thankful to the invaders as it at least might make them easier to handle.

If managing Adora and Entrapta was tough, adding Catra to the mix was almost impossible. She was climbing anything she could find, dangling here and there and scraping pictures deep into the metal walls. Every picture seemed to be a caricature of Adora, that she would pull the blond over to look at and receive a sloppy kiss in return. It was sweet, in a nauseating way, but not getting them anywhere.

Before Glimmer could blow, a half dozen assorted robots whirred around the corner, eyes red and murder on their mechanical minds. Adora pointed and laughed, tripping again and flopping onto a box, while Glimmer started to fire glitter bombs at the closest threat.

Catra pounced straight over her head, laughing like she was at a funfair and tore the head of the first robot clean off. Then she was bounding around them, swiping playfully with her claws and slicing off limbs and wheels until there was just a lot of sparking wreckage. Adora was clapping in the corner like the worlds happiest cheerleader. Catra's ears twitched and she flicked at them irritably, which could only mean more danger was coming.

"Entrapta, if you have any idea how to stop all this now is the time." Entrapta's whole demeanour shifted as she smiled, this was a problem to solve and with the cat-girl, maybe they could get back into her lab.

"This way!"

Bow looked down at his bandaged arm. A broken bone reset and a lot of stitches and he was good as new, or he would be. The mission to Dryl had been a success, Entrapta was working with them and now all they needed to do was get Frosta on board and they would be ready to take the fight to the enemy. When they had made it back to Brightmoon, a journey made faster by Entrapta pulling a prototype vehicle out of storage. It was rusty and dusty but had mangled to get them home before it gave up

the ghost and broke down for good, he had been whisked away to the infirmary and given the best care.

Glimmer and Adora had visited him a lot, each of them fussing over him in their way. Even Perfuma had come to see him while she was there to talk with the Alliance. He liked the flower princess, she was easy to be around and lacked the more frenetic energy of his other friends. It was why he enjoyed Catra too.

Catra and Glimmer might have a lot of similarities to the casual observer, but there was a studied stillness in the cat. She watched and thought and planned. Her sharp edges had been ground out to protect herself and not because she was frustrated with her parent. She was calm on the inside when there needed to be calm and her absence from his room had said more than any words could.

He knew that Glimmer had shouted at her once they found Bow and all of the affects of the First Ones technology had left the two girls. He had been vaguely aware of it. He was pretty sure she had been cruel in her state of fear. He was equally sure that the other girl would have believed every word.

It was how he found himself in the gardens, arm in a sling and steps slow as he did more exercise than he had in several days. He was pretty sure where he would find her as he headed to the tallest tree on the edge of the garden with the best view of the Whispering woods. A tail hung down, moving slowly and he reached up with his good arm to pull at it.

“There room up there for me?”

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for delay this week - had a terrible head cold and things should get back to normal this week.

Not all witches

Chapter Summary

A brief interlude in Mysticore.

Chapter Notes

Not my favourite episode but I wanted to get Catra's take on it a little.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Steam poured through the grotto and Catra squirmed. Her fur felt limp and lank, the damp penetrating down to her skin and making it crawl. Even only being draped in a loincloth wasn't enough to dispel the discomfort. But still she stayed splayed out beside the pool, staring up at the stalactites that cast strange shadows around the roof, one hand resting on her stomach while the other reached out and toyed with the ponytail of the girl in the water.

Adora shot her a grateful smile as she talked tiredly to Glimmer, that was enough to make her want to stay. The Brightmoon pair had been convinced that coming to Mysticore would settle the frayed nerves of the human girl. Catra had hoped that they were right but since they arrived at the kingdom in the clouds Adora had become more and more agitated and withdrawn. Catra had even attempted to enter the water with the others to try to cheer up the other girl, but the water was too hot and she could only stand it for a few minutes. She wasn't sure how the others could stand it. It had made Adora laugh when she yelped and flew out of the water, and for that she'd boil herself if necessary.

She wasn't entirely sure what was going on with the other girl, she'd been strangely tight lipped and skittish since the woods. Usually being in the woods was like going home for both girls, Adora loved it as much as she did, or so she had thought. They had been in a makeshift camp, no-one standing guard as they were well inside the protection of the trees, but Adora had been

agitated as night began to fall. Catra had noticed her staring out into the trees and shaking her head.

"Hey," she'd reached out a hand and touched the girl's waist only to feel her flinch from her. It had been unnerving but she had been able to convince her to lay down with her.

Usually the pair of them would sleep in the trees but when she had suggested it Adora had looked up into the dark canopy with fear in her eyes and insisted that it would be better to sleep closer to Glimmer and Bow. She hadn't argued, just wrapped herself around the walled girls back and held her close, hoping that her familiar presence would help sooth whatever was troubling her girlfriend.

Adora had slept fitfully, fighting more than usual and had pulled out of Catra's arms and huddled into a ball. It had been early when she had startled herself awake and caused the chain reaction of concern that had led them to Mysticore. They had all hoped that a chance to relax in a safe environment would help knit together her frayed nerves.

So far it wasn't working.

Adora had been agitated on the cloud beech, though so had Catra. It had been completely purposeless and boring. Then there had been the less than successful tour of the mage's palace. It had started well enough, the magical elements and importance of the writings and crystals had genuinely interested both of the new girls. What they were both learning, through bumps in the road, was that magic could be good. That not all sorcerers were monsters using their abilities to control others. Catra should have known that the tranquility couldn't last.

As they had been led through the hallway that was lined with statues, Glimmer's aunt (neither Catra or Adora really understood the need to give everyone connected to you a special title) had pointed out some of the most prominent former member's of Mysticore. When they had come to a stop in front of the statue of

a squat, broad shouldered man there had been something about him that the feline had recognised. Castaspella's voice was an odd mix of mellow and excitable as she told them that this was Micah, Glimmer's father and how much Glimmer looked like him. Catra had laughed when her friend was horrified, exclaiming that she didn't have a beard. She noticed that Adora only managed a forced looking smile, and that was when she saw what she was looking at.

In a darker part of the hall, lost in shadows, was another statue. This was an elfin woman with a cloth mask hiding the lower half of her face and long flowing robes. Light Spinner, Castaspella had said. Shadow Weaver was what they heard. They would know that silhouette anywhere, it was friend into the back of their eyes. Adora had become even more tense which had been what led them to the grotto in the first place. At least the blond seemed to be relaxing a little.

Catra wished that she could be the one to rest against the human in the water as she saw Glimmer begin to cuddle up to her, Bow having wandered off to get them refreshments. She had tried but that level of discomfort would have just made her snippy. But, much like her counterpart, she couldn't just lay there doing nothing all day, especially not when something was crawling at the back of her mind. She leaned over the water, pressing a gentle kiss to Adora's cheek before jumping to her feet and heading away from the heated pools, heedless of her near naked state.

Sitting with her legs dangling over the edge sheer drop down from the floating isle, she shivered a little as a light breeze drifted up from below, ruffling her still damp fur. The faint chill was a respite from the cloying warmth that permeated the place. It was too much for her, really, all of these serene people living in a bubble and hiding from the danger posed by the war being waged below. It grated on her. She had been alone for so long in the wild, only getting glimpses of another life through Adora, and here were

people who were deliberately isolating themselves in the lavish luxury of a gilded cage.

She blew out a sigh into the wind, wondering if her natural ability to land on her feet would work if she allowed herself to drop down from here. It was an old thought, climbing up to the highest place her childish claws could carry her and looking down. Feeling the seductive pull of vertigo and destruction, she edged closer, hands clasping the edge. Feeling almost weightless, her ears caught that sound of footsteps approaching, her spine going rigid as she pushed herself back on the edge.

She could tell from the tread that it was Bow, his sense of self oozing out of his feet as much as every other part of him. Her natural instinct to tense, waiting to strike or be struck was easy to quell in his presence, so she relaxed and waited for him to join her at the edge. She was unsurprised when he sat a little ways back, crossing his legs and reaching out to rest a careful hand on her shoulder until she inched back to join him.

"Everything all right?" Bow had thrown his crop top back on but was still wearing the shorts that they had been given.

In the grotto she had been the only one of them to be topless and wondered why the boy was wearing the criss-cross top like the girls, but hadn't asked him. It wasn't her business. When she had wandered away, following the strange crawling feeling that had moved up her spine, she hadn't thought to grab any clothes. She was still most comfortable bare, though now, as she sat with her friend, she realised that she may have scandalised some of the locals. As though he could read her mind, Bow held out the shirt that he had brought for her and she gratefully puled it over her head.

"I'm fine, you know. You could have stayed with Adora and Glimmer." It was true, she wasn't a fan of this place but she was fine. It was Adora he should be worrying about.

“They’re dozing in the pool, some other bathers came so I was sure they wouldn’t drown. I just thought we could hang out.” He shrugged and gave her a goofy smile that she couldn’t help but return. “You were real close to the edge there.”

Bow was looking at where she had been and she craned her head to look back there too. She supposed it did look frightening to a human. To her it was just the temptation of the unknown. “I wasn’t going to do anything, Arrow-boy. Just hanging out. I like the hight.” He seemed reassured by that and visibly relaxed.

“Sorry, it’s just with Adora being so jumpy I was worried that you might be feeling it too.” She enjoyed Bow’s voice, it always had a caring lightness to it.

“No, as long as I feel free you don’t have to worry about me.” She won’t sure that was entirely true but his shoulders relaxed and she knew that she had said the right thing.

They talked for a while as the clouds moved around them. This was peaceful, though she missed the blond girl like she was missing a part of herself. Her feelings must have been clear on her face, as Bow got to his feet and held down a hand for her to grasp. He knew that she could just as easily uncoil, but she appreciated his care. They started to walk back to where they had left their other friends. They would need to get ready for the eclipse ritual that Glimmer’s aunt had been so excited to tell them about.

Adora and Glimmer had moved from the warm water of the pool, the place empty now. The two wanderers split up, heading to the rooms that they had been given. Glimmer and Bow were sharing a room in Cataspella’s private rooms, because they were family, while she and Adora had been given a room down the hall from the sculptures. As Catra passed the statue of her old tormenter, movement caught her eyes and she turned to see a dark figure disappear behind the statue. It was black, darker than the rest of the shadows that surrounded the statue and Catra felt her heckles rise, unsheathing her claws and stalking forward.

She hadn’t moved far when the darkness flew at her, causing her to lose her footing and slam into the floor, her head hitting on the corner of the plinth the statue sat on. As he vision started to fade, an all too familiar bark of cruel laughter filled her ears.

Catra woke in a daze, head throbbing as she lurched up from where her face had been pressed against the cool marble floor. Her thoughts were a jumble. One minute she had been heading to see Adora and the next she was here. Still sitting on the floor, the coolness seeping into her, grounding her, she rubbed her face vigorously with her hands and tried piece together what was happening.

Pulling her hands away she finally looked around her, seeing a familiar figure looming over her and scrambled back, hissing in fear before remembering it was just a statue. That was when the threatening shadow and dark laugh filled her memories and she was on her feet and lurching sluggishly to the room where the ritual was meant to be taking place. Her innate sense of time told her it was late, that the eclipse should be happening soon.

She burst through the doors of the ceremony room just in time to see Adora vanquish a black effigy of Shadow Weaver withe the energy that refracted off of her sword and bounced around the room. On the floor she spotted the unconscious bodies of Bow and Glimmer, rushing to their side and trying to wake them. The darkness around them dissipated and they were joined by Adora who slumped against her still naked back, enjoying the feel of fur against her cheek, grounding her after a confusing few minutes.

Hours later they were tucked in bed, Adora cradled against her chest and running her fingers through the thicker fur in the middle there. Catra had her arms wrapped around her, holding her lie something precious and fragile. They still weren’t certain what Shadow Weaver thought she would achieve today; a wedge between the group, luring Adora home with kind words or just chaos. Whichever it was, she had lost and Adora had managed to vanquish her all by herself.

Catra pressed a kiss to the crown of the blond head, and blue eyes turned up to look at her. The tension that had been etched into her face gone. There were still dark circles there, the recent sleeplessness not so easily erased but that was easily remedied.

"You're amazing." It was mushier than they usually got with each other, but she wanted to chase away any of the doubt that Shadow Weaver had planted that might still be spinning around inside that head.

"You're not so bad yourself." A yawn split her words and Catra moved one hand to start gently stroking the small of the other girl's back. Her head went bak to its place on her chest and Catra felt her starting to go limp.

"Go to sleep Adora, I'll still be here in the morning." That seemed to be all the permission she needed as her breath began to slow and her leg wrapped around Catra, trapping her in place. They still needed to talk about what had happened, why Adora hadn't shared her fears, but that could wait till morning.

Chapter End Notes

...Shall we dance?

Shall We Dance?

Chapter Summary

So, Prom?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was only the hand at the small of her back that kept Adora from turning tail and running back to the coat-check area to demand her sword. She felt naked without it, or that's what she told herself. The dress billowing around her bare legs and the dainty shoes might have had something to do with her sudden feeling of vulnerability. When Glimmer had explained what the All Princess Ball entailed, Adora had felt a ball of dread settle in her stomach. Catra had looked at the long invitation with all its rules and instructions, rolled her eyes and wandered off to terrorise the gardeners, while she had been unable to take her eyes off of it. She had plotted and planned for the better part of a day until the others had barrelled into the room and tried to shake her out of her hyper fixation.

Instead of an obstacle course, Glimmer had hustled her and Catra to the tailor who had poked and prodded them into multiple outfits until the cat-girl was growling and Adora feared that she might snap at the hand holding the tape measure. Eventually they had been left together in a room with several choices. Glimmer had winked at them as she walked out of the spacious changing room and pulled the door closed behind her. Catra had been annoyed to the point where her claws were flexing in and out and Adora was worried that she would shred the delicate fabric.

Without thought she had moved forward to the shorter girl and reached out for her dangerous hands, cupping them gently and feeling the tension melt out of the wild girl, claws disappearing. Catra let her head fall forward to rest against the conveniently

close shoulder and they just stood there, breathing with each other for a while. Sometimes, all of the joyful life of Brightmoon was a little too much to take and they just needed a little quiet.

“I am not wearing a dress, no matter what Sparkles says.” Catra’s voice grumbled into the thin fabric of Adora’s sports bra. Her habit of mangling Glimmer’s name making the blond laugh softly.

“You don’t have to wear anything that you don’t want to.” She pulled back and lifted Catra’s chin so that they were looking at each other. She couldn’t imagine what it much be like for the younger girl, after a lifetime of running around the woods naked to have to wear clothes. It surely felt restrictive to the incredibly physical creature. Catra had been forced to do a lot of things that she hadn’t had a choice about in the last few years and Adora was pretty sure that this was supposed to be fun.

“You know that goes both ways, right?” Catra leaned her forehead against Adora’s as she spoke.

“Fine, how about I pick something and you pick something and we change and show each other?” Catra was already collecting her last few options in her arms as the human spoke and walking to the far corner.

“No peeking Princess.”

With their backs to each other, they both began to sort through the outfits that Glimmer had deemed most appropriate. Adora felt her palms sweat, the pressure she had always felt to be perfect making her uncertain and she touched silk and lace and found each alien to the touch. There were a couple of suits, a skirt and top and several dresses. She bit her lip ad worried at her fingers as she tried to decide which one she could stand for an evening. She tried not to spiral as she thought about what a party was and what would be expected from her there. She wished that she could just wear her normal clothes but knew that wouldn’t be acceptable.

Then, as her fingers brushed passed another dress, she stopped. The red material was similar to her jacket and it felt mush less slippery than some of those of the others while still light. She picked it up and pulled it on over her underwear, raising that she would need some help to close it up. She looked in the mirror and didn't recognise the person looking back. Her arms and shoulders were bare and her hair had fallen down around her making her look soft and vulnerable. She was about to pull it off, not comfortable seeing the girl looking back at her from the glass when a hand slid up her back and pulled up the zipper. Her eyes moved away from her own reflection to meet Catra's over her shoulder in the looking glass.

"You okay there, Adora?" Catra had her hands resting lightly on Adora's hips as she spoke softly into her hair.

"I don't know." It was true, the dress felt comfortable, freeing in some ways and she was sure that she looked pretty but she felt like a stranger to herself.

As though reading her mind, Catra disengaged from her, ducking down and then returning to run her fingers through blond tresses. Quickly and efficiently she wound Adora's hair back into its familiar ponytail, tying it up with a discarded hairband before resting her head back against her bare shoulder, pressing a quick kiss there. The girl in the mirror smiled back, this was her. Softer, gentler but finally Adora could breath as she saw herself draped in a flattering red dress.

"That better?" Catra was pressed so close to her back, arms winding around her waist, that she could feel every breath.

"Yeah, I think this one." Because she didn't want to try any others and red was her colour.

Catra chuckled and then pulled away, grasping one of Adora's hands and spinning her around to face the feline. The skirt of the dress swished around her legs and tickled, making a small giggle

bubble out of her which died on her lips when she focused her eyes on Catra.

Catra was dressed in a maroon tuxedo jacket, the trim a lighter shade of pink, with darker pants that she had already artfully slashed across the thighs to give her the always dangerous look she was so good at. Her hands and feet were tucked into leather gloves that left most of her fingers and all of her toes bare but looked sexily menacing. None of that was what caught her attention though, all of her attention was focused on the tie that was loosely tied, hanging low around her neck as though it was half pulled off and resting on her bare chest where it was revealed by her open suit jacket. Under the blond's scrutiny, Catra put her hands in her pockets, cocking a hip and making the muscles in her stomach stand out under her sleek fur. Adora's mouth felt dry as she struggled to pull her eyes away.

"What do you think?" Not that she really needed to ask, she could see the affect her outfit was having on the human girl.

Adora surged forward, reaching out to grab the loose tie and pulling Catra towards her until there bodies collided and kissing her so deeply that Catra lost her breath at the passion being poured into her. She let Adora control the kiss, resting her hands lightly on the thin fabric across her hips, enjoying the feel of the other girl through the material of the skirt. They stayed like that for a long time, Adora's hands slipping from the tie to curve around her ribs and disappear under the jacket to meet on her spine, toying with the thicker fur that trailed down towards her tail. As blunt nails began to scratch at her, Catra let out a low growl and pulled away, causing Adora to whimper adorably and almost making Catra pull her closer again.

"I think Glimmer would get real mad if we ruin these clothes making out." She smiled and pecked a quick kiss onto pouting lips.

"Fine." Adora moved forward to start slipping the jacket from her shoulder's which made Catra quirk a brow. "You look amazing, but where we're going is cold and I'm not going to be able to keep my

hands off you if you're not wearing a shirt." She reached around the smaller girl, careful not to move to far from her, and picked up a shirt in a shade of red more like her own dress and slipped it onto Catra, buttoning slowly and making the cat-girl's fingers itch to touch her but they hadn't gone beyond kissing yet in their own room and she didn't want their first time to be in the tailor's dressing room where anyone could interrupt them.

Shirt buttoned only part way, Catra pulled on the jacket again while Adora reached for something else and draped it around her neck. It was a smaller tie, undone, in a darker colour. The previous tie seemed to have disappeared, Catra flicked around, unable to see where it had gone, bit was distracted again when Adora took the two ends of the tie and pulled her in for another searing kiss.

Pounding on the door and Glimmer's shrill voice broke them apart. Giggling, they started to take off the outfits, each carefully folding them before slipping on their normal wear. While Catra wasn't looking, Adora tucked the long tie into the pocket of her red jacket.

That had been several days ago, but as she walked away from her sword, eyes longingly going to the weapon check area, she wondered if she shouldn't have just come as She-ra. A kiss was pressed to her bare shoulder, startling her until she turned to look at the glowing eyes of her girlfriend. Her hand was grasped from the other side as Glimmer joined them, returning from talking to someone she knew at the door, and the three of them made their way into the ballroom.

Frosta was a little ball of 'fuck you' and Catra loved her!

They had made their way up to the dais where she was dwarfed by her throne, Glimmer had instructed them on how to bow, certain that they would not curtsy, and they had all made the motion. Catra moved in her usual languid way, bowing quickly and

then standing, uncomfortable with having her gaze to the floor. She could hear Adora counting out the perfect bow length under her breath before straightening. It was very endearing. That was when things had gone sideways. Adora had looked at the child on the throne and very loudly commented on her age. Honestly, it was Catra's fault, Adora had wanted to study everything about the ball and instead Catra had teased and seduced her until they were dancing and kissing rather than studying. She'd do it again, but the flush that she saw colour her cheeks as Frosta roundly dismissed them made her feel a little guilty.

Before Adora could open her mouth and say something else to offend the young girl, Catra grasped her hand and pulled her to follow Glimmer back down to the main area of the ballroom. Before Adora could start to fall into a pit of self recrimination, they bumped into the other princesses. Everybody looked good, though not as good as Adora though she held back from telling the other girl that, knowing that she would be embarrassed here, she'd tell her tonight.

Satisfied that Adora was surrounded by people who would keep her distracted, Catra made her way back to the throne. There may be rules and roles to play at this shindig, but Catra was something wild, and had sauntered up to the throne, cocking her hip against the lavishly carved arm and settled next to the little girl. She had looked down at her and started to talk to her, swishing her tail languidly as she spoke. Frosta's jaw had set and her eyes had squinted into an angry pout even though she couldn't stop the twitch in her fingers that told Catra that she really wanted to pet her tail.

"Seems kinda boring to stay up here on your own. Why don't you come and hang out with us?" Catra let a little purr come out with her words, knowing how cute the humans seemed to find it. It just made the child's face scrunch up more.

"You need to get down right now. I need to stay here to greet my guests and you need to go away! I shouldn't expect someone like you to understand how to behave." She folded her arms over her

narrow chest, scowling, and Catra wasn't sure if she was referring to her as an animal or Horde but either way the kid had a temper.

"Well, if you want to hang out, we're down there." Catra kept her voice playful as she pointed to the group on the floor who had now been joined by Bow and Perfuma, looking prettily floral. She stood and sauntered away able to hear Frosta cussing her out under her breath and smirked. She'd come and hang out. For sure.

Scorpia stood at the top of the winding staircase, her name falling from the herald's lips. Rogelio stood at her side, the pair of them making a striking pair as the startled eyes of the people below looked up to see their arrival. The black dress that wrapped around her, clasped with jewel like bombs at the waist, in plain sight, made her feel powerful. Lonnie had said she looked sexy and that had given her a boost of confidence and made her blush all the way to the tops of her ears. She wished that Lonnie was with her, but it was far easier to hide Lonnie and Kyle than Rogelio who stood out as much as she did.

Resting a large claw on Rogelio's outstretched arm, she allowed herself to be led down the staircase, carefully taking in the faces of the people watching them. The sour expressions on the faces of the gathered princesses were easy to see where they clustered together and she let it wash over her until she spotted a face that looked more sad than angry. Catra looked up at her with her big mismatched eyes and for a moment Scorpia lost her step and only didn't trip thanks to her arm resting on Rogelio's. Nobody seemed to notice but the lizard-kin grunted a question.

"Everything is fine, just not used to these shoes." She couldn't admit that she felt guilty when she saw the younger girl, looking healthy and well cared for, standing down there. She had known what was happening to her in the Fright Zone was wrong, she was sweet not stupid, but she had let herself be convinced that it was better for her than living in the woods. Shadow Weaver was

very persuasive. It was easy to see now why she had run away from the home they had all shared together.

The imposing pair walked across the full length the ballroom, the crowds parting before them almost comically, as though to touch them would be to be tainted. All of the words that she had heard growing up about how the other princesses loathed her and her family for being different sprang into her head, swirling around and she saw not even one kind face. It was fine, she had managed her whole life without these people. She had people who cared about her in the Horde.

They moved up to stand in front of the young queen and made to Bow when then the pounding of feet followed them up to the dais. Both she and Rogelio had to stop themselves from falling Ito a fighting stance. It was imperative that they stick to the rules and look innocent, there was nothing to be won from being kicked out.

Turning, she saw that it was the Brightmoon Princess and Adora who had run up and were now falling all over themselves to say why she didn't belong. She shouldn't have been surprised but a little part of her was. She had done nothing except follow the rules so far. She looked behind Adora, assuming that Catra would be there, but the feline was nowhere to be seen.

"Enough!" Frosta's voice was loud and authoritative and Scorpia wondered how someone so small could sound that in command. Maybe she could ask for some tips later. "Princess Scorpia was invited and so long as she abides by the rules of the ball then she and her companion are welcome to stay. You have no right to say who attends this event." She waved a hand and guards moved to briskly move the members of the Alliance back to the dance floor, Adora's face looking anguished at her failure.

Scorpia turned her attention back to the young woman whose dark eyes were looking at her so intently that she had to fight the urge to squirm. Next to her, Rogelio was not as successful and started to fidget with the hem of his tuxedo jacket. "Follow the

rules and you are as welcome as any other guest. Enjoy the party." It was clear that they had been dismissed and they walked back down to the main area.

Adora was at their side almost immediately, matching their pace as she cast grim glances at them. "I know you're up to something. We'll be watching you!" She made a two fingered gesture between her own eyes and them and then peeled away to join the small group of girls by the wall. Catra was still noticeably absent and that bothered Scorpia, though she couldn't place why.

Continuing to walk towards the buffet table, she mumbled lowly to Rogelio, who peeled away from her and made his way closer to the band that was playing in the corner. They would need to divide the princesses to keep them distracted for their plans to go ahead. Scorpia stood in front of the spread of delightful looking food, reaching out a claw and making happy little sounds as she sampled new things.

"Excuse me? Garson?" As she raised her hand for some attention she didn't notice the mismatched eyes that had been watching her the whole time from the shadows.

Catra smelt the explosives as soon as they entered the room. She looked up from her place beside the dance floor where she had been trying to coax Adora to dance with her, up to the two people that had just walked into the room. She heard Scorpia's name called out, ringing around the suddenly too quiet place. The metallic, acrid smell of explosives wafting around the woman, though from where she could not tell. As they moved down the stairs, she caught dark eyes and wondered as the bigger woman stumbled almost imperceptibly. The more she moved, the more the feline caught the smell of danger.

She let her eyes roam over the woman in the black dress, already assessing Rogelio and finding nothing but his natural musk emanating from him. Her dress was sleek and sheer, no room for

pockets as it hugged every curve of her body and left one shoulder exposed. She was wearing red stones in her ears and around her waist but there was nowhere hide anything. Maybe she was just being paranoid and the scopioni had been working in the weapons bay earlier. She wasn't willing to let her out of her sight though.

As Glimmer and Adora ran off to no doubt cause an international incident, Catra held back. She scanned the room for any other sign of trouble, catching two guards, shorter than the others, slipping out of a door on the balcony. There were other guards around though so she turned her attention back to the throne where Adora and Glimmer were being forcibly removed. She rolled her eyes, but felt warm affection for both the other young women. She knew them well enough to know that this would happen.

Scorpia and Rogelio separated as soon as they walked down the dais, Catra stuck with the tall woman. She saw that Adora was also making a more obvious show of watching the big woman and smiled softly. Adora was many things, but surreptitious was not one of them. Scorpia was delicately sampling the food at the buffet, calling out for help to find out what each thing was. It looked like she would be there for a while. Adora had just picked up a plate when a gasp went round the room. The blond head whipped around to see Entrapta toppling over the edge of a balcony. Catra tensed, watching as Adora dashed to try and save the scientist only to see her amazing hair catch her and watch as she ambled away as though she hadn't just broken her neck.

Pulling her attention away from the distraction, Catra gasped when she realised that Scorpia was gone. She moved out of the shadows and picked up that metallic smell again, following it up and out of the door, entering a long hallway with Scorpia sauntering down it. Catra moved on silent feet, ducking behind a pillar and seeing Scorpia pull one of the red jewels from her belt and attach it to a column where it started to glow menacingly. The origin of the smell became clear.

“Scorpia, you don’t have to do this!” Catra stepped out from her hiding place as Scorpia got further away. The bigger woman flinched, but didn’t hesitate to place another bomb before she turned.

“Hi Catra. Looks like you’re having a good time with the princesses.” Her voice had it’s usually cheerful tone, but she kept moving, making Catra move with her further down the hallway where she could now spot two guards waiting.

“Scorpia, don’t do this. You could leave the Horde, you’re not like the rest of them. You’re kind, you could be a real asset to the Alliance. They accepted me, I’m sure they would accept you.” They were both unique creatures, it only made sense.

“Maybe I don’t want to just be an asset.” There was a steeliness to her voice that Catra hadn’t heard before from the woman who had shown her kindness. They were almost on top of the guards now, and as much as she was loath to do it, Catra knew she had to get Scorpia arrested.

“She’s planted bombs down there. You need to arrest her.” There was no reaction from the guards, who now she thought of it, must have known what Scorpia was doing, the corridor was long but straight.

A chill went down her spine. Realising that she had made a fatal mistake, she took a step back, only to collide with a soldi body, big arms wrapping around hers to pin them to her sides. Rogelio squeezed her tightly and she watched helplessly as the two guards lowered their hoods to reveal Lonnie and Kyle. Lonnie smirking grimly at her.

“Did you get it?” Scorpia looked over her head at Rogelio.

The big man grunted and Scorpia moved around him, the metallic slide of a blade being pulled from a belt told her all she needed to know, and then Scorpia was back in front of her with the sword resting casually over her shoulder. She smiled a little sadly at the

younger girl and whipped out her tail, striking Catra in the chest and leaving her to collapse in Rogelio's waiting arms. He scooped her up and the four of them made their escape.

The call for the first dance range out around the ballroom and Adora looked around for Catra. She knew that she was watching Scorpia but it seemed like both women were missing. Glimmer and Perfuma took to the dance floor, but Adora was intent on finding her partner. She wasn't worried, she knew that she could handle herself, but she had really hoped for a dance.

The music moved and swelled, the lights swirling as she searched high and low in the main room. Catra was nowhere in sight. Unwilling to leave the dance alone, in case she needed backup, she saw Mermista languishing in a corner looking bored as Sea Hawk twirled and danced with a big blue skinned man in a turban. Walking over she took her hand and led the water princess from the room without resistance.

"What's the matter with you?" Mermista's voice had a small hint of interest at the edges.

"Catra was watching the Horde people but I can't find her or them." Adora was starting to feel panicked as they moved into a long straight corridor where red jewels adorned the ice.

"She was doing it on her own?" There was clear judgement there.

"I kind of got distracted." And she had, by Entrapta and Glimmer and a hundred other things in this infernal palace that she had never experienced before.

A piece of paper pinned under one of the glowing red jewels caught Mermista's eye and she moved to pull it out, thinking it was curious that it could be there. She unfolded it and swallowed convulsively moving quickly to Adora and pulling her back to the ballroom.

“What?” Adora was about to struggle when she saw the fear in dark eyes.

“They took Catra and those are bombs!” As though her words were the trigger, down the corridor a series of explosions began.

Chapter End Notes

No princess left behind is going to take a turn!

Not On My Watch!

Chapter Summary

> No princess left behind (though some may be a little frustrated by the end).

Straps dug into her chest and ankles, holding her down onto the cold table that she knew like her own skin. Even with the ringing still in her ears and her eyes clouded by the lingering remnants of Scorpia's venom, she knew this place. The cold seeped into her skin from beneath, while the air around her was heavy and cloying with the smell of electricity and magic. As her eyes cleared the red glow of the Black Garnet chamber surrounded her, making the green walls all the more sickly.

Catra had woken up in this position many times since her capture by the Horde, she knew better than to move her head. The more information that she could glean before Shadow Weaver realised she was awake the better. The room was silent, save for the hum that permeated the whole of the Fright Zone. There was no footsteps or rustle of robes. She strained her ears and was certain that she couldn't hear even the fastest hint of breathing. Closing her eyes again, she tried to work through what had landed her here.

She remembered the ball and following Scorpia. There had been bombs and she had wanted to stop them. Rogelio, Lonnie and Kyle had been there too, hadn't they? Things got a bit hazy then, there had been hands on her body and then a sharp pain. Now she was here. She hoped that Adora hadn't be taken too. She strained her ears, only hearing the thrum of hidden electricity and the crackle that always accompanied the Black Garnet. There was no ragged breathing but her own, no whimpers and she thanked whatever providence that she was alone. All she had to do was wait until Adora transformed into She-ra and she would transform too and be able to fight her way out.

She let her eyes close and her head fall back onto the table. Things would be all right. Her body would ripple and roil and burst out of her restraints. For a few minutes she revelled in the idea of tearing Shadow Weaver's throat out as she had would a rabbit or a deer. It was something that she knew her human friends would not understand, but at her core she was still an animal. She almost relaxed.

Then a hazy memory hit her and she tried to bolt up, the bonds pulling on her wrists and neck painfully. She looked around the room as best she could and, sure enough, there was the sword, propped up next to the big gem. There would be no transformation. No chance to save herself. All she could do is lay here and hope that Adora would have the foresight to go to the Crystal Castle. Maybe Light Hope had another way for her to tap into She-ra without the sword. Catra wasn't important to the Alliance. She knew that. She was Adora's plus one, a hand weapon that came along with her but they didn't need her. Adora did, Adora needed someone in her corner who would stop her incessant need for self sacrifice. But she would live without her.

Catra was pretty sure from all her training as a child that there was no way for Shadow Weaver to tap into the sword. It was just a conduit for the power that only Adora could wield. She could try. She could torture Catra as much as she wanted but in the end the truth was, that without Adora she had nothing. But Shadow Weaver was smart, she knew that just as well. Catra was only here as bait for Adora.

As though thinking of the woman had conjured her, like the spectre of evil that she really was, the door opened with a hiss revealing Shadow Weaver gliding in, in that unnerving gait-less way she had. The masked woman didn't even spare her a look as she moved over to the sword and picked it up, but Catra knew that she knew she was awake. The tall woman held the sword up and admired it in the sickly light, taking a few laughable swipes of the blade.

Then she was walking towards the prone girl who just glared back at her in defiance. A dark chuckle came out from behind the mask and the tip of the blade was placed at the base of her throat, nestled into the small indent there. The edge was sharp, biting into her flesh with the smallest of pressure, she could feel a small trickle of blood coiling its way down her neck as she was forced to lay still.

"Looks like I caught you again, mongrel. You really are useless." The sword was lifted away, placed down so that it rested against the edge of her imprisoned body. "Though, if Lonnie is to be believed, you may have hidden uses yet."

Shadow Weaver took hold of the sharp chin and squeezed viscously, Catra was certain that she would have finger marks under her fur but managed to hold in the hiss of pain that threatened. From behind the mask she was certain that Shadow Weaver was appraising her, trying to see the beast that she became though the girl that she was. At least she wasn't crawling around inside her mind this time, those had been memories that she wished had not been returned to her.

"It seems that Adora is She-ra and you are something too. A giant wild cat, Lonnie said, bigger than anything she had ever seen. How do we bring that out of you, I wonder? If you had shown me that as a child things would have been very different." There was an almost maternal edge to that voice, and were she still in a haze with only memories of the last few years, she may have fallen for this fake care, but she was not the girl that Shadow Weaver knew but she didn't need to share that.

"I'll never tell you, you might as well kill me. Adora won't come for me, she has more important things to do!" She spat the words at Shadow Weaver and tried to ignore the hurt in her heart as she said it.

"We'll see. Adora never has had particularly good judgement when it comes to you." With the arrogance that comes from knowing that you are universally feared, Shadow Weaver turned

her back on the younger woman and went to her desk. Catra knew when she had been dismissed. Good. More time to think.

It felt like hours passed as she heard the scrape of pen against reports. In that time she had tested her bonds, quietly flexing her wrists and realising that she could manipulate her hand just enough to slowly use her claws against them. She couldn't risk doing it on the side closest to the desk, but soon her other hand was free as she just bided her time. She didn't have a plan yet, but partially free was a good start.

That was when she heard it. A feint but audible clang in the vent above her. Her heart froze in her chest. She knew that sound, it was the sound of somebody crawling around up there she had done it enough herself in the passed. It was quieter than the sound of Adora up there, she bumbled around and made so much noise it was a wonder they never got in trouble when they were teens. Just dumb luck stopped it. Whoever was up there was much quieter, almost as stealthy as the feline and she was certain that it was one of the princesses.

Damn it! Why had they come? The thought whirred in her brain but she knew. They had come for the sword and for her. It was foolish and reckless but quintessentially who the Rebellion were and it was why they would win. Keeping her ears locked on the vent, she looked over at Shadow Weaver who had not reacted to the sound at all. Good, there was still a chance.

That was when the alarm started and things fell into chaos!

The lights in the room began to flash as the siren blared at levels that were almost unbearable for the prone girl. She flinched and recoiled, only just managing to stop herself from reaching up with her one free hand to cover her ear. She barely heard Shadow Weaver chuckle, rising to her feet and walking out of the room without a backward glance. Good, if she though the plan was working there was hope.

Fighting against the headache the siren was causing, Catra made short work of slicing through the bonds around her arm, legs and torso. Her suit was ruined, and she quickly divested herself of her jacket to be as free as possible. She used it instead to wrap the sword and make a crude sling to carry it over her shoulder. It all took moments and then she was leaping from the table, up into the vent, pulling the cover away and flinging herself inside before pulling it closed again. She followed the faint noises she had noticed and almost screamed when she reached a large area of the ventilation system that was dominated by a bot.

Even though she held the exclamation in, it was enough for the machine to swivel, getting her in its sights and for its weapon to begin to power up. Looking around her quickly, feeling panic race through her, she guessed that she could jump on top of it before it fires. Bracing herself to leap she DID scream when a voice range out.

"Catra! Don't shoot, Emily, that's our friend." Entrapta's voice was the last thing that she had been expecting to hear.

"'Trapta?" She hadn't realised how exhausted she felt until she heard the slurred sound of her own speech.

"Hey Catra. Why did you scream? I am sure you have seen bots before. This is Emily. I found her all by herself and took a look inside and now she is my friend." The bot in question beep and whirred as though it understood and agreed with what the tech princess was saying.

"Ok, Entrapta. Nice to meet you Emily. Entrapta, why are you by yourself?" It seemed out of character for the group to have let the older woman run around by herself. They were better than that.

"Oh, I was with Perfuma, but she seemed to be getting rather frustrated so I went to look for tech to help us so that she could cool off. And then I found Emily and now I have you." So they were all here, though it said a lot about how hard it was to keep Entrapta on task that even Perfuma had snapped.

“That’s great. Do you have comms?” Please, please, please, Catra thought.

“Oh yes, we can use Emily to contact Bow!” Entrapta clapped started pressing buttons. Somewhere between finding Entrapta and now the siren had stopped, she just hoped that she wasn’t too late to stop the others doing something stupid.

“There you go!” Entrapta pointed at the circuit board on top of Emily and motioned for Catra to talk.

“Bow?” Her voice was incredulous.

“Catra?” Bow’s voice broke in that way it did when he was surprised.

“Yeah, I’m with Entrapta. Get the others together now! Entrapta can bring me to the rendezvous. I have the sword, we have to go now! They want Adora not me.”

“I’ll get the others, we’ve got a skiff at the south-side entrance. Meet us there.” The line went dead and she knew she could rely on him.

Now it was just a case of getting Entrapta to the skiff without her getting distracted by more shiny tech. She was a genius but it was often like trying to hold water, trying to keep a grip on her. Catra grabbed hold of Entrapta’s hand, made bulky by her big welding glove, and started to pull her along behind her, hearing the bot moving slowly behind them. It was creepy, but she ignored it, keeping a tight hold on the princess.

Adora sat on the skiff, the engine turning, there was a chaos of fire and explosions on the other side of the compound thanks to SeaHawk. It seemed that he didn’t need a ship to set a fire. Bow had managed to contact them all, Adora had run so fast to get back to the skiff that she had almost forgotten to breath. She had been the first to arrive, Glimmer hot on her heels. Mermista had

dragged SeaHawk on board, where she had been forced to slap a hand over his mouth to muffle his newest shanty about his exploits. Now they just needed Perfuma and Entrapta to arrive, and of course Catra.

Adora should have known that the cat girl would be able to save herself but she had been so afraid that she couldn't leave her behind. They were a team. More than that, the other girl was a part of her. She could not more turn her back on her than her own arm.

A mess of vines appeared at the side of the skiff and Perfuma was lifted into view looking frazzled and worried. Her eyes scanned the passengers and her worry increased as she saw that some of their number were still missing.

"I am so sorry I let Entrapta get away from me. I just got so frustrated. She was everywhere at once and just not listening…I am a bad friend!" Now was not the time for Perfuma to start spiralling.

"Perfuma, it's fine. If she hadn't gone off on her own then Catra wouldn't be with her." As Adora spoke an explosion sounded, closer than the others, and she knew that they had been made.

"We need to be ready to move the minute they get here!" Shots began to sound out, missing them but too class to call.

Then there they were, dashing down a culvert. Catra had the sword swung over her back and Entrapta in her arms bridal style. The princess was laughing maniacally and calling out to somebody called Emily to hurry up. As they got closer, Catra pounced and barely made it on the skiff, thankfully Perfuma's vines were ready to grab them out of the air and lift them fully on board. Bow was at the controls, powering up to leave when Entrapta ran back to the railing.

"Emily!" She was calling out, moving as though she wanted to jump off the skiff. They wall washed as a heavy metal door

descended on the tunnel that they had escaped from, inches in front of a bot.

"Damn it!" Catra's voice was resigned as she dropped the sword and vaulted back where she had come, Adora reaching out to where the girl had been with desperate hands.

They all watched, terrified as she hit the ground and raced to the barrier. Around them they could see soldier's converging now, they couldn't wait much longer! They didn't know what she was doing but the delighted hoot from Entrapta gave them a clue as they watched Catra pull back and slice through the metal as though it were butter. In seconds a huge panel was sliced out and the bot was clumping along towards the skiff, Catra now perched top of the dome of its head.

"Hey, Perfuma, can we get a lift?" Catra's voice was outwardly cheeky but Adora could hear the fear quivering beneath.

It was something like a miracle that they had got home without any casualties, in fact there was barely a scratch on any of them. Adora was still trembling though. Sitting on their bed, waiting for Catra to come out of the shower, she worried the sheets between her fingers to try to distract herself. She had come so close to losing Catra.

While they planned a hasty rescue she had imagined finding her dead or, worse somehow, lobotomised by Shadow Weaver. Left just a host of the girl she loved. She didn't know why she had worried, if anyone could save themself it was her wild forest spirit. Adora had stripped off her clothes as soon as she got home, changing into her sleeper so that the other girl could have the shower. She was certain that she would want to be free of the Fright Zone.

Her spiral into fear was stopped in its tracks when Catra walked out of the bathroom, fluffily clean and sporting her own sleep

shorts. It was her one concession to the castle, but she refused to wear a shirt when they were alone. She smiled her big predators smile at Adora and the blond girl found herself blushing to the tips of her ears. Catra walked towards her with a swagger in her step, it was the last thing that she had expected from the girl so recently kidnapped by her long term tormentor. Before she could think to much about that a hand was thrust out to her.

"Can I have this dance, Princess?" Her voice was more gravelly than usual and Adora had no words, just reached up and took the hand letting herself be pulled to her feet and into the other girls arms.

"I'd like that." The words finally made their way out as she rested her arms over the shorter girls shoulder and felt her settle one hand on her waist. The other she lifted and Adora heard a click for music started to fill the room. Then Catra was throwing something onto the desk and settling both hands on her.

"Bow gave it to me." She reached up and placed a kiss on the other girls lips before, manoeuvring them so that they had hands clasped and Adora was holding onto her shoulder while she kept a hand on her waist. "We never did get to dance at prom."

"No." Adora's words were a sigh as she felt soft, slightly damp fur against her stomach and chest.

"Bow had been showing me how to dance, do you want to see what I learned?" Catra whispered the words directly into her ear and she felt a shiver run up her spine.

"I was learning from Glimmer." She was sure that there was a dopey smile on her face, but it must have been charming because Catra kissed her again and stole her breath.

Then they were twirling around the room, giggling a little when they bumped into the bed. Catra lifted Adora, twirled her around and held her close. In turn, Adora spun Catra until her back was to her front and whispered her love into her ears. It went on for

song after song until Catra dipped Adora deeply and then placed another kiss to her lips.

They were both giggling as the music player went silent, throwing themselves onto the bed and looking at each other with their heads rested on their pillows. Adora reached out a hand and trailed it through the thick fur in the centre of Catra's chest. She rested it over her heart and counted the beats in her head.

"You saved Entrapta's pet bot." The words ghosted out of her lips and then they were both laughing and rolling around.

"Yeah, she told me she'd make me something cool. I hate to imagine!"

Then Catra was pinning her down, looking her in the eyes and leaning down to press hot kisses along her jaw. Adora reached up to thread her fingers through the other girl's hair and moaned as the kisses started to move lower. Sharp claws began to gently glide up from her waist to the underside of her spots bra as lips moved their way down to the tops of her breasts. The fabric started to yield to the pressure of the claw, Adora's breath hitching as Catra ran her tongue along the curve of her breast.

The door slammed open and a babble of princesses spilled in.

Catra growled theatrically and slumped onto Adora who couldn't do anything but laugh as the others threw themselves onto the bed, and onto them, in a pile of people who all loved them. They were all laughing and teasing, the relief in the room palpable while Emily bleeped in the corner.

Catra wished they all had better timing!

Wish

Chapter Summary

Inside the Crystal Castle you see yourself.

Chapter Notes

Slightly longer update.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Do you really think that this is a god idea?” Adora slashed her sword through the underbrush petulantly.

“Yes. The Crystal Castle has all the answers about the sword. Light Hope trained me to protect it and you, but she never told me I would turn into,” and here Catra rolled her eyes as Bow squealed, “Battle Cat, so who knows what else the sword can do?”

“She’s right. We didn’t know She-ra could heal until Perfuma told us.” Glimmer was huffing and puffing behind them, her shorter legs finding it hard to keep up with the two taller humans and the ball of energy that was the feline. When she had said she would teleport, all three had turned grim faces on her and told her to keep her power stored in case they needed it in the first ones ruin. She’d known they were right, but it still didn’t stop her grumbling as she had to quicken her pace for the second time.

“You never know, maybe She-ra can fly!” Bow’s eyes were trickling as he dropped back to stick with Glimmer, giving her one of his charming smiles and a shoulder bump, making Glimmer have to fight a blush. That was happening more and more around her old friend, she blamed Adora and Catra and their childhood romance for putting thoughts in her head.

“Really, Arrow-Boy? I don’t think she’ll be able to fly. Catra looked appraising at Adora as she lopped off another tree branch with the sword. “Would be cool though.”

“What would be cool?” Adora’s confused voice made the other three start to laugh as they realised that she hadn’t heard a word they said.

“Don’t worry, dummy.” Catra slung her arm around Adora’s shoulder and hugged her, feeling the other girl start to relax.

They walked for another twenty minutes, Adora finally laughing and joking with the rest of them. By the time the towering figure of the Crystal Castle came into view, they had almost forgotten why they were there. The Horde had been quiet, suspiciously so, since Catra’s breakout, but it was nice to go for a walk in the woods with their friends, even if the end goal was to find out how to use their best weapon better. Adora wasn’t sure that she was all that happy to be a weapon, even though she knew that was what Shadow Weaver had always raised her to be.

They broke into the clearing that had once been Catra’s home, what felt like two lifetimes ago now and stopped in front of the blue tinted wall. The building itself rose up and up ahead of them, but Catra broke away from the group and made her way over to her cave. She ducked down and crawled through the small opening, feeling her shoulders brush against both walls as they never had before. Inside the place was as she had left it, Adora’s old bedroll moulding in the corner and the screwed up blankets dustily balled. She shuffled forward, having to stoop now that she was grown for fear of banging her head, reaching out to pick up one of the small cache of bones and stones that she had collected as a cub.

Adora left Bow and Glimmer looking at the building, Bow with his tracker pad taking photos of the various sigils scattered over its surface to show to his fathers. The one time that he and Glimmer had been to this place they had been being hunted by a giant worm, there had been no time to take a good look at it. Adora ducked into the short tunnel like entrance of the cave that she used to think of as a second home, feeling more claustrophobic than she had been in the past. Breaking into the main room, she watched quietly as Catra turned something over in her hands.

Adora noted that the things he had given Catra so long ago to keep her comfortable were still there. She sighed, the small exhalation making Catra turn to her in the dim light that came threw the small breaks in the walls.

“Hey Adora, look at my cave. When did it get so small?” Catra sank to sit cross legged on the floor, her movements barely disturbing the dust.

Adora crawled the short distance towards her, knowing her pant legs would be dirty when they left but not caring. She sat beside the other girl and reached out for her hand. They were quiet for a moment, just looking around the dark space. The cave itself was squat and wide, small enough to keep warm but big enough to hold a family of large animals. “I don’t know. I’m surprised nothing else moved in.” It was obvious that the place had been left undisturbed.

“I don’t think Light Hope would let them.” Catra spoke absently as she reached out and ran her fingers along a set deep groves carved into the floor. They dwarfed her hand even when she splayed it out.

“They look like Battle Cat’s claws, maybe a little smaller.” Adora rested her head over her shoulder to look at what had captured her attention and Catra realised she was right.

The sounds of their names being called from outside broke them from their revelry, remembering why they were there, and the pair of the made their way, blinking, back out into the daylight. Bow and Glimmer were standing at the mouth of the cave and looking at them curiously. Bow ducked down and peered down the entrance.

“What’s in there?” Glimmer spoke as she helped dust off Adora’s pants.

“That was my home when I was a cub.” Bow’s eyes got even bigger and twinklier if that was possible and she promised him

that he could go inside when they were done. He was going to be sorely disappointed by what he saw, she wagered.

"Let's get this show on the road, people." Glimmer clapped her hands and Bow handed Adora back her sword as they walked towards what they all knew to be the door.

"Eternia!" Adora raised her voice and the door withdrew, leading them once more into the dark depths of the building. "Remember not to touch anything!"

They entered the large foyer area where the interface hologram existed. Adora made her way there and started to talk to the interface growing more and more frustrated as it seemed not to understand her questions about She-ra. Catra stayed by her side, smirking lightly as Adora's voice became more and more comically animated in her frustration. It was clear that only Light Hope would be able to answer their questions about She-ra's abilities and the sword. She was lifting her hand to rest it on Adora's shoulder when a tinkling sound caused her to turn around and see Bow standing with his hands over his mouth with a mortified look on his face as Glimmer looked between him and the red data crystal that was now sitting on the ground in pieces.

That was when a siren started to scream and the sound of the hologram claiming that they were unauthorised blared out even while Adora raised her voice to try to be heard. The hologram glitched and pixelated for a moment and then the doors around the room started to lower as the menacing sound of thousands of metal tipped feet came down the halls.

"Not again!" Adora's voice was frustrated as she looked between the doors, trying to guess which was the best exit.

Catra grasped her wrist and pulled her towards the right, Bow and Glimmer hot on their heels as the first of the menacing metallic spiders began to spill into the room. The four of them barely made it through before the door slammed shut, severing a few metal legs along wit hit. The siren continued to wail in the

distance, the corridor around them lit up in menacing reds to signal that the place was in danger. Catra wracked her brains, trying to remember the layout o this place. She had once known it by heart but having lost and regained her memories, she wasn't sure if she had retained that information.

"This way." Nobody argued, a fact for which she was very thankful as they followed her down the hallway with its sharp turns. They were moving further and further into the castle, and she strained her ears for any sign of the guard spiders.

"I am so sorry you guys." Bow spoke lowly, his voice laced with tears. "I just turned and I hit it with elbow and then it was on the floor all broken up."

"It was an accident Bow, but now that we can't return it this place just sees you as invaders and me by extension because I am with you." Adora had an almost white knuckled grip on her sword as they moved. She didn't want to hurt Bow's feeling but this situation was deadly.

The group turned another corner, only to finally hear the spider sounds and break into a run. It wasn't long before they were in front of yet another doorway. Without thought, Catra used her claws to slice through the metal and break the lock, the others pulling the sides apart just long enough to get through before they closed tight behind them leaving them in pitch darkness so deep that even Catra's cat-eyes couldn't penetrate. Thankfully they were all already touching when they made it into the room. Adora clasped her hands while she felt Glimmer's hand on her tail and imagined Bow's hand in hers.

"Stay together. I've never been in this area before." Catra's admission caused Adora to squeeze her hand tighter.

"Hang on!" Glimmer's voice was loud in the darkness and then there was as power of sparks penetrating the dark as she held a stuttering ball of purple light in the palm of her hand. Her face

held a look of intense concentration as she maintained the magic but at least they could see each other now, if nothing else.

"Oh! OH!" Adora's voice sounded and then she was calling for She-ra, the large warrior replacing the young woman, glowing like a beacon in the darkness and Glimmer was able to let the light ball fizzle out in her hands. "Can you transport us out Glimmer?"

Glimmer concentrated hard, but all she managed was to stutter out and back into existence. "No, it's like there is a shield around the room."

"That's ok. You two should get onto Battle Cat, we can move faster that way." Adora smiled at Catra's giant form, both now wearing their larger and more imposing visages.

Do you know where we are? Adora's voice filled her head and Catra wiggled her tail even as the two others climbed onto her back with poking knees.

Light Hope never showed me an endless room full of darkness.

They gingerly began to move away from where they had entered the room, or their best guess about it. Even with She-ra's glow the darkness encroached on every side and they had no idea where they were going. That was when light suddenly filled the area in front of them, pulling them up short, as figures began to emerge out of the darkness…

…The big cat slunk past them, Glimmer gasped as it got close enough to brush against her but it simply passed through, along the forest floor, belly brushing the ground as it surveyed its prey. Water trickled and hid the feint sound of grass rustling as it drew closer and closer to the deer-like animal that was drinking. Between one breath and the next the deer ducked its head to drink and then it found its neck lock between two jaws so large and powerful that they almost surrounded it. The deer was dead

before it could even struggle and being dragged between the legs of the successful predator. The four youths watched the scene with rapt attention, Catra hunkering down and slinking towards it on all fours to be closer to the events that she barely remembered.

From out of the trees, the cub flew, tiny and loose limbed but capable of exceptional silence. Adora gasped at the sight, her She-ra form stuttering out and causing her and Catra to go back to her normal shape. She had known Catra since they were young, but this was a toddler, maybe two or three years old. Her wild and untamed mane of hair was as big as she was and her small body was pudgy and fuzzy. She glanced to the side and saw Bow holding his hands over his mouth with eyes glittering, even Glimmer seemed captivated. Catra was laying on her belly, with a hand outstretched just shy of trying to touch the very large male cat who was now laying with his kill as the little one approached. He swiped his rough tongue across fur and flesh, starting to tear at it.

The cub snuck closer, little butt wiggling in the air before she pounced and threw herself onto the big broad head that was larger than she was and started to lick at the blood smearing the male's muzzle. A broad paw reached up and batted her away gently until the small body flopped to the ground with a little huff, before being pulled closer by the same paw until she was half cradled by the hunter as he continued to lick the hide from the kill. Soft rustling made two pairs of large ears swivel in the direction of a second cat that emerged from the cover.

Adora examined the new arrival, knowing that Catra was doing the same. This was clearly a female, a little smaller in stature but no less imposingly muscular. Both the bigger cats were dark furred, almost black and it was hard to see, even though she was obviously human like, where Catra had gotten her colouring from. The pelts of both adults were a flat dark brown, their eyes green. Something twitched at the back of her mind and she filed away a thought to share with Catra later.

The two larger cats made a deep chuffing noise at each other while the toddler let out a human-like giggle before chirping and bounding over to her mother, clambering up her leg to settled slumped over her head. The big meow that left the animal couldn't be mistaken as anything other than affection, and then all of the cats curled together as they began to tear at the carcass together. As tiny child teeth began to tear into flesh the scene shimmered out of existence, leaving the three humans staring into darkness as Catra reached out towards nothing.

"Ok, what the heck was that?" Glimmer's voice broke the moment, even though they couldn't see each other they knew they were all thinking the same thing.

"I don't know." Catra's voice was small, sounding a little loss, and Adora reached out to where she heard the sound, closer now revealing that she had got up from her prone position on the floor.

"That was you as a baby. Do you remember that?" Adora knew the answer to that before Catra responded to Bow in the negative.

"Well, whatever this room is, if we keep moving we're bound to find a wall we can hug and find a door." Adora had always been a doer and she wanted them out of this dark place.

The blond started to utter the words that would bring She-ra's glow back, when the room began to shift again and with a hum that had been omnipresent all her life Adora found herself standing in the Fright Zone…

…The pipes above the little girl's head rattled and hummed. They were warm and familiar as the small child tucked herself into a corner where she had tucked her blanket. The floor was hard but as she curled into a little ball she felt the comfort of the pipes. Her belly was full of ration bars and she began to feel sleepy. Her head began to bob as she fought sleep as small children often do.

It had been a cold winter in the Fright Zone. The generators had suffered a power surge and the people that had suffered had been the cadets. There was still a war to be fought and all available power went to the maintenance of equipment. These particular pipes led to the mech yard. It was important to keep the engineers warm so that they could work. It hadn't taken the five year old long to realise that sleeping in her bunk was no good. Even though she was Shadow Weaver's favourite, she still suffered the same fate as the rest of the children.

As though thinking about them made them appear, she heard the sound of three pairs of small feet running down the corridor. Distantly she could hear Kyle calling out plaintively for her through teeth that were obviously chattering. She was the best at finding the hidden crooks and crannies in their home that the older kids hadn't found yet. Their last warm hidden hole had been stolen from them two days ago when some of the pre-teens had dragged them out by their shirts, tearing Lonnie's and getting reprimanded and losing her dinner that night.

"Over here guys!" Adora called out, hoping that no-one else would hear.

Lonnie came into sight first, Rogelio slumped over her back as she piggy-backed the small lizard-kin. He had been struggling with the cold more than any of them, he wasn't cold blooded but he had less body fat under his scales and struggled to regulate his temperature. Kyle scampered behind them, looking furtive and visibly shivering. The trio spotted her in the tangled corner of pipes and hustled their way over, Kyle was holding all of their blankets too.

Little Adora reluctantly got up and helped Kyle to lay two of the blankets on the metal floor and then the four children gathered together in the corner like a pile of puppies, covering themselves with the remaining blankets to keep their body heat in. Even as small as they were they had already had some survival training and with the warmth of the pipes on the outside and the trapped body heat inside they were all able to relax. Lonnie and Adora

made themselves the walls of their little cocoon while Kyle and Rogelio nestled into them.

"Thanks 'Dora." Kyle's teeth had stopped chattering and Rogelio was sat on his lap with his spine little head tucked under the boys chin, Lonnie was pressed up against the liars-kins back and Adora was pressed to Kyle's.

"We're a team Kyle. I can't let anything happen to my friends." A yawn broke up her words and she knew that the others were just as tired as she was.

"You all need to shut up. I wanna go to sleep." Lonnie's voice was grumpy and held a whine that showed that she was over tired.

The group of children fell into silence and Adora allowed herself to curl further into the warmth of her little family. They had been together for as long as she could remember and she knew that they would stay a team always…

…Adora jolted as she felt a hand on her shoulder. The world around her was blackness again, Glimmer's glitter ball illuminating the area.

"Adora?" Catra's worried face was cloaked in shadow but her concern was obvious.

"I was there." Her voice was laced with confusion. When Catra's past had been displayed they had all been watching, it had been clear that Catra was looking at events as an observer. Why had she felt like she was living that memory?

Sadness pulled at her chest as she thought of the other three people who had filled her childhood and been so important to her that she had just left behind, still in the clutches of the Horde. Even though she knew it must have been them who figured out what she and Catra were and told Shadow Weaver, she couldn't blame them.

"Ok, I don't know about you but I want to get out of here before anymore weird stuff starts happening." Bow's voice trembled a little, they had all watched as adult Adora was replaced with the child version.

"I agree with Bow. Let's hustle." Catra grabbed Adora's limp hand and dragged her quickly forward.

Unfortunately, in her desire to get the blond girl, who seemed dazed, out of this place Catra pulled the two of them out of the corona of Glimmer's light and suddenly they were swallowed by darkness. Catra tried to step back, but found her back against a wall, Adora's hands still clasped tightly in hers as they both became disorientated. Then a whirl of different holograms? Visions? Surrounded them showing them their parallel lives. A baby was left blinking up at coloured lights while laying exposed in a field until large hands were scooping her up and holding her in front of a blurry white face. A cub returned to a cave to find itself all alone, curling up and mewling in the cold of abandonment. Catra reached up and touched her cheek where Adora had kissed her on the cheek for the first time. Adora laid in her bunk, scratching a secret picture of the cat-girl beside her bunk… On and on their separate moments swirled until both of them were forcefully yanked sideways and out of a door.

The corridor outside was so bright after the other room that the four of them were left blinking their eyes to shake the darkness. Glimmer and Bow had found an exit and managed to pull the other two out. It had been overwhelming to see the other girls swirling memories, to be a part of them must have been overwhelming. Adora threw herself into Catra's arms and squeezed her eyes tightly closed, relieved to feel the real ness of the other girl, not caring that Bow and Glimmer were watching.

"What were those?" Glimmer's voice cut into their moment, but Adora didn't pull away, instead just resting her head on a furry shoulder and turning to look at her friend.

“Our memories, little things that were bittersweet.” Catra nodded along with Adora’s words, uncharacteristically quiet.

Adora opened her mouth to say something to the feline girl, only to snap her mouth shut as Catra’s eyes began to dart around the corridor and her ears move furiously back and forth. The other girl had heard something, and Adora began to tense in her arms.

“Why didn’t we see any memories?” Bow spoke quietly, also aware of Catra’s new alertness.

“We belong to this place.” Catra spoke absently as she disentangled herself from Adora and began to move towards the sounds that had caught her ear. It wasn’t the skittering of the spider feet that had been chasing them, it sounded more like scratching from beyond the wall. Behind her Catra could hear the other three talking but her attention was focused on following the sound, her desire to protect Adora making her seek out the source of possible danger and eradicate it.

She was nearing the end of the corridor when she saw something that looked like a hatch in the wall. Cautiously she approached it, ears straining to hear the sound that had gone suddenly silent. Reaching out a hand, claws extended and ready to strike, she touched the hatch and it exploded outwards. Metal shards sliced across her face, leaving her stunned for just long enough for a net of sticky material to whip out and wrap around her, pulling her towards the now gaping fissure. Distantly she could hear shouting through the pounding of blood in her ears, but all her focus was on trying to fight her bonds.

Her hands were trapped at her sides, claws rendered useless. Her mouth and eyes were covered and she could feel her body being pulled through the small hole and towards an unseen something. Struggling, she was able to free her mouth and let out an anguished cry.

“Adora!”

“Catra hold on.” She felt a touch brush her shoulder but then she was moving fast and there was no sound.

Adora watched with wide, terrified eyes as Catra disappeared through the hole, slipping through her fingers. The emotional whiplash of the last few minutes making her head spin. They were meant to be getting answers and instead had run for their lives, been trapped in the past and now Catra was gone. Adora raised and fist and slammed it into the wall beside the hole, feeling pain shoot up her hand. She was about to do it again when Bow grabbed her elbow to stop her.

“Adora. Stop it. You can transform into She-ra and Catra will transform and be able to get free.” Bow’s words broke through her haze and she berated herself for not thinking about that first.

“For the honour of Greyskull!” The words echoed down the corridor and her body transformed, the comforting pull of She-ra’s power wrapping around her.

From within the hole they heard a roar reverberate and three pairs of eyes looked at each other with relief just as a roving band of spider’s turned the corner towards them. Glimmer grabbed Bow and She-ra and transported them down the tunnel revealed by the hole and directly into the path of the snarling Battle Cat. Adora wanted to drop to her knees and pet the big striped head, but there was no time. The sound of skittering was getting closer and the four of them bolted away. Battle Cat’s senses were more acute like this and she was able to lead them to where she could hear a voice. It was feint but she knew it was Light Hope.

I can hear Light Hope. Her voice entered Adora’s mind and the blond smiled even as she ran for her life.

What is she saying? They rounded a corner, the light getting brighter as they moved.

I can’t make it out yet.

Battle Cat came to a sudden halt, the others careening into her as they came to a sudden drop. It was as though they had been herded to this point. They could easily have careened down into the depths. The four of them leaned over to look down when Light Hope's voice filled the room.

"Adora, you need to let go." The youths looked at each other in confusion at the words.

"What is she talking about?" Glimmer hissed out of the side of her mouth. Adora shrugged just as confused.

Catra stayed quiet, looking down into the depths with her acute vision. There was something down there. Less far away than it seemed. Her sense of space had been disrupted by the darkness and the encounter with her childish self but her ears twitched as she realised what she was seeing. She batted her head against Adora's hip to get her attention.

"What's wrong?"

I know where we are and I think I know what Light Hope wants. Worry seeped between their connection. **send Glimmer and Bow away. If we're where I think we are then that's a wall to the outside, Glimmer should be able to make it.**

Adora didn't ask why Catra wanted to send the others away. She simply told them to go, they agreed with only minimal argument saying that they would wait for them in the clearing and then they were gone in a shower of sparkles. Adora let She-ra dissolve and watched as Catra chewed at her lip as she looked down the fissure.

"You need to let go!" Light Hope's voice filtered up again, more insistent this time.

"I think we've been driven here. I think you were supposed to fall down there and give in to falling." Catra's voice was distant.

“Why would she do that?” Adora was looking down now as they stood shoulder to shoulder.

“She wants you. I served my purpose, I got you to the sword and I protected you long enough to get here. She wants you to go to her.” Catra sighed.

“Well, we wanted answers from her.” Adora was waiting for more spiders to appear and push her down there but none came.

“You ever wish our lives were normal?” Catra’s voice was soft and Adora wrapped her arm around her shoulder and pressed a kiss to her temple.

“Wouldn’t have you then.” Catra trilled a little. “I wish this war was over so we could just be together though.” Adora looked into mismatched eyes. “I feel so guilty for leaving Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio behind.”

“I didn’t remember what my parents looked like.”

“Why do you think we were shown all of that?” Adora couldn’t shake the feeling that she had abandoned her other friends. “Is that what we’re supposed to let go of, do you think?”

“Only one way to find out.” Catra wasn’t willing to blindly follow the hologram as she had as a child, but Adora needed answers and the only way to get them is down.

Chapter End Notes

Next time Light Hope.

Alien Invader

Chapter Summary

> Light Hope tells Adora about balancing the planet, Catra worries.

Chapter Notes

> Hey! Sorry for the delay in updating both this and Hidden Kingdom. We're looking at a big update for that so stay tuned.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Turning into She-ra and Battle Cat had seemed like the most logical choice. Adora climbed astride the massive cat beast, feeling the powerful muscles ripple and bunch between her thighs and felt a blush rise up her chest. It was the most inappropriate feeling in the circumstances, but this was still Catra beneath her moving with barely restrained power. She pushed the thoughts down, storing them away for later, and flattened herself across the wide back, holding tight with her sword strapped to her back in the scabbard that appeared there.

Ready Princess? She had expected Catra's mental voice to sound amused, but it was clear that she was just trying to keep things light, just as worried as Adora was.

"Ready." Even though she said the word, when Battle Cat's whole body coiled like a spring and them lurched into the air, she let out an embarrassing scream and found herself holding onto thick fur for dear life as they were suddenly hurtling through nothingness. She could feel Catra breathing, body ready to hit the ground with all her catlike prowess.

It was then that Adora felt She-ra stutter, like a glitch in one of the computers back at the fright zone. Her body jerked, the one beneath her doing the same, and then their forms stuttered out.

Adora and Catra were falling in their normal bodies, operated now by gravity and the impromptu change. Catra still managed to keep her body poised to hit the ground but tried to reach out for the flailing human girl, managing at last to grasp her hand and pull the other falling body towards her, confident that she could save them both from the fall. As long as the fall wasn't much further.

As though her thoughts controlled the world around them, the dark depths glitched to reveal a shiny metal floor only a few metres away. With all her strength, Catra pulled Adora into her own body, twisting them in mid fall so that she would take the brunt of the impact. When it came, Catra felt every breath pushed out of her lungs and pain shot through her back, thankfully she managed to keep her head from slamming into the floor. She lay gasping, fingers and toes tingling, as Adora climbed off of her.

Crouching beside the felled cat, Adora helped her sit while feeling for any broken bones. Catra winced and hissed when she hit a sensitive spot, but did not pull away. Whatever was hurt would soon be fixed once they transformed again. What was more pressing was finding out what Light Hope wanted from Adora. Adora stood, pulling the wincing girl up with her as they turned to look at the bright, cavernous room around them. The walls glittered like they were speckled with diamonds, electronic lights racking around the rooms in sharp lines. Catra looked around, wide eyed. This was yet another part of the Crystal Castle that she had never seen, Catra was beginning to wonder just how much Light Hope had hidden from her over her years of training as a child. Her tail twitched as she looked at Adora whose eyes were fixed on the front of the room where Light Hope had just shimmered to life.

"You have done well, Guardian. Your mission is accomplished." The flat voice of the hologram filled the room, and Catra's ears twitched.

Adora, feeling as unsettled as Catra, reached her hand out to find the cat girl, never taking her eyes off of the towering woman glowing with soft blue light. Her hand clutched at nothing, so she

moved her grasp but still found nothing. Finally, giving in to the need to be connected with her partner, she tore her eyes away from the projection, only to wheel around as she saw that she was alone in the room. There was no sign of the feline at all. Even the dust on ground seemed undisturbed by their fall.

She spun on the hologram, jaw clenched and fists balled at her side. The serene face gazed down at her, impassive and blank. Adora walked closer, inspecting this projected woman who seemed to know more about who she was than herself. When she was standing almost toe to toe with the woman, lifeless eyes turned to meet hers.

"Adora, I have been waiting for you since you were an infant, but you were not ready until now. I could not protect you from the Horde, but I sent you the guardian and they have brought you at the right moment. I have watched you grow up from afar." Light hope's voice was smooth and hypnotic, like the mirror image of Shadow Weaver's dark molasses tones.

"Wow, that's… that's kind of creepy." It was made creepier, in Adora's mind, that she had made Catra disappear for this.

"Creepy? Yes. I have been called this before. I chose this form so as not to alarm you, but if it does not suit you, I will choose another." Light hope shimmered and reformed into the form of a smirking child, the flat dead face more terrifying than anything Adora had ever seen. She let out an undignified shriek when it started to speak. "Is this better?"

"Oh, no. That's--that's, um, that's definitely way worse." Adora had stepped back several paces from the blank child who thankfully grew and shifted back into the taller form of the woman. "Where did you send Catra?" Her worry still gnawed at her.

"The Guardian has no purpose here. She will wait outside the Crystal Castle until you have need of her again." The words were

dismissive, as though talking about a robot or pet. Adora sighed, at least Catra was safe then.

"So, who are you?" Adora needed answers that Catra couldn't give her and there was no reason not to get them.

Catra appeared outside the walls of the monolith that had dominated her life, several feet above the ground and hit the dirt with a whine as pain lanced through already bruised ribs. Vaguely she heard a commotion, and then gentle hands were lifting her from the floor and brushing dirt off of her clothes. She opened eyes that had squeezed shut on impact, to find herself looking into the worried face of Glimmer.

"Where's Adora?" Glimmer's voice was trembling. It might have been the cold that had crept into the clearing, or maybe it was the come down after their flight for freedom inside the building.

"With Light Hope." Catra's voice sounded flat even to her own ears. She moved away from her friends and to the wall, resting her hand flat against the symbols there. Every part of her wanted to rip and tear at the walls, to get back in pull Adora away. But they had gone into the Crystal Castle for answers and if Adora got them alone, she would tell her.

Catra turned back to her companions and was about to speak when a rustling from the trees caught all her attention. Her aching body tensed, her ears pricked forward and her tail began to thrash. Bow and Glimmer saw her reaction and instantly both took up a fighting stance, Glimmer filled her hands with energy while Bow loaded his weapon and waited. Even while most of her attention was focused on the imminent threat, a small part of Catra felt warmed by the way that they could work so seamlessly as a team.

Catra's skin was almost vibrating by the time that the invader crossed the boundary from forest to clearing. She was pouncing

forward before she even saw their face, legs a little wobbly but just as fast and powerful as ever. She was only inches away when she recognised the intruder, pulling herself back as best she could only to come crashing to the floor for the third time in the last hour. This time her body betrayed her, leaving her lying on the floor and aching.

"Wildling, dearie, you really should get up off of that floor." The thickly accented old voice drifted down from above her and she smiled into the dirt at the words. It had been months since she and Adora had last seen the old woman who could make herself as elusive as smoke when she chose. A rap to the side of her head from a broom made her mewl. "Up! Up lazy bones. You should introduce me to your friends, yes?"

Razz walked to the centre of the clearing where a rock now sat, that Catra was certain had never been there before, and lowered herself down onto it, propping her broom up beside her. She looked at the three youths in front of her and blinked owlishly through her thick glasses, smiling at them all benignly, simply waiting. It took Catra a moment to realise that she was waiting on her.

"Oh, right. Bow, Glimmer, this is Madam Razz. She used to give me snacks when I was a cub and helped me learn to talk. She lives in the woods and Adora's met her too." She turned to the old woman. "Razz, these are my friends Bow and Glimmer. Glimmer's the princess of Brightmoon. We all work together to take down the Horde." Her voice was proud and Bow and Glimmer were beaming at her, as was Razz.

"Good. That's good. About time you found yourself a family, Wildling. You must stay on the path though, my girl, the future isn't set yet." As ever her words were cryptic and Catra felt a small thrill of fear. "Where is my Adora?" It was rare for Razz to remember that Adora was Adora and not the mysterious Mara.

"She's inside." Razz nodded, not seeming to need to know more for which Catra was grateful.

“Ah, that girl has much to learn and understand.” A red clothed arm extended and gestured to the others in the clearing. “Come sit by old Razz and let me learn a little about these friends of my Wildling.”

Catra hung back for a moment, warmed beyond measure as she watched her old and new worlds come together. She let her eyes travel back to the wall of the castle, hoping that Adora would appear beside her but knowing that patients was needed. She was certain that Light Hope wouldn’t harm the blond. Less certain that she wouldn’t plant some dangerous ideas in her mind.

The daymoon was fading by the time that Adora walked out of the Crystal Castle, Catra’s ears had heard the door opening and she was up and moving before the blond stepped out, ignoring the other three in the clearing. It had surprised her that Razz had stayed around, there had been some mysteriously appearing pie that had been delicious and Bow was obviously charmed. None of that mattered though, when Adora was back with her.

Catra got close to the opening as Adora stepped through and threw herself into the cat-girl’s arms. She buried her face into the feline’s neck and held her tightly. Catra wasn’t sure what was wrong, but wrapped her arms around her mate and waited for her to be ready to pull away and talk. Everything fell away as the two girls held each other. Whatever had happened inside had shaken Adora in a way that Catra had not seen before. She waited, not speaking, just purring softly into blond hair, thankful that the others kept up their lively conversation as though they hadn’t noticed the two o them embracing.

Catra wasn’t sure how much time passed, just that it was full dark before Adora spoke softly into her ear. The warm breath tickled and she held the other girl closer as she listened to her words.

“I’m just a cog in a machine, Catra. I’m a chosen one only because I complete the runestone that link the planet. She said I

would bring balance.” There were warm tears seeping into Catra’s fur and she felt angry at how lost Adora sounded.

“You are more than a tool, Adora.” Catra knew that was what she was, but never this special young woman in her arms.

“She said that Mara,” with this both of them looked towards Razz, who although hearing their low words, looked over to them with a soft smile. “She said Mara was the She-ra before. That she couldn’t let go of all the things that tied her to her life to balance the planet and that she snapped. That she almost doomed the world.” Adora pulled back, looking hard into Catra’s eyes as though trying to forge a connection between their very souls. “I don’t want to let you go. You’re a part of me.”

“Then don’t. You aren’t going to lose it, I won’t let you. I’ll stand between you and anyone who says otherwise. Trust me. We’ll take down the Horde with of without Light Hope.” There was a fire burning in her chest and she pulled Adora back into her arms and held her tight. She was this woman’s Guardian and she would protect her from everyone if she could.

Finally Glimmer grew impatient and called out, “You two going to come over? Razz said we can go for dinner at her cottage if you stop dragging your feet.”

Adora snorted a small laugh, and pulled away from Catra, catching her hand and the whole group made their way into the deep, dark woods. They were unafraid as they followed the eccentric old woman for whom the branches seemed to part to make a path. Catra and Adora were last in their little procession and as they moved, Adora kept close to her side.

“You’re limping.” The worry for Catra pushed aside everything else.

“I fell. A lot.” Truthfully, she felt better than she had any right to.

Adora leaned close and sealed their lips together in a kiss so tender than it made Catra’s soul ache. There was a tingling in the

kiss, different than any before. If she were a more romantic creature she would have said that it was true love. But Catra was not made for romance, she was made for survival, and as the kiss swelled and the others walked further away, she felt all of the pain in her body melt away to nothing until Adora pulled back looking a little dazed.

“Did I just?”

“Yeah. You healed me. I guess some good came out of today.” Catra forced a laugh, not sure why she suddenly felt cold. “Not sure you can go round kissing everyone like that though.”

Adora blushed prettily to the tops of her ears, her blue eyes standing out even in the darkness. “I’m sure I’ll find a different way. I just need practice.” There was a smirk on her lips before they pressed to hers again. It was cheeky and the gloom Catra couldn’t explain lifted.

They started to walk again, moving faster to catch up with the others, when Adora’s voice filled the night again. “Oh, Light Hope also said that I am from another planet.” Adora delivered the words so flatly for a moment Catra thought that she misheard.

“You’re an alien?” As if their life needed to be any weirder.

Chapter End Notes

Next up, prelude to The Battle of Brightmoon!
We're almost there and the final chapter is already written!

Get Ready/Fight!

Chapter Summary

The Battle of Brightmoon.
How do you win a battle and end a war?

Chapter Notes

I am so sorry that I have been gone since June...
Back now though!
Hope this update doesn't disappoint.

Mismatched eyes watched as the others left the cozy confines of the cottage. They passed through the ragged curtain that acted as a door, it was a wonder of the woods that the old woman never got cold here. Adora was the last to leave, holding the curtain over her head as she looked back at the cat girl with questioning eyes, one foot already back out into the world. Catra smiled wanly back at her, unsure why but knowing that it wasn't her time to leave yet and waved her out. The other girl smiled back, and was gone, the moth-eaten fabric falling behind her and coming to rest as though she had never been there.

For a moment, Catra sat in the stillness of the empty room. Her ears twitched but there was no sign of the old woman who usually filled the place. It was as though she was suddenly adrift somehow out of time. Was this what Light Hope had made, a creature that didn't belong in the world with the others now that her job was done? Before she could fall into a well of doubt and longing, something thwacked against the back of her head. Tutting accompanied the rough bristles of the broom.

"So gloomy, Wildling. Your friends and your girl are pleased, no? You have answers that you did not have before?" Though Razz's voice was its familiar upbeat tone, the large eyes, made bigger by her glasses, seemed haunted.

“It feels like more questions to me Razz.” Catra looked up at her expectantly, the unshakable sense of dread still pulsing through her chest, it seemed incongruous in the warm coziness of the small home but as she watched the thin line of the old woman’s mouth turn down she knew that it was more than a feeling.

Bowing her head, Catra let out a shuddering sigh as she squeezed her eyes closed. A gentle hand landed in her hair and simply rested there, letting her know that the old woman was there. There were no more words passed between them. She knew that she could ask Razz what was to come; the crone had a way of almost looking into the future. After so long among the princesses, Catra was almost certain there was magic involved. She was neither sure she wanted the answers to any question she may ask, and not sure she would understand what the inscrutable older woman would tell her anyway. Everything was riddles with Razz.

The pair of old friends stayed that way for a time, the sounds of Adora and the others trampling their way through the forest with their clumsy feet fading so far that even Catra’s ears could not pick up a trace of them. It felt like an ending, this moment between the two of them. The tension in the air about to be broken by a change that could not be taken back.

Eventually the buzzing of a fly disturbed the peace, humming its way too close to Catra’s ear and making it flick to avoid the invader, dislodging Razz’s hand. The young woman wanted to reach out and grasp the fragile wrist, force the hand back to where it had been, but knew that the moment had passed. Whatever was to come, would come no matter how long she spent inside this little shack. If she left now she could catch up to the others in no time, traversing the canopy of the trees and moving faster than their clumsy feet could carry them.

Catra stood, uncoiling to her feet with her usual grace but feeling as heavy as sand on the inside. She squared her shoulders and firmed her resolve as she made for the door, Razz’s shuffling footsteps following her. She reached up and pulled the frayed

curtain aside, one foot already over the threshold, when she spun to face the old woman who stood behind her. It was rare to catch the wise one off guard, but the small gasp that left her wrinkled lips showed that she hadn't expected the sudden motion. Catra smiled sadly as she leaned down and pressed a soft kiss to the parchment like cheek.

"Thank you Razz." An old hand reached out and cupped her cheek before she could pull away.

"Good luck, Wildling."

The thud of feet hitting the ground up ahead caught Adora's attention, pulling her away from the conversation with Glimmer and Bow. A smile covered her face as she saw Catra step out from the trees and fall into step with them. The taller girl reached out her hand and was rewarded with the feline slotting her own into her grasp. The solid warmth of the their hands together was grounding and Adora smiled over at the girl that she adored, if Catra's returned smile was a little more wane than usual she chalked it up to leaving Razz. It was always sad to say goodbye to the strange old crone.

Squeezing the hand in hers, she swung their arms between them. After seeing what the Crystal Castle had to offer, she felt more confident than ever. She and Catra were an unstoppable team, so what if her lover had been made just to bring her to the sword? Now they worked together, a perfect unit of woman and animal who would be able to defend Etheria from all comers. She reached up to push a low hanging branch out of her face, and as she moved her head caught a glimpse at the tight lines of Catra's jaw. It was so unusual to see the smaller girl anything other than confident or wryly amused that she let the bough go too soon only to have it ping back and thwack her in the face.

Glimmer and Bow, walking a few paces behind, burst out into laughter, sending a few small birds scattering from the brush, and

she couldn't help but blush, making the red of her abused cheek deeper as she flushed with embarrassment. She expected to hear Catra's wheezy laugh join theirs and was unnerved when, instead of mirth, she caught weariness in the mismatched eyes as the feline pulled her to a stopped and cupped her cheek to examine it for any damage. She tried to catch those eyes with her own, to ask a silent question, but her girlfriend avoided her gaze, instead running a thumb over a welt that was quickly blooming on her face.

"You didn't break the skin this time, but you're going to have one hell of a bruise there in the morning." Catra's voice seemed normal and Adora questioned if maybe she was just being paranoid. Any further thoughts if the other girls strange behaviour were washed away when she leaned forward and planted a soft kiss on the wound. "All better." The words were soft, the smile tender but Adora felt another shiver down her spine as their friends pushed passed them to take the lead.

"All better?" The blond put a question into her words but got no reply other than another soft kiss, this time to her lips, before she found herself being pulled along, back home.

Shock still rattled around Brightmoon. Hours had passed since the tanks had first rolled over the villages on the outskirts of the palace, leaving a swath of destruction in their wake. Homes had been turned to rubble and lifetimes of memories crumbled to dust, but the people had been safe, long since evacuated by the forethought of the Princess Alliance. They had known that the attack was looming, but for it to happen today had come out of the blue. After the Rebellion's last rout of the Horde forces, it had seemed inevitable that it would take them a while to regroup and build back the strength of their forces. That assumption had been very wrong.

Wave after wave pummelled the palace, breaking down all their defences. Adora had hacked and slashed, carved up tanks and

sent soldiers to their knees. Glimmer blinked in and out of existence, throwing member's of the Horde away from the field of battle while Perfuma's vines and Mermista waves swept others away but it seemed no good. The bots and tanks seemed to come from an inexhaustible supply. Where Hordak had been hiding them She-Ra could not fathom, but she and her people were being pushed back towards Brightmoon, overwhelmed by the sheer numbers of the enemy.

Somewhere in the fight Catra had disappeared into the melee, the dangerous bulk of Battle Cat cutting a path through the enemy as she moved out to dispatch the bots that hung back to provide reinforcements. Adora sent her good luck over their connection, but there was a hollow emptiness on the other side as she realised for the first time that she had not been able to hear Catra's side of this battle since it began. Before she could contemplate what that meant, a shell impacted the ground to her side and only Glimmer's intervention pulled her out before she could be torn apart in the explosion.

Falling back, surrounded on all sides and with Brightmoon at their backs, there seemed like there was nothing for it. She looked at these people at her side. This new family that she had brought together to protect a world that she had only seen in bits and pieces, warped and blackened by Shadow Weaver's lies, would stand with her even now as they looked down the barrel of defeat. She shared a sad smile with Perfuma, who reached out a long fingered hand and settled it with a reassuring squeeze on her forearm. A grunt from Mermista was followed by her hand joining the taller girls as Adora saw the sorrow hidden behind the usual nonchalance there. Soon Glimmer and Frosta joined them, all connected in their love for each other and this place.

Something inside Adora's chest popped with an almost audible sound as a wave of something like peace swept through her and burst out where the princesses were connected. It felt as though the power was surging through the ground, racing over her skin and out of her like the sense of a laser. Where the rainbow hued power hit the enemy they were scattered and thrown to the wind.

There was peace at the centre of the light, even as the Horde leapt from their machines and scattered in a screaming and terrified thong. There would be time to chase them later, but as the light died down, there was only one thing left for it. This was what Light Hope had shown was possible back in teh Crystal Castle!

They had won this battle, but they were still at war. They needed to strike while the power thrummed inside them all. Sea Hawk and Bow joined them as they moved with new confidence in the direction that the assault had come from. Their steps were sure and their resolve firm. She looked to the others again, hoping that they would cross paths with Catra on their way to Horde command. She-ra needed to capture Hordak and end this once and for all.

She ran. She couldn't look back, couldn't stop. Splinters of torn metal bit into the tender flesh of her bare feet as she pelted over the debris of shattered lives and smoking weapons. Her frantic dash to the woods had started on all fours, her powerful chest and haunches barrelling her forward through the last pockets of fighting. She knew that soon it would stop , the news of what she had done would crash like a wave and the Horde would dissolve like smoke. None of her old comrades would continue to fight once they learned that their leaders were gone. Thoughts as scattered as the fleeing soldier's would be, she failed to feel the wash of power recede from her body until she stumbled and the power of her movements sent her into a tumble that almost broke her neck as she went from unstoppable war machine to lithe and fragile young woman in the blink of an eye.

Adora knew, then. It was as obvious as the need to pick herself up, shoulder throbbing from the graceless crash to the ground, and continue to disappear into the woods, on two feet this time. There was no way that the blond girl wouldn't. She and her merry

band of princesses were bound to have found the carnage she had wrought by now. The trees blurred passed her, as she moved from the desecrated town into the cool shadows of the Whispering Woods, but she barely saw them, only instinct guiding her movements while her mind played over what must surely be happening.

Adora would have burst into the Horde field command, sword drawn and glowing as she prepared to stand toe-to-toe with Hordak and look him in the eye as she compelled his surrender. She would have been so stunning, tall and righteous as the goddess that she became, striding into the command centre ready to call an end to a war that would truly never be over as long as Hordak and Shadow Weaver lived. She would have had a speech prepared in that gorgeous blond head of hers, demands for surrender and capitulation ready on her lips for when she set eyes on her foes. But of course, she would never get a chance to say them now.

Catra had known all along, from the moment that she left Razz's cottage, what she would do. Perhaps it hadn't been at the forefront of her mind over the next few days, but her subconscious had been whispering to her even as she laughed and planned with the others. She knew what she alone had the power to do. Adora was too good, too honourable, to ever consider the only real solution to the problem that was the Horde. She and all of the princesses, with their belief in justice and rehabilitation, would capture them and put them into a room that they would call 'prison' but would really be so much more lavish than anything that even the leaders of the Horde experienced. It would be a reward for ravaging the land and indenturing its people like Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio until they would, inevitably, escape and the cycle would start all over again.

No. Catra knew she would make sure that Adora's life would not simply be the same fight over and over, until she was broken and hopeless as she stood across the battlefield a shell of who she was now. If that meant that Catra would lose, then it was what she was for, after all. Light Hope had made it clear that she was

no hero, that her job was done and that she was simply another weapon for Adora to wield, like the sword. So, Catra had wielded herself. As Battle Cat she was a giant slavering beast, paws larger than a man's head, and jaws that could easily tear through steal… why not flesh?

It was that very question that had led her to break away from the fighting, running with all the speed that her altered form could manage, towards the eye of the enemy storm. She had been able to hear Adora in her head, the connection between her form and She-Ra still open from the blond's side, even while Catra worked hard to keep her intentions under lock and key. She felt it when the princesses joined their power, felt the wash of power as the arching rainbow had filled the sky and everything had become euphoric but nothing could dissuade her from her self imposed mission. They were busy, focusing their powers around Brightmoon and now she was free to end things for good.

It had been ridiculously simple to get into the command tent (though tent was an understatement, the place was a huge fortified metal shell). She dove on top from an outcropping rock that was intended to add fortification but not from her. Landing soundlessly, she had soon unsheathed her claws and sliced through the roof with ease, parting the spiteful metal and slipping her huge girth inside. She knew Hordak and Shadow Weaver well enough to know that their great hubris would mean that there would be no guards inside. They would be plotting and scheming in secret, pushing their soldier's around the field of battle like the pawns that they were, regardless of loss of life. There would always be more cannon fodder to fill the void, after all.

Slinking down the dimly lit, deserted hallway, her keen ears picked up the voices of those who had ruined so many lives. For just a moment, as she planted herself in front of the metal door, her chest heaved and a moment of indecision filled it. Yes, she had taken life before. She had felt flesh tear beneath her claws and fangs, gulped down the blood of her prey to nourish herself all her life before the Horde and Brightmoon. She was a predator, after

all. Yet, she had never killed a person before. Would it feel different to tear their flesh, hear their screams?

Shaking her head, unwilling to let her resolve be clouded, she lowered her giant head and swiped out with claws that decimated the door as easily as cardboard, revealing the stunned face of Hordak as he looked with disbelief at where the screaming of metal had left a gaping void filled by a giant animal, and Shadow Weaver whose mask was, as always, a cool visage of indifference. She didn't even flinch. The animal let out a loud roar and changed towards them. Neither had a chance to move before they were swiped in one blow to the ground. It had seemed impossible that one of the Alliance would do this, but underestimating her had always been Shadow Weaver's biggest weakness.

The sorceress careened into the ground hard, her head slamming into the food the command console and sending her into darkness. Catra was only dimly aware that the woman had gone totally limp, all of her attention focussed on the man that she had pounced on and pinned to the floor. He stared up at her, defiance radiating from his red eyes, a smirk blooming over his face as she hesitated, teeth bared and breath ruffling the ridiculous tuft of blue hair that sat atop his head.

"What are you waiting for? You're all so weak!" The arrogance in his voice made her growl, teeth dripping saliva onto his neck but he refused to yield. "I will make a rug of you and make your She-Ra my soldier." He laughed darkly, the vibration travelling through the paw on his chest until the mirth turned into a pained gurgle as vice like jaws settled around his throat and tore it open.

The eyes, so sure a second before, were filled with terror as a tear trickled down his face. The part of Catra that was a terrified young woman felt a pang in her chest, but Battle Cat was more than her, and fangs moved through flesh and into bone until with a final shattering crunch the hands that had been scrabbling at her side fell away and the man beneath her lay in a spreading pool of his own warm blood. Her fur was matted with it and stuck together in clumps, it oozed down her throat with a familiar tang

and she hated herself for being unable to resist the urge to lick her face clean of it with her rough tongue.

Groaning from the floor stopped her before she could begin lapping up the fast congealing blood and the part if her that was a hunter, now awake again after sleeping in the luxury of a human life, purred with delight as she flew to pin the magic users hands to the floor with her massive bulk. She heard and felt the breath whoosh out of the woman and let out the cat equivalent of a chortle. Raising one giant paw, a single claw extended, she reached up and flicked that damn mask off of the woman's scarred face and sent it flying through the air. There was a shattering noise as it hit a far wall and fell to the ground in three unequal parts. Catra would have been happy about that, but Battle Cat was only focused on the woman who had wronged her. This creature below her had tortured her for nothing but power and made Adora believe that she was nothing but her successes.

Big eyes, blown out to blackness gazed down and as Shadow Weaver went to open her mouth, the same paw, now alive with knife-like claws, lashed out and severed the woman's head from her neck. With a whimsy out of place among the carnage of blood and viscera, she batted the head which rolled away like a ball of yarn. That was when her humanoid side took over and she flinched, the smell of blood no longer enticing but a sickening reminder that in either form, she was less than the humans she walked among. Backpedaling, four legs slipping and sliding in the blood until she was covered in it, and the smell of fear, she managed to make it out of the command centre, running so fast that the few guards stationed outside didn't know what they were seeing.

That was how she had ended up running through the woods, alone again. The sound of a stream nearby caught her sharp ears and she made towards it, shedding her clothes which had become soiled as soon as she transformed back and they rubbed against her fetid fur. She wouldn't need them anymore anyway. She had let all her rage, vengeance and protectiveness have free reign and there was no way that she could go back now. Adora would never

be able to look at her after she saw what the feline was capable of.

Tears began to run down the dirt on her cheeks as she took a leap and threw herself into the icy water, darkness quickly falling around her, as she was washed clean of the world.

Sitting in a tree

Chapter Summary

What comes after the war?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Blood thundered in her ears, so loud that even her own panted breaths were drowned out. Tears trickled down her face mixing with the beading sweat that had pooled as she stood amongst the gore and echoes of violence, casting her eyes around wildly. The world swam around her as she went from being the statuesque goddess back to simply the lost girl among the devastation. Blood trickled lazily down the walls. How could this be happening? Why would Catra do this?

A choked sob tore from her throat along with a single word.

"Catra!"

Adora bolted up in bed, sheets pooling at her waist and shirt plastered to her sweaty back. The sight of those corpses, mauled almost beyond recognition, still haunted her nights. Shadow Weaver's head laying so far from her body, unmasked and blank stared, was a sight that had forced her to empty her stomach all those weeks ago, and even now just thinking of it made her stomach roil.

Scrubbing roughly at her wet face with the edge of her shirt, she tried to get her breathing back under control. This dream was always the same, reliving the elation of battle and the sinking realisation that Catra had killed for her. Not just killed, but tore two people apart, so that she wouldn't have to. The others had tried to tell her that it had been Catra's animal nature taking over, that it must have been a spur of the moment thing and that it was no fault of the younger girls. Adora knew better. She knew Catra

almost as well as she knew herself. She should have been suspicious after the Crystal Castle, the cat girl had become more withdrawn and on the day of what was being called The Battle of Brightmoon, her unwillingness to open her mind should have been a red flag but Adora had been too caught up in the adrenaline of the moment to interrogate it.

Huffing loudly, Adora threw the sheets off her body and staggered to her feet. She hadn't had a decent night's sleep this week. It was like that sometimes, this week she would dream of Catra or that day every night, and others she wouldn't dream of it at all. She wasn't sure what was worse. What she did know was that she missed the smaller girl like a missing limb. Nobody had seen her since the war had been ended and the Horde had surrendered. She had vanished like smoke, almost as though she had never been.

Adora had briefly let herself consider that Catra had just vanished. Light Hope had made her and now that her job was done, could she have just unmade her? The young blond had trekked to the Crystal Castle several times to ask just that question, every time accompanied by one of her friends, all of whom were concerned about her state of mind. The first time she had found herself sinking to her knees and weeping at the entrance to Catra's old cave, before wriggling her way inside in the vain hope that she would find the other girl hiding there. She hadn't been, but Adora had been in no state to go and talk to the enigmatic hologram.

The next few times she had managed to make her way inside the obelisk only to find the interior cold and dark, no matter how much she called out there was only silence, not even a killer robotic spider crept out to greet them. Eventually she had given up on answer from that quarter and found herself seated in Razz's cottage, once again holding a hot cup of tea and only learning that Catra was, in fact, still in the corporeal world but after having succumbed to being 'the angry cat' needed time to deal with her actions. How Razz knew what those actions were was unclear, but the way the elderly woman shuddered as she spoke said that she knew everything.

In her lonely bedroom in Brightmoon, Adora made her way into the bathroom and turned on the light, wincing as it hit her tired eyes. She stood at the sink, shoulders hunched as she grasped the edges of the basin, head bowed. Sucking in a few deep breaths, she finally reached forward and ran cold water into her hands and splashed her face knowing that there was no chance of more sleep tonight. When she looked up, meeting exhausted blue eyes in the mirror, the evidence of her sleepless nights was evident in the bags under her eyes and the drawn, pinched shape of her mouth.

Harshly pulling her hair back into an untidy ponytail and hastily brushing her teeth, she went back into the bedroom. She picked up the blanket and dragged it to her desk and wrapped it around herself to ward of the chill of the very early morning, and drew out the documents that she had been working on before bed. Rehabilitating and reintroducing an entire army of people took a lot more logistics than she, or the Princess Alliance, had ever imagined and Queen Angella had been all too happy to let her take charge.

Snapping on the desk lamp, she began to read through yet another personal profile as she let her mind become distracted by the work.

Cheek resting on her fist, Adora tried to hold back a yawn that threatened to bubble up. When she had been a member of the Horde, she'd had no idea of just how many members there were. Even while fighting them, there had not seemed to be as many as had passed through the tribunals. Her training in logistics and military paperwork meant that she was the best equipped to run these brief trials. They were called tribunals, but really it was just an opportunity for most of the rank and file soldiers to have some closure and catharsis and to work out where they would be best placed for their resettlement.

The young man in front of Adora now was a few years older than her. She vaguely recalled him from being in one of the training

groups that used to use the simulators right before her year. She could see that Perfuma and Glimmer were both listening intently to what he had to say about how much he regretted destroying people's homes and how he hoped that he would have the opportunity to help people rebuild. It was a common story from the younger soldier's (from all the soldiers, in fact, once they actually met the princesses and the scales fell from the eyes) and Adora knew that she shouldn't be zoning out but she had slept poorly and their was an incessant buzzing in her ears that she couldn't seem to shake. The man sat back with his arms folded and she realised that all eyes had turned to look at her expectantly.

Straightening in her seat, she smiled at him and asked him to wait outside while they conferred. This was the hard part, made harder by her inattention, deciding where in the world these lost boys and girls belonged. She could see the concern on Glimmer's face as she looked at her once the door closed and shook her head, not wanting to talk about this again. No amount of talk with these women would change the fact that Catra was gone, and apparently not coming back. How could they tell the feline that they didn't hod what she had done against her if they could not find her?

They talked briefly about the man's words and interests and it seemed obvious that he would be a perfect fit for one of the coastal towns of Selineas. Jotting the words down, she felt the buzzing in her head get louder and more intense. Her vision began to swim and the pen fell from her fingers and clattered onto the table. The sounds of Glimmer and Perfuma's worried voices seemed very far away as, suddenly, the bracer on her arm seemed to burn and as she clutched it with her other hand she fell to the floor as She-ra.

Her eyes were squeezed tightly closed and in her minds eye she was bombarded with images of trees and grass moving passed at enormous speed. A large, plump bird was ahead, growing larger all the time as she got closer and closer until she pounced. Delight and relief rolled through her and then the connection was severed

again as though a switch had been flipped. Adora sat up shakily, instantly shrinking back down to her normal size, grateful that Perfuma's cool hands were there to guide her up while Glimmer brought her some water and fussed over her.

"Catra's in the woods, she's all right." Her words came through a smile that stretched across her face and made her cheeks ache.

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There was something comforting about the Whispering Woods in the dead of night. Even after the threat of the Horde had been dissolved to nothing and the people repatriated back into normal society, the woods would still often send unwary travellers down blind paths and turned them around until it spit them out. Once, when they had all been children and believed that princesses were evil and ate kids like them for lunch, they had thought that the Whispering Woods was out to get them. Now it seemed, the woods was indiscriminate in who it messed with. Perhaps the place was alive and just wanted to be entertained? Lonnie wasn't sure what the answer was, she was just glad that her life was this now.

When Adora had first suggested that her old and new friends get together to go camping once a month, after everything had started to seem normal, it had seemed like a crazy idea. What did she and the boys have in common with a bunch of stuck up, spoiled princesses? The war might be over and their differences resolved, well there were no differences with Hordak gone, but they were still not likely to have anything in common. But, Adora had looked at them all with those big, pathetic blue eyes and every one of them had capitulated her will. How the big dope had never really understood the power she had over other people when she was just being herself, the stocky girl wasn't sure, but she was glad that Adora only used it sparingly. She was also glad that the older girl never carried that sword with her these days. In the first few weeks after the war (and wasn't that still such a

strange thing to think) she had moved inland out of her She-ra form regularly to deter any violence but the need seemed to be over now.

A hand landing on her shoulder broke Lonnie's chain of thought and she turned her head to look up at the smiling man beside her. Sea Hawk was the loudest, most obnoxious member of the Alliance and yet had quickly become firm friends with the straight talking, no shit taking ex-soldier. In fact, had anyone asked the pirate (but nobody ever did) he would say that he saw a lot of his delightful Mermista in the belligerent woman. They had bonded over a love of casual brawling and one-upmanship that left the others shaking their heads.

"Come Lonnie-lass, 'tis time for s'mores and tales of terror and daring do!" His voice boomed around the edge of the woods where they had set up camp and the woman smirked as the groans of the others reached her ears from where they sat around the blazing fire. That had also quickly become part of this odd little ritual that they had played out one night each months for the past eight.

"Lead the way SH." She could do nicknames too.

The pair joined the others in the glow of the healthy bonfire. They were camped, as they always did, where the cadets would be taken for training in the Horde. They were not the only ones who did this, she knew, it was like reclaiming a part of their childhoods and making it a part of their fixture instead. No more rivalry, danger or competition, only the fun parts of camping that she had always enjoyed as a kid. She broke away from Sea Hawk and went to sit in the spot between Kyle and Rogelio that had been left just for her. The three of them had stayed together after everything and were giving real life a good try. She turned her green eyed gaze to see Sea Hawk slump to the ground and drape his torso loosely across Mermista's lap, who in turned rolled her eyes and sighed dramatically but made no move to dislodge him as she began to run her fingers through his hair.

Kyle moved to rest his head against her broad shoulder and she rested her cheek on top of his nest of soft blond hair. This was what safety and comfort felt like. She couldn't stop herself from seeking out Adora around the fire, sat among the various couples and groups. The blond looked softly happy, her blue eyes shining in the flames, but something was obviously missing. Someone.

Nobody had seen the feline since that day.

Adora felt eyes on her and looked back at Lonnie. She was closer to the other girl now than she had ever been when they were cadets together, finding common ground as she helped her old fiends start to find a place in the world even as she was unsure where she belonged now. She had filled her days with helping ex-soldiers get jobs and homes, and been surprised that she was good at it. She was the link between the old and the new for so many people. She smiled at her old friend and watched her settled back down to cuddling with Kyle and Rogelio.

Adora turned her attention to the rest of the group. Never in her wildest dreams could she have imagined that this would be her life now. No more fighting, no more fear and all of the people that she loved all in one place. She trued her attention to Perfuma who was curled in the circle of Scorpia's large pincers. That had been an unexpected surprise. The two had quickly grown close as Perfuma worked with some of the older Horde soldiers who struggled to slot into society. For most it was a case of breaking away from years of indoctrination. Scorpia had been different, self loathing and purposeless she had fallen into a spiral of depression that had shocked the people who knew her. Perfuma had helped her get back to herself and eventually, moths after they had stopped working together, they were at the beginning of an adorable relationship.

"Guys, isn't it time for a ghost story?" Bow's exuberant voice pulled all eyes to him and there was laughing and clapping in agreement. Kyle sat up straighter, it had turned out that he was the king of campfire tales.

The wiry young man began to spin a story of haunted ruins and vile creatures that preyed on lost travellers, the flames of the fire throwing his face into twisted shadows. The others leaned closer, drinking in every word, gasping and flinching as Kyle ramped up the fear. Adora's eyes strayed to the tree line and the deep, dark shadows beyond.

Soon yawns filled the air and people started to break away and head to the cluster of tents that sat close by. They were large and luxurious compared the small, shabby things that the Horde youths had slept in, with bedding more comfortable than their bunks had ever been. The tents were mostly shared, but Adora chose to sleep alone in the smallest of the tents. She didn't need anyone else to be woken by her nightmares should they visit her here. She hung back, banking down the fire and stowing the gear that was strewn around as the others disappeared into their temporary homes.

It didn't take long before the sound of people changing their clothes and setting down faded into soft, and in some cases not so soft, snores. Frosta's shockingly loud wheezing snorts brought a smile to Adora's lips as she shook her head. The youngest princess was sharing her tent with Perfuma and Scorpia and she hoped that the older women had earplugs. She reached down beside her and picked up the small lamp and turned on the beam, a warm glow lighting up the leaf littered ground ahead of her as she made her way in the opposite direction from the camp.

Her feet took her along the familiar path towards the small gap where she had disappeared from another group a lifetime ago. It was harder now to squeeze through the gap between the trees, her shoulders had broadened and her frame thickened with access to better food and exercise. With some wiggling and grunting, she managed to slip through to the other side. She swung her torch around the clearing. It was just as it had always been and for a moment she almost expected a small, rag tag ball of fur to come pouncing out at her from the darkness. She let a little laugh escape her and heard rustling as some small critters were disturbed and ran for cover. She chose not to turn her light on

them, happy not to know if they were mice or large spiders - the idea of either making her skin crawl.

She started walking to the edge of the clearing, where the thin trickle of the tiny stream almost sounded like bells in the nighttime quiet. She lowered herself cross legged beside it and dunked one hand under the flow, feeling the coolness run across her skin and reminiscing about all the times she had started her nights here. Her head snapped up as the creaking of the trees caught her attention. Bats burst out of the branches and she jumped to her feet, swinging the torch around until it caught something hanging from a large tree up ahead.

Smiling brightly, she ran towards the lowered limb, grasping the brown furred arm and allowing herself to be swung up into the leafy canopy of the tree, sheltered from any prying eyes. She clambered up higher, careful to move where the lithe body in front of her did until she was settled into the juncture of two thick branches and drinking in the presence of the naked, furred form lounging before of her. She leaned forward, cupping the downy cheeks in her hands and locking eyes with the luminous, mismatched ones she loved so dearly. She leaned forward, tottering slightly before sure arms steadied her, and pressed her smiling lips to the grinning ones of her lover, pulling away just enough to settle their foreheads together.

And if things would never be the way they were before, she could live with that as she felt the vibration of the purr rolling through her hands. This seemed better. Right. This was where Catra belonged, bare and free among the trees, while she was woven into the fabric of Brightmoon now. But these moments, stolen on camping trips seemed almost perfect to the human girl and her cat like love.

“Hey, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

And that is Wild. I have had this last section written since around chapter 28. It's not a perfect happy ending, but a fitting one.

Thanks for everyone who stuck with this.

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